

HABS/SABRES: Young Powerhouses Ready to Pop

DobberHockey's

FANTASY GUIDE

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21st Edition



Dobber's 2026-27 Fantasy Hockey Guide

Home of the Top Fantasy Hockey Player Rankings

For the last couple of seasons, I have noticed that players have been starting off slowly with regard to meeting my expectations. Then things turn around by January and start falling into place. It's a reminder that statistics can be wild, but start to settle in over a larger sample size. The turnaround in Buffalo is a great example. I felt, in the preseason, that this team would push for a playoff spot. By December, they were in last place in the NHL. A week later, they had won three games in a row. Then GM Kevyn Adams was fired (let's not forget that the winning streak started prior to his firing!). By the end of the season, the Sabres finished fourth in the entire league.

Anyway, the players on Buffalo had been floundering and, in my mind, as were the focal point of my projections also floundering. They turned it around, as did most of the other guys who were lagging to start. I'll try harder to work in the slow-start/fast-finish players within each team so you can push them down your draft lists and/or acquire them via trade after the sluggish October.

The big news this year is that I am ready to deploy my new formula. That's right—after 29 years of using one formula developed in fourth-year university statistics, I back-tested a new one and had it on the sidelines for last season—as one last test. With all the new metrics so easily accessible, there were many ways to improve this. My cancer battle in 2024 prevented me from doing this two years ago, but last year I dug in and this year I verified and finalized it. The result was overwhelming: on average, the projections were 5% closer, approximately 7% more of the 700 players were projected closer, and 15% more of the top 250 scorers were projected closer. I'm very excited to see how things shake out.

That said, elite fantasy hockey owners know that my guides are not only about the projections. The notes and advice provided are a guide to how you need to think about each player—not just for the draft, but for in-season decisions. Now dig in. Read it twice. Refer to it often. And go kick ass.

- Dobber: @DobberHockey

Important: Any updates beyond this original release will be in **red**. BUT, as usual, on **September 20** (to save your ink, for those who print this) the red will be removed. Any updates after that will again be in **red**.

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A LOOK INSIDE THE 2026-27 SCHEDULE

By Caleb Desjardins

Welcome to the schedule analysis for the 21st annual *DobberHockey Fantasy Hockey Guide*. The 2026-27 NHL schedule will be the first to feature an 84-game season instead of 82. We've entered the dog days of the offseason, and while hockey isn't at the forefront of everyone's mind, it's never too early to start thinking about fantasy hockey.

Our schedule analysis aims to give fantasy managers an edge over their competition by highlighting potential advantages and disadvantages in each team's slate. We break down every game for all 32 teams so you don't have to. So, without further ado, let's dive into this year's schedule analysis.

BACK-TO-BACKS

One major factor when looking at the schedule is back-to-backs. Teams that have to play two games in two nights are more likely to drop at least one of those contests. Furthermore, the lack of rest can often hinder individual player performances, especially in the second half of the two-game stint. Here are the NHL clubs facing the most—and the fewest—back-to-backs in the upcoming campaign.

	B2B		B2B
Pittsburgh Penguins	15	Philadelphia Flyers	12
Boston Bruins	14	St. Louis Blues	12
Buffalo Sabres	14	Anaheim Ducks	11
Florida Panthers	14	Edmonton Oilers	11
Ottawa Senators	14	New York Rangers	11
Washington Capitals	14	Nashville Predators	11
Columbus Blue Jackets	13	Toronto Maple Leafs	11
Dallas Stars	13	Vancouver Canucks	11
New York Islanders	13	Colorado Avalanche	10
New Jersey Devils	13	Los Angeles Kings	10
San Jose Sharks	13	Minnesota Wild	10
Seattle Kraken	13	Montreal Canadiens	10
Tampa Bay Lightning	13	Utah Mammoth	10
Carolina Hurricanes	12	Winnipeg Jets	9
Chicago Blackhawks	12	Calgary Flames	8
Detroit Red Wings	12	Vegas Golden Knights	8

- Pittsburgh gets the short end of the stick next season, facing a daunting 15 back-to-backs. On the other side of the coin, Calgary and Vegas will play in roughly half that number, with just eight on the schedule.
- In fantasy, back-to-backs have a significant impact on goaltending workload. Teams typically try to lighten the load on their starters by limiting how many of these sets they play. This means backups will see more action—and could become worthwhile fantasy adds.
- Based on the schedule, here are some starters projected for heavy workloads, along with backups who may see increased roles.

MOST PROJECTED GOALIE STARTS

- Connor Hellebuyck — The Jets will once again lean heavily on Hellebuyck as they push for a return to the postseason. That's assuming he's still with them when training camp opens.

- **Dustin Wolf** — Wolf has carried the load for the Flames over the past couple of seasons. The schedule suggests he'll see plenty of starts; however, as the season progresses and Calgary slips out of playoff contention, expect Devin Cooley to also get his share of the crease.

- **Karel Vejmelka** — Vejmelka is no stranger to a heavy workload, having started 63 games for Utah last season. With rookie Sebastian Cossa behind him and very few back-to-backs on the slate, he should surpass 60 starts again next year.

INCREASED WORKLOAD FOR BACKUP GOALIES

- **Akira Schmid** — The Panthers have a new-look tandem after letting Sergei Bobrovsky walk and acquiring Jacob Markstrom from New Jersey. But Markstrom didn't play at an elite level last season and is now 36. With the number of back-to-backs ahead, Schmid should see plenty of action.

- **Alex Lyon** — Lyon and Ukko-Pekka Luukkonen battled for the starter's crease last season. Buffalo appears ready to lean toward Luukkonen to begin the year, but Lyon should still see meaningful action—especially if the younger netminder falters.

- **Sergei Murashov** — Murashov may be unfamiliar to many fans outside Pittsburgh, but for now, the 22-year-old projects as the team's backup heading into next season. He posted solid AHL numbers, and with Pittsburgh's difficult schedule, he'll have opportunities to show what he can do behind another young goalie, Arturs Silovs.

STRENGTH OF SCHEDULE

Strength of schedule refers to the level of competition a team faces relative to the rest of the league. This is based on each club's performance last season in terms of goals-for and goals-against percentages. This analysis helps project where teams may finish in the standings during the upcoming campaign.

Opposition goals for		Opposition goals against	
Detroit	3.12	Los Angeles	2.91
Florida	3.12	Vegas	2.91
New Jersey	3.11	Colorado	2.91
NY Islanders	3.11	Calgary	2.90
NY Rangers	3.11	Seattle	2.90
Toronto	3.11	Tampa Bay	2.89
Boston	3.10	Minnesota	2.89
Columbus	3.10	Dallas	2.89
Montreal	3.10	Edmonton	2.89
Ottawa	3.10	Buffalo	2.88
Philadelphia	3.10	Utah	2.88
Buffalo	3.09	Anaheim	2.88
Chicago	3.09	San Jose	2.88
Tampa Bay	3.09	Detroit	2.87
Washington	3.09	NY Islanders	2.87
Calgary	3.08	NY Rangers	2.87
St. Louis	3.08	Boston	2.87
Vancouver	3.08	Montreal	2.87
Winnipeg	3.08	Ottawa	2.87
Carolina	3.07	Philadelphia	2.87
Los Angeles	3.07	Chicago	2.87
Nashville	3.07	Washington	2.87
Pittsburgh	3.07	St. Louis	2.87
Seattle	3.07	Vancouver	2.87
Minnesota	3.06	Winnipeg	2.87
Utah	3.06	Carolina	2.87

Anaheim	3.05	Nashville	2.87
Dallas	3.05	Florida	2.86
San Jose	3.05	New Jersey	2.86
Vegas	3.05	Columbus	2.86
Colorado	3.04	Pittsburgh	2.86
Edmonton	3.04	Toronto	2.86

- Vegas and Colorado have some of the best combined goals-for and goals-against percentages among their opponents. Meanwhile, Florida and New Jersey get the short end of the stick in both categories.
- For a team like Edmonton, which has struggled to keep the puck out of its net, having opponents with the lowest goals-for percentage should be a positive next season. As for Toronto, who struggled to score last year, these numbers mean their stars will need to step up in a big way.
- While these numbers can't account for offseason roster turnover—nor can they predict the future—they still give us a solid idea of the strength of schedule teams will face next season.

LIGHT DAYS

Light days refer to Mondays, Wednesdays, Fridays, and Sundays. The bulk of NHL games typically land on Tuesdays, Thursdays, and Saturdays. Drafting players who play the most on light days can give managers a slight edge when building their rosters. Having too many players on heavy-schedule days leads to benching players and missing out on maximizing your total possible games played.

Light Days		Light Days	
Washington	40	Montreal	32
NY Rangers	39	Seattle	32
Colorado	38	Vegas	32
Utah	37	Los Angeles	31
Anaheim	36	Ottawa	31
Chicago	36	Toronto	31
Edmonton	36	Buffalo	30
San Jose	36	Calgary	30
Detroit	35	Boston	29
Dallas	34	New Jersey	29
Philadelphia	34	Columbus	28
Pittsburgh	34	Minnesota	28
Winnipeg	34	NY Islanders	28
Vancouver	33	Tampa Bay	25
Carolina	32	St. Louis	24
Florida	32	Nashville	22

- Washington leads the league with 40 light days, accounting for nearly half of their season. Nashville, meanwhile, has only 22.
- Teams like Washington, Colorado, and Utah have enough fantasy-relevant depth to help fill rosters on light days and give poolies an edge when setting lineups.
- Nashville and St. Louis already have limited fantasy value outside their elite options—Robert Thomas, Filip Forsberg, and Roman Josi—so managers should avoid digging too deep into their depth pieces.

TEAM SCHEDULE NOTES

- Anaheim — The Ducks have a massive nine-game homestand immediately following the Christmas break.
- Boston — The Bruins enjoy a six-game homestand heading into December.
- Buffalo — The Sabres face Alex Tuch and the Washington Capitals on November 19.
- Calgary — April 10 marks the Flames' final game at Scotiabank Saddledome before moving to a new arena.
- Carolina — Newly crowned Stanley Cup champion Frederik Andersen returns to Carolina on November 21.
- Chicago — The Blackhawks will play two games in Germany in December.
- Colorado — Colorado heads to Utah for the NHL Winter Classic on New Year's Eve.
- Columbus — The Blue Jackets could start hot, with seven of their first nine games at home.
- Dallas — The Stars will look to avenge their playoff defeat with four games against rival Minnesota.
- Detroit — The Red Wings will celebrate their centennial game, marking exactly 100 years since their inaugural contest.
- Edmonton — The Oilers close out the campaign with a home-and-home versus the Jets.
- Florida — Sergei Bobrovsky returns to Florida on March 6 as the Panthers host the Maple Leafs.
- Los Angeles — The Kings will enjoy two seven-game homestands, balancing out a seven-game road trip.
- Minnesota — The Wild will play 10 road games in October.
- Montreal — Longtime Canadien Brendan Gallagher returns on March 6. Montreal also plays its first outdoor game since 2017 this October in Winnipeg.
- Nashville — Nine of the team's first 14 games are at home.
- New Jersey — The Devils face a grueling second half, with matchups against nearly all playoff teams.
- NY Islanders — The Isles host the All-Star Skills Competition in February, which also marks former captain Anders Lee's return.
- NY Rangers — The Blueshirts close out the season with three games at MSG.
- Ottawa — Brady Tkachuk makes his anticipated Ottawa return on October 21. Expect a hostile crowd—especially with Matthew in the building.
- Philadelphia — Seven of the Flyers' final 10 games are on the road.
- Pittsburgh — Pittsburgh faces more back-to-backs than any other team—not ideal for an aging core.
- San Jose — The Sharks' seven-game homestand is split by the All-Star break. They also have two six-game road trips.
- Seattle — The Kraken will play two games in Finland in November.
- St. Louis — Six of the Blues' first eight games are on the road.
- Tampa Bay — The Lightning have a packed March, including nine games against division rivals.
- Toronto — Gavin McKenna's expected NHL debut is set for September 29 against the Canadiens. The Leafs also open the year with a four-game homestand.
- Utah — The Mammoth has both a six-game homestand and a six-game road trip this season.

- Vancouver — The Canucks open their season with a home-and-home against division rival Edmonton.
- Vegas — The Golden Knights will be out for blood on December 21 in a Stanley Cup Final rematch against Carolina. They also have the fewest back-to-backs next season.
- Washington — If this is indeed Alex Ovechkin's final season, his last matchup with Sidney Crosby would be April 4, with his final career game on April 10.
- Winnipeg — The NHL Trade Deadline falls during the Jets' longest road trip of the season.

IMPORTANT SCHEDULE DATES

- **September 29** — Start of the 2026-27 NHL regular season
- **October 13** — All 32 NHL teams in action
- **October 25** — NHL Heritage Classic: Winnipeg hosts Montreal
- **November 12 & 14** — NHL Global Series in Finland: Carolina vs. Seattle
- **December 18 & 20** — NHL Global Series in Germany: Chicago vs. Ottawa
- **December 31** — Winter Classic: Utah hosts Colorado
- **February 5** — NHL All-Star Skills Competition
- **February 6** — NHL All-Star Game
- **February 20** — Stadium Series: Dallas hosts Vegas
- **March 8** — NHL Trade Deadline
- **April 10** — 2026-27 NHL regular season concludes, all 32 teams in action

Caleb Desjardins pens 'Top 10' every Monday and 'Looking Ahead' every Friday on DobberHockey.com



THE H2H LEAGUE SCHEDULE PLANNER

By Alexander MacLean

With the release of the NHL schedule, we can start breaking down a lot of the numbers, data, and trends it reveals. Building on Andrew Santillo's schedule write-up on page 4—which covers major fantasy implications throughout the season—it's worth digging into the week-to-week impact, specifically geared toward Head-to-Head (H2H) leagues and those crucial penultimate playoff weeks.

H2H managers who plan well can thrive in the final few weeks of the season, when the top teams square off and the winner advances toward a championship. Those win-or-go-home weeks are critical, and gaining any advantage is essential to compete. One simple edge? Having more man-games than your opponent. It's one of the easiest paths to success and doesn't demand deep hockey knowledge or research. Just grab productive players from teams with favorable schedules and trade away players stuck with poor ones.

Of course, it's easier said than done—especially when trying to balance winning now with making sure you actually get to the playoffs. How do you weigh a slightly better player with fewer games against a weaker player with more games? And what happens when NHL trades shake things up mid-season, just to add complexity? I'll leave those juicy decisions to you as the manager—that's the fun part of fantasy hockey. What I will give you is the list of teams to target.

One caveat: Sometimes it's smarter not to draft these favorable-schedule players right away, because they might cause you to miss out on valuable in-season man-games. That could drop you lower in the standings than expected—just something to keep in mind.

Depending on when your H2H finals are set, you'll want one of the first, second, or third lists below.

Double- and triple-check which one applies, and make sure your commissioner doesn't tweak the schedule mid-season. Any structural changes like that should begin the following year, as managers like you could already be making key decisions based on earlier information.

One more note: Week numbers can differ depending on how service providers or custom league settings structure the calendar around the new year, Christmas, and the All-Star break. To avoid confusion, it's best to reference specific dates rather than week numbers when possible.

Fantasy Weeks: March 15 to April 10

This stretch includes a three-matchup playoff setup, where the Championship matchup spans two weeks, running right to the end of the season.

Teams to Target

- Washington leads with the highest number of games at 15. They are the only team that plays four games in each of the final three seven-day weeks from March 15 to April 4.
- Colorado, Florida, Seattle, St. Louis, and Tampa Bay each play 14 games across this playoff setup.
- Be cautious about stacking Colorado, Florida, and Tampa Bay players. If they lock in playoff spots early, they're likely to rest starters in the final week or two.
- Minnesota and San Jose each play seven of 13 games on light days, which could add as many actual man-games to your lineup as the teams above.

Teams to Avoid

- Anaheim, Columbus, New Jersey, Nashville, New York Rangers, Ottawa, Philadelphia, Vancouver, and Vegas all play just 12 games in this span.
- Among those, stars from Anaheim, Vegas, and others could play fewer than 11, with rest days tacked on.

- Nashville, Columbus, and Philadelphia are especially tough to manage—they have just two games on a light day over this entire four-week period.
- Calgary, Columbus, Minnesota, and Philadelphia all have zero back-to-backs here, so their backup goalies' playing time will be unpredictable at best.

Fantasy Weeks: March 15 to April 4

This setup mirrors the previous structure, but with the final partial week removed, making the last week a standard seven days.

Teams to Target

- Washington still leads, with 12 games across the final three full weeks—nicely balanced with four games each week. Colorado, Florida, San Jose, St. Louis, and Toronto each play 11 games in that span.
- Minnesota and San Jose again have the most off-day games, which matters more in the more imbalanced final two weeks, where San Jose's off-day advantage will carry more weight. Minnesota's four-game week on all off-days is also a nice advantage.
- Washington and St. Louis each have three back-to-backs over this span, meaning their backup goalies are likely guaranteed at least one game a week.

Teams to Avoid

- Buffalo, Columbus, Dallas, New Jersey, Nashville, Ottawa, Philadelphia, Utah, Vancouver, Vegas, and Winnipeg each play only nine times during this period. New Jersey, Utah, and Winnipeg have two-game weeks sprinkled in, while the other eight play three per week. Utah and Winnipeg each play four games in the first week before the volume tails off, making them tough to win a championship with.
- New Jersey's split is risky, as they only play two games in the first week. You would have to survive less volume from them right out of the gate, and you might not even benefit from their heavier final-week volume. However, if your league has first-week byes and you can secure one, then they suddenly regain a lot of value.
- Boston, Philadelphia, and Tampa Bay each have just one game on a light day, meaning you'll likely struggle to get meaningful production from their players due to lineup congestion.

Fantasy Weeks: March 16 to March 28

This setup mirrors the one above, but with the final week ending prior to the large combined week—making the last week a standard seven-day slate, ending a little earlier for leagues that want to finish before players start getting rested.

Teams to Target

- Chicago, Seattle, St. Louis, Toronto, and Washington each play 11 games across this three-week stretch. With players unlikely to be rested at this stage, managers can expect more fulsome contributions from stars on these squads.
- Chicago has a big advantage here with eight off-peak game days, two more than Washington and at least three more than every other team.
- Washington has three back-to-backs in addition to their favorable off-peak schedule, meaning their backup goalie will hold extra value in this setup.

Teams to Avoid

- Columbus, New Jersey, and Utah each play just eight games during this stretch. The Devils in particular will be tough to roster with none of their games on light days.
- Utah plays only two games in the first and third (championship) weeks, while their middle week is a four-game slate. New Jersey's two-game week is the middle week, while Columbus' is week one—meaning you could dodge it if your league includes bye weeks.
- San Jose plays eight of their 10 games in this stretch on the road—a tough run for their goalies.

Other Specific Week-to-Week Notes

- Four-game weeks with all games on off-days are rare but valuable. From March 8 to April 10—the full possible range of the H2H playoff schedule—Calgary, Colorado, Minnesota, and Seattle have full off-day weeks, the only four such instances in this year's H2H playoff stretch. Calgary, Colorado, and Seattle have theirs between March 15 and 21, while Minnesota's is a standalone between March 29 and April 4.
- This season's schedule starts earlier in the year, and even with the new 84-game slate, it is only two days longer than last season. However, instead of a 19-day Olympic break, there is a four-day All-Star break with no regular-season games played. The schedule is therefore slightly less condensed than last season, allowing bench players to cycle in for a couple more games across the duration of the year.
- The less-condensed schedule is also more evenly spread out, with at least two games every day between the first and last day of the season—except for breaks on November 20 and 26, December 23–25 for Christmas, February 4–7 for the All-Star break, and a one-game day on November 24 (Edmonton vs. Vegas).
- The other result of a less-condensed schedule is that there are zero five-game weeks this year. There are plenty of one-game weeks, though they all occur on shortened weeks (first week, Christmas break, pre/post All-Star break). In fact, a few teams don't play at all on the active Monday–Wednesday leading into the All-Star break and end up with the full calendar week off. Every team has at least eight straight days off, but for some it's spread over two calendar weeks.
- The first week of the season is shortened (starting on a Tuesday), so grabbing a few extra Canucks or Rangers could pay off—they play four games, while no other team plays more than three in the first six days. The Rangers will be especially valuable since their four games all avoid the busy 13-game slate on Saturday, meaning you'll be benching fewer players that first week. Watch off-days to avoid benching active players.
- On the flip side, the Senators have only one game by the end of the first Sunday. They make up for it the very next week with a Monday/Tuesday back-to-back and a four-game week in total. That means volume starter Linus Ullmark likely plays his third game of the season on the 10th day of the schedule.
- The Senators' only games between December 14 and December 27 are the two games in Germany against Chicago. Chicago, meanwhile, has an even longer break before and after, with only the two international games on the schedule between December 12 and December 27.
- There are zero five-game weeks this season, a change from the past few years when there was at least one week for astute managers to stock up on volume from one team and win a matchup.
- All 32 teams play on Tuesday, October 13, and Saturday, April 10 (the final day of the regular season—more on that below). These are the only full-league slates, meaning you will inevitably leave some points on the bench. Playing your best players usually beats chasing the hot hand.
- Christmas break falls Wednesday to Friday this year. Most teams play at least two games, while Columbus has four games, with back-to-backs on both Monday/Tuesday and Saturday/Sunday. Chicago, Colorado, Edmonton, Ottawa, and Seattle each play only once.
- February features a four-day All-Star break—a full week longer than the usual midseason rest. The three-day week before (Monday to Wednesday) does not carry enough volume to function as a standalone week, and all providers should be merging them. Typically, it gets lumped in with the week post-break. Across those 10 combined days, each team plays between two and four games, meaning there isn't as much of an advantage to be gained here as in other years.
- Having all 32 teams in action on the last day of the season theoretically means a full fantasy lineup, with a big chance to swing your matchup right until the end—but with playoff spots likely set, there could be a lot of players rested for that full slate.

Stay on top of your team's schedule throughout the season, and be ready to adjust if any games are moved due to weather or other disruptions. These rescheduled matchups often get pushed toward the end of the year, adding unexpected volume during the fantasy playoffs—something you'll want to catch early. Stay sharp!

***Alexander MacLean writes Daily Ramblings and Capped Rankings,
and is Assistant Managing Editor at DobberHockey.com***

The advertisement features a dark blue background with a faint, glowing hockey rink and player statistics. At the top left, there is a cartoon illustration of two men: one with glasses and a white shirt, and the other with sunglasses and a black shirt, pointing towards the text. The main headline is in large, bold, red letters. Below it, a white box contains a sub-headline and a bulleted list of features. At the bottom, another headline is in white letters, followed by the website name in large, bold, red letters.

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SLEEPER PICKS: EASTERN CONFERENCE

By Khurram Sher

Finding value in your fantasy draft starts with targeting players whose actual value is higher than their average draft position. You want to be able to draft a 70-point player while others are drafting 50-point players.

Here is my 2026–27 Eastern Conference list of sleepers with breakout potential. These NHLers are all undervalued and will outproduce their ADP:

(Listed alphabetically)

Jackson Blake, RW, Hurricanes

Blake finished the season strong with 27 points in his last 34 games. He levelled up in the playoffs, adding 20 points in 19 games. Let me do the math: that is 47 points in his last 53 games, regular season and playoffs combined. Coach Rod Brind'Amour gives him some time on the top power play, and he is a volume shooter (2.15 SOG/game).

Nico Daws, G, Devils

New GM Sunny Mehta noted that Daws "hasn't really had the path to develop. For me, we're pretty excited about the potential opportunity in front of him." With Jacob Markstrom shipped off to Florida, the Devils' only other options are journeyman David Rittich and 36-year-old veteran Jake Allen. The Devils had the lowest 5-on-5 shooting percentage in the league last year; that number will regress upward and bring in more run support to help him notch wins.

Josh Doan, RW, Sabres

Doan was fourth in the league in takeaways, and only seven of his 27 assists were secondary. He accumulated 52 points but did so in only 15:52 of average ice time. The TOI and the secondary assists should rise in 2026–27. Doan received over 50% of power-play time but will have to compete with Zach Benson, Jack Quinn, Jason Zucker, Josh Norris, Noah Ostlund, Jiri Kulich, and Konsta Helenius for that coveted power-play ice time, so keep an eye on the Sabres' power-play deployment.

William Eklund, LW, Senators

In San Jose, Eklund didn't always play with Macklin Celebrini. In fact, his most common linemate was Alexander Wennberg. In Ottawa, it appears he will be centered by Tim Stutzle both on the top line and the top power play. Eklund is hitting his prime, and moreover, his shooting percentage last year (8.5%) was lower than his career average (10.4%). His -7.1 goals above expected should bounce back as well.

Adam Fantilli, C, Blue Jackets

Fantilli before the Olympics last season: 36 points in 56 games (0.64 ppg). Following the Olympics, 23 points in just 26 games (0.88 ppg). He is the unquestioned No. 1 center on the Jackets, will turn 22 in October, and is entering his breakout phase. Your peers may look at his season points-per-game of 0.72 and not see the urgency in drafting him. His average time on ice post-Olympics also increased by half a minute (19:17 vs. 18:44).

Brandon Hagel, LW, Lightning

Oliver Bjorkstrand (62.4%) spent more time on the power play than Hagel (45.0%), but Bjorkstrand is off to Broadway. Hagel will gobble up that extra PP1 time. Hagel was above a point-per-game pace (74 points in 71 games) without PP1 deployment. He could easily double his power-play total from last year (12). In the Bolts' playoff series against Montreal, he received 70.7% of the power-play time and didn't disappoint, accumulating eight points in seven outings.

Dougie Hamilton, D, Devils

Hamilton suffered from bad puck luck early last season, but he finished strong with 30 points in 38 games. While the competition on the right side is reduced with Simon Nemec dealt to Calgary, the key for Hamilton will be securing more power-play time than Luke Hughes. Hamilton should also see his even-strength shooting percentage rise, as last season's 6.7% was unusually low—and that alone should translate into more points.

Marco Kasper, C, Red Wings

Kasper, the eighth overall pick in 2022, makes the sleeper list not just because of the depth-chart opening due to the impending Dylan Larkin trade. Kasper's output tanked from 0.48 ppg (2024–25) to 0.23 ppg (2025–26). Under the hood, he suffered from a low shooting percentage (6.9%, down from 13.1%), a low 5-on-5 shooting percentage (5.9%, down from 7.3%), and low secondary assists (20%, down from 61.1%). All these luck-based metrics will regress upward.

Alexis Lafreniere, RW, Rangers

With Artemi Panarin and Vincent Trocheck gone west, Lafreniere finally gets a cushy spot on the top power-play unit. We have a sample of his production after the trade deadline when he replaced Panarin on the man advantage: 28 points in his last 27 games, 10 of which were power-play points. Lafreniere could follow Nathan MacKinnon as a late-blooming 1st-overall pick.

Jacob Markstrom, G, Devils

Markstrom returns to the friendly confines of Amerant Bank Arena. With Aleksander Barkov healthy and the summer addition of Brady Tkachuk, the run support for Markstrom will increase (the injury-riddled Panthers scored 251 goals, which was still more than the 230 by the Devils). In only two of his last 11 seasons has he had a sub-0.900 save percentage. His quality-start percentage is usually between 50–60%, but last year it fell to an uncharacteristic 38.6%.

Porter Martone, RW, Flyers

The sixth overall pick in 2025, Martone got called up late in the season and couldn't stop scoring (10 points in nine games). As an 18-year-old, he led Michigan State with 50 points in 35 games. The year before, as a 17-year-old, he led the Brampton Steelheads with 98 points in 57 games. None of his six NHL assists were secondary. His 8.9% even-strength shooting percentage will likely be better as well.

Timo Meier, LW, Devils

Meier's points per game have dropped for five consecutive seasons from 0.99 to 0.85 to 0.75 to 0.66 to 0.57, but he is better than his perceived value. He had the fourth-worst goals scored above expected (–10.3), a low 5-on-5 shooting percentage (6.4%), and a low shooting percentage (8.9%) compared to his usual career average (10.6%). He also brings a healthy dose of shots on goal (3.49/game, ranking him second in the NHL) and Hits (1.70/game).

J.T. Miller, C, Rangers

Miller normally shoots at 14.7%, but last year that number fell to 11.8%. His 5-on-5 shooting percentage was even lower (8.5%), meaning his linemates were not burying goals either. In the previous four seasons, his points per 60 minutes fluctuated between 3.0 and 3.9, but last year it dipped all the way down to 2.3. The analytics numbers started stabilizing in the second half of the season, and that was evident from his production: 31 points in his last 33 games.

Matvei Michkov, RW, Flyers

Michkov's time on ice from March onward was 15:22 (pre-March it was 14:38), and he registered 18 points in his last 16 games. He also finished with an even plus/minus, whereas the year before he was a minus-18. Coach Rick Tocchet won't be able to hold back this talent indefinitely. His Points/60 at 5-on-5 (1.94) was better than Lucas Raymond, Nik Ehlers, Andrei Svechnikov, Kirill Marchenko, and Trevor Zegras.

JJ Peterka, LW, Bruins

After receiving 63.9% of power-play time with the Sabres in 2024-25, the Mammoth only gave him 42.0% last year. In Boston, the coach is fellow countryman Marco Sturm. Peterka plays the opposite wing as David Pastrnak, so look for him to mooch points off his elite linemate. Peterka's deployment can't be worse than it was in Utah; if he also becomes a staple on the top power play, look out.

Darren Raddysh, D, Maple Leafs

Raddysh led the NHL in shots (97) with a speed greater than 145 km/h. The next-highest player was Evan Bouchard with 51! That heavy shot will be given the keys to the top power-play unit in Toronto. Raddysh has 67 points in his last 62 regular-season games (1.08 ppg). Even if his points drop off by 20%, that would still be elite production from a defenseman.

Calum Ritchie, RW, Islanders

Ritchie led the 2022-23 Hlinka Gretzky Cup in assists (six) and points (10). He was getting more than 50% of power-play time for the Isles since January 2026, and he upped his production with 19 points in his last 30 outings (0.63 ppg). New bench boss Peter DeBoer also used Ritchie on the top power-play unit. One word of caution: Ritchie led the league in IPP (94.12), which will come down.

Dylan Strome, C, Capitals

Strome is guaranteed great wingers at his side: Alex Tuch, Jordan Kyrrou, Alex Ovechkin, Aliaksei Protas, Tom Wilson, and Ryan Leonard. His IPP strangely dropped from 75.9 in 2024-25 to 53.2 last season. That number should rebound in 2025-26. He gets favorable deployment with 26% of his shifts started in the offensive zone (second in the NHL), and he won 523 faceoffs (sixth).

Linus Ullmark, Senators

In his 11-year career, Ullmark never posted a save percentage below 0.905 (career average 0.914). Last year, it fell to 0.891. Ottawa was third in the league in expected-goals percentage (55.16%), third in shot-attempts percentage (53.27%), and third in expected-goal differential (+50.87). Ullmark righted the ship in the playoffs (0.932). Furthermore, his backup competition is less than impressive, as both Sam Ersson (-17.3) and Leevi Merilainen (-16.5) were ranked 94th and 95th out of 98 goalies in GSAX.

Mika Zibanejad, C, Rangers

Zibanejad's 2024-25 campaign was marred by poor production despite good underlying analytics numbers. He rebounded nicely in 2025-26 with 78 points in 81 games. What is hidden in those numbers is his even hotter second half: Zibanejad notched 48 points in his last 40 games. While others are unsure how he will do without Artemi Panarin and Vincent Trocheck, you can probably nab him at a lower ADP.

***Khurram Sher pens the 'Eastern Edge' every Tuesday on DobberHockey.com
and contributes to GoaliePost.com***



SLEEPER PICKS: WESTERN CONFERENCE

By Lucas Main

Everyone is looking for deep-round sleepers to gain an edge over their fantasy opponents, but you don't always need a late-round guy to put your team over the top. You just need players who will perform at their ADP or exceed it. If you compile a roster of those players, you should be in pretty good shape. Here is a list of 20 Western Conference "sleepers." Good luck.

(Listed alphabetically)

Mavrik Bourque, RW, Predators

After scoring 20 goals in his second season with Dallas while averaging only 14 minutes at even strength and one minute on the power play, Bourque was dealt to Nashville and given a substantial six-year, \$33 million contract. The deal signals that Bourque will help lead the next generation of Predators under the new regime.

Braeden Bowman, RW, Golden Knights

We had a good sample size of Bowman filling in for Vegas' top six last season, recording nine points in 11 games during their injury-ridden stretch. New Coach Ryan Craig is very familiar with Bowman, as he previously coached their AHL affiliate in Henderson. The Golden Knights are always looking for inexpensive contracts to fill out their roster, so Bowman has a strong opportunity to remain in Vegas all season.

Bowen Byram, D, Blackhawks

Chicago traded its 2026 fourth-overall pick for Byram (who was coincidentally selected fourth overall in 2019). The BC native posted 42 points last season with virtually no power-play time in Buffalo. He now steps into a situation where he becomes the number-one defenseman and will likely absorb all of the power-play minutes. Expect his numbers to rise across the board as his workload increases.

Leo Carlsson, C, Ducks

Carlsson is not a sleeper—his name was everywhere this summer because of the offer sheet he signed with Philadelphia—but now that he is the highest-paid player in the NHL, you can expect him to become *the* guy. We sometimes forget he was leading the league in points in November before a rare thigh injury sidelined him and disrupted his momentum. If healthy, he should push 90+ points, offering excellent value at his ADP.

Igor Chernyshov, LW, Sharks

Chernyshov drew the short straw last season, as he was waiver-exempt while the Sharks were carrying several players who were not. The Russian winger is still on his ELC but showed promise and chemistry with Macklin Celebrini, recording 19 points in 28 games. The Sharks' selection of Ivar Stenberg could push Chernyshov further down fantasy draft boards, making him a strong late-round target.

Logan Cooley, C, Mammoth

Cooley is the young star leading the charge in Utah. He opened the season with 23 points in 26 games before suffering a brutal injury that caused him to miss 28 outings, but he finished strong with 13 points in his final 10 contests. At just 22 years old, he should develop into a point-per-game player moving forward.

Jack Drury, C, Predators

When Chris MacFarland took the GM job in Nashville, he contacted his former employer and traded for players he believes can reshape the Predators. One of those players is Drury, whom MacFarland has called "one of the best defensive forwards" in the league. After acquiring him from Colorado, management handed Drury a hefty \$22.5 million contract. With that level of investment, he should receive plenty of opportunities and significant ice time to justify the deal.

Brendan Gallagher, RW, Canucks

The BC native is back with his hometown team, and this is a complete dart throw because the move could motivate him to push himself and re-live some of those prime Montreal days. The Canucks are also projected to be a lottery team, so he has an opportunity to earn top-six minutes and contribute in deeper fantasy leagues.

Emil Hemming, RW, Stars

The Stars have done an excellent job drafting and developing talent, and Hemming looks to be next in line. Mavrik Bourque was a cap casualty, and depending on what happens with Jason Robertson's contract, Dallas will need prospects on entry-level deals to step in and contribute. Hemming will have the first shot at replacing Bourque, and we could easily see another 20-goal scorer emerge in Dallas.

Dylan Holloway, LW, Blues

Holloway had a rough start to 2025 as he battled multiple injuries, but once he was fully healthy after the Olympic break, he went on a rampage. He is a multi-category stud and is entering only his third full NHL season. He, Robert Thomas, and Jimmy Snuggerud formed the hottest line to end the season. The trio should pick up right where they left off.

Alex Laferriere, RW, Kings

Laferriere was the Kings' Swiss Army knife last season, playing up and down the lineup and at all three forward positions. Aside from Mats Zuccarello, Los Angeles did not acquire any major pieces in the offseason, focusing mostly on depth. Laferriere will look to build off a career year, and with no established 2C on the roster, he may be first in line to audition for that role.

Mason Marchment, LW, Sharks

Want to hear something funny? Marchment is the highest-paid forward on the Sharks. The youngsters remain on their ELC contracts for another year, but management gave Marchment a sizeable deal to bring grit and tenacity to their skill group. He can play anywhere in the lineup and is bound to skate with players who can feed him the puck.

Connor McMichael, LW/C, Blues

One of the key pieces acquired when the Blues sent Jordan Kyrou to Washington, McMichael also secured a six-year contract from St. Louis this offseason. The Blues ended the year on a heater after Robert Thomas returned from injury, and while it seems unlikely that they break up the Holloway/Thomas/Jimmy Snuggerud line that registered 88 points in their final 23 games, the Blues have Dalibor Dvorsky and Mason McTavish, either of whom could help push McMichael over the top.

Frank Nazar, C, Blackhawks

With Connor Bedard expected to miss at least four months due to recent shoulder surgery, Nazar should be thrust into extra minutes. The former first-rounder is on a point-per-game trajectory and should easily outperform his ADP this fall. Bedard will be out until at least November, making Nazar Chicago's top pivot for roughly a quarter of the season.

Simon Nemec, D, Flames

GM Craig Conroy acquired Nemec from New Jersey over the summer and signed him to a significant contract. It's an interesting move because the Flames already have Zayne Parekh as the heir to top power-play minutes, but Nemec is expected to receive top-pairing minutes at even strength plus special-team usage. The Flames' roster isn't particularly appealing, but someone has to produce points. Nemec will have the puck on his stick constantly, moving it out of the zone and trying to generate offense.

Victor Olofsson, RW, Golden Knights

The Golden Knights traded away their leading goal scorer from the previous two seasons when they sent Pavel Dorofeyev to the NY Rangers. Vegas is looking to replace at least some of those goals, and this is Olofsson's second stint with the franchise, suggesting management sees a potential fit.

Isak Rosen, RW, Jets

Rosen was acquired at last year's trade deadline and then given even less ice time than he had in Buffalo. After a full offseason in the Jets organization, the former first-rounder should receive more opportunity in 2026-27, especially if Winnipeg trades Connor Hellebuyck and shifts its focus toward the future.

Jaden Schwartz, RW, Avalanche

Schwartz fits perfectly into a veteran Avalanche lineup after the team dealt Val Nichushkin to Columbus over the summer. He averaged more than half a point per game on mediocre Seattle teams, and now joins an Avs roster full of high-end talent and scoring chances. If he lands on Nathan MacKinnon's line or the top power-play unit, he could return to the 60-point production he posted during his years in St. Louis.

Beckett Sennecke, RW, Ducks

Not necessarily a sleeper—he had a strong rookie season and will likely be drafted in all leagues—but he's absolutely a player who should outperform his ADP. Troy Terry will start the year on the shelf after offseason hip surgery, leaving plenty of minutes available during the first two to three months. Additionally, Cutter Gauthier remained unsigned in late July and the Ducks hadn't not moved out a contract to clear cap space (likely a winger), which could open even more opportunity for Sennecke to rack up points.

Danila Yurov, RW, Wild

After the Wild's top line and top two defensemen, the roster is filled with players who profile more like third-liners. Yurov spent a stretch last season skating alongside Kirill Kaprizov, and with Vlad Tarasenko and Mats Zuccarello departing, the opportunity is there for Yurov to establish himself as Kaprizov's new running mate—and potentially his best one yet.

Lucas Main pens 'The Wild West' every Monday and 'Lining Up' every Tuesday on DobberHockey.com

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2026 DRAFT PICKS: WHAT TO EXPECT?

By Jordan Harris

There can be some big differences between NHL Draft rankings, the actual NHL Draft results and fantasy hockey lists. Using the actual Draft results is a good starting point when preparing for your fantasy draft, but from there, you need to do some research.

Things you want to take into consideration should be your league format, scoring, roster requirements, and prospect depth. How long are players projected from being in the NHL, is it four to five years, as of this year, or the next? Does your pool only tabulate goals and assists, or do you include peripherals like Hits and blocked shots? What are your team's positional needs? This ranking will save you some time and help prioritize your list.

1. Gavin McKenna, W, Maple Leafs

McKenna has the highest point-production upside of any player from the 2026 NHL Draft, both in terms of skill and organizational fit. He should work his way into Toronto's top six and onto PP1 almost immediately, playing alongside star or superstar talent such as Auston Matthews, John Tavares, William Nylander, or Matthew Knies. From a fantasy perspective, there may not be a more favorable situation for a prospect to enter.

Upside: 10.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2026-27

2. Ivar Stenberg, W, Sharks

Stenberg will play in North America this season after cutting ties with his Swedish club, Frolunda. The question now is whether he'll suit up as a Shark or an AHL Barracuda. Stenberg projects as a future top-of-the-lineup player on a team that already boasts the NHL's best young talent in Macklin Celebrini. Even better for Stenberg, a hole has opened at LW with William Eklund's departure, giving him a chance to make an impact sooner rather than later.

Upside: 9.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2026-27

3. Chase Reid, D, Kraken

Reid joins a Kraken organization that had never previously selected a defenseman in the first round, meaning he'll be given every opportunity to become "the guy" in Seattle. He has top-pairing upside and is the clear favorite to eventually run PP1 for the Kraken. He will likely play one year of college hockey before turning pro.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2027-28

4. Caleb Malhotra, C, Canucks

Malhotra doesn't possess the same point ceiling as Gavin McKenna or Ivar Stenberg, but he should have no difficulty producing at a top-six level. He instantly becomes Vancouver's top prospect and should log heavy minutes and power-play time once he reaches the NHL. Expect him to spend one or two seasons in the NCAA before turning pro.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2027-28

5. Viggo Bjorck, C, Jets

Like Ivar Stenberg, Bjorck will not return to Sweden this season, meaning he could push for NHL games as early as 2026-27. He is extremely skilled and an excellent playmaker who compensates for his lack of size. Bjorck enters a great situation, joining a team with established stars such as Kyle Connor and Mark Scheifele while also projecting as a potential future cornerstone of the next iteration of the Jets.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2026-27

6. Wyatt Cullen, W, Predators

Cullen is both a skilled goal scorer and playmaker, making him Nashville's most offensively gifted prospect. He should have no trouble carving out a top-six role once he's NHL-ready. He projects as a future PP1 half-wall option who can rack up significant production both on the power play and at even strength. His timeline may be slightly longer than others ahead of him on this list, but once he arrives—and once the Predators progress further into their rebuild—he could become a major force.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

7. Nikita Klepov, W, Ducks

Like the player below him, Klepov had top-10 talent but fell in the draft because his game needs more refinement. He joins a highly favorable situation in Anaheim, a team already featuring star or future-star players such as Leo Carlsson, Cutter Gauthier, and Beckett Sennecke, giving him plenty of skilled linemates. He doesn't need to be an all-situations player for the Ducks and should be able to carve out a role as a pure point producer. The only hesitation is that Anaheim selected two other highly skilled wingers (Marcus Nordmark and Mathis Preston) in the 2026 Draft who could become fantasy handcuffs if they also hit.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

8. J.P. Hurlbert, W, Red Wings

Hurlbert does present some NHL projection concerns, as he occasionally plays a style more suited to junior hockey. However, if his offensive game translates, he could become a dual-threat point producer. He joins a team with a strong foundation of young players and prospects but lacking a true offensive game-breaker outside of Lucas Raymond. There is some risk in his projection, but Hurlbert could become that player.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

9. Tynan Lawrence, C, Blues

Lawrence has elite speed and produced extremely well at the USHL level. He isn't ranked higher due to mixed results after joining Boston University for the second half of last season. He has 1C potential, even if he's more likely to settle as a 2C. The Blues are quietly assembling a deep prospect pool, which should give Lawrence plenty of skilled teammates to play with as he develops.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

10. Oscar Hemming, W, Blue Jackets

Hemming lands on this list for the same reason as Tynan Lawrence: he could have ranked higher had things gone more smoothly in the NCAA. He is a big, skilled goal scorer who plays a power game and could eventually become the trigger man on an NHL power play. If he reaches his potential, he should develop into a top-six winger. Columbus has a strong track record of developing large wingers who can score, which bodes well for Hemming's future.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2027-28

11. Alberts Smits, D, Rangers

Smits doesn't have the same offensive ceiling as Chase Reid, but he still projects as an NHL producer. What earns him a spot on this list is his top-pairing potential and the possibility of logging 25 minutes a night next to Adam Fox. Smits could see NHL action as early as late 2026-27 before joining the Rangers full-time in 2027-28.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2026-27

12. Carson Carels, D, Flames

Like Alberts Smits, Carels is unlikely to become a PP1 quarterback, but he has long-term top-pairing potential in Calgary. He still carries offensive upside, having posted strong numbers in the WHL this past season, and he projects as a future 20-plus-minute NHL defenseman. His performance at North Dakota will be telling—whether he becomes a 40-point player or pushes into the 55-plus range will be the key question.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2027-28

13. Keaton Verhoeff, D, Sharks

Both Sharks defensemen (Ryan Lin being the other) appear lower on this list than they would have if only one had been selected early in the 2026 Draft. Verhoeff and Lin both have PP1 quarterback upside and lean heavily toward offense. Verhoeff is the better shooting threat and more opportunistic finisher, with legitimate 20-goal potential if everything breaks right. From a fantasy standpoint, he and Lin handcuff each other significantly, even though both are excellent blue-line talents.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2027-28

14. Ryan Lin, D, Sharks

Lin is a more cerebral playmaker than Keaton Verhoeff and, despite his size, projects as someone who can handle big minutes while producing strong offensive totals. Whoever emerges as the Sharks' top power-play defenseman will have an embarrassment of riches to work with—Macklin Celebrini, Will Smith, Michael Misa, Ivar Stenberg, and more.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

15. Ethan Belchetz, W, Mammoth

Belchetz is a massive power winger who can score from anywhere. He does have pace issues that may limit his ceiling, but his size, hands, and shot give him legitimate 30-goal potential. He'll head to college for a year or two and may spend time in the AHL before reaching the NHL. Fortunately for him, Utah is loaded with talented forwards, so he should have no trouble playing with teammates who can get him the puck.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

16. Xavier Villeneuve, D, Blackhawks

Villeneuve carries significant risk, as elements of his game may not translate to the NHL. But if he overcomes those concerns, he has major offensive upside. He was the most offensively gifted defenseman in the 2026 Draft yet fell to the second round. He joins a team with Connor Bedard, Anton Frondell, and several strong young players and prospects, which would normally give him sky-high fantasy potential. However, Chicago traded heavily for Bowen Byram and signed him for \$12.5M per year, making the latter the likely PP1 quarterback of the future. That contract puts a clear cap on Villeneuve's fantasy outlook.

Upside: 9.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2029-30

17. Jonas Lagerberg-Hoen, F, Senators

Lagerberg-Hoen is a true wildcard. He was an older player in Sweden's J20 league and dominated, but he played only nine games before suffering a season-ending injury. He has excellent size, speed, and a heavy shot. He joins an NHL team with tremendous center depth that badly needs high-end wing talent, making the fit extremely promising. If his development stays on track, he could find himself in Ottawa's top six and on PP1 in a few years. The risk lies in the time he has already missed due to injury.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

18. Tommy Bleyl, D, Predators

Bleyl is another 2026 Predators draft pick to appear on this list—Wyatt Cullen being the other. He's a dynamic puck-moving defenseman who can run a top power-play unit as a high-end distributor. If he reaches his ceiling, he could produce huge assist totals at the NHL level. There is risk in his profile—he's not a strong defender and may struggle with the transition to the NHL—but the upside is worth betting on. He joins a Predators prospect pool that lacked a player with his skill set, putting him on the inside track for favorable offensive minutes once he arrives.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2029-30

19. Elton Hermansson, W, Kings

Hermansson was excellent value at the spot where the Kings selected him. He's a dual-threat winger who has already produced at Sweden's second-tier pro level as a 17-year-old. Los Angeles doesn't have a deep prospect pool, so he should have a clear path to top-six minutes once he reaches the NHL. He projects as an NHLer within a couple of years.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

20. Mathis Preston, W, Ducks

Preston is a highly talented winger with exceptional speed and skill. On talent alone, he could have been selected in the top 10–15. However, inconsistency and injuries led to a draft-day slide. Preston has the tools to become a high-end NHL scorer if everything comes together. The challenge is that he faces an uphill battle to secure a full-time role, and Anaheim drafted two other skilled wingers—Nikita Klepov and Marcus Nordmark—who could become fantasy handcuffs. He will need to outperform both to carve out a big role on an ascending Ducks team, which places him lower on this list.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2029-30

21. Adam Novotny, W, Canucks

Novotny doesn't have the same raw skill as some others on this list, but he plays a highly complementary game that fits in any situation. He does many of the little things right and owns a strong shot. He could easily work his way onto a top line in a Zach Hyman-type role. Playing with talented teammates and earning preferred minutes—even without being the primary driver—still carries significant fantasy value.

Upside: 8.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

22. Tobias Trejbal, G, Flames

Goalies are always wildcards and take time to reach the NHL, but when one hits, the value is enormous. Trejbal was the best goalie in the 2026 Draft and has legit starter upside. Like all goalies, he'll need time to develop, but his timeline aligns well with Calgary's rebuild. By the time he's NHL-ready, the Flames' toughest years should be behind them.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2030-31

23. Ryan Roobroeck, W, Blackhawks

Roobroeck is another player who fell in the draft due to consistency issues. He's a big, dual-threat winger who could eventually play in a very talented future top six in Chicago. There is risk in his projection—pace, compete level, and consistency—but any player with a realistic chance to earn top-six and power-play minutes on a team featuring Connor Bedard, Anton Frondell, Frank Nazar, and others is a worthwhile fantasy gamble.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2029-30

24. Tomas Galvas, D, Penguins

Galvas was a double re-entry who finally heard his name called on his third attempt. He's an undersized offensive defenseman who has already produced at a high level in Czechia's pro league. There are legitimate concerns about his NHL projection, but his success in professional hockey reduces some of the risk. If he hits, he carries power-play upside on a team that will eventually need to replace Erik Karlsson and Kris Letang.

Upside: 8.5 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2028-29

25. Adam Valentini, C/W, Mammoth

It was surprising to see Valentini fall to pick 96, but he lands with a team built for future success in Utah. He's a very skilled center who will likely shift to the wing due to his size and Utah's center depth. Valentini brings a different offensive profile compared to other Utah wingers such as Ethan Belchetz and Daniil But, making him a potentially strong complementary top-six piece if he reaches his ceiling.

Upside: 8.0 — **Likely 1st NHL game:** 2029-30

Jordan Harris is Head of North American Scouting at DobberProspects.com





CALDER CANDIDATES

By Puneet Sharma

The Calder Trophy is one of the NHL's most prestigious individual awards, recognizing the league's top rookie and often marking the beginning of a standout career. That path starts long before a player reaches the NHL, with years of development in junior hockey, college, or overseas. Forwards usually have the edge since offensive production is the easiest way to stand out, while defensemen and goalies need truly exceptional seasons to enter the conversation.

The race is notoriously unpredictable, and while Gavin McKenna and Porter Martone enter the season as the early frontrunners, it wouldn't be shocking to see Anton Frondell, Roman Kantserov, or Cole Hutson tighten the battle far more than expected.

To be eligible for the Calder, there are a few requirements to be met. Here are the top 25 Calder nominees.

(Listed alphabetically)

Artur Akhtyamov, G, Maple Leafs

Akhtyamov is coming off a breakout year, leading the AHL Toronto Marlies to the 2026 Calder Cup while earning the Jack A. Butterfield Trophy as Playoff MVP. He posted a respectable 2.88 GAA and 0.904 save percentage in 37 regular-season games before signing a three-year extension through 2028–29. With Sergei Bobrovsky and Anthony Stolarz ahead of him, regular NHL starts will be hard to come by. Still, Akhtyamov has established himself as Toronto's next man up and would likely be the first goalie recalled if injuries create an opportunity.

Ethan Belchetz, LW, Mammoth

Belchetz is a physically dominant winger who has shown flashes of being a true difference-maker, but consistency and injuries have slowed his development. His ability to win battles, protect pucks, and make quicker plays along the wall will be key to unlocking his upside. While his skating can look heavy at times, he has the size, skill, and shot to create offense once he gets moving. The big question is where he fits with a crowded Mammoth forward group. He may need more seasoning before he reaches the Mammoth, but his ceiling remains that of a potential top-six power winger.

Viggo Bjorck, C, Jets

Bjorck is a highly-skilled, intelligent, and competitive playmaking center who has consistently produced at every level, including record-setting seasons in Sweden's junior ranks before earning a first-line role in the SHL at just 17 years old. Despite his smaller frame, he's strong on pucks, excels in the faceoff circle, and plays with impressive detail in all situations. His vision, poise, and creativity make him a natural facilitator, while his quick skating and agility allow him to create space and attack defenders. He processes the game at an advanced level and projects as a dynamic top-six offensive center.

Braeden Cootes, C, Canucks

Cootes is a smart, reliable two-way pivot who has earned the trust of coaches with his compete level, work ethic, and all-around game. He skates well, plays with energy, kills penalties, and drives play at even strength. He has a knack for finding open ice, winning battles, and creating plays in key areas. While his offensive upside may limit his chances of becoming a true top-six forward, he projects as a dependable top-nine NHL center. On the Canucks, he may see time higher up the lineup in small spurts.

Caleb Desnoyers, C, Mammoth

Desnoyers signed a three-year entry-level contract with Utah after a strong season with the QMJHL Moncton Wildcats, scoring 22 goals and 78 points in 45 games. The path to an NHL roster spot could be difficult after Utah matched Barrett Hayton's offer sheet and added Vincent Trocheck, creating more competition for lineup spots. If

Desnoyers does not make the team out of camp, the new AHL eligibility rule for 19-year-old first-round picks could provide the best development path.

Cole Eiserman, LW, Islanders

Eiserman is one of the most dangerous pure goal scorers outside the NHL. He can score from virtually anywhere, making him a constant offensive threat whether it's off the rush, on a one-timer, or in tight around the net. While questions remain about his decision-making and tendency to force plays, he showed progress in big games last season with Boston University. He's also more competitive than he often gets credit for, consistently battling for pucks and applying pressure on the forecheck. If he continues to round out his game, Eiserman has legitimate top-line, high-end scoring upside.

Victor Eklund, RW, Islanders

Eklund checks a lot of boxes as a prospect, combining high-end hockey sense, skill, and skating with an outstanding compete level. He plays with pace, wins battles, finishes checks, and consistently makes effort plays that drive results. His puck skills, vision, and quick release allow him to create offense in a variety of ways, while his instincts make him effective in all situations. Despite his smaller frame, he has the tools to develop into a top-six NHL winger. The next step is turning more of his offensive chances into goals.

Jacob Fowler, G, Canadiens

The Habs may once again begin the season with three goaltenders on the roster as the battle between Sam Montembeault, Jakub Dobes, and Fowler remains unsettled. The latter took advantage of his opportunity last season, posting a 9-6-2 record with a 2.43 GAA and 0.908 SV% in 17 games. With Dobes also pushing for NHL time after signing a new contract, Fowler's path is not guaranteed. At just 21 years old, the Canadiens could still choose an AHL assignment for development, but if Fowler secures the job, he has the talent to make an impact.

Anton Frondell, C, Blackhawks

Frondell likely would have opened as one of the Calder favorites had Connor Bedard been healthy, but he remains firmly in the top-five conversation. After scoring 20 goals and adding eight assists in 43 SHL games, he has shown he has the tools to become a high-impact top-six center. His scoring instincts, NHL-ready frame, and pro experience should help ease the transition to North America. Any chance of starting the season in AHL Rockford became much less likely with Bedard sidelined until mid-November, creating an immediate opportunity for Frondell to earn a full-time role with the Hawks from opening night.

James Hagens, C/LW, Bruins

Hagens is the player Bruins fans are most excited to see arrive. The former Boston College standout posted 23 goals and 45 points in 33 games last season while earning a Hobey Baker nomination. Hagens continues to show why he is viewed as one of the most dynamic playmakers in college hockey. After getting a brief taste of NHL action late last season, he enters his first full professional campaign with plenty of hype. If he earns a significant role, Hagens has all the tools to be a serious Calder Trophy contender.

Konsta Helenius, C, Sabres

The Sabres made few changes to their forward group this offseason, but moving on from Alex Tuch creates a major shift in the lineup and opens the door for Helenius. After a strong playoff debut and a gold-medal performance with Finland at the 2026 IIHF World Championship, Helenius enters the season with a legitimate opportunity to earn a top-six or third-line center role. Often underrated in prospect rankings, his skill, maturity, and two-way game continue to stand out. If he secures consistent NHL minutes, Helenius has the potential to become a serious Calder candidate.

Cole Hutson, D, Capitals

Hutson has made a strong first impression since signing his entry-level contract with the Capitals, quickly showing why he is considered one of the organization's top defensive prospects. Washington burned the first year of his deal, and Hutson rewarded them with five points in his first five NHL games late last season, all on the power play. His offensive upside should be no surprise after posting 80 points in 74 games at Boston University over two seasons. However, with Jakob Chychrun ahead of him on the top power-play unit, expectations should be tempered, but Hutson still remains a top Calder candidate.

Tij Iginla, C, Mammoth

The sixth overall pick in 2024 and one of the most exciting prospects in hockey, Iginla is tracking as a future top-six forward thanks to his combination of pace, physicality, and elite scoring ability. With the WHL Kelowna Rockets, he posted 41 goals and 90 points in 48 games, showcasing his offensive upside. Iginla will compete for a spot with the Mammoth this season, but despite the opportunity, a bottom-six depth role is the more realistic outcome. Expect him to spend most of the year in the AHL with the Tucson Roadrunners continuing his development before making a full-time NHL push.

Roman Kantserov, RW, Blackhawks

Kantserov is one of the more intriguing prospects in the Blackhawks system, coming off a dominant KHL season in which he scored 36 goals and 64 points in 63 games while leading the league in goals. Despite his smaller frame, he has the skill, creativity, and offensive instincts to make an impact every time he steps on the ice. His combination of elite production, relentless motor, and ability to create plays gives him legitimate top-six upside. Projected as a top-line winger, Kantserov is a prospect dynasty managers should be targeting.

Fabian Lysell, RW, Avalanche

Lysell was acquired by the Avalanche in a summer trade with Boston and signed a one-year contract for the upcoming season after posting 42 points (17 goals, 25 assists) in 57 games with the AHL Providence Bruins. The 23-year-old still has the skill set to become an impactful NHL forward, but improving his consistency and decision-making will determine how quickly he reaches that potential. With Colorado's veteran-heavy lineup, a regular NHL role may be difficult to find without injuries opening the door. Lysell has the talent, but his path to the Avalanche lineup remains uncertain.

Brady Martin, C, Predators

Martin cracked the Predators' opening-night roster last season, appearing in three NHL games and recording an assist before returning to the OHL Soo Greyhounds. He picked up right where he left off in junior, tallying eight goals and 24 points in 24 games. Martin's calling card is his relentless compete level, consistently winning battles and doing the little things coaches value. Nashville's veteran-heavy lineup creates a difficult path to a top-six role, making a middle-six spot the more realistic projection. Even so, he's in a strong position to earn another opening-night roster spot with the Preds.

Porter Martone, RW, Flyers

Right behind Gavin McKenna as a Calder Trophy favorite is Porter Martone. After joining the NHL late last season, Martone immediately made an impact with 10 points in nine games, including four power-play points and 36 shots on goal. He followed that up with five points in 10 playoff games while averaging over three minutes per game on the top unit. His deployment alone puts him in a great position heading into 2026-27, with a top-six and likely top-line role expected. Add in his skill set and offensive upside, and Martone has everything needed to be a serious Calder contender.

Gavin McKenna, LW, Maple Leafs

This one feels almost guaranteed, as McKenna should step into a top-six role and has a legitimate chance to start alongside Auston Matthews. The Leafs have been searching for a playmaking presence since Mitch Marner's departure, and McKenna has the skill set to help fill that void. Expectations will be extremely high, especially in Toronto, but the 19-year-old has the talent and offensive instincts to handle the pressure. With elite veteran talent around him, he enters the season as one of the Calder favorites and a candidate to make an immediate impact.

Roger McQueen, RW, Ducks

Making the jump from the WHL to the NCAA is challenging, and transitioning again to the AHL is an even bigger test. McQueen may not have put up eye-popping numbers at Providence College, but his 11 goals and 27 points in 36 games represented a strong first season. He added three points in seven games with the AHL San Diego Gulls and continued to take on more responsibility as the year progressed. McQueen should begin the season as a full-time AHLer, but if his development continues in the right direction, a few NHL call-ups could be possible.

Bradly Nadeau, RW, Hurricanes

After winning the Stanley Cup, the Hurricanes may not be looking to make major changes to a lineup that already found success. That raises the question: where does Nadeau fit in? Nadeau enjoyed an impressive rookie season with the AHL Chicago Wolves, scoring 32 goals and 58 points in 64 games. The challenge will be finding a path down the wing with Nik Ehlers, Andrei Svechnikov, Taylor Hall, Jackson Blake and Jordan Martinook already occupying wing roles. If Nadeau earns NHL time, it will likely be in a bottom-six role unless injuries open the door wider.

Sam O'Reilly, C, Lightning

O'Reilly is one of the OHL's most polished two-way forwards and plays a mature pro-style game. He excels at winning board battles, making smart plays under pressure, and creating space in the offensive zone. A natural center, he's a reliable faceoff man, aggressive on the penalty kill, and isn't afraid to block shots. While he may not possess elite offensive skill, his strong skating, hockey sense, and dependable all-around game project him as an effective middle-six center, with a long-term ceiling as a reliable third-line pivot on a dominant Tampa Bay lineup.

Ilya Protas, C, Capitals

At 6-6 and 225 pounds, Ilya Protas uses his size much like his brother Aliaksei, especially around the net where he can protect the puck, establish position, and create scoring chances. The 19-year-old broke out with the Hershey Bears, posting 48 points in 57 games while earning AHL All-Star honors. He now looks locked into Washington's lineup, although Alex Ovechkin's return pushes him down the depth chart behind his older brother and Alex Tuch. Still, Protas should see second-unit power-play time alongside strong offensive talent, giving him a chance to surprise and challenge other Calder candidates.

Alberts Smits, D, Rangers

He's one of the safest defensive prospects in the 2026 Draft class, and while he may not project as a high-end offensive producer, he's an efficient puck mover who can quarterback a power play and excels in transition. His physical edge, skating, and well-rounded game give him legitimate top-pair upside. Offensively, he attacks with confidence, creates off the rush, and owns a strong shot, giving him more upside if that part of his game continues to develop. Given his complete skill set, an NHL debut this season is a realistic possibility.

Ivar Stenberg, RW, Sharks

Stenberg signed his entry-level contract with the Sharks following the team's prospect scrimmage this summer and is expected to enter training camp with a legit chance to earn an NHL roster spot. Early reports suggest San Jose plans to give him a serious look, although nothing is guaranteed. If Stenberg cracks the lineup, his Calder Trophy upside becomes very intriguing, especially if he lands in a top-six role with consistent minutes alongside elite young talent like Macklin Celebrini, Will Smith, or Michael Misa. The opportunity is there, but earning that role will be the biggest challenge.

Carter Yakemchuk, D, Senators

Yakemchuk made an immediate impact in his NHL debut late last season, stepping into a lineup missing both Thomas Chabot and Jake Sanderson due to injuries. He took advantage of the opportunity and showed why he remains the Sens' top defensive prospect. His first AHL season in Belleville was another positive step, recording 36 points in 50 games as a 20-year-old defenseman adjusting to the pro level. All signs point to Yakemchuk opening the 2026-27 season in the NHL, likely in a depth role, but he has a legitimate opportunity to earn a full-time spot if he continues to develop.

Honorable Mentions:

Oliver Bonk, D (Flyers), Andrew Cristall, LW (Capitals), Zac Funk, RW (Sabres), Riley Heidt, C/LW (Wild), Caleb Malhotra, C (Canucks), Tanner Molendyk, D (Predators), Radim Mrtka, D (Sabres), Brayden Yager, C (Jets)

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ONE-WAY VS. TWO-WAY CONTRACTS

By Alexander MacLean

A largely overlooked detail in depth-contract signings is the one-way or two-way status. Players who can earn or negotiate their way to a one-way contract are far more likely to get a second look or an extended opportunity to prove themselves at the NHL level, and it signals that team management expects them to make an impact with the NHL club.

Many of the players listed below won't rise to fantasy stardom—or, in most cases, even to relevance in standard leagues. However, this is where you want to aim your late dart throws: players who have not just talent, but also the means and the opportunity.

The hits from this section tend to exceed expectations more than anywhere else. Breakout seasons in recent years from players such as Jet Greaves, Mason Marchment, and Mackie Samoskevich have been unearthed in this section. Let's see who emerges this time around.

(Listed alphabetically per section)

Michael DiPietro, G, Bruins

Cap Hit: \$812,500

DiPietro's impressive AHL season in 2025-26 led the Bruins to move out a quality NHL backup to make room for him. Jeremy Swayman should see around 60 games, but the 27-year-old DiPietro could be one of the best streaming options next year. Last season's numbers—1.91 GAA and 0.930 SV%—won't be repeated with the Bruins, but those are star-level goalie stats at any level.

Marc Gatcomb, RW, Golden Knights

Cap Hit: \$875,000

Looking for a dark horse to lead the league in Hits this year? Marc Gatcomb. He averaged 3.8 and 3.9 Hits per game in consecutive partial seasons with the Islanders, despite playing 10 minutes or less per night. If he gets a full season at the 12 minutes per game that Vegas' fourth line saw last year, he could surpass 400 Hits. Only three players topped 300 last season.

Stephen Halliday, C/LW, Senators

Cap Hit: \$1,075,000

The Sens are thin on scoring up front, and that's where some growth from Halliday could make a difference. The 24-year-old posted 11 points in 30 NHL games last year, plus 29 in 29 in the AHL. If he can become a 40-point middle-six player, he has a path to fantasy relevance—especially since the Sens have shown a willingness to give him power-play time.

Zachary L'Heureux, LW, Avalanche

Cap Hit: \$875,000

L'Heureux will never contend for a scoring title, but he appears locked into a fourth-line role with the Avalanche this season. He has averaged three Hits per game across his 87-game NHL career, along with heavy penalty minutes and respectable shot rates for a fourth-liner. His offense could peak with the Avs, given the increased offensive-zone starts he'll likely receive.

Alexander Holtz, RW, Golden Knights

Cap Hit: \$835,352

Holtz has been on the prospect radar for a while, though he's still only 24. He has produced well in the AHL and has played enough NHL games to be nearing his breakout threshold. That might only mean 45 points, but that still carries value as a third-line scorer who can raise the floor of a second power-play unit. He just needs an opportunity—and Vegas hasn't been the place for it.

Nikita Nesterenko, LW, Ducks

Cap Hit: \$837,500

Nesterenko's underlying numbers last season were extremely impressive. An IPP of 75% is excellent for any player, let alone someone lower in the lineup and often skating with more talented linemates. The soon-to-be-25-year-old suffered from terrible luck, including a 5-on-5 shooting percentage of just 7.5%. Combine that with a low secondary-assist rate, and you get a player who drives play himself and deserves more ice time.

Joel Nystrom, D, Hurricanes

Cap Hit: \$1,250,000

The Canes still have their top six defensemen under team control, but with Alexander Nikishin unsigned and circulating in trade rumors, they may be looking to create space for Nystrom. The right-shot blueliner would fit well in Carolina's system and looked the part in his 39 career NHL games. He doesn't bring much in the way of peripherals, but he produced a point every other game in the SHL during his age-21 and age-22 seasons, suggesting there is some scoring upside as well.

Jakob Pelletier, LW, Lightning

Cap Hit: \$875,000

Pelletier signed a three-year deal in 2025, with the final two seasons being one-way contracts. In the first year of that deal, he lit up the AHL as the team's leading scorer and earned All-Rookie Team honors. He is now one of 12 Lightning forwards on one-way contracts and waivers-exempt. Pelletier checks all the boxes here: scoring upside, contract security, and a clear path to a role on a scoring line.

Erik Portillo, G, Kings

Cap Hit: \$833,333

Portillo is in an unusual contractual situation: he's on a one-way deal, still waivers-exempt, and will become a UFA next year if he doesn't reach a minimum of 27 games played this season. For now, he's stuck behind two veteran, soon-to-be UFA in their mid-30s, but it would be difficult for LA to let him walk next summer. Portillo is worth monitoring for potential surprise volume paired with legitimate upside.

David Rittich, G, Devils

Cap Hit: \$1,000,000

Rittich wanted out from behind Ilya Sorokin, and Vitek Vanecek was happy to take the same contract and fill the vacancy with the NY Islanders. Both will earn \$1 million this year, but Rittich's numbers last season—on a comparable team—show he is the far superior goalie. Now he gets the chance to split starts for a potential playoff contender. He could provide both volume and strong peripherals this season.

Isak Rosen, LW, Jets

Cap Hit: \$925,000

Is there anyone more forgettable who could suddenly pop into fantasy relevance than a 14th-overall pick from five years ago who was traded to Winnipeg? Rosen's underlying numbers suggest he has deserved better puck luck so far. There isn't much competition for third-line minutes or second power-play time with the Jets, and his two-year, one-way deal indicates that's exactly how the front office expects things to unfold.

Riley Tufte, LW, Devils

Cap Hit: \$850,000

Tufte is a big-bodied forward who just crossed the 400-game threshold in professional hockey last season (AHL and NHL combined). At 28, he's not going to suddenly become a star, but he did put up 56 points in 64 AHL games while contributing Hits, PIM, and shot volume. A breakout to the tune of 35 NHL points plus peripherals would be surprising—but not without precedent based on his recent production.

Remaining Free Agents to Watch

If any of these players manage to secure a one-way contract, they should be worth monitoring for potential fantasy relevance:

Jonathan Drouin, LW, UFA

It feels odd to see such a longtime NHL regular on this list, but after a failed stint with the Islanders and Blues that ended in a buyout, Drouin's chances of landing a solid NHL deal are slim. He has had stretches of success alongside players like Nate MacKinnon and Bo Horvat, with whom he had prior chemistry. Maybe he finds a spot opposite Timo Meier or Nik Ehlers for one more shot, but as an "empty-calories" scoring winger, it's a tough sell.

Nikita Grebenkin, RW, RFA — Flyers

Grebenkin has spent the summer rehabbing an injury while also navigating contract negotiations. With the Flyers' opening-night roster essentially set—and Grebenkin unlikely to be healthy for October—a two-way deal is very possible. A one-way contract, however, would signal that the organization views him as a present-day contributor who should make an impact once he's up to speed.

Connor Ingram, G, UFA

Ingram rebuilt some of his value with the Oilers last season after a long journey managing OCD and depression. Most tandems are already set, but teams have increasingly carried a third goalie, and a one-way deal would indicate he's expected to share the load. Sometimes all a goalie needs is an opportunity to run with.

Vincent Iorio, D, RFA — Rangers

Iorio's numbers have fluctuated throughout his development, and with seven healthy defensemen already signed, the Rangers may not have room for him regardless of contract type. A one-way deal here might simply be a cap-rich team trying to reduce the risk of losing him on waivers. His seven assists in six AHL games last season look more like a blip than a sign of things to come.

Arthur Kaliyev, RW, UFA

Kaliyev has dealt with his share of on- and off-ice issues over the past few years, but his calling card remains goal scoring. After potting 40 in the AHL last season, 25 in a full NHL year doesn't seem out of reach—he just needs consistent NHL ice time to get there. At 25, the clock is ticking.

John Klingberg, D, UFA

Once one of fantasy hockey's premier offensive defensemen, injuries and declining foot speed have turned Klingberg into more of a risk than an asset. He still has puck skills and could be useful in the right situation, but it would take a perfect fit to bring him back to fantasy relevance. Among the players on this FA list, though, his potential usefulness might be the highest.

Jacob Melanson, RW, UFA

If Marc Gatcomb doesn't excite you as a dark-horse Hits leader, Melanson and his 5.22 Hits per game might—especially considering he did that in just 9:22 of ice time per night. Using the same math as Gatcomb, he could surpass 550 Hits in a full season. His underlying numbers show he was an effective checking-line forward last year, giving him value for many teams.

Pavol Regenda, LW, UFA

Regenda is looking to prove he's more than a flash in the pan after scoring nine goals in 24 games with the Sharks last season. The 26-year-old also has a deft passing touch and brings physicality, averaging over two Hits per game despite limited minutes. He was an excellent fill-in last year and can provide points and peripherals if he gets another shot.

Mike Reilly, D, UFA

After returning from surgery to correct a congenital heart defect, Reilly provided reasonable depth scoring for the Hurricanes when they ran six defensemen—though he struggled in games with lower ice time. His underlying numbers were solid, and he remains a viable injury fill-in for teams needing a PP2 option. When playing regularly, he generally settles into the 20–30-point range.

In Smith's case, it's about getting a contract at all at this point rather than specifically looking for a one-way deal. Last season in Vegas, Smith saw his ice time and scoring drop, but that can be more than explained by bad luck and reduced usage, while his possession and play-driving metrics remain solid. He can still put up 40-plus points next year in the right situation.

ADVANCED STATS
EXPECTED GOALS (xG)
PLAYER USAGE CHARTS
GAME LOGS
LINE COMBOS
NHL EDGE REPORTS
GOALIE STEALS
GOALIE PREVENTABLE LOSSES
AHL LINE COMBOS
HOT/COLD REPORTS
SCHEDULE PLANNER
DFS TOOLS
POWER PLAY DATA
GOAL TYPES
FACEOFFS
HITS & BLOCKS
CORSI/FENWICK
PNHLe
PDO (LUCK)
TEAM STRENGTHS
GOALIE PROJECTIONS
DYNASTY RANKINGS
SEASON STATS
HISTORICAL DATA
GOALIE RATINGS
GOAL TYPES
FESTIVE FRANCHISES
GOALIE PROJECTIONS
CAREER PROJECTIONS
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OUTLIERS

By Rick Roos

When it comes to predicting a player's fantasy performance for the upcoming season, there is a trove of information available, especially in this invaluable guide. Much of it can be taken at face value, which is great. Some highly informative data, though, not only lies farther beneath the surface but also does not fit within expected patterns. Enter outliers.

An outlier is a player—or team—whose stats departed from the norm enough to have caused atypical results that might not otherwise stand out as being “abnormal.” Identifying outliers, as well as determining whether—and, if so, to what extent—they should be valued higher or lower than predicted due to their outlying status, is helpful information, particularly for drafting, trading, and keeper decisions. It can serve as a tiebreaker between two similar players when, for example, one was an outlier but the other was not.

Below are outliers based on certain 2025–26 statistics and criteria, plus a look back at how 2024–25 outliers fared in 2025–26 to help determine the weight that should be placed on a player's outlying status. Also, at the end, there will be a list of players who, due to the extent to which they—and/or their teams—were outliers, might have their 2026–27 projections raised or lowered accordingly.

PART 1: FORWARDS

Overall ice time and scoring

In 2025–26, a total of 139 forwards (up from 130 in 2024–25) played in at least half their team's games while producing at a 50-point or better scoring pace (i.e., 0.61+ points per game). Of the 139, though, a total of 14—more than double the six from 2024–25—did so despite not also averaging 16:00+ TOI per game:

- Anthony Mantha (0.79 points per game, 15:11 TOI per game)
- Victor Arvidsson (0.78, 14:36)
- Josh Norris (0.77, 15:50)
- Ivan Demidov (0.76, 15:30)
- Jason Zucker (0.73, 15:37)
- Zach Benson (0.66, 15:53)
- Marcus Johansson (0.65, 15:25)
- Jordan Kyrrou (0.64, 15:44)
- Josh Doan (0.63, 15:52)
- Vladimir Tarasenko (0.63, 14:56)
- Matvei Michkov (0.63, 14:50)
- Jack Quinn (0.62, 15:39)
- Tyler Toffoli (0.62, 14:58)
- Kaapo Kakko (0.62, 14:15)

Looking back at the list of players from 2024–25, those over 30 (Jamie Benn, Mason Marchment) saw small dips in production, as did Nicolaj Ehlers, while Patrik Laine missed most of the season. Younger players had mixed results, as Cole Perfetti fared worse, but Will Smith achieved large gains. The takeaway is that if a forward is an up-and-comer, this may be a stepping stone to better things, whereas otherwise expectations should be more of the same or slight regression.

That bodes well for Demidov and Michkov, while Zucker, Johansson, Tarasenko (if signed), Arvidsson, and Toffoli are unlikely to see gains but also are not major risks of being much less productive. Mantha, fresh off signing a UFA deal with New Jersey and having been quite productive early in his career before injuries took their toll, should receive ample opportunity to replicate his 2025–26 bounce-back if—big if—he stays healthy. Kyrrou gets a fresh start with Washington, and he had been a very dependable fantasy asset, so banking on a return to form seems reasonable. For Kakko, despite lofty expectations, it is now safe to say he is no better than a point-per-every-other-game guy.

The other four are young Sabres forwards, where, although Alex Tuch is now gone, there is still a logjam. Who could step up? Benson's new deal makes him and Norris considerably higher paid than the other two, but that does not always lead to "favored son" status, especially where, like here, there are other viable options, also including Peyton Krebs. Plus, look at what happened with JJ Peterka in Utah and Mason McTavish in Anaheim. In short, it might be difficult for any of the four to truly break out; and since no one has a crystal ball, plus things worked so well in 2025–26 with a balanced approach, resist the urge to overrate any of them.

What about the flipside, i.e., forwards who were minute eaters yet did not produce well? The 2025–26 season saw 268 (barely down from 270 in 2024–25) play in 41+ games while averaging under 0.61 points per game. How many scored below a 50-point pace (i.e., under 0.61 points per game) despite averaging 18:00+ per contest? Only five, which was down from seven in 2024–25:

- Anze Kopitar (19:07 TOI per game, 0.57 points per game)
- Timo Meier (18:31, 0.57)
- Alex Laferriere (18:19, 0.54)
- Dawson Mercer (18:14, 0.51)
- Jonathan Huberdeau (18:08, 0.50)

How did the seven from 2024–25 fare in 2025–26? Five (Pavel Zacha, Zach Hyman, Alexander Wennberg, Palmieri, and Elias Lindholm) had double-digit scoring-rate gains, while the other two, Matty Beniers and Mikael Backlund, also improved. So, things bode well for Meier, Laferriere, Mercer, and Huberdeau in 2026–27. Laferriere hit his 200-game breakout threshold late in 2025–26, finishing with 16 points in 21 games and a spike in TOI per game; plus, with Kopitar retired, there is a top-six vacancy at center. Although the once-elite version of Huberdeau is almost assuredly not resurfacing, he is still better than the mere point-per-every-other-game player he was in 2025–26. Meier has now seen his scoring rate drop in four straight seasons, but his TOI improved for 2025–26, as did his SOG rate, so he is a good candidate for a bounce-back. As for Mercer, he is well past his 200-game breakout threshold yet has not found success despite that and opportunities galore. Still, if New Jersey has kept Mercer in the top six throughout his struggles, his spot is likely safe; and he has seen his TOI per game rise with each season, so he too might be due to see gains.

PP Ice time and scoring

Some forwards produced well despite not getting heaps of man-advantage minutes, while others took to the ice a lot on the PP but without ample PPPTs to show for it. Starting with the former, in 2025–26, a total of 100 (down slightly from 102 in 2024–25) tallied 15+ PPPTs. But whereas seven did so in 2024–25 despite fewer than 200 PP minutes and averaging 2:20 or less per game on the PP, just one (Luke Evangelista) met both criteria for 2025–26, as many who failed to hit 200 PP minutes only did so because of missed games. So, looking at forwards who were at 200+ PP minutes but under 3:00 PPTOI per game and played 70+ games, there is Evangelista (81 games, 17 PPPTs, 171:26 PPTOI, 2:10 PPTOI per game), plus Pavel Buchnevich (81, 15, 193:33, 2:23) and Alexis Lafreniere (82, 16, 198:29, 2:25).

How did those who made the 2024–25 list fare? Only Pavel Dorofeyev improved, while younger players thought to be on the rise (Logan Cooley, Cole Perfetti), one usually a safe bet to produce well (Jordan Kyrou), and four for whom there were question marks (Barrett Hayton, Stefan Noesen, Michael Bunting) all did worse. Seeing those names and their fates, Buchnevich most closely correlates to Kyrou, which is concerning, although ironically the exodus of Kyrou might be what Buchnevich needs to rebound, unless Connor McMichael is the beneficiary instead. One may be tempted to put Evangelista in the same bucket as Hayton or Perfetti, but he took major strides as he was hitting his 200-game breakout threshold; so, despite all the forwards added by the Preds, he might be to 2026–27 what Dorofeyev was for 2025–26. And Laffy makes the list due mainly to struggling in the first three quarters, as in Q4 alone he totaled nine PPPTs and averaged 3:38 PPTOI per game, suggesting he does not really belong here.

Looking at the other end of the spectrum, a total of 77 forwards (up quite a bit from 64 in 2024–25 but still lower than the 82 in 2023–24) logged 220+ PP minutes in 2025–26. But only four of the 77 failed to tally 15 PPPTs:

- Brayden Point (11 PPPTs, 238:22 PPTOI)
- Adrian Kempe (12 PPPTs, 248:27 PPTOI)
- Sam Bennett (14 PPPTs, 247:04 PPTOI)
- Oliver Bjorkstrand (14 PPPTs, 250:05 PPTOI)

How did the seven from 2024–25 fare in 2025–26? All saw their overall scoring rates rise. Does that mean these four will produce better in 2026–27? Seemingly yes. Point only made the list due to missing 19 games and remains a PP1 staple; and although his days of being a sure-fire 90+-point performer might be done, especially if

once again he is separated from superstar Nikita Kucherov at ES, it seems unlikely he will fail to exceed his 65-point scoring rate from 2025–26. Bennett is a tough call, as he received far more PP time due to Aleksander Barkov missing the entire season and Matthew Tkachuk the bulk of it; but Bennett had 11 and 12 PPPts in his two prior seasons, meaning he did not see a major boost, plus he has proven chemistry with Tkachuk, such that a full season with the two together, plus Florida having the makings of an offensive juggernaut, might be a net benefit to Bennett even if his PPTOI falls. For Kempe, seeing how few PPPts he had despite maintaining his 2024–25 overall scoring rate is impressive and bodes well for him to see gains. Bjorkstrand had been a solid scorer, but after two down seasons he only received a one-year \$4.5M UFA deal from New York, likely translating to a middle-six, PP2 role. He could be reinvigorated if put into a position to succeed, but most likely he will not rise again to prior levels and could even fare worse, à la what happened to Andre Burakovsky.

SOG and Goal / PPG scoring

There were instances of lots of SOG not translating to many goals, but also low-volume shooters lighting the lamp plenty. Starting with the selective shooters, of the 77 forwards (down from 89) who tallied 25+ goals for 2025–26, just six (down from nine in 2024–25) did not average 2+ SOG per game:

- Anthony Mantha (33 goals, 81 games, 152 SOG)
- Pavel Zacha (30, 78, 130)
- Gabe Vilardi (30, 82, 150)
- JJ Peterka (25, 82, 159)
- Ryan O'Reilly (25, 81, 154)
- Robert Thomas (25, 64, 102)

Those on the 2024–25 list included Vilardi, whose scoring rate was similar, suggesting he will remain a selective shooter and might not have another gear in terms of scoring rate. As for the other six, each saw a scoring-rate drop, with most being double digits. So, this is a list on which one does not want to find oneself. Most have pegged Mantha, Zacha, and O'Reilly to regress, so this lends support, although Mantha has a chance to buck the odds if—big if with him—he stays healthy. Peterka averaged barely below two SOG per game; plus, with Boston, he should go back to being prominently featured, although immediately returning to 70+-point production seems a stretch. Thomas landed above the two-SOG mark in 2023–24 and 2024–25 but had been at this low of a rate previously, including a season where his scoring rate was 87 points. So maybe Thomas does not surpass 90, but he also could avoid a scoring drop entirely.

As far as high-volume shooters who did not have ample goals to show for it, there was only one forward (Timo Meier) who averaged three or more SOG per game and scored 20 or more goals yet failed to tally one goal per every three contests, although very close was Clayton Keller. For 2024–25, two met all the criteria—namely Matt Boldy and Sam Bennett—and both did considerably better in 2025–26. That having been said, the two near misses from 2024–25 were Carter Verhaeghe and Meier, each of whom fared worse. With Meier making the list again after barely missing, yet seeing his downward trend in scoring rate continue, it could signify he has bottomed out and will improve, but with more modest gains than those of Boldy and Bennett. As for Keller, his 88 points is misleading, as he had 52 points in his last 40 games of 2025–26, so it seems like a virtual lock that he will finish well above a 90-point rate for 2026–27.

Shifting to SOG and the PP, 38 forwards (down sharply from 49 in 2024–25) had 10+ PPGs in 2025–26. Of those, five (one less than 2024–25) hit double digits despite firing fewer than 40 PPSOG:

- Ryan Nugent-Hopkins (11 PPGs, 36 PPSOG)
- Pavel Zacha (11 PPGs, 32 PPSOG)
- Brock Nelson (10 PPGs, 36 PPSOG)
- Jason Zucker (10 PPGs, 31 PPSOG)
- Zach Hyman (10 PPGs, 39 PPSOG)

What befell the six from 2024–25? Zucker was on the same list and saw his scoring pace stay the same despite the success of Buffalo's youth, so he should be fine for 2026–27, as should Gabe Vilardi, who has already been shown to be a selective shooter overall, plus had double-digit PPGs for a second straight season, legitimizing him as a PPG specialist. Tom Wilson was the only Caps forward who did better in 2025–26 than 2024–25, and Tyler Bertuzzi also achieved greater success versus 2024–25, meaning only Jonathan Huberdeau and Michael Bunting did worse from 2024–25 to 2025–26—in Bunting's case, barely. Thus, being on this list suggests improvement being more likely than not.

That counteracts other metrics pointing to Zacha doing worse, so perhaps it means his scoring rate will drop less than feared, if even at all. RNH rebounded from a very poor 2024–25 and, due to being on this list, might be in line for further gains in 2026–27, with the same being true for teammate Hyman. Nelson was the beneficiary of being on a PP1 featuring some of the best in the NHL; but in the playoffs, he was pushed off the top unit in favor of Nazem Kadri and/or Gabriel Landeskog. Also, the Avs were fifth-worst in PP percentage for 2025–26 with Nelson a PP1 fixture. Thus, even though Valeri Nichushkin is now gone, if everyone is healthy—big if with Landy—Nelson might be an odd man out for PP1 when 2026–27 comes, meaning he would buck the trend and do worse.

As for those who peppered the net on the PP, a total of 46 forwards tallied 50+ PPSOG, but that was a major decline from 63 in 2024–25. Yet looking at 2025–26 versus 2024–25, there were actually more (eight, versus six) who failed to translate at least 10% of those PPSOG into PPGs:

- Alex Ovechkin (87 PPSOG, 5 PPGs)
- Artemi Panarin (70, 4)
- Tage Thompson (67, 6)
- Tyler Toffoli (62, 6)
- Jack Eichel (52, 1)
- Adam Fantilli (52, 4)
- Brady Tkachuk (51, 5)
- Leo Carlsson (51, 4)

How did the six who made the list in 2024–25 do this season, in comparison? The younger they were, the better they fared, as Matt Boldy saw major gains, Sebastian Aho had a modest boost, and Jack Eichel stayed in neutral. Of the three graybeards, Anders Lee and Jonathan Marchessault both saw their scoring rate crater, but Brad Marchand was revitalized, albeit with a smaller sample size.

So, if there is a conclusion to be drawn, the younger the player on this list, the better results might lie ahead, which is great news for Fantilli and Carlsson owners. Eichel is a repeat offender, but his scoring seems to be just fine despite it, so no reason that cannot continue, especially with John Tortorella not returning. Thompson and Tkachuk are comparable in age to Aho, so they might be in for small gains, although Tkachuk will need to ensure he gets—and keeps—a spot on PP1 in Florida. Panarin, Toffoli, and Ovi are the graybeards this time, which is worrisome to those hoping Ovi and Panarin will rebound. For Toffoli, by Q4 his PP time had shrunk, although San Jose trading away William Eklund, plus Alexander Wennberg likely having a less firm grip on a PP1 spot, should help Toffoli's odds to stay within the PP1 picture.

Scoring and number of games with at least a point

At one end of the spectrum are those who score more consistently but might have fewer games with two or more points. Others are more “all or nothing” types, meaning they have a high rate of multipoint efforts but, with that, quite a few games with zero points.

The 2025–26 season saw a total of 60 forwards (up from 54 in 2024–25) both play at least half of their team's games and register at least one point in 60% of those games. Of them, though, 10 (versus seven in 2024–25) failed to average 0.9 points per game:

- Kirill Marchenko (76 games, 67.1% of games with at least one point, 0.88 points per game)
- Mathew Barzal (81, 65.43%, 0.89)
- Alex Tuch (79, 64.56%, 0.84)
- Travis Konecny (77, 63.64%, 0.88)
- Trevor Zegras (81, 62.96%, 0.83)
- Pavel Zacha (78, 62.82%, 0.83)
- Roope Hintz (53, 62.26%, 0.83)
- John Tavares (82, 62.20%, 0.87)
- Auston Matthews (60, 61.67%, 0.88)
- Rickard Rakell (60, 60.00%, 0.80)

What befell the seven from 2024–25? Rakell, as we see above, made the list again, suggesting he is what he is. Otherwise, successes were Cole Caufield and Alex DeBrincat, but that is where the good news ends, as Logan Cooley saw a small reduction in scoring rate, while Jordan Kyrou, JJ Peterka, and Nazem Kadri all did substantially worse. From this, perhaps the takeaway is that if one is a sniper and finds himself on this list, that might be okay, whereas otherwise it is not a good sign.

The most notable name for 2025–26 is Matthews. He most assuredly meets the sniper qualification, which bodes well. Tuch was off PP1 for Buffalo; on Washington, though, and with the huge deal he signed, bank on him being a PP1 fixture and featured more prominently overall, meaning he should improve. For the rest, it could be more of the same. Zegras and Konecny are being throttled by playing under Rick Tocchet; and with the Flyers making it to the Conference semis, Tocchet is unlikely to fix what he sees as not broken. Zacha makes yet another list, but he seems to be an outlier in as many good ways as bad, meaning perhaps he might produce similarly or, if not, then regress less than many are predicting. Hintz is here despite taking the ice for two-thirds of Dallas' PP time, so him not being able to climb back to prior point-per-game levels despite this makes him unlikely to do so again. Marchenko's presence may mean he has reached his ceiling or, as a larger player, might not truly ignite until 2027–28. The issue with Barzal is lack of supporting cast, as even the addition of Matthew Schaefer failed to revitalize him, suggesting until/unless those around him improve he will continue to produce—but consistently—rather than with the scoring bursts needed to rise back to a point-per-game level. Tavares remains productive, but with each passing season there is a bigger risk of father time taking a major toll.

Focusing next on those with many multipoint games but also less consistency, of 91 (down from 94) forwards who took the ice for at least half their teams' games while producing at a 0.74+ points-per-game rate (i.e., at a 60+-point pace), just three (versus nine in 2024–25) tallied a point in under 52% of their games played:

- Matthew Knies (79 games, 50.63% of games with at least one point, 0.84 points per game)
- Nico Hischier (81, 51.22%, 0.80)
- Logan Cooley (54, 50.00%, 0.80)

Looking at the nine from 2024–25, it was a mixed bag in terms of their 2025–26 results. Mika Zibanejad and Evgeni Malkin thrived, while Patrick Kane, Anthony Cirelli, and Mason Marchment essentially held steady in terms of scoring pace. But each of Jonathan Drouin, Matvei Michkov, Jared McCann, and Kevin Fiala did markedly worse, though all but Michkov missed a chunk of time, which may have contributed. For Michkov, conditioning/effort issues and him being the oil to Rick Tocchet's water led to struggles. For Cirelli and Marchment, it likely was a case of them just getting their usual points in a different way in 2024–25. Kane showed his age but had flashes of his old self. The keys to Zibanejad and Malkin both thriving—and not shared by any others on the 2024–25 list—were heaps of PP1 time on top of a locked-down top-six spot.

In terms of the three for 2025–26, each is a PP1 and top-six staple but also considerably younger than everyone on the 2024–25 list other than Michkov. Thus, despite the age differentials, if the trio are to be likened to members of the 2024–25 list, it would be Malkin and Zibanejad, suggesting all three should do better in 2026–27.

Posts and Crossbars

Here too there were extremes, namely forwards to whom the iron was unkind versus those who hit an abnormally low percentage of posts and crossbars. For the first group, in 2023–24 only six forwards hit a combined 15+ posts and crossbars, whereas in 2024–25 there were six who hit 15 crossbars and, on top of that, 12 more who hit a combined 15 posts and crossbars. Thus, for 2024–25, the focus was on the seven players who hit 20 or more posts plus crossbars. But 2025–26 was more like 2023–24, in that none hit that many combined; so instead the threshold was lowered back to those who hit at least 16 posts and crossbars, with the group totaling these seven:

- Sam Reinhart (16 posts, 3 crossbars)
- Kirill Kaprizov (15, 2)
- Alex DeBrincat (15, 1)
- Dylan Larkin (12, 4)
- Tage Thompson (12, 7)
- Cole Caufield (12, 4)
- Nick Suzuki (8, 9)

Needless to say, this is an impressive list. And although the 2024–25 forwards also included top-tier talent like Nathan MacKinnon, Auston Matthews, and Artemi Panarin, only MacKinnon did better. If he is to be likened to anyone for 2025–26, it is likely Suzuki, who also dishes out more assists than goals; so, seeing him here not only legitimizes Suzuki's 2025–26 output but gives hope he still might have another gear. Of the others who made the list in 2024–25, only Matt Boldy thrived, with Travis Konecny, Filip Forsberg, and Kevin Fiala, plus Matthews and Panarin, doing worse. Each of Panarin, Forsberg, and even Fiala was older than the rest, so that might have been a factor. As for Konecny, he was throttled by Rick Tocchet, and thus the deck was stacked against him.

For the other 2025–26 players, Kaprizov and Larkin are about the same age as Fiala, but Reinhart is older. Kaprizov and Reinhart have been snipers in the past, though, so this helps explain Kaprizov's poorer-than-expected showing and suggests Reinhart is likely a safe bet to return to at least point-per-game

output. Caufield, Thompson, and DeBrincat check the sniper and not-old boxes, suggesting they should do as well if not better in the 2026–27 season on this basis.

As for those who were luckier, of the 77 forwards (down from 89 in 2024–25) who had 25+ goals in 2024–25, only one (versus two in 2023–24) had a combined total of posts and crossbars less than or equal to 10% of their goal total, that being Zach Hyman (31 goals, 2 posts, 1 crossbar). But looking at those who had 20+ goals, there are six who met the criteria for 2025–26:

- Anthony Cirelli (23 goals, 2 posts, 0 crossbars)
- Brady Tkachuk (22, 2, 0)
- Parker Kelly (21, 2, 0)
- Artturi Lehkonen (21, 0, 1)
- Collin Graf (21, 1, 0)
- Blake Coleman (20, 0, 1)

Of the two who were on this list for 2024–25, Tom Wilson saw modest improvement, but Anders Lee had a 20% drop in scoring. So, a proven performer being on here is less concerning versus a non-scorer. As such, Tkachuk, Hyman, and Cirelli are unlikely to do worse and may, like Wilson, fare better, especially Brady for what figures to be a juggernaut Panthers team. Of the rest, Coleman is most akin to Lee in age, which would make his presence worrisome unless he can land in the Wild's top six. Kelly and Graf are not proven scorers but young enough that it might not hinder them. Lehkonen is in a middle ground age-wise, but Valeri Nichushkin is out of the picture, providing less cause for concern.

Goal types

Certainly, outliers exist for all goal types; however, data over the years has suggested that outlier status for some goal types generally is more predictive than others. With this in mind, as usual the focus will be on five specific goal types: slap shots, wrist shots, snap shots, backhanders, and tip-ins (which are all available for viewing on *Frozen Tools*). Because they do not score enough goals, defensemen will not be covered—only forwards.

Looking first at slap shots, whereas in 2024–25 there were six forwards with 8+ slap-shot goals, and five in 2023–24, that number shrank to just three in 2025–26:

- Nathan MacKinnon (53 goals, 11 via slap shot)
- Dylan Guenther (39, 11)
- Mika Zibanejad (34, 11)

What were the fantasy fates of the six from 2024–25? One was Patrik Laine, who missed virtually the entire 2025–26 season. Of the rest, two—Kevin Fiala and Alex Ovechkin—saw major declines, while the others, namely Steven Stamkos, Tage Thompson, and Sebastian Aho, had gains. Given these outcomes, things seem to look best for Guenther, as the younger players did better. For Zibanejad, despite his advanced age, he cannot really be likened to Stamkos or Ovi, for whom goal scoring is their bread and butter. Plus, like Tage and Aho, Zibs is a center, making his inclusion more likely a positive. For Mack, he too is a center, and his percentage of goals by slapper is almost identical to what Thompson's was, making it also unlikely he does worse. So, in all, look for these three to do as well, if not better, for the 2026–27 season based on this.

Focusing next on wrist shots, of those with 20+ goals in 2025–26, just one forward (Shane Pinto, who tallied 23 goals) had 70% or more via wristers (17). In comparison, there were four who met the criteria in 2024–25: Nazem Kadri, Tim Stutzle, Matt Coronato, and Ilya Mikheyev. Of the four, all but Kadri had modest gains, although in the cases of Coronato and Mikheyev, their production still stayed low overall. And it would be them to whom Pinto, a middle-six forward, would be likened. As such, look for him to possibly see his scoring rate inch upward.

Turning to snap shots, past data has suggested if a forward has a disproportionate ratio of goals via snap shots and is not a sniper or up-and-comer, it could signal trouble for the following season, while for those who are goal scorers and/or rising stars, it often portends improvement. Sure enough, for those on the 2024–25 list, Alex DeBrincat, Adam Fantilli, Seth Jarvis, and Wyatt Johnston all improved, Kirill Marchenko did a bit worse, and Aliaksei Protas saw a sizeable drop, which makes sense, as among them the first four were considered more likely to shine. For 2025–26, among the 107 forwards who potted 20 to 35 goals, nine relied upon snap shots for at least half of their goals:

- Alex Ovechkin (32 goals, 52.1% via snap shot)
- Andrei Svechnikov (31, 51.6%)
- Bo Horvat (31, 51.6%)

- Juraj Slafkovsky (30, 60.0%)
- Tom Wilson (30, 56.7%)
- Nick Suzuki (29, 51.7%)
- Lawson Crouse (24, 50.0%)
- Logan Stankoven (21, 61.9%)
- Ryan Leonard (20, 55.0%)

Ovi might be slowing, but the sniper label still applies, so he could be due to rebound. On the other hand, Horvat is not a sniper nor young, so seeing him here is a concern, as it is for Crouse, Wilson, and, arguably, Svechnikov. Suzuki is still young enough for this not to be concerning, whereas it is seemingly very good news for those who own up-and-comers Slaf, Stankoven, and Leonard.

Shifting to backhand goals, the pattern that had emerged over several seasons was that those who had a high ratio of this type of goal and were up-and-comers tended to fare better the following season, while otherwise it normally did not bode well. And considering the list for 2024–25 consisted of Warren Foegele, Kevin Fiala, Brett Howden, and Corey Perry—with just Perry not doing markedly worse, and only due to him having far better deployment—the trend continued, with it being a predictor of Fiala’s poor 2025–26 when seemingly there were no signals of him struggling to the extent he did.

For 2026–27, just six forwards had seven or more backhand goals, those being Jason Robertson (nine), Zach Hyman (eight), William Nylander (eight), Anthony Mantha (seven), Anthony Cirelli (seven), and Mikko Rantanen (seven). Although none fit the up-and-comer label, JRob, Nylander, Cirelli, and Rantanen are all under 30, plus, in the cases of all but Cirelli, proven top-tier fantasy options. Where concern arises is with Hyman, who is 33, and Mantha, 31. Hyman had a nice bounce-back, but he had a poor 2024–25, and this might suggest his best days are behind him, while for Mantha, his unexpected 64-point season now seems even more unlikely to be repeated despite having signed a deal with New Jersey.

Finally, tip-ins, where unless a forward has a proven record of many of this type of goal, having a high percentage normally is a sign of similar or worse stats the following season. And sure enough, of the 11 forwards in 2024–25 who had 20+ goals and with 25% or more of those being tip-ins, most either did worse or, at best, about the same, including Alex Tuch, Brock Boeser, Jake DeBrusk, Vincent Trocheck, Matthew Knies, Anze Kopitar, Barrett Hayton, and Matthew Tkachuk, with only Matty Beniers and Tyler Bertuzzi faring better. Who makes the list for 2025–26, meaning 20+ goals and 25% or more via tip-in? Only two; but lowering it 23% adds another two:

- Jordan Staal (20 goals, 35.0% via tip-in)
- Alexis Lafreniere (24, 29.2%)
- Morgan Frost (22, 27.3%)
- Parker Kelly (21, 23.8%)
- Alex Laferriere (21, 23.8%)

For Staal, notwithstanding his better production in the playoffs, he is basically a point-per-every-other-game player, so he is likely someone for whom this will mean either nothing better or perhaps a bit worse given that he will be 38 years old come the start of 2026–27. For Laffy, this is a bit of a concern, as he was firing on all cylinders in Q4, leading many to think he had finally connected the dots. This might suggest he will not be able to maintain, let alone build upon, his 20 points in 21 games in Q4 of 2025–26. For Kelly, this is the second concerning metric, seemingly signifying he is one to avoid for 2026–27. As for Laferriere, much like Laffy he started doing well in Q4; but in his case, it coincided with his 200-game breakout threshold, plus there is a vacancy for a top-six center with Anze Kopitar having retired, so of the four he might be the one who ends up seeing gains despite being here.

PART 2: DEFENSEMEN

Using the same reasoning and analysis as in Part 1 (above), let’s take a look at the blueliners.

Overall ice time and scoring

Like forwards, some defensemen made the most of their minutes. Specifically, in 2025–26, a total of 83 defensemen (down a notch from 84 in 2024–25) played 41+ games while taking the ice for less than 19:00 per game, with only three (the same number as in 2024–25) meeting both criteria and scoring at a 35+-point pace (0.425 points per game):

- Sam Malinski (82 games, 42 points, 17:37 TOI per game)
- Ryan Shea (80, 35, 18:53)
- Brent Burns (82, 35, 18:53)

How might these three fare in 2026–27? Looking back at the 2024–25 list, those on it were Brandt Clarke, who saw modest improvement, but also Shane Gostisbehere and some guy named Darren Raddysh. Yes, two of the biggest defensive fantasy success stories for 2025–26 were on this list for 2024–25. Does this mean any of the three for 2026–27 are in line to see significant gains like those of Ghost or Raddysh?

Unlikely, as key to the success of those two was that they manned PP1, whereas neither Malinski nor Burns is going to do so, since if Cale Makar got hurt his PP1 spot—and favorable minutes—likely would go to Devon Toews, as it did in the playoffs. In fact, the Avs rearguards being here is more a case of a rising tide lifting their boats, as the Avs had a superb 2025–26 in terms of scoring and it had a spillover effect on their production. With Shea, the Pens shot 13.0% at even strength with him on the ice, so even if he gets more minutes with the Oilers, it would be a net wash since that number is all but assured to go way down. So, although this was a great predictor for 2025–26, do not look for gains for any of the three in 2026–27, but also not likely a drop in production either.

On the other end of the spectrum were defensemen who logged plenty of minutes yet without the level of production that would have been expected. Of the 53 (up a tad from 49 in 2024–25) defensemen who averaged 22:00+ per game, a total of 14 (the same number as 2024–25) failed to score at a 35+-point pace. Some are very clearly defensive defensemen and thus not listed; however, here are those who scored at a 35+-point pace in 2024–25 and met the two criteria for 2025–26:

- Colton Parayko (77 games, 18 points, 22:12 TOI per game)
- Neal Pionk (51, 12, 22:43)
- Drew Doughty (72, 23, 23:05)
- Devon Toews (68, 24, 22:22)
- MacKenzie Weegar (79, 28, 22:28)
- Aaron Ekblad (72, 26, 22:29)
- Noah Hanifin (71, 28, 22:36)
- Philip Broberg (81, 34, 23:21)

Looking back at the 2024–25 names, they included Brock Faber and Rasmus Andersson, who both had major rebounds, plus Mike Matheson and Kris Letang, each of whom fared better but nowhere near what they had done in the past, as well as Justin Faulk, the ageless wonder who held steady. In fact, just Gustav Forsling did worse, and only by a little.

Likening those from 2024–25 to the 2026–27 rearguards, Doughty, Parayko, and Ekblad would seem to fall into the same camp as Letang and Faulk, so expect perhaps minor gains from each. Pionk seems analogous to Matheson, so he too should rebound, as should Hanifin and Weegar, and even Toews, as although his scoring rate has dropped for several straight seasons, he is still tethered to Cale Makar and his 2025–26 scoring rate seems too low for him not to right his ship. Broberg is young but still blocked by Cam Fowler, although Fowler did not do great in 2025–26. If Broberg can find a way to get PP time and make the most of it, he could do the best of all, as none of the others—barring injury—appears to have a more viable path to PP1.

PP Ice time and scoring

Starting first with the rearguards who saw a good number of man-advantage minutes but did not have a high PPPT total to show for it. Of 36 (down from 38 in 2024–25) defensemen with 150:00+ of PP TOI, six (down from seven in 2024–25) finished with a single-digit PPPT total:

- Jamie Drysdale (180:14 PPTOI, 9 PPPTs)
- Morgan Rielly (178:14, 6)
- John Klingberg (165:29, 9)
- Aaron Ekblad (155:51, 5)
- MacKenzie Weegar (155:23, 6)
- Justin Faulk (151:22, 9)

How did the seven from the 2024–25 list fare in 2025–26? Charlie McAvoy, Miro Heiskanen, Rasmus Andersson, and Jackson LaCombe each saw major overall scoring gains, as did Drysdale, who was also on the list and did improve substantially, albeit from a 23-point pace to a 34-point pace—so good news, bad news. If there is a takeaway from the results, it is that if a defenseman is locked into a PP1 role, like McAvoy, Heiskanen, LaCombe, and Andersson were, they are good bets to improve. But those who lost that role, or never had it, either did worse, like Walman, or stayed the same, like Chabot, who still had ample ice time and over 40% of the PP time.

With their trajectories in mind, Rielly is unlikely to rebound, as the Leafs made a major commitment to Darren Raddysh, so it would take Raddysh imploding for Rielly to even have a chance to rebound, and even then Rielly

might not be up to the task given his age and trends. Drysdale also should get a decent amount of PP time even with Cam York in the picture and, as such, continue to see gains. As for the rest, Klingberg might not even be an everyday player anymore, while although Ekblad's days of being a viable scoring threat are likely over, when the Panthers averaged over four goals per game in 2021–22, Ekblad scored at a 77-point pace, so a rise back to 40–45+ seems achievable. Faulk, like Chabot, is what he is and should not see a gain or decrease. Weegar went from at times running Calgary's PP1 to being entrenched behind Mikhail Sergachev; so, if he bounces back, it likely would be only modest gains.

Seeing the great 2025–26 results for the defensemen who made the most of their PP time in 2024–25, it likely does not come as a surprise that nearly all who failed to thrive despite a good amount of PP time in 2024–25 fared worse in 2025–26, as other than Jakob Chychrun, who had his best season in 2025–26, the rest—namely Mason Lohrei, Luke Hughes, Matt Grzelcyk, and Thomas Harley—all disappointed. As such, making this list is indeed a sign of concern. With that in mind, of the 24 (the same number as 2024–25) defensemen with 15+ PPTs in 2026–27, just three had that many despite under 225 total PP minutes in 70+ games (down from five with under 220 PPTOI in 2024–25):

- Filip Hronek (82 games, 21 PPTs, 158:42 PPTOI)
- Dmitry Orlov (82, 18, 202:55)
- Vince Dunn (81, 21, 222:43)

For Hronek and Orlov, they were thrust into unfamiliar PP1 QB roles and made the most of it. But with Zeev Buium having had a season to acclimate to the NHL, Hronek should cede that role. Orlov also seems unlikely to keep running the PP, as although the Sharks still lack a true PP1 QB, chances are they give the role to a youngster or turn to Darnell Nurse instead of Orlov. As for Dunn, he finally was healthy for an entire season and took the ice for 62.0% of Seattle's PP minutes, with his lack of PPTOI being a function of the fact the Kraken had the fifth-lowest PP time per game. And Dunn did as well as he could, with a 75% IPP on the PP, meaning he had a point on three of every four PPGs his team scored. What he needs is better scoring in front of him. So, his fate is tied to that of his team, where if they struggle offensively in 2026–27 like they did in 2024–25, Dunn could again finish below a 50-point scoring pace. Otherwise, he seems like a nice bet to make gains despite being on this list.

Scoring and number of games with at least a point

It is rare for defensemen to have a high percentage of multipoint games without also being top scorers, but it can happen, as it did in 2024–25 for Luke Hughes, Noah Hanifin, Noah Dobson, and Roman Josi, with Josi and Dobson faring better in 2025–26 but Hughes and Hanifin markedly worse. What this seems to show is if one is not a proven scorer yet relied on multipoint games quite a bit, they will likely do worse the following season, whereas if they have a track record of success, this could be a sign of better things to come.

Focusing on 2025–26 stats, Adam Fox had the ninth-most multipoint games among defensemen even though, due to injury, his point total put him 20th overall, suggesting his 2025–26 rebound was not a fluke and, with the Rangers needing more scoring, it could result in Fox returning to point-per-game production. Brandt Clarke was 30th in defensemen scoring but tied for 19th in multipoint games. He has long been seen as a future "the guy" rearguard, and with him having signed a major extension in the offseason, 2026–27 might be the year he makes large gains given how he is already finding a way to have big games but just needs more consistency, which he now should get a better chance to achieve. Hughes returns to the list, ranking tied for 27th in multipoint games despite only landing 43rd in defensemen points. Seeing him here again suggests he might still have it in him to connect the dots, provided he can become more consistent plus get the keys to PP1 handed to him once and for all. And Seth Jones had seven multipoint games, tying him 31st overall despite his point total putting him only tied for 52nd. Jones has disappointed in Florida amid lofty expectations, but this perhaps offers at least a glimmer of hope he will finally thrive in 2026–27, especially given Florida's likely firepower.

Looking at the 2025–26 "steady eddy" defensemen, of the 47 (up a good amount from 39 in 2024–25) defensemen who tallied 35+ points, there were 11 (nearly double the six from 2024–25) for whom their number of games with a point was at least 80% of their point total:

- Justin Faulk (40 points, 32 games with at least a point)
- Sam Malinski (40, 33)
- Shea Theodore (39, 33)
- Travis Sanheim (37, 31)
- Dmitry Orlov (37, 34) Thomas Harley (36, 29)
- Morgan Rielly (36, 29) John Marino (36, 29)
- Vladislav Gavrikov (35, 28) Jacob Trouba (35, 30)
- Brent Burns (35, 32)

Looking back at the 2024–25 group, four of the six—Vince Dunn, Colton Parayko, Matt Grzelcyk, and Owen Power—saw drops in scoring, with all but Dunn’s being double-digit drops. As for the other two, Thomas Chabot held steady as he always does, while Seth Jones saw small gains. Overall, though, it is more likely a bad sign to be on this list. But looking at specific players, this reinforces Faulk as being akin to Chabot and to thus expect more of the same, whereas Theodore is here due to Vegas running a five-forward PP1 for most of 2025–26 and is less likely to recur with a new coach and the exodus of Pavel Dorofeyev, poisoning Theodore for 2026–27 gains. Gavrikov, Orlov, Burns, Marino, Malinski, and Sanheim all are risks to do worse given their ages and/or roles, but Trouba might be the exception due to being on what figures to be a high-scoring San Jose team. Harley took a major step back, but in 2023–24 he actually made the other list, suggesting 2024–25 was an off year for him and he might be due to rebound, unlike Rielly, who, as already noted, has been rendered an offensive afterthought by Darren Raddysh.

Posts and crossbars

Even though they score far fewer goals than forwards, normally quite a few defensemen hit a good number of posts and crossbars. For 2024–25, 10 rearguards had a combined double-digit total of posts and crossbars hit, whereas for 2025–26 the number was cut in half, to only five:

- Evan Bouchard (8 posts, 5 crossbars)
- Cale Makar (10, 2)
- Darren Raddysh (7, 4)
- Jakob Chychrun (8, 2)
- Rasmus Andersson (6, 4)

How did the 10 from 2024–25 fare? Those with the most (Zach Werenski, Makar, and Chychrun) all had great 2025–26 results, while Victor Hedman and Shea Theodore fared worse, although for both it had a lot to do with being displaced from their team’s PP1, while Thomas Harley also saw his scoring drop but did not have any clear excuse. Of the rest, John Carlson fared quite a bit better, while the likes of Olen Zellweger, Brandon Montour, and Braden Schneider essentially did about the same.

What does this mean for the 2025–26 names? Makar and Chychrun appear again, likely meaning both should do just fine, if not improve. Raddysh being on here lends some added legitimacy to his breakout, plus he is now assured a PP1 spot for the Maple Leafs. Bouchard’s presence also suggests he might have truly graduated to the ranks of the highest echelon of offensive defensemen. As for Andersson, maybe this helps allay some concern as to his strong 2025–26 being solely motivated by cashing in on his UFA status, and perhaps he turns into the 2026–27 version of John Carlson. Most likely not though, as Carlson was far more proven, so there is still a good chance of Andersson’s scoring coming back to earth.

Far fewer defensemen are lucky enough to avoid posts and crossbars entirely or almost entirely. Of 37 defensemen (way up from 25 in 2024–25) with a double-digit goal total for 2025–26, those who hit a combined number of posts and crossbars that was less than or equal to 10% of their goal total were:

- Matthew Schaefer (23 goals, 0 posts, 1 crossbar)
- Justin Faulk (16, 1, 0)
- Mattias Samuelsson (13, 0, 0)
- Noah Dobson (12, 1, 0)

In 2024–25, only one defenseman—Vince Dunn—met the criteria, and he saw his scoring rate drop. But can Dunn be analogized to any of the three? Maybe Dobson, who is not a huge scorer but still tends to produce well, meaning this is likely not a good sign. Also, for all the talk that Schaefer could be the next young superstar defenseman, for the most part they tend to hit a lot of posts and crossbars, whereas Schaefer hitting so few might suggest he could be in line to see his scoring either drop or not rise as yet. As for Samuelsson, his come-from-nowhere 2025–26 looks more concerning when seeing he hit no posts or crossbars.

PART 3: TEAMS AND ICE TIME

Most teams do have what would be termed a true first line, meaning a trio of forwards who get heaps of ice time. Still, in 2024–25, five teams (Anaheim, Dallas, Nashville, Vancouver, Washington) had no forward who played 41+ games average 19:00 of ice time per game, up from three in 2023–24. What about the 2025–26 season? Amazingly, only one team (Columbus) had not one single forward average 19:00 per game, although if the minimum is raised only a little to 19:10 per game, then that would lump in Vancouver, St. Louis, Philadelphia, and Anaheim, with the Ducks and Canucks being carryovers from 2024–25. For Vancouver, only Elias Pettersson

(EP40) is a contender to play that much, but he would need to rebound, while Anaheim likely will play at least its new \$18M man Leo Carlsson at least 19:00 per game. As for the other teams, Philly not only made the playoffs but advanced to round two, so expect more of the same. And neither Columbus nor St. Louis had poor 2025–26 results and did not make coaching changes, so stingy forward TOI may recur for both squads in 2026–27.

But even though that means 27 teams had at least one forward average 19:00 per game in 2025–26 while playing 41+ games, a total of 10—up from eight for the 2024–25 season—had at least two forwards average 20:00 per game: Colorado, Dallas, Edmonton, Minnesota, New Jersey, Islanders, Rangers, Sharks, Tampa Bay, and Winnipeg. Dallas has gone full circle from making the other list to this one, and it showed in the improved offensive outputs from most of its top forwards. San Jose appears due of course to Macklin Celebrini; but its other 20:00+ forward was Alex Wennberg, who has been enjoying a career resurgence, although despite the exodus of William Eklund, it is unclear if he can keep a spot on PP1 with so many up-and-coming forwards on the team, so his TOI should slip. The Isles do not have a depth of talent, leading to those who do have skill being leaned on a lot, which should continue, and it being a similar story now for the Rangers.

Otherwise, Colorado, Edmonton, Minnesota, New Jersey, Tampa Bay, and Winnipeg make the list for 2025–26 after also being on it for 2024–25, meaning likely more of the same for these squads in 2026–27. The two teams which were on the 2024–25 list but not for 2025–26 were Toronto, which is not surprising with Mitch Marner no longer being in the fold, and Florida, likely due to Aleksander Barkov being out for all of 2025–26, although Florida is so stacked now that two forwards will not see 20:00+ per game.

Looking next specifically at the PP, a total of 58 forwards (the exact same number as 2024–25) took the ice for at least two-thirds of their team's PP time while appearing in at least half their games. Despite that number, just five teams (up from four in 2024–25) had what could be rightfully called a true PP1, where four forwards each met the two-thirds threshold: Edmonton, Dallas, Vegas, Minnesota, and Pittsburgh, with only Edmonton and Minnesota being repeats from 2024–25.

Those who were on the list for 2024–25 but not for 2025–26 were Toronto, again likely due in large part to no more Mitch Marner, plus the Rangers, who were in shambles, but Colorado as well, which is quite surprising since no team had more PP TOI per game than they did, yet other than Nathan MacKinnon and Martin Necas the forwards on PP1 were a rotating cast. For 2026–27, however, there is a good chance Nazem Kadri and Gabriel Landeskog could meet the threshold and put them back on this list. With Pavel Dorofeyev gone, Vegas might not run a 5F PP1 again, as they did for most of 2025–26, yet still have four who qualify. For Pittsburgh, the same players will be in the fold, but will age finally prevent Sidney Crosby and/or Evgeni Malkin from logging as many PP minutes? For the Oilers, Minnesota, and Dallas though, it seems safe to expect more of the same.

As with overall TOI, there were teams which did not heap lots of PP minutes on any forward, meaning none getting 61%+ of the squad's PP minutes, but for 2025–26 only two: Seattle and St. Louis, although Philly was a near miss. So, two of the three are on this list plus the overall TOI list, with only Seattle being a 2024–25 carryover for this list, and Dallas, Calgary, and Anaheim gone after being on it for 2024–25, although Calgary likely will be here again for 2026–27 since the only player above 61.0% was Nazem Kadri, who is now gone. But as was the case with overall TOI, do not look for Philly to fix what they likely see as not broken, which is not ideal for those who own Flyer forwards. St. Louis seems intent on running two fairly even PP units, meaning more forwards getting meaningful PP minutes but none taking the ice on the PP enough to get the benefits that come from doing so. As for Seattle, it is a chicken-and-egg type situation in that arguably no one is performing so well as to "deserve" more PPTOI, but that is likely due at least in part to none getting to take the ice for enough PP time to shine. Absent a coaching change, they likely will keep things the same for 2026–27.

That covers things for forwards, but what about defensemen? For them, within the last decade things have gone from teams routinely having a PP1 with two defensemen on it to instead often having one rearguard log the vast majority of PP minutes. For 2024–25, a total of 15 teams, or just under half of all NHL squads, had one defenseman who played in at least half their games take the ice for, on average, two-thirds of its PP time. For 2025–26 though, the number shrank to just 13, namely Buffalo, Columbus, Colorado, Dallas, Edmonton, Minnesota, Montreal, Nashville, Islanders, Rangers, Pittsburgh, Tampa Bay, and Utah. Thus, four of the five teams which had four forwards take the ice for two-thirds of its PP minutes also had a defenseman do the same, with the exception being Vegas, due to them deploying five forwards on PP1 for most of 2025–26. Are things likely to change for any of these teams in terms of one defenseman running the show? Not likely, as all have a proven and/or well-paid player who is in that role, although both Roman Josi in Nashville and Erik Karlsson in Pittsburgh are getting older, so it could be possible they either are pushed aside somehow or get hurt and do not meet the requirement of playing at least 41 of their team's games.

Which of the 19 teams who did not make the list might for 2026–27? Ottawa and Detroit, where Jake Sanderson and Moritz Seider each should take that next step. Carolina after Shayne Gostisbehere thrived, plus Anaheim for

Jackson LaCombe with John Carlson now gone, and Washington for Jakob Chychrun as there too John Carlson is out of the picture. Toronto, with Darren Raddysh having been signed; Vegas, if Shea Theodore is reinstalled as PP1 QB; plus Winnipeg, where Josh Morrissey was a near miss. And with Bowen Byram being paid what he is, chances are PP1 will be his in Chicago. A wild card is Vancouver, where if Zeev Buium shows he is ready for prime time he could be a go-to guy.

Of those same 19 teams, how many—and which—had no defenseman even log 55% of their PP time in 41+ games? For 2024–25, it was seven teams, while for 2025–26 there were six: Calgary, LA, New Jersey, Philly, St. Louis, Toronto, and Vegas. Vegas and Toronto, as noted, are all but assured to be off the list. Calgary's waters might stay muddy unless Simon Nemec or Zayne Parekh emerges. In LA, if Brandt Clarke makes the same percentage gains from 2025–26 to 2026–27 as he did from 2024–25 to 2025–26, he could be at or near the two-thirds mark. But look for more of the same in St. Louis, which has no clear PP1 defenseman, and Philadelphia, as neither Cam York nor Jamie Drysdale has been able to grab the PP reins. For New Jersey, it all depends on who the last one standing is between Dougie Hamilton and Luke Hughes, as now Nemec is out of the picture.

CONCLUSIONS

To again emphasize, outlier status is a factor to use when assessing a player, hinting at players who are more likely to do better or worse than is otherwise being predicted. With those caveats, players who could see gains due to outlier status include Jonathan Huberdeau, Dawson Mercer, Adrian Kempe, Timo Meier, Clayton Keller, Adam Fantilli, Leo Carlsson, Luke Hughes, Nico Hischier, Logan Cooley, Matthew Knies, Sam Reinhart, Dylan Larkin, Neal Pionk, Noah Hanifin, Brandt Clarke, Shane Pinto, Jamie Drysdale, Aaron Ekblad, and MacKenzie Weegar. There is a shorter list of those for whom things could turn out worse than is expected due to their outlier status. They include Anthony Mantha, Ryan O'Reilly, Pavel Zacha, Zach Hyman, Bo Horvat, John Tavares, Andrei Svechnikov, Parker Kelly, Matthew Schaefer, Filip Hronek, Dmitry Orlov, Mattias Samuelsson, and Brock Nelson.

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STOCK DROPS

By Mike Clifford

For fantasy managers to find success in their leagues, they not only need to draft, trade, or add players who provide good value, they need to avoid players who provide poor value. There are indicators that point us in the direction of players set for a value downswing, so let's go through some forwards, defensemen, and goalies that fantasy managers should be wary of as they prepare for the 2026-27 season.

(Listed alphabetically per section)

Forwards

Mavrik Bourque, RW, Predators

In Nashville, Bourque is no higher than their second right winger and is on the outside of the top PP unit. Last year, no Nashville forward who was not a top PP regular reached 40 points, and only Erik Haula had more than 31. Considering Bourque spent over half his 5-on-5 minutes last season next to sniper Jason Robertson, he is getting a downgrade in linemates, as well.

Dylan Cozens, C, Senators

With Cozens on the ice at 5-on-5 since arriving in Ottawa, the team lands 29% fewer shots and scores 19% fewer goals when he's on the ice without Brady Tkachuk. Now that Tkachuk is with the Florida Panthers, any winger that Cozens skates with this season will be a downgrade, so his 5-on-5 point rate is unlikely to rebound in 2026-27, giving him a lower fantasy outlook.

Conor Garland, RW, Blue Jackets

Garland went from 18:57 per game in ice time with the Vancouver Canucks to 13:01 per game with Columbus, losing nearly six minutes in the transition. Even with an improvement in the team around him compared to the Canucks, that is a death knell to fantasy value. He went from a potential 20-goal, 50-point forward to unrosterable in anything but the deepest fantasy formats.

Peyton Krebs, LW, Sabres

Alex Tuch may be gone, but Noah Ostlund and Konsta Helenius should be lineup regulars, and Jiri Kulich has recovered from his blood clot issues. Last year, Krebs benefited from injuries and subpar play from some Sabres forwards, and that got him a top-line role for an extended stretch. Without similar injury issues popping up again, it's back to fourth-line duties for Krebs.

Ryan Leonard, RW, Capitals

Washington's busy offseason means Leonard went from a potential top-six role to a potential fourth-line role. At best, he'll be stuck on the third line with secondary power-play time, and if that's his optimistic outlook, then the outlook isn't good. Leonard's long-term upside is still very high, but expecting him to repeat his 20-goal, 45-point performance with all the competition in front of him is expecting too much.

Mason McTavish, C, Blues

This could be a case where McTavish improves his play compared to 2025-26, but the downgrade in the team around him will negate that improvement. The Blues have one of the worst puck-moving defense groups in the league, and that makes it hard to generate offense, especially whenever Robert Thomas is off the ice. This is not an ideal breakout situation for McTavish.

Nick Schmaltz, C, Mammoth

Clayton Keller and Dylan Guenther are locks to be two of the four forwards on Utah's top power-play unit. The final two spots come down to Schmaltz, Logan Cooley, and the newly acquired Vincent Trocheck. Schmaltz is a right-handed center with a poor face-off percentage, while Trocheck is a right-handed center with a great face-off percentage and plenty of experience in such a PP role.

Teuvo Teravainen, LW, Blackhawks

In the second half of the 2025-26 season, Teravainen lost over two minutes of ice time after New Year's as the Blackhawks turned the keys over to younger options. Making matters worse is the offseason injury to Connor Bedard, which may cause him to miss around 15 games. Teravainen didn't often play with Bedard, but it moves all the centers up one rung, leaving Teravainen with inferior options.

Tyler Toffoli, RW, Sharks

As with Teravainen, Toffoli lost significant ice time in the second half of 2025-26, dropping 1:46 per game in calendar 2026. Now, he has to contend with a healthy Kiefer Sherwood, the signing of Mason Marchment, and the drafting of Ivar Stenberg. Toffoli is destined for a third-line, second PP role for a full season, and that puts 20 goals and 50 points in peril for the veteran.

Dmitri Voronkov, LW, Blue Jackets

No forward lost more ice time per game in calendar 2026 than Voronkov did, going from nearly 16 minutes per appearance to under 11 minutes, and that was when he wasn't a healthy scratch. Head Coach Rick Bowness clearly has no use for Voronkov, and the team replaced Mason Marchment with Valeri Nichushkin. Without a massive reversal in fortunes, Voronkov's fantasy value is cooked.

Mats Zuccarello, RW, Kings

The problem for Zuccarello isn't only leaving Kirill Kaprizov's wing, but also the power-play production, as Zuccarello averaged 24 power-play points every 82 games across the last two years. Conversely, Kevin Fiala is the only Kings forward to average at least 20 PPPs every 82 games over these last two seasons. Zuccarello may not even get a regular top PP role, and even if he does, he's sure to see a decline.

Defensemen

Jonas Brodin, Wild

A certified Band-Aid Boy, Brodin has missed at least 20 games in each of the last four seasons. Even when healthy, the big problem is that Brodin lost nearly 3:30 per game in ice time after the Quinn Hughes trade. For a guy whose fantasy value relies on solid production with a lot of blocked shots, both those things are in peril if he's averaging under 20 minutes each outing.

Mario Ferraro, Jets

Ferraro is coming off a career-high 23-point season in 2025-26, but that was with 21:02 per game in ice time. In Winnipeg, he seems destined for the third pair behind Josh Morrissey and Dylan Samberg, meaning a drop in ice time. To make matters worse, Winnipeg's depth scoring is non-existent. Ferraro's fantasy value rests with Hits and blocks, but do not expect another 20-point season.

Victor Hedman, Lightning

Hedman missed over half the season with mental health issues, but even when he was in the lineup, he lost over four minutes per game in ice time. That probably rebounds some, but the signing of John Carlson gives the Lightning a top power-play replacement for Darren Raddysh. Compared to this time last year, Hedman has a fraction of the fantasy value he once had.

Dmitry Orlov, Sharks

Orlov led Sharks defensemen in ice time per game last season, and that helped him to a career-high 37 points. However, the team brought in Jacob Trouba and Darnell Nurse, both of whom will surpass Orlov on the even-

strength depth chart. There are also youngsters Sam Dickinson and Luca Cagnoni expected to make an impact. This all makes the team better, but it does not improve Orlov's fantasy outlook.

Zayne Parekh, Flames

With both Rasmus Andersson and MacKenzie Weegar traded, Parekh had a clear path to top power-play minutes in Calgary. That path now has a giant Simon Nemec-shaped roadblock in the way, and the trades of Nazem Kadri and Blake Coleman thin out the forward group. Parekh could have a good season individually, but the team around him, and the roadblocks in front of him, are not conducive to fantasy success.

Morgan Rielly, Maple Leafs

Trade rumors or not, the Leafs signing Darren Raddysh gives them a top power-play defenseman, and that relegates Rielly to secondary PP duties. A healthy Chris Tanev figures to cut into Rielly's even-strength role, too, and there's also the chance Emil Andrae takes a step forward with his new team. A diminished role will make it hard for Rielly to improve on last year's 36-point season.

Goalies

Frederik Andersen, Oilers

Even if he stays healthy, Andersen is now on an Oilers team that looks prepped to run a three-goalie setup, so he'll split starts with Tristan Jarry and Devon Levi. That means Andersen is unlikely to make more than the 35 starts he did last year, and he's in a worse defensive environment than he was as a Hurricane in Carolina. All this makes his move to Edmonton a downgrade.

Joonas Korpisalo, Rangers

The Rangers may improve from their last-place finish in 2025-26, but Korpisalo is still leaving a playoff team. He made 28 starts with the Boston Bruins last year, and former Rangers backup Jonathan Quick averaged 22 starts per season over the last two years with New York. Korpisalo could lose 25% of his workload, and that's even if youngster Dylan Garand doesn't assert himself in any meaningful way.

Stuart Skinner, Jets

Whatever we think of Skinner, he appeared in at least 50 games in each of the last four seasons and is top-10 in goalie wins in that span. Going to Winnipeg puts him firmly in a backup role behind Connor Hellebuyck, giving him no chance of a starter's workload when Hellebuyck is healthy. Even if Hellebuyck is traded, Skinner goes from playing in Edmonton/Pittsburgh to a bottom-10 team.

*Michael Clifford writes **Daily Ramblings** and is Assistant Managing Editor at **DobberHockey.com***



GOALIES TO WATCH

By Garrett Finlay

Goaltenders are fantasy hockey's most volatile and unpredictable position. Maximizing draft capital and return on investment is the key to solving the position. Here are 20 undervalued netminders poised to outperform their acquisition cost and deliver major returns in 2026–27.

(Listed alphabetically)

Jake Allen, Devils

The only thing standing in the way of Allen starting 60 games this season is Nico Daws. Allen's career marks of 2.75 GAA and 0.907 SV% seem well within reach, and, as the Devils are always just a Jack Hughes injury away from competing in the playoffs, the 35-year-old veteran seems primed to top the 30-win mark for the first time in nearly a decade.

Justus Annunen, Predators

On one hand, playing behind incumbent starter Juuse Saros could put a hard cap on Annunen's starts, but on the other hand, Nashville actually split starts down the stretch, and when Annunen got the net for eight of the team's last 17 games, he largely outperformed Saros (Annenen: 1.65 GAA, 0.946 SV% vs. Saros: 3.25 GAA, 0.895 SV%). If "Big Juice" can build off last season's 2.64 GAA and 0.907 SV% in 28 games, he has a great chance at stealing even more starts from "Juice" in 2026–27.

Yaroslav Askarov, Sharks

The 23-year-old Askarov has a bright future ahead of him, but last season's campaign didn't exactly translate to fantasy success. However, the Sharks are investing to win now, and the front office recently went out and bought a brand-new blue line packed full of veteran stalwarts. If the defense gels and improves from third-worst in the NHL to just somewhere in the middle of the pack, then a more NHL-ready Askarov will easily outplay his acquisition cost in one-year pools.

Sebastian Cossa, Mammoth

A first-round draft pick by Detroit in 2021, Cossa has only one NHL game to his name entering this season, but joins a Mammoth team that is desperate for reliability behind workhorse Karel Vejmelka. A full-time NHL gig is his to lose entering camp, and the 23-year-old could feel added comfort being reunited with forward Dylan Guenther, with whom Cossa won a WHL championship in 2021–22. At 6-6, Cossa has the frame and pedigree to be given plenty of opportunities to succeed at the NHL level as soon as this year.

Joey Daccord, Kraken

Bit by bit, the Kraken offense is starting to define itself and may even enter the 2025–26 season with a legitimate top line of Bobby McMann, Matty Beniers, and Mackie Samoskevich. If the offense can take a step forward (big IF), then Daccord has 30-win potential as the clear-cut starter in Seattle. His career marks of 2.83 GAA and 0.904 SV% will hold their own if the wins improve.

Thatcher Demko, Canucks

The Canucks will be hard-pressed to play worse defensively in 2026 than they did in 2025. Even amidst last year's disastrous campaign, Demko finished nearly perfectly aligned with the NHL's status quo (Demko: 2.90 GAA, 0.897 SV% vs. NHL avg: 2.88 GAA, 0.896 SV%). Although injuries are always a concern, the talent is not, and landing a goalie just two seasons removed from a Vezina nomination at a major discount could be a boon for fantasy managers in 2026–27.

Casey DeSmith, Stars

Barring significant injury, DeSmith will not be a volume play. However, an 84-game schedule should have the ever-reliable 34-year-old sniffing 20 wins this season. Add that to his high-floor category coverage (since joining the Stars: 2.43 GAA, 0.907 SV% in 2025; 2.59 GAA, 0.915 SV% in 2024), and you have yourself a highly predictable and incredibly cheap fantasy contributor.

Michael DiPietro, Bruins

After trading away Joonas Korpisalo, the No. 2 goalie slot should belong to DiPietro, the back-to-back Aldege "Baz" Bastien Award winner as the AHL's most outstanding goalie. The 26-year-old has made just four NHL appearances thus far but has been lights out in his time with the Providence Bruins of the AHL, posting a combined 60 wins in 85 outings alongside a 0.929 SV% over the last two seasons. The Bruins, like fantasy managers, are hoping DiPietro will be this year's Brandon Bussi.

Lukas Dostal, Ducks

While his outlook in category leagues is mixed, Dostal could shine in points-based formats that emphasize wins and saves. His GAA may never get below 3.00, but the Czech native should eclipse the 30-win threshold for the second straight season and has a great "shot" at leading the league in saves playing behind a thinned-out Ducks defense following key offseason departures.

Jacob Fowler, Canadiens

The Canadiens are becoming a powerhouse in the East, and last year's promotion of Jakub Dobes over incumbent Samuel Montembeault proves that the team is willing to put winning ahead of niceties. Fowler, who went 9-6-1 with a 2.43 GAA and 0.908 SV% in 17 games as a rookie last season, should push for a heavier workload in 2026 as he continues his ascent toward becoming Montreal's goalie of the future.

Jet Greaves, Blue Jackets

Greaves was able to cement himself as the starter for a Blue Jackets club that very narrowly missed the playoffs in 2025. With a full season of Rick Bowness at the helm, who guided Columbus to a 21-11-5 record and top-five GAA after taking over head-coaching duties mid-January, Greaves will look to improve upon his 26 wins, 2.60 GAA, and 0.908 SV% in 55 appearances. Look for the 25-year-old to finish in the top 10 of fantasy goalies in 2026.

Adin Hill, Golden Knights

Hill watched Vegas' postseason run from the sidelines as then-Coach John Tortorella favored crease-mate Carter Hart for 25 straight starts (regular season and postseason combined). But this is a new season, and there is a new sheriff in Sin City with Ryan Craig set to lead the Golden Knights. Hill's stock has fallen considerably this offseason, making him a potential bargain for fantasy managers willing to take a risk and bet on Hill making 40+ appearances on a strong Cup contender in Vegas.

Joel Hofer, Blues

Hofer, 25, finished last season with a slight edge in starts over crease-mate Jordan Binnington (43-39), and that gap could grow even larger as Hofer continues to prove himself as the Blues' full-time starter while Binnington continues to wear out his welcome. Hofer has increased his starts and win totals in each of his five NHL seasons consecutively, and his career metrics of 2.67 GAA and 0.908 SV% are respectable enough to build a fantasy hockey contender around.

Pyotr Kochetkov, Hurricanes

Due to injuries and the rise of Brandon Bussi, Kochetkov appeared in just nine games last season. However, as things currently stand, he looks to be starting the 2026-27 season as no less than a 1B for the reigning Cup champs. Carolina has finished in the top five of the NHL in goals against in five of the past six seasons (finished 10th in 2024-25), indicating they have a system in place that any goalie could thrive in.

Devon Levi, Oilers

Once the future of Buffalo, Levi has moved out west for a change of scenery and now sits behind a hot-and-cold Frederik Andersen and the contract nobody wants in Tristan Jarry. If either goalie falters for long, look for Oilers

faithful to chant “Levi, Levi” until the young gun gets his shot at living up to his once-lofty expectations. It’s Cup or bust in Edmonton, so if Levi makes the most of the chances he’s given, Oilers brass won’t look back.

Sergei Murashov, Penguins

Murashov, age 22, may only have five games of NHL action under his belt, but he looks to be entering the 2026–27 season as a full-time NHL goalie. He posted a 0.919 SV% in 38 AHL games and a 0.931 SV% in 15 AHL playoff games last season. With only an unproven Arturs Silovs (58 career games) to compete with, Murashov could get hot behind Sidney Crosby and Co. and go on a run akin to last year’s Brandon Bussi or Jakub Dobes.

Akira Schmid, Panthers

From one Cup contender to another, the 26-year-old Schmid joins the Panthers after going 16-10-6 with a 2.59 GAA and 0.893 SV% for Vegas last year. The roster in front of him will be stacked with gritty veterans, so even though a timeshare behind Jacob Markstrom looks inevitable, Schmid could become the better option in net should the 36-year-old Markstrom continue his declining production from last year (3.07 GAA, 0.883 SV%).

Anthony Stolarz, Maple Leafs

After leading the entire NHL in save percentage and finishing in the top three in goals-against average in two consecutive seasons (min. 25 GP), Stolarz came crashing down to reality in 2025–26. The Maple Leafs, however, took this offseason to revamp their blue line, acquiring puck-moving defensemen Darren Raddysh and Emil Andrae. Behind an aging Sergei Bobrovsky, Stolarz should get his share of opportunities, and if he can capitalize on them like he did from 2023–2025, Stolarz could be a category-league darling in 2026.

Daniil Tarasov, Red Wings

Tarasov played his way into 33 games last season, a career-best mark, and while his 3.05 GAA and 0.895 SV% won’t jump off the page at you, both marks were better than future Hall of Famer Sergei Bobrovsky could muster on an injury-riddled Panthers team. His new crease-mate, John Gibson, is a “Band-Aid Boy,” well known for missing significant chunks of time due to injury. Tarasov may very well be setting a new career high in starts for the second straight season.

Linus Ullmark, Senators

Ullmark may have fallen out of fantasy managers’ favor after last year’s up-and-down campaign. Still, it’s worth noting that since his return from a personal leave of absence on January 31, Ullmark was second in the NHL with 14 wins in 21 starts and provided a healthy 2.40 GAA and 0.904 SV%. With an 84-game schedule and backstopping a Senators club that has made back-to-back playoff appearances, Ullmark should easily be able to top 30 wins and set a new career high in games played (49).

Garrett Finlay contributes to GoaliePost.com and is Social Media Video Coordinator for Dobber Sports.

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24

FILIP GUSTAVSSON

W-L-OT	GAA
28-15-6	2.79
SV%	SO
0.900	4

■ CONFIRMED

@JoeSmithNHL

Gustavsson leads #mnwild onto ice for warmups here in Detroit. Spurgeon on the ice, so is Petry, so he's probab...

FINAL

FLA

PIT

23

CAM TALBOT

W-L-OT	GAA
12-9-6	3.39
SV%	SO
0.876	0

■ CONFIRMED

@HeleneStJames

Cam Talbot leads Red Wings for warmups ahead of matinee against Minny at LCA. His first start since...

FINAL

FLA

PIT

25

DANIIL TARASOV

W-L-OT	GAA
13-15-3	3.18
SV%	SO
0.891	0

■ CONFIRMED

jamesoncoop

#FlaPanthers lineup notes vs. Pens - Reinhardt, Kunin and Hovorka are OUT - Hinostroza, Foote and...

FINAL

FLA

PIT

26

ARTURS SILOVS

W-L-OT	GAA
19-12-8	3.04
SV%	SO
0.888	2

■ CONFIRMED

@JG_PxP

Arturs Silovs & Daniil Tarasov lead the @penguins and @FlaPanthers onto the ice for warmup.

PIT — Win Probability +4.97

Projected Saves: 23

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starting goalie
info. Don't get
caught sleeping!

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activated.

Tiered goalie
rankings to help
you dominate
your fantasy
draft.

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notifications.
Because losing
your pool is
embarrassing.



PERIPHERAL CHANGES

By Mike Clifford

With power-play opportunities and major penalties declining, penalty minutes are becoming rarer with each passing year. This makes the top PIM skaters more valuable, but it also makes them more coveted. Let's go through the league to identify some of those top PIM takers to target in fantasy drafts, while looking for others on the rise who won't get the same focus from other fantasy managers.

(Listed alphabetically per section)

Forwards

Zack Bolduc, LW, Canadiens

Bolduc is 23 years old and will cross the 200-game threshold sometime in November. With some veterans leaving the team, Bolduc has a very good chance at securing a middle-six role, which should give him a bit more ice time. He increased both his Hit and block rates on a 60-minute basis last season, and a bigger role is good news for bigger peripheral totals.

Gage Goncalves, LW, Lightning

Following the Olympic break, Goncalves averaged over 15 minutes per game, a huge increase from 12:13 per game leading up to the pause. He was also seventh among Lightning forwards in TOI per game in the playoffs. The team likes him, and he performed well in return. With a bigger role, Goncalves has the ability to post 50 PIM, 30 blocks, and 100 Hits to go with solid offensive production.

Ryan Hartman, RW/C, Wild

With 95 blocks in 76 games last season, Hartman set a career high in that area, and it's not out of nowhere, either, as his blocks per 60 minutes from 2022-2024 were a top-30 rate among all forwards. With Marco Rossi now in Vancouver, Hartman has a great chance at a top-six center role for Minnesota, and that puts block-per-game status back on the menu.

Keegan Kolesar, RW, Red Wings

Despite losing 1:40 per game in time on ice last season, Kolesar posted more Hits and more PIM than the season prior. Being in Detroit puts him in a worse offensive environment, but it also puts him on a roster with maybe two or three reliable wingers and then a bunch of question marks. More ice time improves the outlook on Kolesar's stout Hit and PIM totals.

Alex Laferriere, RW, Kings

In calendar 2026, Laferriere skated 19:43 per game, a three-minute increase over the first three months of the season. Anze Kopitar has retired and it is a full year without Phillip Danault. The Kings will rely heavily on their top-six forwards, and Laferriere averaged over 10 Hits per 60 minutes last season. With a bigger role, there's more security in his ability to post high Hit totals.

Hendrix Lapierre, LW, Penguins

He won't have a featured role in Pittsburgh, but it can't get worse for Lapierre than it was in Washington, where he averaged under nine minutes per game in 2025-26; no regular Penguins forward was under 12:30 per game. He set career-best marks in both Hits and PIM per 60 minutes, and just having a regular role at 12 minutes per appearance should mean a dramatic rise in his peripherals.

Matvei Michkov, RW, Flyers

It was no secret that Michkov wasn't in tip-top physical shape last season, and it cost him a lot of ice time. However, he has averaged 60 PIM every 82 games for his career, and his Hits per 60 minutes increased by 23%

last season. Assuming he comes into 2026-27 with better physical fitness, his role should increase significantly, and that puts 60 PIM and 50 Hits within range.

Frank Nazar, C, Blackhawks

Connor Bedard's injury should mean a bigger role early in the season for Nazar, which is good for his peripherals. He improved his faceoff win rate last season, going from 44.6% to 47.4%. A similar improvement would get him close to 50%, and that means a lot of FOW when combined with more ice time. That puts him in line for 30 PIM, 50 blocks, 50 Hits, and 500 FOW.

Nick Paul, RW, Maple Leafs

Not only did Paul miss 31 games, but his TOI per game declined by 2:46 from the year before. However, he saw big improvements in Hits and PIM per 60 minutes, and a third-line role in Toronto should see him skate at least 14 minutes a game, if not exceed 15. A bigger role and a healthy season put 100 Hits and 40 PIM in his sights.

Elias Pettersson, C, Canucks

How effective Pettersson is offensively is a fair question, but there's little doubt about how much he can help with blocked shots. He had 108 blocks in 2025-26, a career high, and he has averaged 110 per 82 games over the last two years. He may see a little less ice time with a healthy Marco Rossi and Filip Chytil, but he is still a threat for over a block per game.

Logan Stankoven, C, Hurricanes

Stankoven had a very successful playoff run, skating the second-most even-strength minutes per game of any Carolina forward, and the most of any center. Last season, he posted 18 Hits in his first 40 games before totaling 32 Hits in his next 41 appearances. He should push past 16 minutes a game in 2026-27, meaning 60 Hits and 500 FOW are well within range.

Alexey Toropchenko, LW, Blues

Over the last two seasons, Toropchenko is one of nine forwards to average at least 3.5 blocks and 10 Hits per 60 minutes. He won't have a massive role in St. Louis, but a regular turn in the bottom-six means he's capable of 30 PIM, 50 blocks, and 150 Hits. That is solid across-the-board contribution for a forward who can also push for 20 points on the offensive side.

Yakov Trenin, C, Wild

Trenin's physicality is no secret, as he's third in Hits among forwards over the last three years, and he led the league in 2025-26. With Mats Zuccarello, Vladimir Tarasenko, and Marcus Johansson gone, there is now competition for more minutes on Minnesota's wings, and more minutes should help stabilize Trenin's sky-high Hit total. He may not reach 400 again, but the 300-Hit mark is very doable.

Defensemen

Brock Faber, Wild

One interesting fact about Faber's season is that he actually gained ice time after the Quinn Hughes trade, going from 24:14 per game to 24:56. That coincided with a career-high rate in blocks and PIM per 60 minutes, so if Faber is around the 25-minute mark for an entire season, he's staring down career-best totals in both blocks and penalty minutes.

Kaiden Guhle, Canadiens

Staying healthy is Guhle's mission, as he has averaged just 55 games per season over the last three years. Even with just 20 minutes per outing, he has the potential to reach 75 PIM, 175 blocks, and 150 Hits. There is some concern if David Reinbacher exceeds expectations, but Guhle is relied upon to eat minutes at even strength and on the PK. He just needs to stay in the lineup.

Michael Kesselring, Sharks

Kesselring never found his footing in Buffalo, enduring a severe decline in ice time, averaging 13:24 per appearance as he fought injuries all season. With the Sharks, he won't have a featured role, but their bottom-pair blueliners will be around 17–18 minutes per outing. That level of ice time, in a full season, puts 100 PIM, 75 blocks, and 100 Hits on the table.

Kaeden Korczak, Penguins

Korczak lost his role with Vegas as he went from 16:41 per game before the trade deadline to 12:57 per game after. He is now in Pittsburgh, and their third-pair defensemen skated between 18–19 minutes a game in 2025-26. A full season at that level of ice time puts both 100 blocks and 100 Hits into play for Korczak, with room far beyond those numbers.

Jake Middleton, Flames

At 17:30 per outing, Middleton saw a five-year low in ice time and lost over four minutes per game from the year before. Now that he's in Calgary, he's on a team with young blueliners who need veterans like Middleton to eat some key minutes and provide some muscle. As his ice time rebounds, Middleton is capable of reaching 70 PIM, 150 blocks, and 100 Hits in 2026-27.

Darnell Nurse, Sharks

The 2025-26 campaign saw Nurse skate his fewest minutes per game since 2016-17, but now that he's in San Jose, he should be well over 22 minutes again. Considering he had over 100 PIM and 300 total Hits/blocks last season, he is a threat for one-PIM-per-game status to go with 2.0 shots, Hits, and blocks per appearance.

Jamie Oleksiak, Canucks

After averaging 16:56 per game with Seattle, Oleksiak is now on a Vancouver roster that will be without Quinn Hughes and Marcus Pettersson for a full season. That is a lot of ice time to replace, and the team will be chasing the puck on many nights as they go through their rebuild. Oleksiak can reach both 150 blocks and 125 Hits with a bigger role.

Michael Clifford writes Daily Ramblings and is Assistant Managing Editor at DobberHockey.com





20 TO INVEST IN FOR LONG-TERM PAYOFF

By Logan Clarkson

In NHL fantasy, there will never be a shortage of players to look back on and wonder what could have been. The ones who slip through the cracks and end up unfairly (okay, completely fairly) on another roster. The guy you had on your watchlist who exploded for 95 points, or racked up 30 wins seemingly out of nowhere. The new European talent scooped up off waivers in November who carried their managers to the finish line.

The players below could very well fall into one of these categories. In the fantasy game, you have to be smart not only about who you target, but also about who you cut loose. Below is a list of 20 of the most intriguing non-rookie—but still young—targets set to make some noise over the next couple of seasons. Grab them now before the breakout comes in a year or two. If it happens sooner, that's just a bonus.

(Listed alphabetically)

Philip Broberg, D, Blues

Broberg has had a bit of a slow progression into the league, bumping up to nearly half a point per game after going from Edmonton to St. Louis due to signing an offer sheet two years ago. The power play is clearing for him to take over and take off in the near future. He kills penalties as well, so collecting a few extra blocked shots and maybe even Hits isn't out of the question.

Zeev Buium, D, Canucks

This man has all the opportunity in the world in front of him in Vancouver going forward. The problem with that is that he will be passing to a paperclip and receiving passes from a stapler on the man advantage until the organization can figure out which way is up and which way is down.

Igor Chernyshov, LW, Sharks

Chernyshov is technically not a rookie after surpassing the games limit this past season, and he looked pretty good for a 20-year-old on a very young roster. The Sharks are going to be a scary team in a few years, and Igor is going to contribute. He played 15 minutes a night, with only 25% of power-play time. He managed 19 points in the 28 games he suited up.

Easton Cowan, RW, Maple Leafs

Easton played his first full season with the Leafs last year and put up 29 points in 56 games. He has a pretty high draft pedigree and should start to get some better linemates and time on a solid second power play with Gavin McKenna showing up.

Sam Dickinson, D, Sharks

Dickinson posted 91 points in 55 games for the London Knights of the OHL in 2024–25. He's the best D prospect the Sharks have, and he'll be getting more and more opportunity as the roster comes of age. He should take over top power-play minutes from Luca Cagnoni (who finished a few games there last year)—if not this season, then the next.

Emmitt Finnie, LW, Red Wings

In his first season last year, Finnie managed 30 points, with eight on the man advantage. He saw 15:30 of ice time per game, but that should begin to creep up this year and onward, granting him the confidence and repetition on the big stage to bring his game to the next level. Detroit still has a few big, big balls up in the air with the Dylan Larkin situation, but it should only mean more ice time and more Hits for Emmitt.

Jacob Fowler, G, Canadiens

Fowler is one of the best goalie prospects in the league at the moment, and he has one large problem in front of him. That problem is 6-4 Jakub Dobes and how well he played in last year's playoff run and the regular season leading up to it. Fowler will bear fruit next year depending on how the situation shakes out in Montreal this season.

Jet Greaves, G, Blue Jackets

Greaves has recently taken over the starter's role in Columbus from Elvis Merzlikins. He played in 56 games last season and managed a 0.908 SV% with a 2.60 GAA. Some may say he has arrived already, but if Columbus can make a few roster tweaks and Adam Fantillo turns into a superstar, by next year he could be worth his weight in gold.

Isaac Howard, LW, Oilers

Howard has had mixed reviews in his playing time with the Oilers, which is only 29 games so far. He managed five points in that stretch, but the coach's lack of trust in younger players was obvious, and it weighed on their confidence. Howard has a lethal shot, and he's proved to be more than adequate at the AHL level so far in Bakersfield. He should get a shot at real NHL time this season, and if not, he will the next.

Marco Kasper, C, Red Wings

Kasper saw a drop in production last season, mainly due to a lack of ice time. He went from 15:30 a night to 13:40. Whenever he lined up with Lucas Raymond and Dylan Larkin, his production came easily. What remains to be seen is whether he can secure a consistent place alongside one of them as the season goes on—and with Larkin on his way out, elite linemates are growing thin.

Ben Kindel, C, Penguins

After 35 points in 77 games last season, Kindel has a great opportunity in Pittsburgh to continue producing. He saw his ice time dip late in the campaign—from 15:47 down to 13:58—and his production tailed off during that stretch as well, but it shouldn't raise any concern. He barely saw any time with elite linemates, so if he's allowed to ride shotgun with Sidney Crosby, things could move forward quickly.

Artyom Levshunov, D, Blackhawks

Levshunov has only featured in 86 games so far in his career, playing for one of the weakest rosters in the league during that time. He's still developing and will continue to do so as the rest of Hawks' lineup comes of age, hopefully gaining some supporting cast along the way. His power-play points should pick up this season with the exciting Anton Frondell hitching his cart to the horse for a full season.

Matvei Michkov, RW, Flyers

Michkov has been the subject of much discourse in Philadelphia—a very promising player, stunted by a lack of talent around him and limited coaching patience so far. Despite all of this, he's still scoring at a 0.71 PTS/G pace over his two seasons, and if he gets moved to the right situation for him during or after this season, he could explode offensively.

Fraser Minten, C, Boston

Minten was a highly rated prospect coming into the league two years ago, and with only 97 games under his belt, he's scored at a 0.37 PTS/G clip over that time. Given more ice time, including special-team usage, he should continue to develop and see ice time alongside the Bruins' second line. Minten adds a few blocks and Hits in there as well.

Pavel Mintyukov, D, Ducks

Mintyukov is a very exciting player to watch. His biggest problem blocking his development into a fantasy star is Jackson Lacombe. If Mintyukov can get second power-play minutes and produce there this season, he could stick his foot in the door for the conversation to take over that top power play. Albeit an unlikely scenario with how good Lacombe has been, it's not impossible.

Frank Nazar, C, Blackhawks

Nazar has produced well for a young player coming into the league on a less-than-lustrous lineup talent-wise. Up to 0.62 PTS/G last season in his sophomore attempt, he has some real promise as a complementary player to the Blackhawks' big two forwards (Connor Bedard, Anton Frondell) for years to come once the rest of the roster is fleshed out and these guys get some more experience under their belt.

Simon Nemec, D, Flames

Nemec has been asking out of New Jersey for a while now with their logjam, and I'm not sure he had Calgary in mind. With that being said, he's got a lot of opportunity there with such a thin roster. He'll be competing with Zayne Parekh for top power-play time, but he'll certainly be getting fed a lot of minutes, and once things settle, I think he'll be a valuable piece for fantasy rosters in the years to come.

Justin Sourdif, C, Capitals

I'm partial to this man after he got me five points the day I picked him up this past season. Finishing the year with 35 points in 78 games, he did it with only three power-play points. With a possible retirement likely to open a spot on the top power play in the near future, he has a genuine chance to grow his role.

Jesper Wallstedt, G, Wild

Wallstedt closed out the 2025–26 season—his second year in the NHL—with a 0.916 save percentage and a 2.58 goals-against average across 35 games. He's one of the most promising young goaltenders in the league, and he's just waiting for the runway to clear in order to take off. There's been talk of either him or Filip Gustavsson taking a plane ride to another city with their gear. Expect a solid-volume starter after this season.

Matthew Wood, C, Predators

Wood put up 30 points in 71 games last season despite averaging just 12:19 of ice time. On some nights he found himself alongside Steven Stamkos and Filip Forsberg, giving him a sharp glimpse of what it's like to face top-tier competition.

Logan Clarkson wrote 'Injury Ward' every week on DobberHockey.com

A promotional banner for Dobbernomics, a fantasy hockey platform. The banner has a dark background with gold and white text and graphics. On the left, the text reads 'UNLEASH YOUR INNER GM.' in large, bold, white letters, with 'GM.' in gold. Below this, it says 'Master the Market. Win Your League.' in white. In the center, there is a gold bull icon with a dollar sign above it. To the right, there is a screenshot of the Dobbernomics app interface, showing 'My Rosters', 'Live Trade Feed', and 'Value Meter' sections. At the bottom right, there is a large gold button with the text 'PLAY FREE NOW' in black. The website 'Dobbernomics.com' is written in white at the bottom center.



HOCKEY'S ADVANCED STATS (2026)

By Dobber

This is the 15th offseason in which I'm posting my advanced-stats analysis by team. I keep things straightforward for the layperson and make sure I don't get overly *statty*. I focus on a few key metrics that help me evaluate a player and make informed decisions about what lies ahead over the next year. As long as you don't hang your hat on a single statistic, there's a lot that can be revealed. This approach has proven hugely beneficial in developing a strong sense of what a player can do if given the right circumstances—and what those circumstances need to be.

Even if you want nothing to do with advanced metrics, these are worth reading because I present the conclusions for you. You never have to look at the numbers yourself.

Bottom line: *I skip the boring stuff and give you the fantasy-hockey takeaway.*

There are two key things to understand when using advanced stats. First, the sample size is small—very small. The larger the sample, the more accurate the information. A thousand games would be ideal, but we have to settle for 82. Using advanced stats from a single game to judge a player often leads to faulty conclusions. I generally start taking them seriously around the 20-game mark.

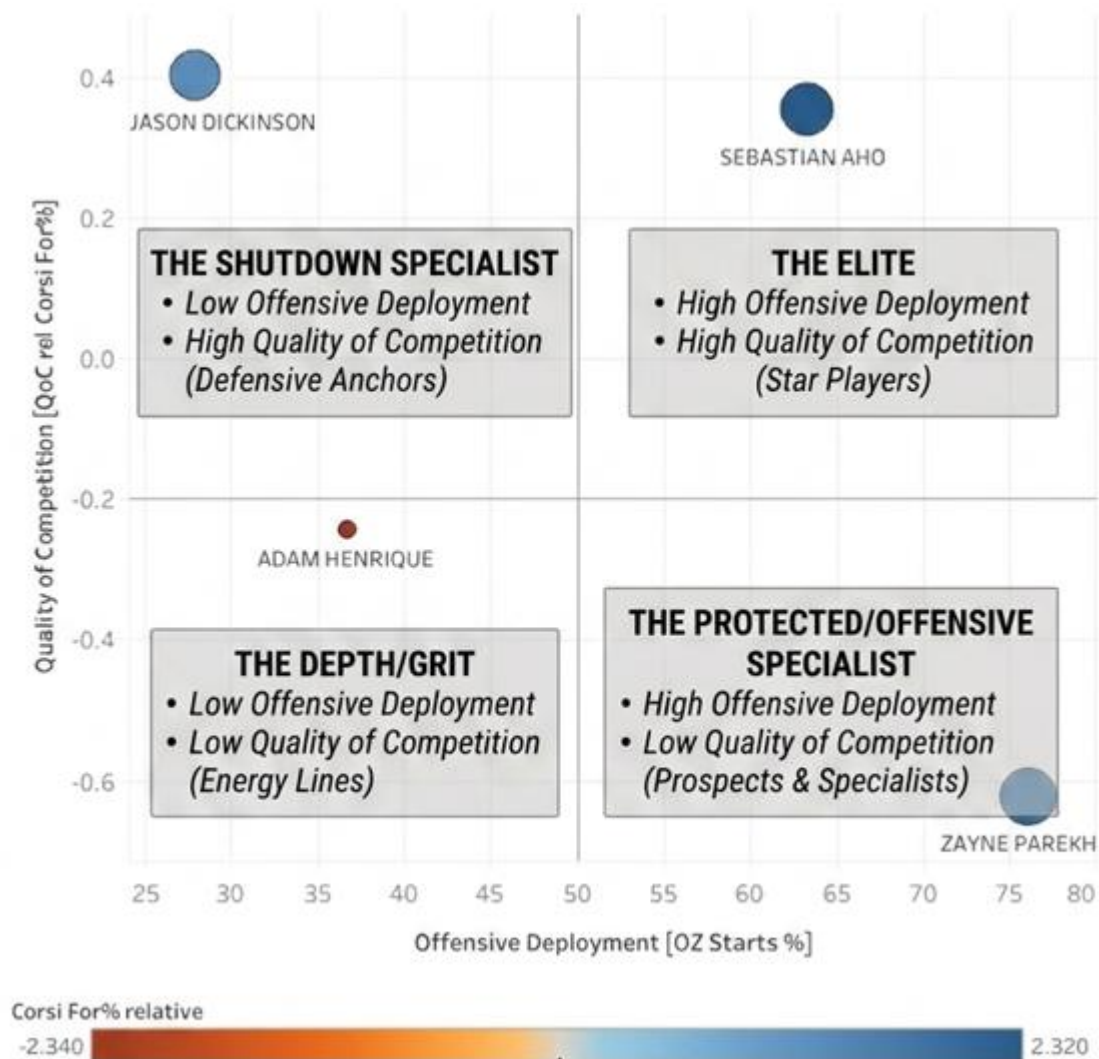
Second, you need context, which comes from **other** stats or even general knowledge of the situation. How old is the player? How good are his linemates? Where was he drafted? How strong is the opposition when he's on the ice? In which zone does he begin most of his shifts? How much did *puck luck* play a role? You can find answers to all of these questions in our [*Frozen Tools*](#) section. To gain the best perspective, you need to look at as many of those stats and details as possible. The bottom line: Don't plant your flag on a conclusion based on a few findings over a few games. Always assume you could be wrong. If you remember that mantra, you'll use the data more effectively. Far too many stat-heads on social media are willing to fight to the death over player stats from a single game or a single month, leaving no room for the possibility that they're wrong—and I just don't get it.

Rather than walk you through what each stat means, how to use it, and how to read the charts, I posted detailed instructions on the website a couple of years ago.

If you need them, here are the links

1. [Analytics – What to Use for Fantasy Hockey and Why](#)
2. [Advanced Metrics: How to Read the Charts](#)
3. [Breakout Threshold \(BT\) – Using Career Games Played to Determine Breakout Potential](#)

Quick Lesson on the Player Usage Charts



I labeled the four quadrants for you, and at a glance you can see their roles. This reflects how they're being used—not necessarily what they're good at or what their potential might be. For example, Parekh was heavily sheltered, but the deep blue shading indicates that he performed extremely well in that role and could likely handle tougher opposing lines. Had he been shaded dark brown, he wouldn't be ready. If a player is getting protected minutes like Parekh but is losing possession—shown in orange or brown—you can probably guess that his NHL job is in jeopardy.

In this example, Dickinson is a fantastic shutdown specialist, Aho is an elite offensive player, Henrique has shifted from defensive specialist to depth piece (and struggles in that role), and Parekh is a promising offensive prospect who is sheltered for now but probably not for much longer.

Dobber founded DobberHockey in 2005 and you can find him in the Dobber Sports Forum under the clever handle 'Dobber', as well as on X @DobberHockey



HITS, BLOCKED SHOTS AND SHOTS ON GOAL

By Eric Daoust

In each team section, Daoust presents a chart of the projected Top 20 players for Hits, BLKS, and SOG. These stats are subject to the bias of the stat trackers in each home arena, and that was taken into consideration—Hits more so than the other two. We actually have a **report** on *Frozen Tools* called *Arena Stat Bias* that reviews each of the SOG, Hits, and BLKS statistics at home versus on the road to determine the bias. If you're interested, you can [find those reports here](#).

As noted, some arenas are more generous than others. But throwing a check on another player or blocking his shot—those are good things. Getting two minutes in the sin bin, or earning a minus-1 simply because you happen to play on a weak team with an even weaker goalie who lets in yet another softie—those are bad things. Penalty minutes (PIM) and plus/minus may never completely disappear from fantasy hockey, but those stats are quickly losing ground to others such as Hits and BLKS.

Furthermore, in the Draft List (included with this Guide—just return to your download section and pick it up), **all players have projections for Hits, BLKS, and SOG**.

For projections of any other stat (over 120 available), take a look at our in-depth [Fantasy Hockey Geek](#) Draft Kit.

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TBL - Win Probability: +4.35

JAKUB DOBEŠ

W-L-OT
1-0-0

GAA
2.94

SV%
0.870

SO
0

CONFIRMED

Eric Engels 12

ANDREI VASILEVSKY

W-L-OT
0-1-0

GAA
3.91

SV%
0.789

SO
0

CONFIRMED

Erik Erdmann 12

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THE 5-ON-5 S% – 2026 EDITION

By Dobber

Shot percentage continues to rise, and save percentage has been dropping—so much so that it fell four percent last season compared with 2024–25, and **seven** percent over the last two years. In my dynasty league, we had to rush in a scoring-rule change for goaltenders because, under the old system, they were starting to become as valuable as a third-line forward. We now adjust the weighting of saves based on the NHL's average save percentage. Last season, you might think a goalie posting a 0.896 save percentage was pretty bad, eh? Wrong—he was exactly average. Thirty-five goalies reached a 0.900 save percentage, but only 26 of them played more than five games. The other 49 goalies who appeared in at least six games finished below 0.900.

What this all boils down to is that, per *Frozen Tools*, the league-wide shooting percentage for all situations (including empty-net goals but excluding shootout winners) was 11.1%. At even strength only, it was 10.5%. That's the new benchmark for evaluating high or low 5-on-5 shooting percentage.

Overall, the Dallas Stars led the league in shooting percentage with an astounding 13.5%. Montreal followed at 13.1%, and Tampa Bay and Pittsburgh tied at 12.6%. The Sabres ranked fifth at 12.5%. At the bottom, the Calgary Flames converted just 9.2% of their shots. The Devils (9.5%) and Kings (9.8%) were the only other teams to finish under 10%.

The 5-on-5 shooting-percentage stat measures luck—or randomness. It reflects the combined shooting percentage of a player and his teammates while he's on the ice. Theoretically, this number should move closer to the league average over a large sample size. Note that the 11.1% figure includes all even-strength situations, which can also mean 4-on-4 or 3-on-3. But it's the closest benchmark we have, so we use it.

Over an 82-game season, most players fall between 10.1% and 12.1% in 5-on-5 shooting percentage. These ranges widen with smaller samples, so at the 20-game mark, studying a player's 5-on-5 shooting percentage can reveal opportunities to **buy low** if he's far below 10.0%, or **sell high** if he's on a tear but sitting well above 13.0%.

For the last 14 years, I've highlighted extreme cases—players set to regress or players likely to improve simply due to this "luck factor." The projections have been shockingly accurate, so I'm continuing the analysis for a fifteenth year. This statistic is available in any player profile on *Frozen Tools* (see the player's Advanced Stats tab) or in any team's Advanced Stats report in the Report Generator. Here's how I did last season...

Declined?

Aliaksei Protas was about as easy a call to make as there ever was. Everyone and their mother predicted he would decline, and he topped my list as well. Sure enough, he dropped from 66 to 52 points in the same number of games (76). His 14.1% 5-on-5 shooting percentage was simply too inflated. Last season, that number fell to a league-average 11%.

Morgan Geekie, on the other hand, actually improved—playing with David Pastrnak will do that for a player. He took his astounding 21.9% shooting percentage, fired even more shots, and still finished with a 21.5% shooting percentage along with a 10.6% 5-on-5 shooting percentage, which is actually on the low side. So that one was a miss.

Alex Ovechkin was another easy call. Everyone knew he would decline from his 1.12 points-per-game average as he entered 2025–26 as a 40-year-old, and his 5-on-5 shooting percentage supported that expectation. Sure enough, he slipped to 64 points despite getting almost exclusively offensive-zone starts and nearly all available power-play time.

Other players on the list included Sean Monahan, who saw his production cut in half (win); Keifer Sherwood, who dipped only slightly (tie); Ryan McLeod (loss—slightly up and increased his 5-on-5 shooting percentage); Ivan Barbashev (tie); and Jason Zucker (another tie). So, it wasn't my greatest year, but with scoring spiking across the league, I'm not surprised. I went 3-2-3—probably my worst record in 14 years.

Overall, my record when looking strictly at 5-on-5 shooting percentage to identify players who will **decline** is now **89-12-12**. Even with the rough season, that's still ridiculously accurate.

Improved?

These are not as easy to nail because injuries can come into play—either an outright ailment that costs a player games, or something that hampers his play while he's out there (dragging down his production).

Last year I had Fedor Svechkov at 5.6%. His 5-on-5 shooting percentage did rise to 9%, but despite that, his production dropped. His ice time was cut, and his power-play minutes went to Matthew Wood. Loss.

Philipp Kurashev followed up his dismal season in Chicago (0.27 points per game) by easily surpassing those 14 points and posting 20. He played fewer games due to scratches and injuries. It's a win, but not an impressive one, and I still don't trust him to establish a reliable NHL career.

Next was Rasmus Andersson, who had just 31 points and a low 5.6% 5-on-5 shooting percentage. Last season he climbed to 9.5%, and his production jumped to 47 points. Big win.

Connor Zary was supposed to improve, but that didn't happen. Big loss. Mattias Maccelli, however, saw a nice jump from 18 to 39 points. As for Trent Frederic... well, let's not go there.

Conor Garland was identified as a rebound candidate due to his 6.4% number. That only nudged up to 6.6% last year, and his production actually worsened. His power-play time dropped significantly, and his overall ice time fell.

And finally, Brady Tkachuk. He had a very good season that *could* have been a bounce-back, but injuries held him to 60 games. He still exceeded his prior year's point total (54 up to 59).

Overall, I went 4-4-0. The cumulative record for the "Should Improve" section is now 63-30-19 (W-L-T).

Over 14 years, **this 5-on-5 shooting-percentage column boasts a 152-42-31 record** in projecting improvement or decline in extreme full-season cases. Very nice.

Let's take a look at this year's crop:

Should Decline...

Nikita Kucherov, RW, Lightning

The multiple Art Ross Trophy winner was dethroned last season and finished second. There's no question he'll continue to be one of the league's top scorers, even at age 33. But he scored 44 goals on a career-high 19.2% shooting percentage, and that won't hold—he's usually around 14%. His 5-on-5 shooting percentage was also a career high at 14.0%. Dropping five or six goals and seven or eight assists would still leave him in the 120-point range and among the leaders, but a decline is still a decline.

Oliver Kapanen, C, Canadiens

The surprise rookie scored 22 goals, but he did it with a 16.8% shooting percentage and a 14% 5-on-5 shooting percentage. He was glued to Ivan Demidov for much of the year, yet he declined down the stretch (five points in 21 games) and was even scratched in the playoffs. A sophomore slump is likely.

Viktor Arvidsson, RW, Red Wings

Arvidsson had a nice bounce-back season, finishing with a 0.78 points-per-game average—the second-best mark of his 11-year career. His shooting percentage was 14.7%. The last time it was that high was 2018-19 (17.4%), and he dropped from 34 goals to 15 the following year. His career-high 5-on-5 shooting percentage was 9.57 back in 2017... until last season, when it jumped to 13.9%.

Anthony Mantha, RW, Devils

Mantha finally enjoyed a healthy season and set career highs across the board. His 33 goals came on a 21.7% shooting percentage, which is very high—but for him, not outrageous, as he's been above 20% over his last 160 games. He doesn't shoot often; he picks his spots. Still, that number should regress a bit. His 13.3% 5-on-5 shooting percentage was also high, so his assists should come down as well.

Ryan Shea, D, Oilers

Shea played his first full NHL season and posted an impressive 35 points. But he did it with a 13.0% 5-on-5 shooting percentage and *zero* power-play points. Matching or beating that total this year will be difficult.

Mark Scheifele, C, Jets

Scheifele just had the most productive season of his career. But his 12.9% 5-on-5 shooting percentage was also the highest he's ever posted. He's obviously a top talent, but 90 points is more realistic than last year's 103.

Jamie Benn, C, Stars

The veteran has been a 50-point-pace player for the last two seasons, but at 37 he's likely to slow down significantly. His 12.9% 5-on-5 shooting percentage supports that expectation.

Ryan McLeod, C, Sabres

I'm a sucker for punishment. McLeod continued to overachieve offensively last season despite the high puck luck the year before, mainly because his ice time increased and he suddenly got power-play minutes. He actually had fewer even-strength points than in 2024-25, so even though I took a "loss" above, I was technically right. Now his 5-on-5 shooting percentage has climbed even higher—from 11.9% to 12.7%. And that power-play time? It vanished in the playoffs when Konsta Helenius arrived. That's not going to change—Helenius is here to stay.

Should Improve...

Cal Ritchie, C/RW, Islanders

It's natural—and common—to assume a rookie will improve in his sophomore season, so this one is a no-brainer. But in Ritchie's case, it's even more certain because his 5-on-5 shooting percentage was just 5.9%. He produced only 19 even-strength points, despite spending much of the second half on a line with Mathew Barzal.

Matt Coronato, RW, Flames

In his second full season, Coronato fell victim to the sophomore slump, dropping from 0.61 points per game to 0.56. But in a league where most players sit around an 11.0% 5-on-5 shooting percentage, his was only 7.0%. That's bound to rise.

Zeev Buium, D, Canucks

Buium stormed out of the gates with eight points in 10 games as a rookie, but struggled afterward—especially following his trade to Vancouver. He finished with 12 power-play points but only 13 at even strength. When your teammates shoot just 6.9% at even strength, points are hard to come by.

Timo Meier, LW, Devils

Meier's value, once high in San Jose, has plummeted in New Jersey. In three seasons there, he hasn't reached 54 points. But last season was *too* low. His 6.4% 5-on-5 shooting percentage was a 10-year career low, and his overall 9.0% shooting percentage was his second-lowest ever. A rebound is coming—maybe not to the level you hope, but a rebound nonetheless.

Marco Kasper, C, Red Wings

Kasper surprised everyone, myself included, with 37 points and 19 goals as a rookie. I didn't project him as a potential big scorer, but that debut forced us to reconsider. His sophomore slump was severe—barely half the points. But his 5.9% 5-on-5 shooting percentage was one of the lowest in the NHL and is bound to normalize.

Nico Hischier, C, Devils

A second Devil makes the list. After posting a points-per-game average of 0.92 or higher for three straight seasons, Hischier dropped to 0.80—his lowest mark in a healthy season since his rookie year. His 6.0% 5-on-5 shooting percentage suggests he left 12-15 points on the table.

Kevin Fiala, LW, Kings

Fiala's point totals have declined for three straight seasons, and so has his 5-on-5 shooting percentage. Coaching is partly to blame—Los Angeles was a playoff team but one of the weakest offensively. A new coach should help, and his 6.4% 5-on-5 shooting percentage was far too low.

MacKenzie Weegar, D, Mammoth

Since becoming a fantasy asset in 2021, Weegar has never posted a 5-on-5 shooting percentage as low as 6.6%—even back when league averages were lower. He spent the season handcuffed to unproven rookies in Calgary and wasn't freed until his trade to Utah. But in Utah, he didn't receive the same power-play usage.



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The advertisement features two cartoon characters standing back-to-back in a hockey arena. The character on the left has dark hair and glasses, while the character on the right has a beard and sunglasses. They are both wearing dark t-shirts. In the background, there is a large screen displaying 'HOCKEY ANALYTICS' with various charts and graphs. The arena has a red and black color scheme.



DOBBER'S TEAM-BY-TEAM PROJECTIONS

- (%) in the charts indicates the percentage certainty that the **prospect** has of making the team, or the percentage confidence that Dobber has that the **sleeper pick** will hit the given point total.
- **Just a quick note on a player's long-term upside.** You may notice that generally speaking the younger players have a higher upside than the older ones. This is because they have not yet established a pattern of production. Their upside could be dramatically lower in as little as a year from now. Whereas a 30-year-old is pretty set in terms of what he can do... a prospect's upside does not mean he will even *make* the NHL. Take the upsides with a grain of salt.
- **The (above) columnists' opinions may not necessarily reflect/match Dobber's...** or even each other's, for that matter. These extras are here to give you another perspective (i.e. some of their predictions/statements may be completely different from what you read below). The writers' opinions are not stifled and they are not forced to conform to a DobberHockey 'party line'. Another advantage to this Guide versus the other ones out there.
- **Goalie wins may not add up on each team** because a trade may be in the cards, or a goalie may miss time with a minor injury (if I knew who, then I would use that crystal ball for every prediction in his Guide!). There may also be too many GP totaled up for the skaters in our depth charts—again, this factors in trades and injuries.

Legend:

1 st Power play (2.4 PP minutes/game +)	 
2nd Power play (1.0 – 2.3 PP min./game)	 

Explanation of Other Terms:

- QS: Quality Starts. Games with save percentage above league average, or games with fewer than 20 shots and a save percentage above the league average.
- 3YP: Dobber's actual long-term projection for that player over his *averaged* peak three years in the future. This could be current year plus next two seasons for veterans on the decline, or it could be seven/eight/nine years from now in the case of an 18-year-old.
- Terms that you see for Advanced Metrics are defined on the website in the following articles: [Analytics – What to Use for Fantasy Hockey and Why](#) and [Advanced Metrics: How to Read the Charts](#)
- Breakout Threshold (BT) definition can be found here: [Using Career Games Played to Determine Breakout Potential](#)

Anaheim DUCKS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Chris Kreider	77	26	42	29	Leo Carlsson	72	32	74	23	Cutter Gauthier	79	41	74	24
Alex Killorn	78	17	30	42	Mikael Granlund	72	18	52	27	Beckett Sennecke	84	21	70	84
A.J. Greer	75	10	22	95	Ryan Poehling	75	12	32	12	Frank Vatrano	73	12	19	70
Nikita Nesterenko	42	7	13	8	Tim Washe	77	8	12	46	Sam Colangelo	17	2	4	4
					Nathan Gaucher	20	2	2	16	Troy Terry	43	12	36	10
Jeff Malott	37	2	4	22	Roger McQueen	14	1	2	14					
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Jackson Lacombe	78	12	58	24	Nick Jensen	72	3	15	13	Lukas Dostal	56	29	1	3.10
Pavel Mintyukov	76	8	31	23	Drew Helleison	69	3	16	41	Ville Husso	30	15	1	3.20
Tyson Hinds	70	5	16	8	Ian Moore	37	3	8	8					
Stian Solberg	17	3	2	20	Tristan Luneau	35	5	10	15					
Travis Mitchell	11	1	1	13										

Restricted Free Agents: Gauthier

On the hot seat: Carlsson, thanks to the offer-sheet fiasco, is being paid the highest salary in the NHL. There will be a lot of pressure to come as close as he can to actually earning his \$18M. In his three NHL seasons, he has missed 27 games, six games, and 12 games, so Job 1 will be staying healthy. His numbers jumped a lot last season, but he got off to a blazing start with 28 points in the first 21 games. Pretty much do that every quarter (i.e., $4 \times 28 = 112$ points) and he's earned his money. His fantasy owners would certainly enjoy that.

What to look for in camp: The unexpected cap issues in the offseason (Carlsson, Mintyukov) have put the Ducks in a bind they didn't anticipate. With Terry out to start the season, not only is there a spot up for grabs, but there is also a need for cheap players (i.e., prospects on ELCs) to fill them. Watch who stands out between Nesterenko, Colangelo, Gaucher, and McQueen. McQueen would make the team for his offense; the others for their defense.

- In mid-November there were a lot of questions about Lacombe. Is he for real? Was the prior year's 43 points his ceiling? At the time, he had just eight points in 21 games and fantasy owners were uneasy because he didn't have a track record. Hopefully, the 50 points he produced afterward (in 61 games) will help owners stay calm during any prolonged slumps.

- On December 9, Sennecke led all rookies in scoring with 26 points in 30 games. Teams adjusted, and he slowed to 34 points in the remaining 50 contests. But at 6-3 and 206 pounds—likely reaching 220—he'll push through added attention and become a prolific fantasy asset on brute strength alone, though he may need a couple of years to grow and gain experience.

- Carlsson usually played with Terry (when healthy) and Kreider. So, when Carlsson was sidelined for nine games in January, it's no surprise Kreider managed just two even-strength points. During that span, the next center in line was Granlund, who had eight points.

- Terry missed 20 of 23 games from January through March. It didn't really impact his linemates, so they weren't reliant on him as a key member of the troika (Carlsson and Kreider). This is good to know, given that he's starting the season

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Leo Carlsson	100	85	Nikita Nesterenko	70%		
Cutter Gauthier	92	77	Sam Colangelo	50%		
Troy Terry	88	72	Tristan Luneau	50%		
Beckett Sennecke	90	70	Nathan Gaucher	25%		
Jackson Lacombe	65	57	Roger McQueen	20%		
Mikael Granlund	65	52	Sean Farrell	20%		
Nikita Klepov	75	50	Yegor Sidorov	10%		
Roger McQueen	85	48				
Maxim Masse	78	47				
Chris Kreider	60	45				
Mathis Preston	75	45				
Nathan Gaucher	60	45	Sleeper	Pts	%	
			Leo Carlsson	85	20%	
Pavel Mintyukov	57	40	Roger McQueen	45	15%	
Lucas Pettersson	67	40	Pavel Mintyukov	40	10%	
Marcus Nordmark	70	40				
Nikita Nesterenko	53	38				
Sam Colangelo	52	38				
Tristan Luneau	50	37				

on IR. Kreider had 17 points in 21 games, while Carlsson had 10 points in 12 games. Gauthier was moved to that line in Terry's place.

- Granlund benefited most from Mason McTavish (now with St. Louis) being out of the lineup. He picked up six points in seven games and was moved to Sennecke's line.

Injuries:

Terry underwent hip surgery in June with an expected recovery time of 5–6 months, meaning he will likely make his season debut in November or early December. Move him down your draft boards... Newly signed Jensen underwent knee surgery in March with a six-week recovery time, ending his 2025-26 season... Poehling missed the final game of the playoffs with an upper-body injury, with no timeline for his return... Helleson missed the last three games of the playoffs with an undisclosed injury. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** *Granlund, Carlsson, Mintyukov.*

Breakout Threshold:

If Lacombe has another gear, he's hitting it this year. He has played 230 career NHL games and just posted 58 points, so a BT would be 72. Mintyukov has played 204 career games and now carries a massive contract with a \$7.2M AAV. The Ducks can't afford for him to fail. With Lacombe taking top PP time, Mintyukov will still see more than last year thanks to Olen Zellweger (now with Buffalo) and Jacob Trouba (San Jose) being gone, but he'll need to step up at even strength. Speaking of massive contracts, Carlsson made a dollar or two in the offseason. He's played 201 career games, and a BT for him would mean 84 points in 70 games, or a 100-point season if he stays healthy. GM Pat Verbeek needs a win here, so you know what he's praying for. Carlsson is 6-3, so he's a borderline 400-game BT candidate, but we're going with the earlier breakout.

Goalies:

Anaheim's 2026–27 goalie setup centers on Dostal, who enters the season as the unquestioned starter. His athletic style and overall consistency position him for a heavy workload, likely around 55–60 games again. The Ducks' defense lost a few names from last season, which could result in a more challenging environment for Dostal, who has not posted a GAA below 3.00 over his past four seasons. Behind him, Husso should serve as the primary backup. Once a top goaltending prospect, Husso is better suited to a supportive role than a starting one. The Ducks have also brought in Brossoit, who has played only one game over the past two seasons. How much he will be able to contribute is unknown. Dostal should carry the load, while Husso should handle back-to-backs and other stretches when Dostal needs rest. **Dobber's confidence that Dostal is the starter: 99%**

Contract Year:

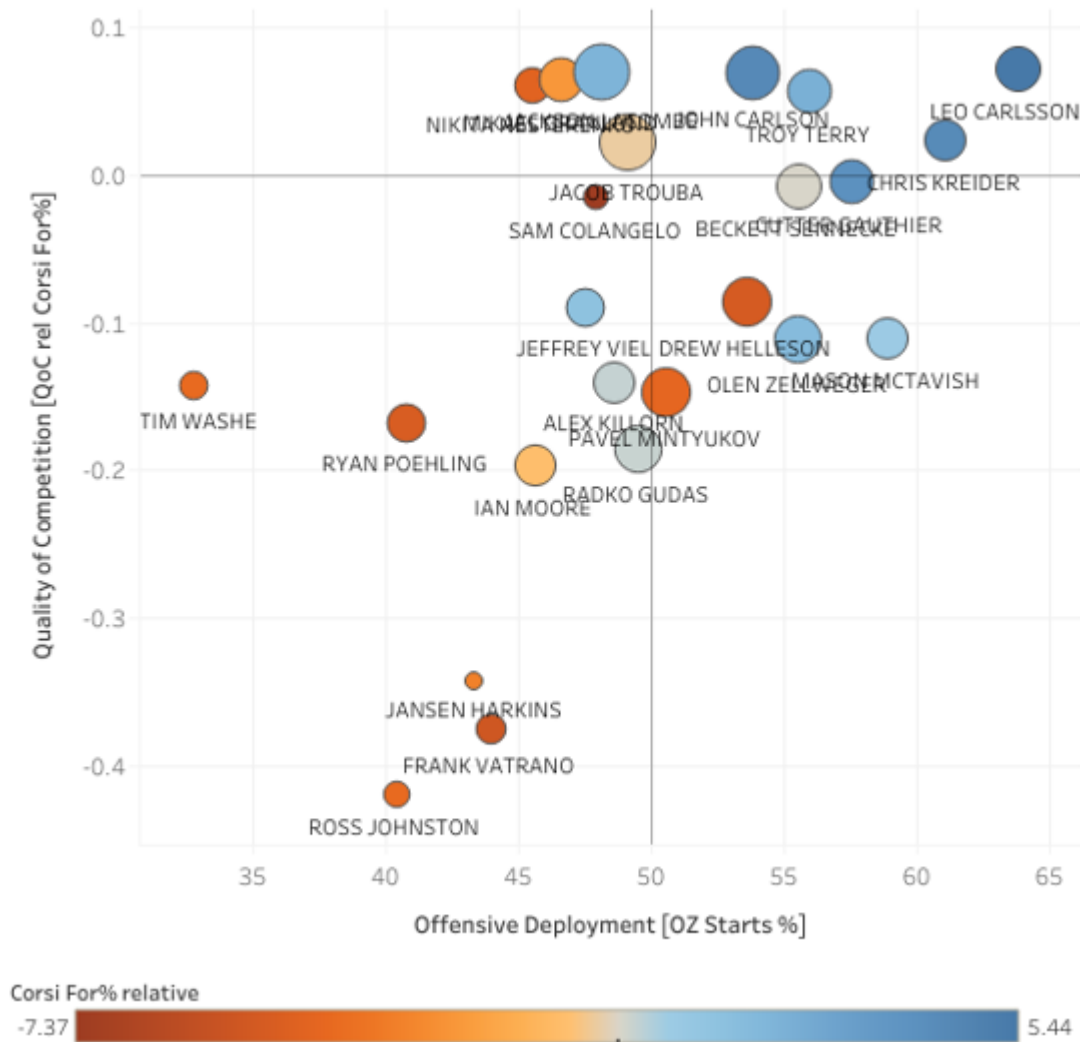
Before discussing players in a contract year, the major immediate concern is Gauthier. His situation has been complicated by Anaheim agreeing to match Philadelphia's offer sheet for Carlsson. This could have ripple effects among Anaheim's 2027 RFA and UFA. Fortunately, the RFA group is not a prominent one, although retaining Helleson and Luneau will become more important with the departures on the Ducks' defense... Being able to move off Kreider and Killorn's contracts will be helpful, assuming the Ducks don't do so sooner to accommodate Gauthier. These two 35-plus veterans will be attempting to land at least one more NHL contract.

2027 RFA: *Gaucher, Washe, Helleson, Luneau*

2027 UFA: *Kreider, Killorn, Nesterenko, Husso, Brossoit*

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Leo Carlsson		
Boom or bust	Chris Kreider		
Multicategory / Banger	Pavel Mintukov		
Salary cap bargain	Beckett Sennecke		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
A.J. Greer	29	205	82
Alex Killorn	29	62	124
Beckett Sennecke	27	109	210
Chris Kreider	19	64	154
Cutter Gauthier	32	67	316
Drew Helleson	90	86	62
Frank Vatrano	45	135	131
Ian Moore	48	26	48
Jackson Lacombe	133	70	164
Jeff Malott	18	102	33
Leo Carlsson	33	22	209
Mikael Granlund	50	36	137
Nick Jensen	94	56	58
Nikita Nesterenko	15	86	50
Pavel Mintyukov	122	61	106
Ryan Poehling	83	45	98
Tim Washe	47	193	85
Tristan Luneau	35	37	49
Troy Terry	13	2	103
Tyson Hinds	99	77	95

Dobber Advanced... DUCKS



* The cluster of bubbles in the top-left quadrant represents Nesterenko (dark orange), Granlund (light orange), and LaCombe (blue).

Observation: LaCombe is the clear standout among the trio in the top-left quadrant, as his blue bubble shows he is the only one successfully absorbing the team's toughest Quality of Competition. Nesterenko and Granlund are struggling to drive possession, and Nesterenko, in particular, is approaching "warning" status; his inability to drive play against top competition suggests his path to a meaningful top-six role is effectively blocked.

Fantasy Impact: LaCombe is your high-floor asset here—he's proving he can handle the defensive "heavy lifting" without cratering the possession numbers. Conversely, Nesterenko is a drop in most standard leagues, as his underlying metrics indicate his role is more likely to shrink than grow.

Observation: Vatrano is being deployed against the weakest Quality of Competition, yet he is still showing poor possession results.

Fantasy Impact: Previous seasons suggested Vatrano might have upside as a bottom-six checker, but this data shows he cannot be trusted to drive a checking line. Since he is no longer receiving prime offensive-zone starts or top-line minutes, his production is heavily dependent on the quality of his linemates rather than his own play-driving. Treat him as a peripheral scorer, not a core fantasy piece.

Observation: Zellweger thrived in his sheltered deployment, actively tilting the ice in the team's favor last year. Mintyukov handled a higher ratio of defensive-zone starts compared to Zellweger, which weighed down his possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: Zellweger was a "thriving" asset—capitalizing on his soft deployment to tilt the ice. Mintyukov is the "long-term" play; don't be discouraged by his orange bubble, as his defensive usage was clearly more demanding than Zellweger's. I'm sticking with Mintyukov as a potential breakout candidate, though he may ultimately need a change of scenery (i.e., a trade). Zellweger's new home in Buffalo could potentially fill the void left by Bowen Byram.

Observation: Washe has settled into the role of the primary checking-line center, handling the highest percentage of defensive-zone starts on the team.

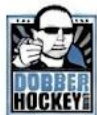
Fantasy Impact: Washe is effectively a negative asset in fantasy hockey unless your league rewards faceoff wins or heavy defensive peripherals. He is being used for damage control, not offensive production, and should be avoided in any format that prioritizes points or plus/minus.

Observation: John Carlson (now with Tampa Bay) drove positive possession in a high-leverage role while contributing 60 points last year.

Fantasy Impact: This is the definition of "set it and forget it." At 36, he remains an elite anchor for your fantasy blue line. His usage shows the coaching staff trusts him implicitly, and his results confirm he is still an elite producer. He is an ultimate target for a contending team seeking reliable, high-end production.

Observation: Carlsson received the team's highest offensive-zone starts, while McTavish remained in a sheltered role despite having 300 games of experience.

Fantasy Impact: This is a strong "hold" signal for McTavish. The fact that a 300-game veteran is still being sheltered is a red flag—he should be demanding tougher deployment by now. Carlsson is the "supernova" waiting to happen; the Ducks force-feed him offense, and he rewards them for it. Carlsson is the player to build your keeper league around.



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Ducks by the Metrics

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>CUTTER GAUTHIER</u>	R	76	57.5	980	0.881	9.9	54.6	51.7	69.7	74.6	61.3	3.2	14	50
<u>TROY TERRY</u>	R	61	55.9	990	0.887	10.3	54.2	58.6	64.8	71.7	50	3	14	36.8
<u>LEO CARLSSON</u>	C	70	63.8	974	0.885	8.9	56.3	62	67.3	71.2	62.1	2.9	15	40.5
<u>BECKETT SENNECKE</u>	R	82	55.5	983	0.894	8.9	51.7	44.5	69	70.8	61.9	2.5	15	40.5
<u>CHRIS KREIDER</u>	L	75	61.1	980	0.884	9.6	55.5	61.5	52.1	52.4	51.5	2.3	11	39.3
<u>MIKAEL GRANLUND</u>	C	58	46.6	975	0.896	7.9	52.4	58.2	63.6	65.9	59.1	2.3	11	47.8
<u>JOHN CARLSON</u>	D	16	53.8	1007	0.902	10.5	53.8	55.3	54.1	53.5	56	2.2	6	60
<u>MASON MCTAVISH</u>	L	75	58.9	964	0.872	9.2	52.1	37.4	61.2	56.6	78.6	2.1	9	37.5
<u>RYAN POEHLING</u>	C	75	40.7	1014	0.9	11.4	48.6	6.4	65.5	67.3	50	1.9	6	24
<u>JACKSON LACOMBE</u>	D	82	48.1	973	0.887	8.6	53.3	60.6	47.5	41.8	60	1.7	19	39.6
<u>NIKITA NESTERENKO</u>	L	29	45.5	992	0.917	7.5	49.2	1.5	75	75	0	1.5	2	25
<u>ALEX KILLORN</u>	L	82	48.6	983	0.9	8.3	52.4	28	53.2	55.1	41.7	1.4	10	55.6
<u>ROSS JOHNSTON</u>	L	62	40.4	1027	0.905	12.2	47.7	0.7	51.9	51.9	0	1.4	5	45.5
<u>JACOB TROUBA</u>	D	81	49.1	977	0.897	8	52.1	13.5	42.7	42.7	66.7	1.1	11	44
<u>OLEN ZELLWEGER</u>	D	76	55.5	1001	0.902	9.9	53.3	14.5	32.4	32.2	60	1	8	53.3
<u>PAVEL MINTYUKOV</u>	D	73	50.5	986	0.901	8.5	49.7	15.3	39.3	39.6	40	1	10	71.4

- Recall from the advanced article earlier in this document that the average 5-on-5 shooting percentage in the NHL was approximately 10.5%. However, that figure included 4-on-4 and 3-on-3 play, so a lower estimate—around 10.0%—is more appropriate. It's only a ballpark number, but it shouldn't be far off. Regardless, most of this team fell below that mark, with only non-fantasy-relevant players finishing above it. Players such as Granlund, Nesterenko, Trouba, and McTavish were victims of significantly poor puck luck.
- Zellweger and Mintyukov, both prolific power-play producers in junior hockey, each received less than 16% of available PP time. Getting traded to a team with a clear need in that area would do wonders for their numbers. Let's see what Zellweger does in Buffalo now and if he can land that PP2 QB role.
- McTavish was the primary driver on the power play, recording points on 78.6% of PP goals scored while he was on the ice. However, he played on the second unit (37.4% of available PP time), which limited his overall production. He is another strong candidate to pop now that he's in St. Louis.
- Kreider received the ice time and linemates needed to boost his numbers; however, based on his IPP and PP IPP, he wasn't a particularly strong contributor to scoring plays. A top-six forward and first-unit PP option should be involved in at least 60% of goals. Looking at Gauthier, Terry, Carlsson, and Sennecke shows where that even-strength IPP benchmark should be.
- Vatrano (not shown) had his PP time reduced to just 14% of available minutes, influenced by his low 41.7% PP IPP the season prior.
- Carlsson is an elite possession driver. He led the team in CF%, and as shown in the usage chart (previous page), he also led in relative CF% despite facing tougher opponents. Yes, he received the most favorable zone starts on the team, but that only highlights how much the coach relied on him for offense.

Key departures	Mason McTavish (STL), Jeffrey Viel (TB), Ross Johnston (STL), Jansen Harkins (TBL), Olen Zellweger (BUF), John Carlson (TB), Jacob Trouba (SJS), Radko Gudas (FLA), Petr Mrazek (UFA)
Arrivals	Jeff Malott (LAK), A.J. Greer (FLA), Nick Jensen (OTT), Laurent Brossoit (SJS)

Boston BRUINS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	
JJ Peterka🔴🟡	82	30	63	31	Elias Lindholm🟡🔵	77	16	46	26	David Pastrnak🔴🟡	82	38	105	55	
James Hagens🟡🔵	78	14	36	31	Pavel Zacha🔴🟡	81	24	62	28	Morgan Geekie🔴🟡	80	35	69	25	
Casey Mittelstadt🟡🔵	79	16	42	23	Fraser Minten	84	17	37	19	Marat Khusnutdinov	80	16	30	20	
Lukas Reichel🟡🔵	42	4	11	6	Sean Kuraly	77	7	18	41	Michael Eyssimont	73	10	20	59	
Tanner Jeannot	68	7	17	79	Brendan Gaunce	22	2	4	8	Mark Kastelic	74	8	21	130	
Alex Steeves	37	4	13	25	Matthew Poitras	25	4	9	7	Ivan Ivan	7	0	1	2	
Defense				Defense				Goalies				GP	W	SO	GAA
Jonathan Aspirot	63	3	13	32	Charlie McAvoy🔴🟡	66	10	54	67	Jeremy Swayman	56	30	2	2.75	
Hampus Lindholm	67	6	23	53	Mason Lohrei🟡🔵	77	7	26	22	Michael DiPietro	29	14	1	3.00	
Nikita Zadorov	81	4	21	144	Henri Jokiharju	60	3	16	18						
Will Borgen	82	4	16	51	Connor Clifton	69	2	10	64						
Frederic Brunet	40	3	7	12	Jordan Harris	18	1	5	5						

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: E. Lindholm has been the weak spot on the power play for a couple of years now. Now that they have Peterka—a German now playing for a German coach—you could see Peterka slot into PP1 over Lindholm. Lindholm's already declining production will obviously continue to decline in that scenario. Peterka, meanwhile, suffered last season without PP1 usage with Utah.

On the hot seat: Reichel was drafted 17th overall in 2020 as a skilled player with top-six upside. Now 24, he hasn't even come close to that. But he's 198 games in—his BT season—and he has a fresh start on a new squad (his third team). If he makes the NHL Bruins, watch to see his power-play usage.

- His PP ice time went down, and his overall production surged. Sound weird? It happened. Zacha's PPTOI dropped after the first quarter, yet in the second half he had 39 points in 37 games to finish the year, 30 at even strength. Same linemates throughout (Viktor Arvidsson and Mittelstadt), but very high puck luck.
- Further hurting Zacha's chances of a repeat is the fact that Arvidsson is now with Detroit. Zacha had five points in 11 games when Arvidsson was out of the lineup last season, and 60 in 67 when Arvidsson was in.
- McAvoy started slow, with 21 points in 29 games and minus-5. Zadorov was removed from the pairing, and McAvoy then partnered with Aspirot. McAvoy ended the campaign with 41 points in 40 games and plus-23. It would be tough to justify moving Aspirot from that pairing.

• When McAvoy was out of the lineup, H. Lindholm had six points in 12 games and two PPPTs, taking over as PP QB. That's not great, but better than what he was doing. The Bruins really have no secondary option. Lohrei had four points in 13 games with McAvoy out. Do not count on a bounce-back season from Lohrei; he is giving absolutely no indication that this could happen.

• It was a tale of two Khusnutdinov's: the one who had a five-point game on January 10 against the Rangers and tallied 14 points in 16 games from Dec. 16 through Jan. 17; and the one who had 16 points in the other 61 games. Which do you expect to show up this season? Bet on the latter version. Peterka replaces Arvidsson, but now Hagens is on the

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
David Pastrnak	115	100	James Hagens	65%		
Morgan Geekie	83	68	Frederic Brunet	45%		
JJ Peterka	75	65	Matthew Poitras	30%		
James Hagens	83	65	Ivan Ivan	25%		
Pavel Zacha	68	62				
Charlie McAvoy	73	58				
Fraser Minten	68	53				
Dean Letourneau	82	53				
William Zellers	72	48				
Elias Lindholm	65	47				
Casey Mittelstadt	63	47				
Marat Khusnutdinov	60	45	Sleeper	Pts	%	
William Moore	72	43	James Hagens	53	20%	
Matthew Poitras	65	42	Fraser Minten	50	20%	
Dans Locmelis	65	42	Marat Khusnutdinov	45	15%	
Mason Lohrei	50	38				
Lukas Reichel	65	36				
Frederic Brunet	47	30				
Alex Steeves	60	28				

roster (or likely will be). But it's really simple: if he plays with Pastrnak again, Khusnutdinov will set career highs, and if he doesn't, he won't.

- After returning from the Olympic Break on February 26, E. Lindholm managed just 11 points in 25 games and was minus-7.
- For what it's worth, Mittelstadt had seven points in six games with E. Lindholm out of the lineup.
- Despite the same linemates and similar ice time, Geekie managed just six goals and 13 points in the last 24 games. His shot percentage was too crazy and unsustainable to continue like that, and his numbers normalized. At the time, it was 25.4%. His S% ended at 21.5%. That's still high, but it's similar to his prior season.

Injuries:

Zadorov sustained a torn MCL in Game 3 of the first round against the Sabres, but he played through the injury. Based on the timeline needed to recover even from a severe tear (3–4 months), Zadorov should be fine for training camp. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Jeannot, McAvoy, H. Lindholm.

Breakout Threshold:

Reichel has played 198 career games, but he would need a huge camp and lots of deployment luck to start making an impact at this point. Still, if he's going to do it, it will be this year. Lohrei has played 191 career games, making this his BT season as well. Khusnutdinov is set to hit his BT around the midpoint of the season, as he has played 168 career games, which is why we have him as a sleeper pick.

Goalies:

The Bruins enter 2026–27 with a clearly defined crease led by Swayman as the No. 1. Swayman has appeared in at least 55 games over the past two seasons since Linus Ullmark left, demonstrating he can be a full-time NHL starting goalie. There's no reason—aside from injury—to think he shouldn't reach that games-played total again. Swayman's performance improved in 2025–26, increasing his quality starts from 29 to 38 in a similar number of games. Joonas Korpišalo being moved to the Rangers means that DiPietro steps in as the backup. He has earned trust through solid AHL development over the past three seasons. He should offer competent relief without threatening Swayman's role. DiPietro's athletic, aggressive approach can produce streaky results, but he's serviceable as a spot-start option. The Bruins should again operate with a traditional starter-backup structure. **Dobber's confidence that Swayman is the starter: 100%**

Contract Year:

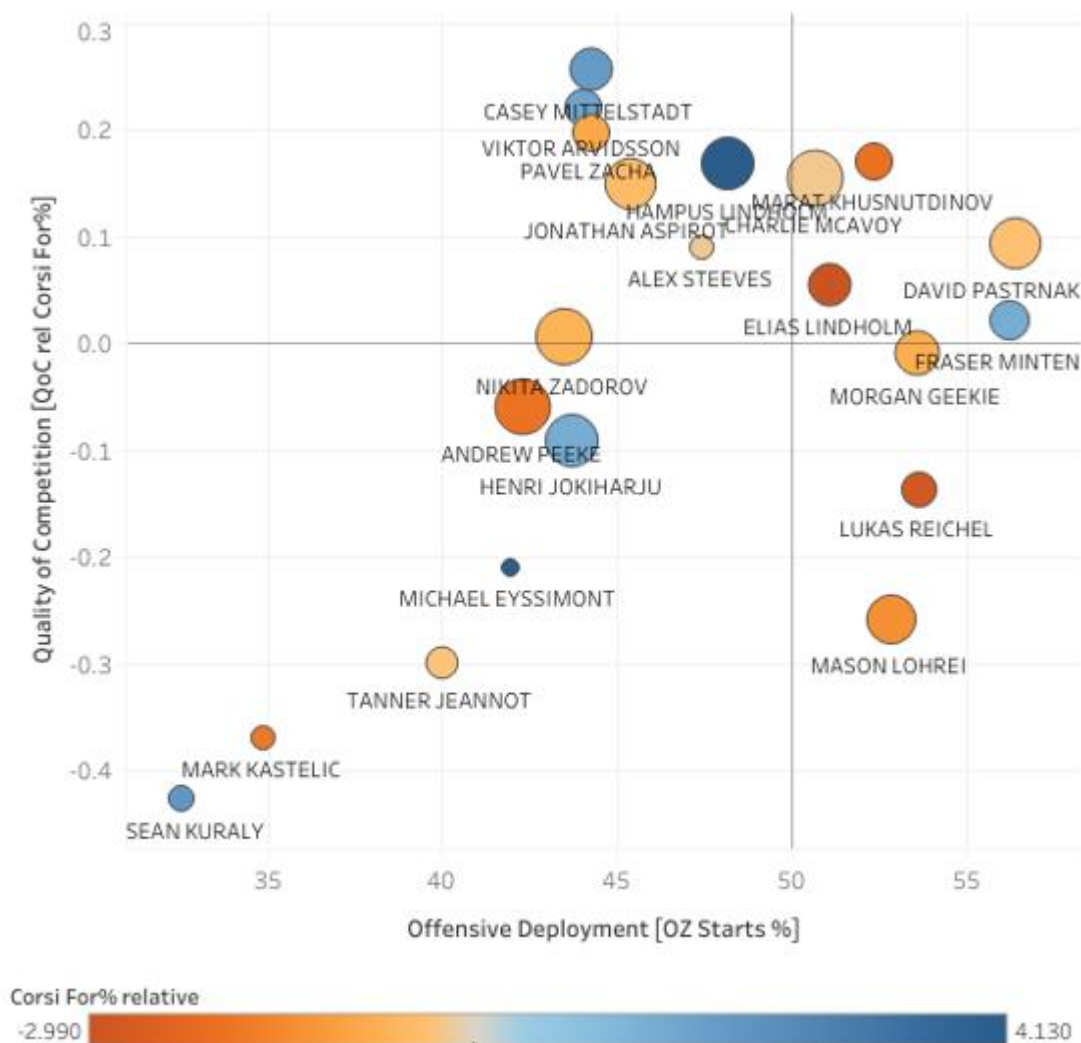
Minten established himself as a full-time NHLer in 2025–26. Taking another step this coming season will be important in determining what his next contract looks like. Minten's status in the lineup could be affected by what happens with Zacha, who has been the subject of trade rumors for a while. Zacha finished 2025–26 with a career-best 65 points, so another big campaign could price him out of the Bruins' budget if the two sides cannot come to an agreement this offseason. Zacha is the closest thing Boston has to a true No. 1 center.

2027 RFA: Khusnutdinov, Minten, Lohrei

2027 UFA: Mittelstadt, Zacha, Kuraly, Eyssimont, DiPietro

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Marat Khusnutdinov		
Boom or bust	Lukas Reichel		
Multicategory / Banger	Nikita Zadorov		
Salary cap bargain	Fraser Minten		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Casey Mittelstadt	24	27	103
Charlie McAvoy	127	86	119
Connor Clifton	98	203	55
David Pastrnak	26	73	296
Elias Lindholm	66	55	139
Fraser Minten	59	151	126
Hampus Lindholm	103	17	101
James Hagens	23	31	156
JJ Peterka	18	25	198
Jonathan Aspirot	88	80	57
Marat Khusnutdinov	47	54	96
Mark Kastelic	52	200	81
Mason Lohrei	96	35	92
Michael Eyssimont	27	78	132
Morgan Geekie	32	110	176
Nikita Zadorov	105	194	105
Pavel Zacha	27	65	146
Sean Kuraly	43	87	93
Tanner Jeannot	46	212	75
Will Borgen	107	119	82

Dobber Advanced... BRUINS



Observation: McAvoy is positioned in high-leverage deployment, hovering near the neutral line for possession impact.

Fantasy Impact: This is a hallmark of stability. He isn't necessarily driving play at an elite level, but he is handling top-tier minutes without being a liability. He is a "set-it-and-forget-it" fantasy defenseman who should continue to see similar deployment and produce similar offense.

Observation: Mittelstadt and Arvidsson are thriving in high-leverage roles (strong blue bubbles), while Zacha is struggling to maintain possession parity despite similar deployment. That line faces the toughest Quality of Competition and absorbs the harder minutes, giving the top line the freedom to post big numbers.

Fantasy Impact: Pasternak, Geekie, and their linemate (Khusnutdinov last season) are able to generate the best offense they can. Zacha's weaker bubble suggests he is replaceable on that line.

Observation: Both E. Lindholm and Khusnutdinov are receiving tough deployment (high QoC, high offensive-zone starts) but are underwater in possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: These players are effectively "on notice." They are producing—or holding onto roles—because of opportunity rather than dominance. They are high-risk fantasy targets because their roles are tenuous. If a legitimate top-six upgrade arrives via trade or free agency, these are the roster spots most vulnerable to being displaced. Lindholm's long-term contract likely protects him for now. Khusnutdinov's youth and upside should give him a longer leash, but it remains something to monitor.

Observation: Pasternak sits in a high-offensive-deployment role, yet his bubble is light orange, indicating he isn't a primary possession driver and can be affected by weaker linemates.

Observation: Minten is receiving offensive minutes and strong QofC, and his bubble is in the blue.

Fantasy Impact: Early scouting reports projected Minten as a bottom-six or middle-six two-way center with strong defensive instincts. Given his offensive-zone starts and early success, there may be more upside here—potentially a legitimate second-line center.



Bruins by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
DAVID PASTRNAK	R	77	56.3	1025	0.9	12.5	49.1	77.1	79.4	83.8	71.7	3.8	14	19.7
VIKTOR ARVIDSSON	R	69	44	1062	0.923	13.9	50.6	42.1	71.1	76.3	52.9	3.2	16	55.2
PAVEL ZACHA	C	78	44.2	1035	0.905	13	48.6	64	61.9	66.2	55	3	18	51.4
MORGAN GEEKIE	R	81	53.5	1018	0.912	10.6	48.5	66.1	66.7	73.3	57.1	2.9	15	51.7
ELIAS LINDHOLM	C	69	51	1000	0.893	10.7	47	60.6	57.1	54.9	60.6	2.3	19	61.3
CASEY MITTELSTADT	L	71	44.2	1037	0.904	13.3	50.6	37.3	57.5	57.4	58.3	2.3	12	44.4
CHARLIE MCAVOY	D	69	50.6	1026	0.902	12.4	48.9	62.6	49.2	45.2	59	2.2	20	40
ALEX STEEVES	L	43	47.4	1020	0.921	9.9	49.5	20.3	55.2	59.1	50	1.9	4	57.1
M KHUSNUTDINOV	L	77	52.3	1038	0.925	11.3	47.6	13.8	60	61.5	33.3	1.8	11	61.1
FRASER MINTEN	C	82	56.2	1040	0.936	10.4	50	21.1	59.3	60.8	50	1.6	7	38.9
TANNER JEANNOT	L	77	40	996	0.918	7.8	48.4	1.6	73.3	72.4	100	1.4	7	43.8
MARK KASTELIC	R	82	34.8	1024	0.937	8.7	47.2	1.5	64.7	65.6	100	1.3	3	30
MASON LOHREI	D	73	52.8	1040	0.94	10	47.8	29.9	44.8	42	62.5	1.3	9	47.4
SEAN KURALY	C	82	32.5	993	0.914	7.9	50.2	1	66.7	66.7	0	1.2	6	37.5
HENRI JOKIHARJU	D	41	43.7	1012	0.894	11.8	50.5	12.7	39.5	36.1	100	1.2	6	46.2
HAMPUS LINDHOLM	D	67	48.1	999	0.9	9.9	51.2	31.3	39.4	39.3	40	1.1	10	47.6

- After a contract year, a high S%, and a very high 5-on-5 S%, Geekie defied the statistical odds and actually improved his numbers. Playing with a superstar and increasing one's shot volume will do that. That said, he benefited heavily from his secondary assists, and it's clear that Pastrnak is the driver of that line. Remove Geekie from that line and you remove not only the goals created by Pastrnak's passes, but those 15 secondary assists quickly become six or seven. It's unlikely Geekie gets removed now that he has proven so effective, so this point is mostly academic—but still worth filing away.

- From the category of "super obvious things we already know": Pastrnak is too good for his line (83.8 ES IPP). Upgrading Khusnutdinov would almost certainly push Pastrnak into the next tier of superstars.

- Minten saw just 21.1% of available power-play time. However, his production throughout the year led to increased usage with the man advantage—rising from an average of 20 seconds per game in the first half to 1:42 per game in the second half. If the trend continues, it will meaningfully boost his output.

- But there is only so much room for Minten. The Bruins established their top unit and stuck with it: Pastrnak, Zacha, Geekie, Lindholm, and McAvoy. They will take roughly 60% of the PPTOI, leaving just 40% for Minten unless he can unseat Lindholm or Zacha.

- Mittelstadt, Zacha, and Arvidsson each had an inflated 5-on-5 S%, suggesting a decline in even-strength production is likely. With Arvidsson moving to Detroit, it puts the production of Mittelstadt and Zacha even more at risk.

Key departures	Viktor Arvidsson (DET), Fabian Lysell (COL), Andrew Peeke (UTA), Joonas Korpi (NYR), Georgii Merkulov (COL)
Arrivals	JJ Peterka (UTA), William Borgen (NYR), Connor Clifton (PIT)

Buffalo SABRES

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Peyton Krebs	83	13	44	70	Josh Norris	52	16	39	33	Tage Thompson	78	39	80	39
Zach Benson	72	17	54	47	Konsta Helenius	79	21	48	24	Josh Doan	83	24	59	26
Jiri Kulich	68	10	29	20	Ryan Mcleod	82	15	46	14	Jack Quinn	81	24	58	19
Noah Ostlund	69	13	31	16	Sam Carrick	79	8	15	77	Beck Malenstyn	81	6	11	31
Jason Zucker	69	20	44	50	Tyson Kozak	36	4	6	4	Justin Danforth	47	6	12	18
Trevor Kuntar	5	0	1	7						Conor Sheary	43	3	11	10
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Rasmus Dahlin	79	19	75	67	Mattias Samuelsson	68	8	34	29	U-P Luukkonen	41	26	1	2.75
Owen Power	81	8	42	21	Conor Timmins	46	1	11	23	Alex Lyon	26	15	2	2.95
Olen Zellweger	79	8	26	28	Radim Mrtka	11	0	2	4	Colten Ellis	20	10	1	2.85
Louis Crevier	79	5	16	52	Zach Metsa	60	3	8	4					
Dennis Gilbert	6	0	1	6	Ryan Johnson	18	0	2	7					

Restricted Free Agents: none

Camp battle: Kulich should be fully healthy, and between him, Ostlund and Zucker, there is only so much ice time and power-play time to go around. Zucker has been a staple on the power play. He wasn't that great at it last season, he's 34, and his contract is up after this season. The other two are young, high-skilled and high-upside players who need to be in the top nine. Zucker is in danger of a dip and losing some PP time. This jockeying should stretch into the season, but if Kulich and Ostlund are healthy, they are potentially far better players.

What to look for in camp: With Bo Byram gone to Chicago, Power gets his PP time back. Then again—the Sabres promptly acquired Zellweger from Anaheim, who is a 23-year-old puck-moving defenseman with upside. He'll probably be eased into such a role, but how things go in camp will determine the start for these two.

- We all knew he had it in him, but it wasn't until Krebs was taken off the fourth line and moved to the Thompson line where things finally clicked. After eight points in 31 games to start, Krebs tallied 31 points in 51 games (50-point pace) and was plus-19. His Hits and PIM slipped a little on the first line, so be forewarned that his job is much different on the first line than it was on the fourth.

- Dahlin finished the season with 45 points in his last 38 games. It's worth noting that he was partnered with Samuelsson throughout the year, but also came out for offensive-zone draws. With Samuelsson during that span (415 minutes) their CF% was 47.5% (385 chances-for vs. 425 chances-against). Partnered with anyone else (324 minutes) he and his partner were on the ice for 359 CF vs. 269 CA (57.1%).

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Tage Thompson	105	85	Konsta Helenius	99%	
Rasmus Dahlin	95	77	Zach Metsa	55%	
Konsta Helenius	85	63	Radim Mrtka	35%	
Jack Quinn	80	62	Trevor Kuntar	30%	
Zach Benson	82	60	Maxim Strbak	15%	
Josh Doan	70	58			
Jiri Kulich	77	55			
Josh Norris	80	55			
Noah Ostlund	77	55			
Ryan McLeod	67	52			
Ilia Morozov	65	48			
Peyton Krebs	68	45	Sleeper	Pts	%
Owen Power	60	45	Zach Benson	65	20%
Jason Zucker	57	43	Jiri Kulich	50	20%
Mattias Samuelsson	52	42	Konsta Helenius	65	15%
Olen Zellweger	55	42	Jack Quinn	65	15%
Brodie Ziemer	70	40	Peyton Krebs	60	10%
Radim Mrtka	52	40	Owen Power	50	10%
Daxon Rudolph	52	38	Olen Zellweger	40	10%

- That's two seasons in a row now where Quinn really picked up his game in the second half. Keep that in mind and lower him down your draft lists (and acquire him in November for cheap). After eight points in 20 games, he then posted 43 in 62 (57-point pace). He had 34 in 50 to end 2024-25—very similar pace.

- Timmins got a new lease on life, getting a second chance with the Sabres when they acquired him and paired him up with Power, giving him nearly 20 minutes per game. That didn't work, so he was rolled back to 19 minutes with new partner Byram. Then he got hurt. Again. Upon his return, he was relegated to the bottom pair. Once a top prospect for Colorado, the now-28-year-old will never reach that potential.

- Zucker started off with a whopping 18 points in 21 games. His production settled into his usual window around the time the Sabres started winning games like crazy (27 in 41).

- Zellweger posted 13 points in a 23-game span from Nov. 6 through Dec. 20. He was primarily partnered with Jacob Trouba during that run, and 11 of those points were at even strength.

Injuries:

Kulich had a blood clot removed from his ear after his season ended last November. He is hopeful that he will be ready for the coming season, but keep an eye on this situation... Danforth (kneecap) was nearly ready to return during the Sabres' playoff run... Ostlund (lower body) missed the second round of the playoffs... Carrick (arm) missed most of the playoffs. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Ostlund, Benson, Kulich, Zucker, Norris, Samuelsson, Sheary, Timmins.

Breakout Threshold:

Sometimes the BT number of 200 career games can be super accurate, especially if Benson continues to roll. He hit his BT with 11 games left in the season—and he had 14 points in his last 14 games and then enjoyed a fantastic postseason. He's primed and ready, and we have him as our top sleeper. Zellweger is 36 games away from his BT, hitting it around the midpoint of the season. Power is a big man at 6-6, and he'll enter his BT season next year.

Goalies:

Rumors continue to swirl about a potential Connor Hellebuyck trade to Buffalo. In the meantime, the Sabres will send out a Luukkonen/Lyon tandem, which wasn't bad in the regular season but faded at different points during the playoffs. Both goalies started 34 games while posting similar numbers. Luukkonen separates himself because he carries a higher cap hit (\$4.75 million) and more term (three additional seasons). Lyon has been a depth goalie throughout his career, with his best years coming in his 30s. The goaltending could be split down the middle again this season, but Luukkonen is still considered the favorite. There's also third goalie Ellis, who is not waiver-exempt and could factor in more should Luukkonen or Lyon be injured or slump. **Dobber's confidence that Luukkonen is the starter: 80%**

Contract Year:

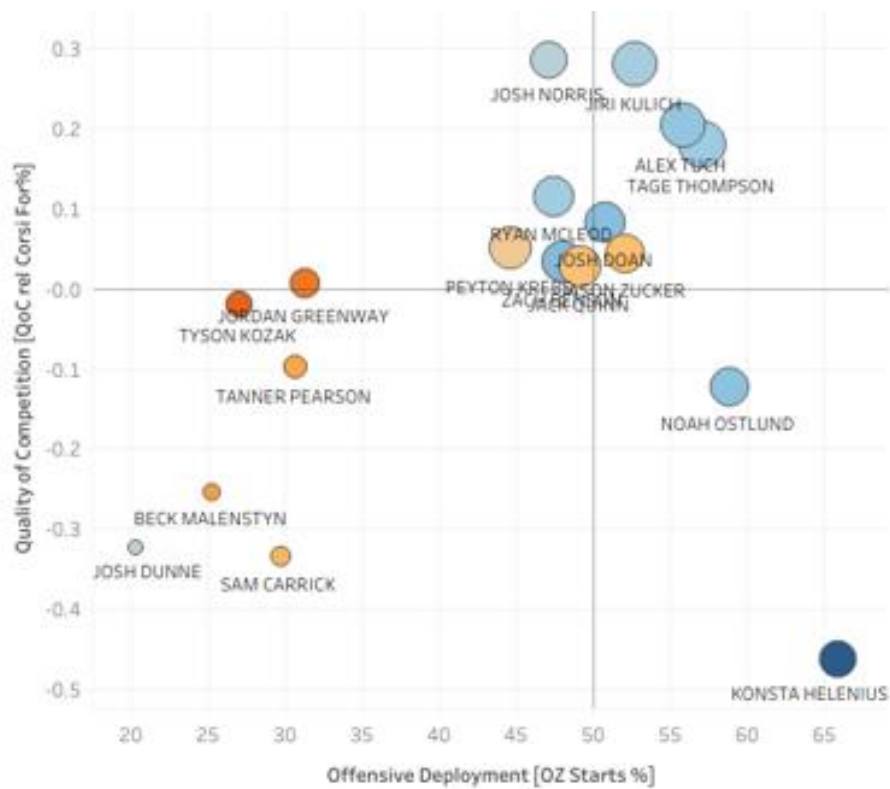
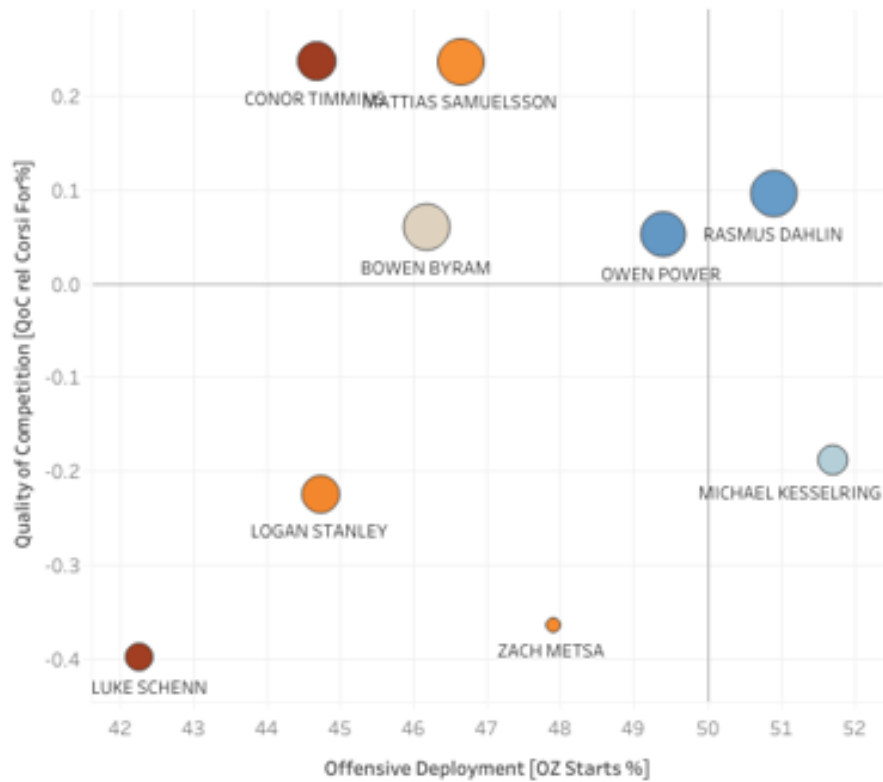
With plenty of young forwards jockeying for position, Quinn and Ostlund have their work cut out for them in their RFA season. Both made strides in their NHL careers in 2026–27, but retaining a spot in the top nine will be important... Zucker has been an important veteran on a young team, but it's possible the Sabres move on from him to continue the youth movement. The 34-year-old may have to land his next contract elsewhere... Lyon and Ellis will try to earn as many starts as possible to secure at least a backup role somewhere next offseason. Ellis, in particular, will need to prove he can be more than a third goalie.

2027 RFA: Quinn, Ostlund, Crevier

2027 UFA: Zucker, Danforth, Carrick, Timmins, Gilbert, Lyon, Ellis

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Zach Benson		
Boom or bust	Jiri Kulich		
Multicategory / Banger	Mattias Samuelsson		
Salary cap bargain	Tage Thompson		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Beck Malenstyn	73	243	65
Jack Quinn	24	49	194
Jason Zucker	23	59	131
Jiri Kulich	43	46	129
Josh Doan	33	87	183
Josh Norris	31	36	94
Justin Danforth	35	82	64
Konsta Helenius	26	88	142
Louis Crevier	111	132	111
Mattias Samuelsson	122	116	88
Noah Ostlund	38	6	83
Olen Zellweger	93	44	134
Owen Power	109	32	145
Peyton Krebs	37	208	100
Rasmus Dahlin	114	82	213
Ryan Mcleod	35	17	91
Sam Carrick	39	102	71
Tage Thompson	37	80	257
Zach Benson	29	51	145
Zach Metsa	54	9	42

Dobber Advanced... SABRES



** To better clarify the usage charts, I provided defensemen and forwards separately. Still, the cluster in the forwards chart consists of Benson (light blue), Quinn, and Zucker (light orange bubbles).*

Observation: The Sabres have successfully implemented a tiered defensive system in which Dahlin and Power are strategically sheltered with offensive-zone starts. Samuelsson, Timmins, and Byram shouldered the heavy defensive workload against elite competition with more defensive-zone starts. The remaining defensemen receive zone starts against depth lines.

Fantasy Impact: This is the ideal environment for your fantasy stars. Dahlin and Power are maximized for point production, while the defensive wall trio provides the necessary support. Since Samuelsson and Dahlin are partners, this chart shows how Dahlin receives additional offensive-zone starts with other partners (just for the faceoff and any immediate chances created).

Observation: There is a clear performance gap between younger rising stars Benson and Doan and an established middle-six veteran like Zucker. Benson and Doan also appear further along than fellow first-rounder Quinn.

Fantasy Impact: Benson and Doan outperformed the other two in possession metrics despite similar deployment. This indicates they are ready for a promotion. In dynasty or keeper leagues, this is your signal to prioritize them—they have both underlying efficiency and upward trajectory that Zucker lacks. In limited games and highly sheltered minutes, Helenius is also showing promising signs.

Observation: Top-six offensive engines like Norris and Kulich (in limited games) dominated their high-leverage minutes, with their possession metrics aligning perfectly with their tough deployment.

Fantasy Impact: These would be the Sabres' "must-own" offensive assets were it not for their injury history and future risk. They are converting opportunity into legitimate ice-tilting performance. While other players may be "on notice," Norris and Kulich are producing at a sustainable rate.

Observation: Thompson is effectively driving possession while maintaining a blue bubble in standard deployment, confirming he is a multi-dimensional offensive anchor.

Fantasy Impact: A blue-bubble Thompson is a premier fantasy asset. He is more than a goal-scorer—he is a play-driver. His ability to maintain possession parity while being relied upon for offense makes him a cornerstone of any fantasy roster. Pair him with high-upside wingers, but rest assured he is the engine of his line.

Observation: Shutdown specialists like Jordan Greenway (now with Chicago) and Kozak operated in high-pressure, defensive-zone scenarios, resulting in the expected orange possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: Do not treat their possession numbers as a red flag—they reflect their role. These players are not fantasy-relevant for points, but they are essential real-world contributors. They are strictly for deep leagues that track peripherals such as Hits and blocks. If you are chasing points, look past them entirely.

Observation: Krebs is trending toward a more permanent top-line offensive role, as his deployment has shifted toward more frequent offensive-zone starts throughout the season.

Fantasy Impact: This is one "buy" signal—though only one of several needed. The coaching staff is clearly experimenting with Krebs in a more offensive capacity, and his production is scaling with that opportunity. Helenius is likely to cut into any PP time, and a returning Kulich could challenge his spot in the top six.

Sabres by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>TAGE THOMPSON</u>	C	81	56.4	1011	0.902	10.9	50.2	70.4	71.7	75.7	63.2	3.1	13	31.7
<u>JOSH NORRIS</u>	C	44	46.8	1055	0.93	12.5	51.1	63.3	58.6	64.1	47.4	2.9	8	38.1
<u>JASON ZUCKER</u>	L	62	52	1022	0.911	11.1	49.6	67.4	63.4	70.7	53.3	2.8	10	47.6
<u>ALEX TUCH</u>	R	79	55.5	1045	0.92	12.5	51.3	33.1	66.7	68.8	75	2.6	15	45.5
<u>ZACH BENSON</u>	L	65	47.6	1042	0.925	11.7	52	35.7	60.6	67.3	35.7	2.5	13	43.3
<u>RASMUS DAHLIN</u>	D	77	50.6	1021	0.913	10.8	51.9	69.5	56.5	55.3	61.1	2.4	29	52.7
<u>JOSH DOAN</u>	R	82	50.2	1000	0.895	10.5	51.6	55.7	57.1	58.3	54.8	2.4	7	25.9
<u>JACK QUINN</u>	R	82	48.8	1036	0.921	11.5	49.2	44.9	66.2	66.7	64.7	2.4	11	35.5
<u>RYAN MCLEOD</u>	C	81	47.1	1031	0.904	12.7	50.7	31.8	56.7	60.5	61.5	2.3	15	36.6
<u>PEYTON KREBS</u>	L	82	44.1	1016	0.912	10.4	48.4	1.8	62.9	62.3	100	2.1	9	33.3
<u>NOAH OSTLUND</u>	C	60	58.3	1030	0.928	10.2	51.3	27.5	60	58.3	75	1.9	7	43.8
<u>M SAMUELSSON</u>	D	78	46.3	1036	0.916	12	47.3	1	39	39.8	0	1.4	16	57.1
<u>BOWEN BYRAM</u>	D	82	45.7	1010	0.901	10.9	49.5	32	39	38.6	50	1.3	15	50
<u>OWEN POWER</u>	D	81	49.2	1012	0.915	9.7	51.9	18.8	33.7	34.2	0	1	15	71.4
<u>BECK MALENSTYN</u>	R	81	25.4	987	0.916	7.1	45.8	0.3	53.8	60.9	0	0.9	2	28.6
<u>ZACH METSA</u>	D	43	46.9	1086	0.961	12.5	46.8	0.7	24	26.1	0	0.8	4	100

- With all the young rising talent on this team, it was interesting to see Zucker sit third in Pts/60 with 2.8. The 34-year-old is under contract for another year. In his 15 NHL seasons, he has reached 2.8 in this stat only once—back in 2017–18. His Pts/GP was exactly 0.73 in each of his two years with Buffalo.
- Norris has poor PP IPP numbers on the top unit, which suggests he may be a candidate to lose that spot. Meanwhile, Tuch was a prolific PP contributor on the second unit. Since Alex Tuch is gone to Washington, Ostlund, Helenius, and Kulich are candidates to slide into that role at Norris's expense. Put your money on the rookie Helenius—not necessarily to start the season, but eventually to win the job.
- Benson is on the second unit but hasn't been productive there (35.7%). Losing that PP spot (with Kulich returning and Helenius arriving) would seriously damage his fantasy outlook, even with his impressive even-strength production.
- The Sabres have several high-upside PP quarterbacks, but none can touch Dahlin. As long as he continues to see nearly 70% of available PP time—and that won't change anytime soon—players like Zellweger and Power will be left fighting over the scraps.
- Unlike JJ Peterka, the player he replaced, Doan posted solid numbers without an inflated 5-on-5 S%. Combined with a low secondary-assist rate, the outlook is strong that he can repeat—and even exceed—last season's offense.
- McLeod saw a career-high 31.8% of available PP time. But you can probably kiss those eight PPpts goodbye given the return of Kulich and the arrival of Helenius. He is a strong candidate for a decline, especially considering his 12.7% 5-on-5 S% (a team high).
- Samuelsson had a 39.8 ES IPP, indicating he was mostly along for the ride when his teammates scored at even strength. That said, if he can get 41 points "just along for the ride," that's a pretty solid return. There isn't much higher he can go from here. His high 5-on-5 S% was driven by playing with Dahlin.

Key departures	Alex Tuch (WSH), Jordan Greenway (CHI), Bowen Byram (CHI), Michael Kesselring (SJS), Logan Stanley (UFA), Luke Schenn (VAN), Devon Levi (EDM)
Arrivals	Olen Zellweger (ANA), Louis Crevier (CHI), Dennis Gilbert (OTT)

Calgary FLAMES

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Matvei Gridin	81	19	55	28	Morgan Frost	80	20	48	25	Matt Coronato	82	25	57	26
J Huberdeau	75	17	44	44	Ryan Strome	76	14	38	68	Joel Farabee	84	21	41	34
Connor Zary	75	18	43	23	Mikael Backlund	84	16	36	25	Martin Pospisil	74	5	20	94
Y Sharangovich	80	20	35	12	Tyson Gross	67	8	11	34	Maxim Tsyplov	65	5	11	15
Samuel Honzek	59	7	13	12	Rory Kerins	34	3	14	6	Adam Klapka	80	13	23	110
Brennan Othmann	51	4	9	41	Ben Jones	19	1	2	2	Sam Morton	22	3	5	10
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Kevin Bahl	79	3	17	56	Simon Nemec	78	16	46	37	Dustin Wolf	58	24	2	2.85
Jake Middleton	76	5	16	66	Zach Whitecloud	78	3	15	36	Devin Cooley	28	8	0	2.80
Yan Kuznetsov	70	4	13	23	Zayne Parekh	75	11	38	30					
Joel Hanley	56	1	5	33	Hunter Brzustewicz	71	6	15	8					
Brayden Pachal	57	2	8	64	Mike Benning	36	3	11	6					

Restricted Free Agents: none

Camp battle: It's a 22-year-old defenseman with high upside versus a 20-year-old defenseman with high upside. Nemec versus Parekh. A second overall pick (2022) versus a ninth overall pick (2024). Nemec is more well-rounded and more experienced, while Parekh has slightly higher offensive upside. Who comes out of camp with PP1 QB duties will get a head start on bigger numbers this year. Bet on experience and pedigree: Nemec. That doesn't mean it's permanent, but bet on him at least for the coming year.

Future fantasy stud: On one hand, Gridin becomes a go-to player on a team that is lacking them. On the other hand, it's Calgary, a very low-scoring team. Being potentially the top offensive gun is one thing, but with no elite offensive teammates to pass to, the production becomes capped. But he has stardom in his future.

- Gridin, after a great camp, initially made the team. But he was a little overwhelmed at times and was sent to the Wranglers, where he really did well despite being a 19-year-old playing against men. When he was called back to the NHL, he made it hard for the team to send him back down. He ended up getting 14 points in his last 20 games and heads into this season as the top candidate to lead the Flames in scoring.

- On a deep Anaheim team, a declining Strome had fallen out of favor and into the press box. Too many better options. That's not the case in Calgary, where he was given top-six minutes and secondary PP time. He had 12 points in 19 games after joining the team (52-point pace).

- Gridin injected more offense into the lineup, and Frost was a beneficiary. Frost ended the season with 16 points (10 goals) in his last 24 games (0.67) after just 27 in his first 58 (0.47).

- It seemed like when the team was struggling and really needed something—anything—reliable old Backlund was there once again. Now 37, Backlund posted his highest point total in three years. After 26 points in 41 games, he had 17 in the next 41, as if riding off into the sunset after Gridin arrived.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Matvei Gridin	78	63	Matvei Gridin	100%	
Matt Coronato	83	58	Samuel Honzek	99%	
Zayne Parekh	80	55	Zayne Parekh	90%	
Morgan Frost	70	53	Hunter Brzustewicz	85%	
Simon Nemec	70	53	Tyson Gross	50%	
Connor Zary	73	52	Rory Kerins	45%	
Jonathan Huberdeau	67	50	Mike Benning	40%	
Samuel Honzek	67	50	Brennan Othmann	35%	
Cole Reschny	75	50	Aydar Suniev	30%	
Cullen Potter	75	48	Sam Morton	20%	
Chase Harrington	73	48	Abram Wiebe	20%	
Ethan Wyttenbach	75	45	Sleeper	Pts	%
Carson Carels	62	43	Matvei Gridin	60	20%
Joel Farabee	65	40	Matt Coronato	60	20%
Ryan Strome	65	40	Simon Nemec	60	15%
Andrew Basha	70	40	Connor Zary	50	10%
Aydar Suniev	65	40			
Chase Harrington	73	40			
Jack Hextall	67	40			

- Farabee really clicked with Backlund and Blake Coleman (now with Minnesota). After Nazem Kadri was traded to Colorado at the trade deadline, Farabee was moved to that line and tallied 18 points in his last 29 games. He had 20 in 53 before that.

- Nemec started off last season with 12 points in 17 games, all at even strength (wasn't getting PP usage at the time). When he did get power-play time later in the season, he only managed two PPTs despite about 84 total minutes. If he doesn't figure it out, then Parekh would take over.

Injuries:

Huberdeau underwent season-ending hip surgery in early February and is expected to be 100% ready for training camp. **UPDATE: He will not be ready to start camp. He should be ready to start the season, but that is not 100% assured. We're tweaking his projected games down to 75...** Zary missed the final game of the season with what appears to be a minor injury... Honzek (*upper body*) underwent surgery in November with a six-month recovery. He practiced in late March but did not return during the season... Perhaps this was simply the Flames shutting players down because they were out of the playoffs, but these defensemen saw their seasons end early: Bahl – 5 games (*lower body*), Kuznetsov – 3 games (*upper body*), Hanley – 10 games (*upper body*). **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys: Zary, Pospisil, Honzek.**

Breakout Threshold:

Both Coronato (192 career games) and Zary (191) are hitting their BT this season, and both have tremendous upside, with Coronato looking more promising due to his durability. Either of them hitting the 60-point mark would be a breakout, and either of them could certainly do that and more. A little further away, hitting their BT in January, are Pospisil and Nemec.

Goalies:

The Flames enter 2026–27 with the 25-year-old Wolf as their unquestioned full-time starter. Wolf has handled a 50-plus-game workload for the past two seasons. For the rebuilding Flames, he is the most valuable player and should appear in 50+ games again. After trading some veterans, the Flames will send out a mostly inexperienced defense in front of Wolf, which could lead to streaky results that may be difficult to stomach in fantasy leagues. Cooley wasn't expected to play much in 2025–26, but he turned out to be much better than anticipated. A 29-year-old minor-league veteran, Cooley could provide decent relief without cutting into Wolf's workload significantly unless Wolf really struggles. Either Arsenii Sergeev or Owen Say will be summoned from the AHL Wranglers in case of injury, as Ivan Prosvetov has returned to the KHL. **Dobber's confidence that Wolf is the starter: 99%**

Contract Year:

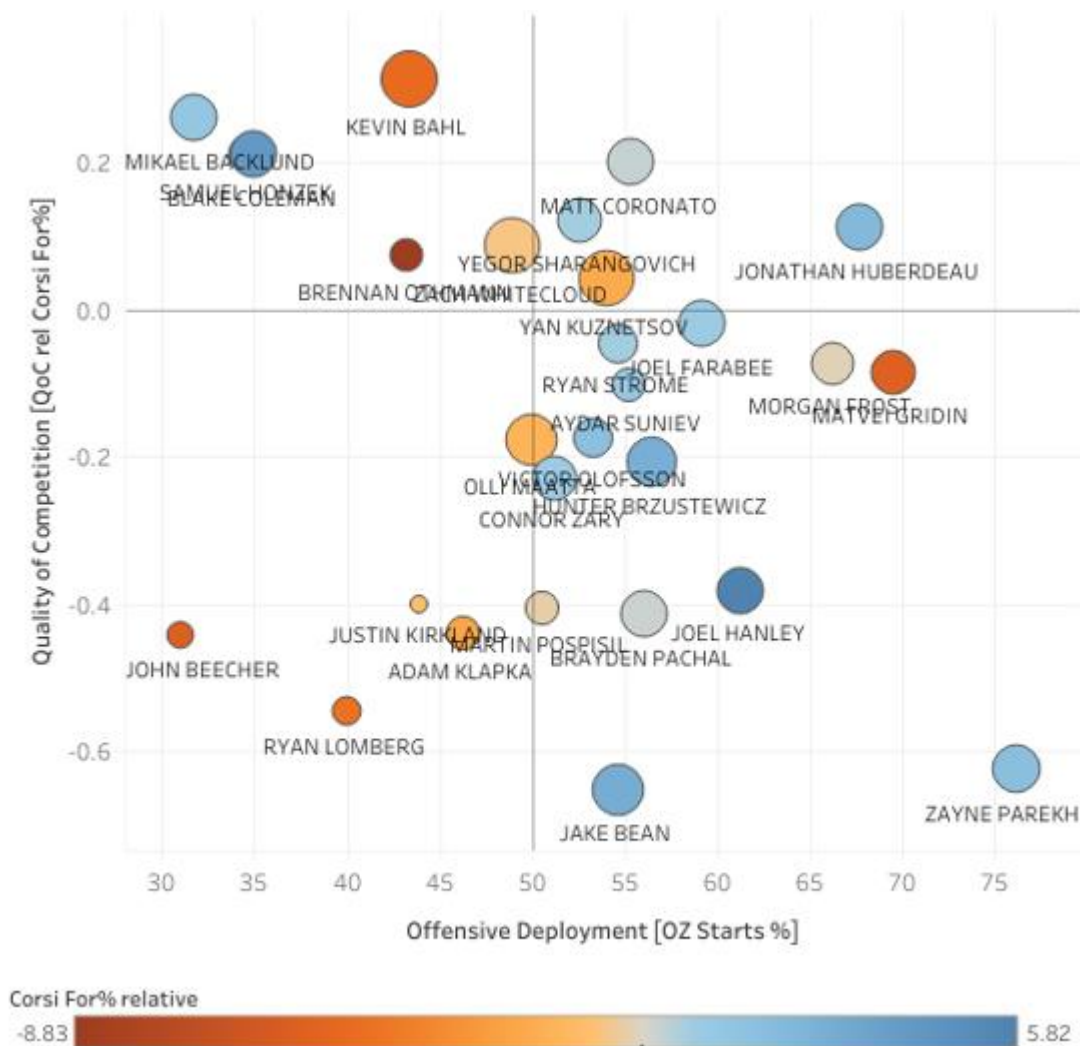
As the Flames play the long game with their rebuild, the 6-8, 235-lb. Klapka has the kind of physical presence they will likely want to keep around. This season could go a long way toward ensuring he becomes a fixture in the Flames' lineup, particularly if he can improve his offense... Strome is the type of player who could be dealt at the trade deadline to a team needing center depth. It's unlikely he fits into the Flames' future plans... Frost seems more likely to stay in Calgary. However, signing him may not be a major priority if he continues to remain in the 40–50-point range. A contending team could also offer a futures package that is hard for the Flames to refuse.

2027 RFA: Klapka

2027 UFA: Strome, Frost, Tsyplakov, Hanley, Pachal, Kuznetsov

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Matvei Gridin		
Boom or bust	Ryan Strome		
Multicategory / Banger	Martin Pospisil		
Salary cap bargain	Matvei Gridin		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adam Klapka	56	293	96
Connor Zary	29	46	135
Hunter Brzustewicz	60	57	78
Jake Middleton	137	110	84
Joel Farabee	53	63	151
Jonathan Huberdeau	39	43	133
Kevin Bahl	103	119	71
Martin Pospisil	22	263	96
Matt Coronato	33	33	205
Matvei Gridin	57	29	170
Maxim Tsyplakov	33	117	72
Mikael Backlund	34	25	185
Morgan Frost	44	60	144
Ryan Strome	23	32	106
Simon Nemec	101	31	148
Tyson Gross	47	45	54
Yan Kuznetsov	119	106	84
Yegor Sharangovich	33	20	151
Zach Whitecloud	127	123	70
Zayne Parekh	74	38	113

Dobber Advanced... FLAMES



Observation: The trio of Backlund, Coleman, and Honzek handled the toughest quality of competition. While Honzek's season was cut short by injury, his placement in that high-leverage "top-line/shutdown" quadrant is a clear indicator of how the organization views his development and intends to use him long-term.

Fantasy Impact: These are your "real hockey" assets. They won't overwhelm you with point production, but their ability to drive play against top lines makes them extremely reliable in leagues that track plus/minus or defensive categories. Honzek, in particular, should stay on your watch list; if he returns to that deployment, he becomes a high-floor option in deeper formats as the "next Backlund."

Observation: Parekh is being fed an enormous number of offensive-zone starts (75%+ OZ starts) against weak competition—and he is successfully driving positive possession.

Fantasy Impact: He is the definition of a force-fed offensive prospect. The coaching staff is putting him in every position to succeed, and he is rewarding them possession-wise. He is a must-own in keeper/dynasty leagues. As a defenseman, his development curve is different, but he is showing he can handle tougher deployment if eased in gradually.

Observation: Huberdeau and Coronato are receiving favorable offensive deployment and are successfully tilting the ice. Frost, meanwhile, is seeing slightly better offensive usage but is not matching their efficiency, as indicated by his lighter bubble color.

Fantasy Impact: Huberdeau and Coronato are currently the primary engines of the Flames' attack—limited as it was. Frost is the one to monitor; his inability to drive play as effectively as his linemates in the same environment suggests he was the weak link. Notably, he performed better when Gridin replaced Coronato on that line.

Observation: Yegor Sharangovich is shouldering a significant load against top-tier competition and holding his own near the neutral line.

Fantasy Impact: Sharangovich is not a sheltered player—he is trusted with legitimate minutes. His ability to stay near neutral while facing tough competition makes him a steady, if unspectacular, fantasy asset. He is a high-floor player who won't hurt your ratios.

Observation: Strome and Zary both operated in middle-to-high offensive deployment and posted similar possession metrics, indicating they played at near-parity with one another.

Fantasy Impact: Strome and Zary provided a reliable, if unspectacular, secondary scoring punch. Given their identical deployment and similar efficiency, neither separated himself as the superior possession driver. Managers can expect consistent middle-six production from both—unless Zary finally breaks out.

Observation: Gridin, a very young rookie, played highly sheltered minutes, and his orange bubble reflected a typical adjustment period to the NHL.

Fantasy Impact: His possession metrics are not a red flag—they're standard for a teenager breaking into the league. He was "ahead of schedule" simply by being in the lineup, and his production suggests he should remain with the big club, especially on a team that struggled to score.



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Flames by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>RYAN STROME</u>	C	19	54.6	979	0.883	9.6	50.8	34.3	56.8	63.3	50	2.5	4	57.1
<u>MATVEI GRIDIN</u>	L	37	69.4	982	0.889	9.3	43.8	47.4	69	68.4	70	2.1	5	35.7
<u>MORGAN FROST</u>	C	82	66.2	990	0.9	9	48.9	58	58.1	60	55.2	2	9	42.9
<u>MATT CORONATO</u>	R	80	55.2	975	0.905	7	49.5	60.3	70.3	76.9	60	2	12	44.4
<u>MIKAEL BACKLUND</u>	C	82	31.7	996	0.92	7.6	50	23.5	67.2	70.6	37.5	1.8	3	11.5
<u>BLAKE COLEMAN</u>	L	69	34.9	995	0.905	9	52.1	27.3	57.4	66.7	16.7	1.8	6	40
<u>OLLI MAATTA</u>	D	21	50	972	0.868	10.4	49.5	2.1	48.4	50	0	1.8	5	41.7
<u>J HUBERDEAU</u>	L	50	67.6	965	0.895	7	52.1	59.3	58.1	64.3	46.7	1.7	6	40
<u>JOEL FARABEE</u>	R	82	59.1	983	0.907	7.6	49.5	23.9	66.7	75.6	50	1.6	7	38.9
<u>Y SHARANGOVICH</u>	L	78	52.5	984	0.91	7.4	49.2	35.1	54.7	56.4	58.3	1.4	5	35.7
<u>CONNOR ZARY</u>	L	74	51.1	990	0.91	8	50.1	34.8	56.8	51.4	77.8	1.4	8	61.5
<u>ADAM KLAPKA</u>	R	79	46.2	995	0.915	8	47.3	9.2	64.3	64	66.7	1.3	4	33.3
<u>SAMUEL HONZEK</u>	L	18	34.6	953	0.873	8	56	1.3	40	40	0	1.1	2	100
<u>RYAN LOMBERG</u>	L	57	40	987	0.916	7.1	47.5	0.3	64.3	64.3	0	1	1	20
<u>ZACH WHITECLOUD</u>	D	31	48.9	986	0.902	8.4	48.7	2.2	30.9	30.9	0	0.9	5	50
<u>ZAYNE PAREKH</u>	D	37	76.1	996	0.931	6.5	49.2	52.8	34.6	17.6	66.7	0.9	2	40

- Strome found renewed life after the trade to Calgary, showing that offensive spark. He wasn't given much power-play time (second unit), nor did he perform exceptionally well there, but at even strength he was a catalyst. He's still signed for another season. His secondary-assist rate was on the high side; combined with his limited PP usage, this caps his upside. However, his floor is likely quite high due to the lack of other options in the lineup.

- Gridin was slowly working his way toward first-unit PP time when the season ended. His PP proficiency was exceptional (70 PP IPP). His IPP was the second highest on the team, meaning he is the driver when he's on the ice, and his secondary-assist percentage and 5-on-5 S% were both low—indicators of bad puck luck. His relative possession numbers weren't great, but every other sign points to him being a future top-line player.

- Calgary finished last in the league in 5-on-5 S% at 9.2% across the roster. When nobody is scoring, players like Gridin and Coronato have fewer goals available to assist on. Coach Ryan Huska needs to adjust his system—it's no longer the clampdown 90s/early 00s—or he risks being replaced. Today's NHL features 80-point defensemen and rising offense. A defense-first structure gets you nowhere. Huska could end up holding Parekh, Gridin, and Coronato back.

- Speaking of Parekh and Coronato, those two led the team in poor puck luck. Parekh's 5-on-5 S% was 6.5, while Coronato's was 7.0. Both should see a market correction at even strength.

- For the second straight season, Zary led the team in PP IPP. He needs to be on the first unit.

- The Flames need an established top PP unit. Coronato, Huberdeau, and Frost played more than most, but not nearly as much as top units on other teams. Parekh saw just over 50% of available PP time, but he only played 37 games. Everyone else was rotated in and out. My suggestion: put Zary and Gridin on the top unit with Coronato, and make Parekh a staple. I would add Frost for faceoffs.

Key departures	Blake Coleman (MIN), Ryan Lomberg (CBJ), Justin Kirkland (MIN), John Beecher (FLA), Olli Maatta (MIN)
Arrivals	Maxim Tsyplov (NJD), Simon Nemec (NJD), Jake Middleton (MIN)

Carolina HURRICANES

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Andrei Svechnikov	77	31	70	67	Sebastian Aho	81	31	82	44	Seth Jarvis	54	24	47	13
Taylor Hall	72	19	44	36	Logan Stankoven	82	24	54	21	Jackson Blake	82	25	54	35
Nikolaj Ehlers	81	27	72	21	Jordan Staal	79	15	30	30	Jordan Martinook	81	14	28	30
William Carrier	53	6	11	17	Mark Jankowski	71	13	17	25	Eric Robinson	67	9	16	13
Nicolas Deslauriers	30	1	2	35	Jesper Kotkaniemi	68	7	19	32	Bradly Nadeau	21	5	9	4
					Justin Robidas	14	3	6	3	Felix Unger Sorum	6	0	3	0
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
S Gostisbehere	73	11	53	32	Alexander Nikishin	83	12	37	42	Brandon Bussi	47	34	2	2.60
K'Andre Miller	77	8	36	43	Sean Walker	83	8	27	53	Pyotr Kochetkov	37	20	1	2.65
Jacob Slavin	72	4	17	9	Jalen Chatfield	76	6	19	33					
Joel Nystrom	69	4	16	12	Charles Alexis Legault	20	2	3	8					

Restricted Free Agents: Nikishin

What to look for in camp: Robidas is no longer exempt from waivers, and he tore up the AHL last season. Furthermore, in two call-ups over the last two years, he has three points in four NHL games (not to mention five points in five preseason games over the last two training camps). But besides the fact that the current roster has no room (plus competition from Nadeau to make the team), Robidas is only 5-8. There is a good chance that he gets placed on waivers and promptly claimed by a team with the room to give him a shot. Keep an eye out for that and be ready with your own waiver claim.

On the hot seat: It's hard to imagine that Kotkaniemi was a third overall pick once upon a time. Now 500 games into his NHL career, all he's shown us is a single 43-point season. That said, his \$4.8M contract (four years remaining) is no longer the untradeable anchor it once was, with today's new cap climate. He may get a fresh start somewhere, but he needs to do something with it because he's running out of chances.

- Jankowski stole Kotkaniemi's job. A first-round pick himself, the 6-4 Jankowski seems to have finally arrived. We know big players take longer, but he's now 32. He had 14 points in the last 33 games (while Kotkaniemi was mostly scratched) on the fourth line, bringing size and tenacity into the postseason. It was enough to earn a two-year contract extension that secures his spot and keeps Kotkaniemi out.

- Hall seems to have finally put all the injuries behind him and is a bit of a dark horse. He's been slowly finding his form, increasing from 0.55 points/game to 0.60 last season, and ending the campaign with 47 points in 57 games, counting his amazing playoff performance. His line is young and on the rise, and if Hall's health continues, he could surprise with a return to 60 points. He's not a bad late-round selection in your fantasy drafts.

- Stankoven had 16 points in 19 games to end the season—and then 16 points in 19 games in the playoffs. He is firmly on our sleeper chart.

- Ehlers took 20 games or so to acclimate to the new system, but after that he went on a tear with 76 points in 80 regular-season and playoff contests. And this is with his mostly playing with Staal and Martinook, though he was the top guy on PP1.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Sebastian Aho	100	85	Joel Nystrom	60%		
Andrei Svechnikov	85	73	Bradly Nadeau	45%		
Nikolaj Ehlers	83	73	Justin Robidas	40%		
Seth Jarvis	85	73	Charles Alexis Legault	30%		
Logan Stankoven	87	68	Felix Unger Sorum	20%		
Jackson Blake	72	55				
Shayne Gostisbehere	67	53				
Alexander Nikishin	70	50				
Bradly Nadeau	75	50				
Taylor Hall	62	48				
Charlie Cerrato	73	43				
Felix Unger Sorum	70	43	Sleeper	Pts	%	
K'Andre Miller	53	40	Alexander Nikishin	50	15%	
Ivan Ryabkin	70	40	Logan Stankoven	68	15%	
Justin Poirier	82	38	Justin Robidas	40	10%	
Nikita Artamonov	68	38				
Justin Robidas	70	38				
Jesper Kotkaniemi	58	37				
Kurban Limatov	50	35				

- Svechnikov also had a strong half, and in fact—nine players on the Hurricanes jumped from first-half to second-half production by at least 24%. It was the final change in matching line combinations, finding that secret recipe, and then everything took off. For that reason, the line combos you find here are about as sure a thing as you'll find across all teams.

- It might have been the Jarvis injury in late December that was the catalyst for the turnaround, as it was around that time that the line shuffling began (Coach Rod Brind'Amour is notorious for sticking with his lines). He had started off playing with Ehlers and Aho. When he returned, it was Svechnikov instead of Ehlers.

Injuries:

Jarvis underwent shoulder surgery in late June with an expected recovery of 4–6 months. That means he will likely make his season debut sometime between early November and Christmas. Move him down your draft boards... Robinson underwent knee surgery in late June with a 6–8-week recovery. He should be fine for training camp... Kochetkov (hip) was activated from IR in April, although he only suited up during the Stanley Cup Final as a backup due to the Canes carrying three goalies. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** *Svechnikov, Gostisbehere.*

Breakout Threshold:

The Canes have several good options here. Miller is a big man who has played 440 career games. His career high to date is 43 points, and a BT would be 54 points. Blake has played 162 career games and should hit his BT by around the midpoint of the season, which hints at a strong second half. The best option here, though, is Stankoven. He has played 183 career games, just 17 shy of 200, and after seeing his playoff performance, one has to think that a big year is ahead. A BT for him would be 55 points, but he is capable of more than that, which is why we have him as a heavy sleeper pick.

Goalies:

With Frederik Andersen off to Edmonton as a free agent, the Hurricanes are hoping to defend their Stanley Cup title with a Bussi/Kochetkov tandem. Bussi played in more games (39) than any other goalie to suit up for the Canes in 2025–26, also taking over during the Stanley Cup Final once Andersen was injured. Kochetkov was injured for much of the season, appearing in only nine games. Don't write off Kochetkov completely as the starter, as he appeared in at least 40 games in each of the previous two seasons. The most likely scenario has Bussi and Kochetkov splitting starts with a combined \$3.9 million cap hit, as the Canes invest their money elsewhere. Bussi gets the slight advantage due to the recency effect. Cayden Primeau waits in the wings if there's an injury. **Dobber's confidence that Bussi is the starter: 55%**

Contract Year:

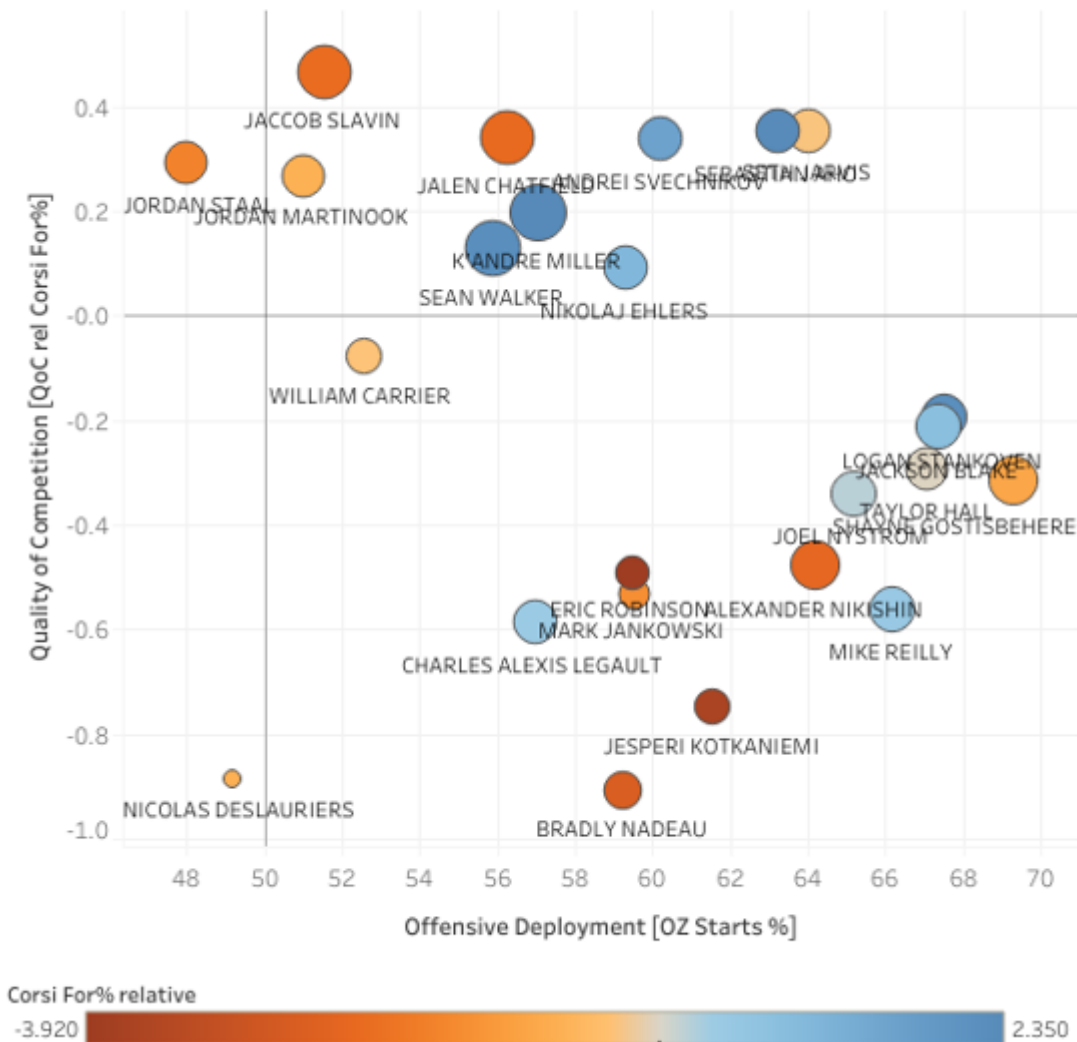
Nikishin has been the subject of trade rumors, as he and the Hurricanes are at odds over his value and his role on the team. Whether he is re-signed or traded could affect other decisions the Canes make, even next season... One player who could be tied to Nikishin's future is Gostisbehere, who has found a home on the top power play for a Stanley Cup-winning team... Staal and Martinook had important roles in the Cup win, even if they are not top scorers. Staal in particular might retire as a Cane, but he may have one more contract left in him... After missing most of 2025–26, Kochetkov will try to re-establish himself as a starting goalie or timeshare option in his first UFA year.

2027 RFA: *None on the NHL roster*

2027 UFA: *Martinook, Staal, Gostisbehere, Chatfield, Kochetkov*

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Logan Stankoven		
Boom or bust	Taylor Hall		
Multicategory / Banger	Alexander Nikishin		
Salary cap bargain	Brandon Bussi		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Alexander Nikishin	108	149	141
Andrei Svechnikov	23	159	200
Eric Robinson	13	84	88
Jacob Slavin	108	14	108
Jackson Blake	37	16	189
Jalen Chatfield	69	61	99
Jesper Kotkaniemi	27	85	75
Joel Nystrom	48	18	90
Jordan Martinook	53	98	106
Jordan Staal	46	161	102
K'Andre Miller	85	104	123
Logan Stankoven	29	53	180
Mark Jankowski	43	43	64
Nikolaj Ehlers	24	24	194
Sean Walker	117	125	167
Sebastian Aho	26	58	210
Seth Jarvis	39	81	254
Shayne Gostisbehere	80	37	146
Taylor Hall	22	44	130
William Carrier	14	121	58

Dobber Advanced... HURRICANES



* Note that most of this chart sits to the right of the axis, indicating that the Hurricanes play a strong possession game with the majority of their starts in the offensive zone. This makes it a "gold" environment if you're a Carolina goaltender. Imagine having minimal faceoffs in your own zone.

Observation: Slavin and Staal are shouldering a massive load against the league's toughest competition, operating deep in the top-left quadrant of the chart.

Fantasy Impact: These are your "real hockey" assets. They won't overwhelm you with point production, but their ability to drive play and suppress elite lines makes them extremely reliable in leagues that track plus/minus or value defensive floor. They provide the structural stability that allows the rest of the roster to play more aggressively.

Observation: Aho and Svechnikov are receiving elite offensive deployment and are successfully tilting the ice in Carolina's favor, with possession metrics that firmly place them in the blue zone. Jarvis is also in that group, though not quite the same possession driver last season.

Fantasy Impact: These are the primary engines of the Hurricanes' attack. They convert opportunity into high-end production and are "must-own" offensive cornerstones. If you're building a fantasy roster, these are the players who provide the ceiling needed to win matchups.

Observation: Stankoven and Blake are being fed a high volume of offensive-zone starts (65%+) against weaker competition, and they are successfully driving positive possession. Veteran Hall fits this mold as well, though—like Jarvis—he isn't as dominant a possession driver as the other two.

Fantasy Impact: This is the definition of a force-fed offensive youth movement. Coach Rod Brind'Amour put them in every position to succeed, and they rewarded that trust with high-efficiency play. Both are prime breakout candidates

and should be prioritized in keeper or dynasty formats, as their usage suggests the team is transitioning them into core top-six roles.

Observation: Kotkaniemi and Nadeau operated in extremely sheltered, high-offensive-zone roles, yet they show some of the most prominent orange bubbles on the team.

Fantasy Impact: These are “buyer beware” assets. Despite receiving every possible protection from the coaching staff, they struggled to drive possession relative to their teammates and competition. They are currently opportunistic players who are failing to capitalize on prime minutes. Nadeau gets a pass as a prospect just getting his first taste of the NHL. Kotkaniemi, however, has no such excuse. A veteran producing such lopsided results in sheltered minutes is a clear sign of a player trending toward being traded, demoted, or bought out if it continues.

Observation: Gostisbehere and Reilly are deployed in highly sheltered, offense-heavy minutes, and while their possession metrics hover near neutral, they are being protected from top-tier competition.

Fantasy Impact: These are classic specialist defensemen. They are essentially used as fourth forwards to chase offense. They hold value in formats that reward power-play points or offensive production from the blue line, but they are high-risk assets—if they aren’t producing, they offer little else to keep them in the lineup. Nikishin received similar deployment, which is expected for most rookies.

Observation: Miller is shouldering significant minutes against top-tier competition and is successfully maintaining positive possession metrics. He and Walker handled the second-toughest deployment after Slavin/Chatfield—and dominated possession.

Fantasy Impact: Their presence allowed players like Gostisbehere to flourish in less-challenging roles. Being able to drive play while facing the league’s best is the hallmark of an elite blueliner. Miller is a high-floor, high-value fantasy asset and the “anchor” of Carolina’s defense.



The advertisement features a dark red background with a subtle snow effect. On the left, there is a white hockey goalie mask icon above the text "GOALIEPOST APP". Below this, a white text box contains the message: "Get confirmed starter alerts sent right to your phone. Never miss a i lineup change again." To the right of this text is a large QR code with a Twitter bird logo in the center. Below the QR code is a yellow button with the text "GET IT NOW ON THE APP STORE & GOOGLE PLAY". In the background, a hockey goalie is visible in action.

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Hurricanes by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>NIKOLAJ EHLERS</u>	L	82	59.3	976	0.885	9.1	60	61.6	68.3	66.7	70.7	3.1	16	35.6
<u>SEBASTIAN AHO</u>	C	79	63.2	974	0.886	8.8	61.2	65.1	63	70	56.3	3.1	21	39.6
<u>ANDREI SVECHNIKOV</u>	L	79	60.2	972	0.891	8.1	60.7	61.3	67.3	69.5	64.4	3.1	15	38.5
<u>SETH JARVIS</u>	R	71	64	965	0.885	8	60	63.6	64.1	78.2	52.5	3	15	44.1
<u>SHAYNE GOSTISBEHERE</u>	D	55	69.3	983	0.882	10.1	58.9	64.1	61	58.2	66.7	2.8	20	54.1
<u>TAYLOR HALL</u>	L	80	67	988	0.891	9.7	58.9	34.8	69.6	71.9	58.3	2.5	11	36.7
<u>JACKSON BLAKE</u>	R	81	67.3	990	0.903	8.7	59.7	45.9	66.3	68.3	60	2.4	14	45.2
<u>LOGAN STANKOVEN</u>	C	81	67.5	992	0.899	9.3	60.5	33.1	57.9	55.6	69.2	2.1	13	56.5
<u>JORDAN STAAL</u>	C	75	47.9	965	0.881	8.4	57.8	16.7	54.5	62	30.8	1.8	5	31.3
<u>MARK JANKOWSKI</u>	C	68	59.5	999	0.92	7.9	58.3	6	64.5	66.7	50	1.6	3	33.3
<u>JORDAN MARTINOOK</u>	R	77	50.9	973	0.879	9.4	58.6	0.8	53.7	56.9	0	1.5	8	47.1
<u>K'ANDRE MILLER</u>	D	72	57	953	0.868	8.5	61.2	20.3	44.6	44.4	50	1.4	16	55.2
<u>WILLIAM CARRIER</u>	L	70	52.5	986	0.888	9.8	59.1	0.6	50	50	0	1.4	3	27.3
<u>ERIC ROBINSON</u>	R	67	59.4	991	0.911	8	57.1	1	58.1	56.7	0	1.4	1	16.7
<u>ALEXANDER NIKISHIN</u>	D	81	64.1	1004	0.913	9.1	57.8	30.6	36.3	36.5	40	1.3	10	45.5
<u>SEAN WALKER</u>	D	81	55.9	960	0.878	8.2	60.5	15.9	35.6	35.9	33.3	1.1	12	54.5

- The Hurricanes played a high-possession, high-shot-volume style that resulted in the team finishing second in the league in shots on goal. Throw it at the net, see what happens. This pushed their team-average 5-on-5 S% lower, with only Gostisbehere above 10% (around the league average).

- Looking at the chart, you may think that Jarvis, Svechnikov, and Aho are due for positive market corrections. However, all three posted similar 5-on-5 S% numbers in 2024–25. As long as Brind'Amour remains coach, this is the style of play—and this is the number—you should expect.

- Notice that everyone on the chart has a CF% above 57.0%, further reinforcing the PUC showing all the bubbles shifted to the right side. The team drives possession, and judging from that giant Cup on their mantle—they do it well.

- The Canes have a set first PP unit, with the top five players on this chart each above 61% of available PP time. The next unit features Hall, Blake, Stankoven, Nikishin, and then a rotation of several players in the final spot. When Nadeau played (12 games), his PP% was 37.5. If he makes the team, he'll likely be the final piece on that second unit.

- Gostisbehere's PP IPP of 66.7% is very good. It shows he is a major contributor on the top unit and the second-best producer after Ehlers. However, it's his lowest PP IPP in six years. He still has a year left on his contract, and the team will still get their money's worth—but if he slips again, even slightly, that will be Nikishin's opportunity to show what he can do.

Key departures	Mike Reilly (UFA), Frederik Andersen (EDM)
Arrivals	None

Chicago BLACKHAWKS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Roman Kantserov	82	26	55	41	Connor Bedard	67	29	85	45	Patrick Kane	65	19	54	15
Anton Frondell	82	23	65	16	Frank Nazar	72	20	47	30	Tyler Bertuzzi	82	33	57	50
Teuvo Teravainen	80	17	47	12	Oliver Moore	76	11	33	19	Nick Lardis	78	17	35	19
Jordan Greenway	59	6	17	58	Ryan Greene	83	14	30	17	Ryan Donato	82	19	36	39
Andrew Mangiapane	73	11	19	38	Sacha Boisvert	6	1	2	3	Landon Slaggert	68	4	11	29
					Dominic Toninato	11	0	1	5	Cole Smith	73	7	11	59
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Bowen Byram	83	10	53	51	Artyom Levshunov	75	5	30	38	Spencer Knight	57	23	3	2.80
Alex Vlasic	82	3	19	25	Sam Rinzel	79	6	27	37	Arvid Soderblom	22	6	0	3.75
Ian Cole	83	2	15	64	Wyatt Kaiser	78	4	15	33	Drew Commesso	7	4	1	2.90
Kevin Korchinski	37	1	5	11	Ethan Del Mastro	17	1	2	9					

Restricted Free Agents: Del Mastro, Korchinski

What to look for in camp: It was a small sample size, but it wasn't good. Don't get us wrong—Frondell is going to be an immediate star. But faceoffs were not his forte, winning just 32 out of 106 (30.2%). He will definitely be a center in the long term, but you may see more wing in this first full year, as he eases into the ins and outs of winning draws. If he is used at center despite this, then it pushes Nazar (who took the most draws on the Hawks last year) to the third line or the wing. How the coach uses these two will give us a hint. Nazar's production would take a hit if he centers the third unit.

Camp battle: Last year's camp battle pitted Levshunov, Korchinski and Rinzel against each other. Levshunov won that one, but it still wasn't good enough because the Hawks acquired Byram this summer. Korchinski fell further back, so that leaves Levshunov vs. Rinzel for both PP2 and to be Byram's sidekick. The winner could mean a swing of 10 points or more.

- The difference between quarterbacking the first PP unit and the second PP unit is massive when it comes to production. As Dobber noted on our TikTok and YouTube feeds—do not underestimate the potential jump in points for Byram going from secondary guy in Buffalo to primary guy in Chicago.
- Bedard had 44 points in 31 games to start last season, including two points in the game in which he got hurt in his very last shift. There were a couple of occasions where he led the league in scoring. Do not underestimate what he can do. Injuries keep slowing him, so we hope he's not going to have a Jack Hughes situation here. But if healthy, he will be among the greats. Mark it.
- Levshunov had 21 points in his first 43 games. The coaching staff then pulled him from the lineup to work on certain aspects of his defensive game throughout the Olympic Break and beyond. His offensive freedom was reined in (three points in 25 games before suffering a hand fracture). He was a second-overall draft pick, and his offense is undisputed. They want to round out his game and make him more of a complete player. This will be another learning season for him.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Connor Bedard	125	105	Anton Frondell	100%	
Anton Frondell	88	73	Roman Kantserov	99%	
Roman Kantserov	82	65	Nick Lardis	95%	
Frank Nazar	80	63	Sacha Boisvert	30%	
Vaclav Nestrasil	70	58	Kevin Korchinski	40%	
Bowen Byram	72	57	Ethan Del Mastro	35%	
Artyom Levshunov	70	57	Drew Commesso	25%	
Oliver Moore	73	52	Marek Vanacker	15%	
Teuvo Teravainen	67	50			
Tyler Bertuzzi	65	50			
Nick Lardis	82	50			
Marek Vanacker	72	47	Sleeper	Pts	%
Sacha Boisvert	68	45	Connor Bedard	115	20%
Ryan Donato	65	43	Roman Kantserov	65	15%
Xavier Villeneuve	68	40	Bowen Byram	60	10%
Ryan Greene	68	38	Artyom Levshunov	45	10%
Sam Rinzel	52	38	Nick Lardis	50	10%
Kevin Korchinski	50	37			
Alex Vlasic	40	30			

- Nazar started and finished the season on a line with Teravainen and Bertuzzi. In between was a mashup of players replacing Teravainen, including Moore and Bedard. Oddly enough, his best numbers were easily with Teravainen there. Nazar had 14 points in 18 games to start, 14 in 20 to finish, but in between was just 13 in 28.

- For those who didn't pick up the Fantasy Prospects Report, Kantserov's KHL-high 36 goals last season "broke Kirill Kaprizov's record for most snipes in the KHL by a U22 player."

- The prevailing thought in the scouting community regarding Moore is that he is more of a middle-six type with a limited ceiling. However, he was a prolific scorer at the USNTDP level, the NCAA level and (briefly) the AHL level. So far, he has been deployed more in the offensive zone when possible. He's already been a 30-point player in the NHL and he's only 21. With increased shot volume and better linemates, he has definite potential.

Injuries:

Bedard is expected to miss around the first month of the season following left shoulder surgery. He was injured in early July with an expected recovery timeline of four months. This is not the same shoulder that was injured during the 2025-26 season, but it's hardly an ideal situation... Mangiapane (upper body, lower body) missed much of last season's final quarter... Moore (lower body) missed the final month but was available for the World Hockey Championship... Levshunov suffered a fractured hand in late March and did not return... **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Greenway, Kane, Bedard, Nazar.

Breakout Threshold:

There's an okay option here for a breakout, if you think Bedard is appealing. You do? Well, you're in luck. Bedard has played 219 games in his career and is right in the wheelhouse of a breakthrough. He is just coming off a campaign in which his full-season pace was 89 points, making a breakout season for him 111 points.

Goalies:

Knight finished his first full season as Chicago's starter, appearing in 55 games, winning just 19 but posting a respectable 28 quality starts. No goalie had as many quality starts with as few wins. Unless the Blackhawks' young core takes a major step forward, expect more of the same this season due to Chicago's defensive inconsistency... Soderblom projects as the primary backup and likely won't play any more than he did in 2025-26 (26 GP). He's a streamer at best and may even be on shaky ground as the backup... Comness enters as the No. 3, likely starting the season in the AHL due to waiver exemption but eager to prove he is an NHL goalie. Should Knight be injured, Comness might be worth watching to see if he can steal starts away from Soderblom. **Dobber's confidence that Knight is the starter: 95%**

Contract Year:

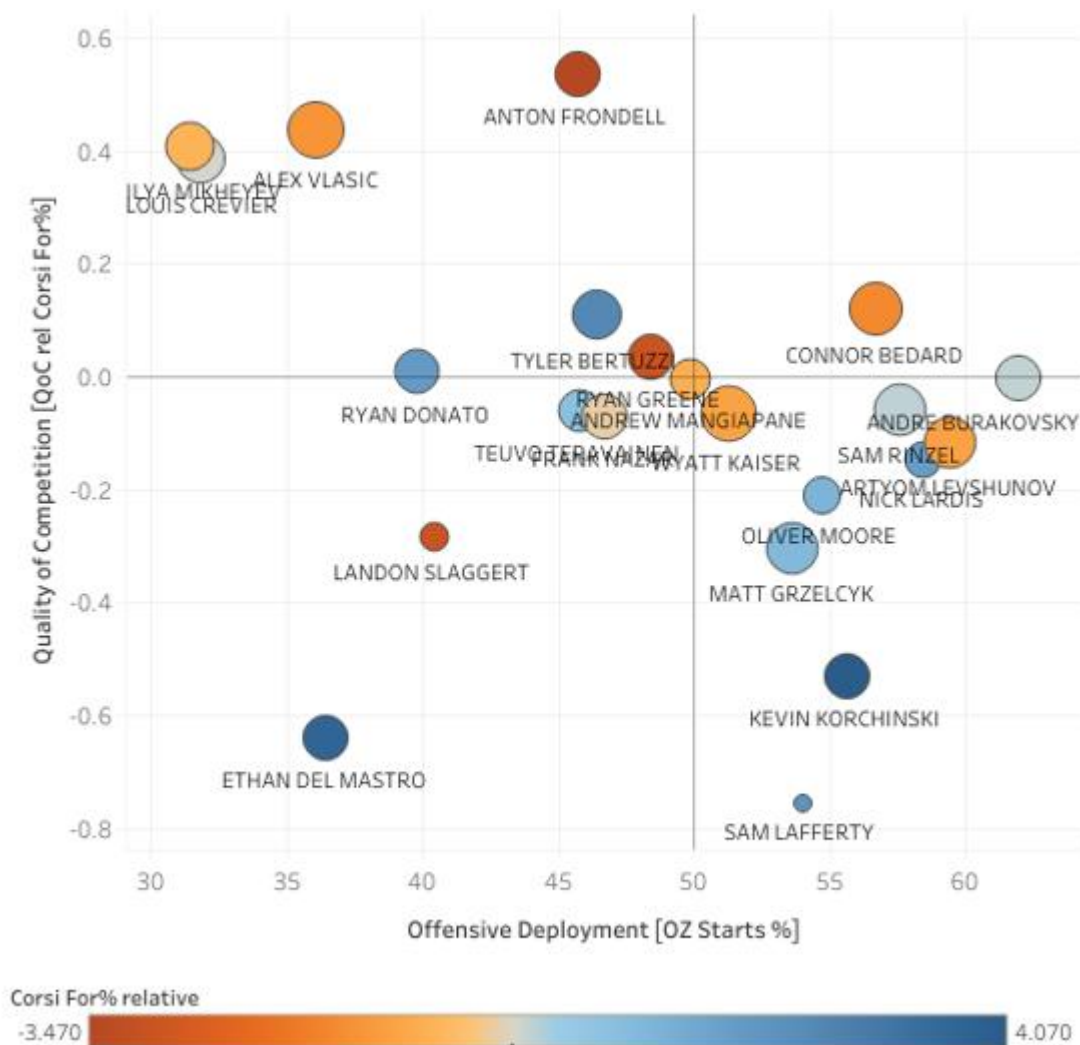
The Blackhawks took care of their main piece of business in the offseason, which was extending Bedard... After acquiring Byram and locking him up to a massive deal, the Hawks will need to make some important decisions on defense. Vlasic is the only other defenseman signed beyond this season, which means that Levshunov, Rinzel, and Kaiser will all need new contracts... The Blackhawks may be out of the playoff race again, which means that Teravainen, Mangiapane, Greenway, and Cole become trade bait for futures.

2027 RFA: Greene, Moore, Slaggert, Kaiser, Levshunov, Rinzel

2027 UFA: Teravainen, Greenway, Mangiapane, Toninato, Ellis, Cole, Soderblom

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Bowen Byram		
Boom or bust	Ryan Donato		
Multicategory / Banger	Sam Rinzel		
Salary cap bargain	Anton Frondell		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Alex Vlasic	131	41	98
Andrew Mangiapane	31	77	73
Anton Frondell	66	62	221
Artyom Levshunov	83	113	98
Bowen Byram	116	66	125
Cole Smith	26	196	73
Connor Bedard	30	34	228
Frank Nazar	47	41	158
Ian Cole	152	79	66
Jordan Greenway	35	122	59
Landon Slaggert	34	105	61
Nick Lardis	27	119	117
Oliver Moore	21	39	99
Roman Kantserov	33	66	173
Ryan Donato	21	88	139
Ryan Greene	41	58	116
Sam Rinzel	87	76	134
Teuvo Teravainen	32	20	112
Tyler Bertuzzi	26	58	173
Wyatt Kaiser	94	56	86

Dobber Advanced... BLACKHAWKS



Observation: Frondell absorbed the toughest quality of competition on the team during his late-season call-up.

Fantasy Impact: While his possession metrics appear dark orange, this is a "real hockey" indicator that the organization was testing him in a high-leverage shutdown role. If he retains this level of trust, he is being groomed for a core, top-line assignment that could eventually translate into strong fantasy production—perhaps sooner rather than later.

Observation: Bedard and Andre Burakovsky (now with Ottawa) were being fed high offensive-zone starts (60%+) against middle- to lower-tier competition.

Fantasy Impact: This is the ideal environment for offensive production. Bedard is the "must-own" cornerstone of the franchise, and this deployment is designed to elevate his scoring floor. Burakovsky's efficiency in those prime minutes suggest he was the primary beneficiary of Bedard's gravity. But he was dragging Bedard's metrics down while his own were being boosted.

Observation: Korchinski (just 13 games) and Grzelcyk are driving positive possession thanks to very sheltered deployment. Levshunov is also being sheltered, though he is seeing tougher minutes than the other two.

Fantasy Impact: Korchinski is showing that he deserves tougher minutes and a chance to prove himself in them. Levshunov excelled on the power play, but at even strength the top offensive role may still be up for grabs. Meanwhile, Grzelcyk likely showed enough to earn another NHL contract despite producing only 12 points (zero goals).

Observation: Lardis received deployment similar to Burakovsky, yet he actually *drove* possession.

Fantasy Impact: This explains why they couldn't send Lardis back down. At 20, he is clearly NHL-ready, and the spot is his barring a disastrous training camp. Drafting him is likely safe.

Observation: Nazar and Greene are seeing standard deployment but are not yet dominating possession the way the team's core offensive players are.

Fantasy Impact: These are developmental assets to monitor for a breakout. Their efficiency suggests they are finding their footing but haven't reached "must-add" status. They are candidates for midseason waiver pickups—if their possession numbers begin shifting toward the blue, that will signal readiness for greater offensive responsibility, especially for Nazar. Greene is expected to become a two-way center, and the team is clearly pushing him in that direction, but he cannot be deployed against top lines until he can effectively drive possession.

Observation: Vlasic absorbs the most defensive-zone, high-competition starts.

Fantasy Impact: His role allows players like Levshunov and Rinzel to receive more offensive-zone deployment. It also means Vlasic has a defined ceiling—his role is set.

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Blackhawks by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
CONNOR BEDARD	C	69	56.6	1007	0.897	11	44.5	72.2	82.4	84.4	77.8	3.1	12	26.7
ANTON FRONDELL	C	12	45.7	1074	0.913	16.1	40.3	70.8	64.3	63.6	66.7	2.6	3	50
TYLER BERTUZZI	R	79	46.4	1018	0.902	11.6	47.4	69.4	61.7	59.7	65.6	2.4	11	42.3
FRANK NAZAR	C	66	46.7	999	0.894	10.5	45	65.6	70.7	78.4	60	2	13	50
OLIVER MOORE	L	51	54.7	972	0.881	9.1	46.4	22.5	76	66.7	100	1.7	8	57.1
NICK LARDIS	R	41	58.4	926	0.846	8	45.9	31	78.9	75	100	1.7	3	60
TEUVO TERAVAINEN	L	75	45.7	964	0.897	6.7	46.5	59.5	61.4	57.1	67.9	1.6	8	38.1
ANDRE BURAKOVSKY	R	75	61.9	974	0.884	9	46.8	46.9	53.2	53.5	52.6	1.6	12	54.5
ILYA MIKHEYEV	L	77	31.4	1016	0.921	9.5	44.8	1.1	72	73.9	0	1.6	5	27.8
RYAN DONATO	L	82	39.8	991	0.906	8.5	47.5	29.7	65.2	71.8	28.6	1.5	6	40
RYAN GREENE	L	81	48.4	1002	0.905	9.7	44.7	27.5	49.2	53.2	44.4	1.3	5	29.4
LOUIS CREVIER	D	78	31.8	1000	0.898	10.2	46.7	1.3	43.9	45.3	0	1.1	9	50
ARTYOM LEVSHUNOV	D	68	59.4	975	0.895	8	45.6	58.9	41.4	35.1	52.4	1.1	16	72.7
SAM RINZEL	D	54	57.6	1013	0.909	10.4	45.1	42.7	31.1	35.1	12.5	0.9	5	50
LANDON SLAGGERT	R	53	40.4	1011	0.927	8.4	42.8	0.1	53.8	53.8	0	0.8	3	75
ALEX VLASIC	D	81	36.1	997	0.904	9.3	45.3	1.6	35.6	36.4	0	0.7	8	42.1

- Proof that advanced metrics are not perfect for predicting future results: Donato had an excellent Pts/60 rate and a very low secondary-assist ratio. His Pts/60 was even higher than Bedard's. But fast-forward one year and see what being removed from the Bedard line does—his Pts/60 plummeted from 2.9 to 1.5. And on the second PP unit, without Bedard, his PP IPP also took a nosedive. These metrics are guides and provide indicators—but don't mortgage the house on them.

- Bedard's 3.1 Pts/60 was a career high, and that number should continue to rise. His 82.4 IPP was also a career high, indicating that he is far exceeding his teammates. Ideally, the highly touted prospects joining the roster (or in Frondell's case—already joining it) will keep up. His CF% is a career high as well, and his secondary-assist percentage is a career low. All signs point to another big step forward.

- Bedard and Frondell are staples on the top PP unit. So was Levshunov—which now changes with the acquisition of Byram. You can now add Kane to the "locks". As for the remaining slot: Teravainen, Bertuzzi, Lardis, and Nazar may lose out depending on how quickly Kantserov acclimates.

- The second unit scored only three power-play goals when Lardis was on the ice, but he was in on all three. This second unit should be dangerous as well, especially with a couple of last year's first-unit players likely getting bumped down.

- Frondell's 5-on-5 S% was very high, but it came over just 12 games—too small a sample to draw conclusions. On the flip side, Teravainen's number was just 6.7%, indicating a spike is likely coming. Much depends on linemates, of course. He also stands to lose his first-unit PP time.

- Moore, Nazar, and Burakovsky posted high secondary-assist percentages. Their assist totals could decline, but as with many players, that depends heavily on linemates. Anyone lining up with Bedard or Frondell will see a production bump—simple as that.

Key departures	Ilya Mikheyev (TB), Andre Burakovsky (OTT), Sam Lafferty (FLA), Louis Crevier (BUF), Matt Grzelcyk (UFA)
Arrivals	Patrick Kane (Det), Jordan Greenway (BUF), Cole Smith (VGK), Bowen Byram (BUF), Ian Cole (UTA)

Colorado AVALANCHE

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Artturi Lehkonen	67	23	46	23	Nathan MacKinnon	82	45	126	42	Martin Necas	80	32	108	30
Gabriel Landeskog	66	22	42	66	Brock Nelson	83	31	56	28	Jaden Schwartz	66	16	34	19
Zachary L'Heureux	68	8	16	61	Nazem Kadri	82	26	59	50	Nicolas Roy	74	11	29	33
Parker Kelly	83	13	25	30	Fedor Svechkov	74	10	21	19	Logan O'Connor	74	10	16	32
Taylor Makar	14	0	2	3	TJ Hughes	20	3	5	7	Fabian Lysell	34	3	7	17
Vinnie Hinostroza	41	4	9	16	Tristen Nielsen	6	0	1	0	Gavin Brindley	31	3	7	5
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Devon Toews	77	8	29	26	Cale Makar	79	24	86	18	Mackenzie Blackwood	44	28	2	2.55
Josh Manson	70	4	20	77	Brent Burns	84	9	29	38	Scott Wedgewood	40	24	3	2.45
Brett Kulak	84	3	15	29	Sam Malinski	82	9	37	20	Trent Miner	4	2	0	2.50
Keaton Middleton	24	1	5	13	Noah Juulsen	49	1	8	20					
Domenick Fensore	32	2	9	14										

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: The Avalanche did their annual shedding of salary, bringing in once highly ranked prospects that other organizations have given up on. This year it's Lysell whom they brought in. Last season, they deployed Brindley game in and game out, even though he was often in over his head. If they decide to do the same with Lysell, he may enjoy more success since he is a couple of years older and more experienced. His disadvantage this year versus a year ago: the Avs seem to be healthier entering camp. Last year, the O'Connor injury opened a spot for Brindley.

On the hot seat: Svechkov was the 19th overall pick in 2021, and he took the AHL by storm, immediately making it clear that he is too good for that league. He forced his way onto Nashville's roster and, despite playing a depth role, he still managed 17 points in 52 games. He followed that up with 17 in 70 last year, seeing his role dwindle and seeing some scratches. Still only 23, he gets a fresh start in Colorado, but again finds himself buried. Fortunately, several players ahead of him tend to get injured, but he needs to seize the opportunities when they come.

- You can excuse Landeskog for starting slow. He did, after all, miss three full seasons. He had just seven points in his first 22 games before ending the campaign with 28 in 38. He also added another 11 in 13 playoff outings. Remarkably, the Avalanche were 45-7-8 when he was in the lineup. When he was out, the team was 10-9-3.

- MacKinnon was otherworldly in the first half, posting 74 points in 40 games. After that, he was a little more human with 53 in 40 in the second half.

- In the 11 games that Lehkonen was sidelined, Necas actually led the team in scoring with 17 points in 11 games, topping MacKinnon (16 points). It shouldn't come as a surprise that Lehkonen's linemates did just fine without him.

- Toews missed most of January with an injury, and while he was sidelined, Malinski became Makar's sidekick and he only managed three points in 13 games. Makar took a hit, slowing to just nine points in that span. It was the Burns-Manson pairing that stepped up, with Manson tallying nine points in 13 games (Burns with six). Makar had 70 in 62 games when Toews was in the lineup.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Nathan MacKinnon	145	123	Domenick Fensore	50%		
Martin Necas	112	105	TJ Hughes	45%		
Cale Makar	108	92	Fabian Lysell	40%		
Brock Nelson	70	57	Gavin Brindley	35%		
Nazem Kadri	67	55	Georgii Merkulov	30%		
Artturi Lehkonen	63	52	Tristen Nielsen	20%		
Fedor Svechkov	67	47	Taylor Makar	10%		
Gabriel Landeskog	63	45				
Fabian Lysell	68	40				
Jaden Schwartz	55	40				
Beckett Hamilton	72	40				
Gavin Brindley	65	38	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Nicolas Roy	55	37	Sam Malinski	45	15%	
Sam Malinski	40	35	Gabriel Landeskog	55	10%	
Sean Behrens	42	33	Fabian Lysell	40	10%	
Devon Toews	50	32	Jaden Schwartz	50	10%	
TJ Hughes	68	32				
Logan O'Connor	50	28				
Domenick Fensore	40	28				

• Schwartz had 15 points in his first 22 games last season in Seattle and was well on his way to a bit of a bounce-back season when he suffered a lower-body injury that cost him 19 games. He wasn't the same when he returned, and then in March suffered a facial injury. He had 11 points in his last 38 contests.

Injuries:

MacKinnon suffered a knee injury after blocking a shot during Game 3 of the conference final. He was able to play in Game 4, with no further news reported... Makar (undisclosed) returned for Game 3 of the conference final after missing Games 1 and 2... **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** *Lehkonen, Landeskog, Roy, Schwartz, O'Connor.*

Breakout Threshold:

Roy has played 443 career games, and at 6-4 he fits our big-man category for a 400-game BT. But his upside is somewhat limited, and he is too far down the PP depth chart to have much in the way of expectations here. Malinski has played 181 career games, but one could argue that he just had his BT season, jumping from 15 points to 40. So, in a nutshell: nobody.

Goalies:

In an unusual turn, Wedgewood took over as the starter from Blackwood during 2025-26 due to superior performance. Wedgewood was even the starter for much of the playoffs. Blackwood wasn't necessarily terrible, but the Avalanche had a lot riding on the season and couldn't ignore Wedgewood's stat line (31-6-6, 2.02 GAA, 0.921 SV%). With more invested in Blackwood in both cap hit and term, expect Coach Jared Bednar to turn to Blackwood to start the season, although Wedgewood could easily turn this into a timeshare or even win the job outright... Goaltending prospect Ilya Nabokov should start his first season in North America, but he could be given a look if one goalie is injured and the other is struggling. Both Blackwood and Wedgewood should be worth drafting, but neither should be a top-5 goalie due to the uncertainty of the situation. Miner provides organizational depth. **Dobber's confidence that Blackwood is the starter: 60%**

Contract Year:

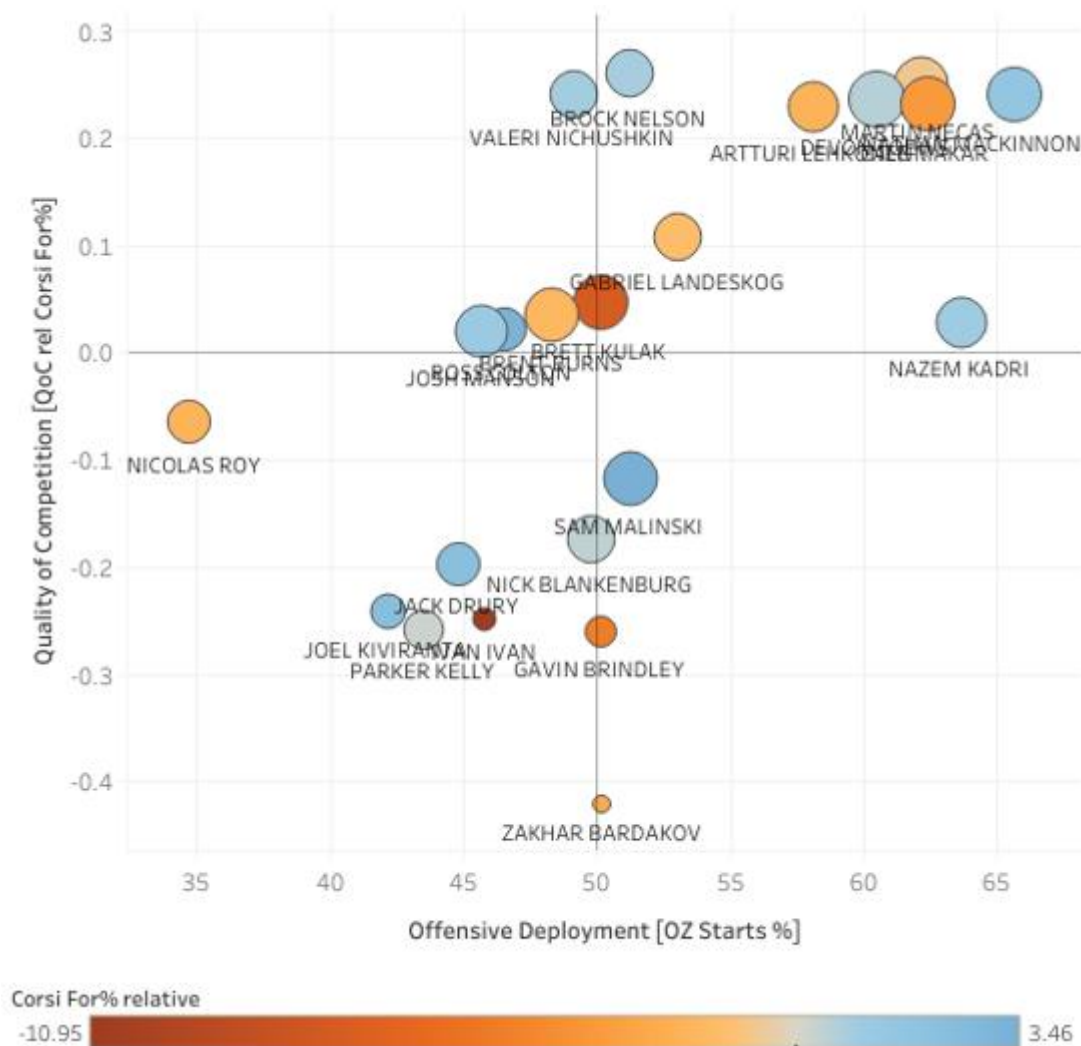
Colorado contracts start with Makar. The rising cap means he should be in for a huge raise from his \$9 million cap hit. It seems unthinkable that the Avalanche would allow him to walk to free agency or trade him like they did with Mikko Rantanen, but they will need to clear cap space. That necessitated the trade of Valeri Nichushkin, but it could also mean one or more of Lehkonen, Roy, Burns, and Wedgewood won't be offered contracts beyond this season with the Avs tight against the cap. If Makar is re-signed soon, the status of the other players will be worth watching... Lysell is the only RFA because the Avalanche don't have much young talent, with the focus on winning now. He will need to prove he belongs in the NHL.

2027 RFA: *Lysell*

2027 UFA: *Lehkonen, Roy, Makar, Burns, Wedgewood, Merkulov*

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Fedor Svechkov		
Boom or bust	Fedor Svechkov		
Multicategory / Banger	Josh Manson		
Salary cap bargain	Brent Burns		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Artturi Lehkonen	37	40	147
Brent Burns	97	17	168
Brett Kulak	114	25	101
Brock Nelson	54	37	191
Cale Makar	127	44	222
Devon Toews	101	35	139
Fedor Svechkov	33	67	81
Gabriel Landeskog	33	92	152
Jaden Schwartz	50	43	113
Josh Manson	87	153	98
Logan O'Connor	46	63	81
Martin Necas	26	76	216
Nathan Mackinnon	56	54	354
Nazem Kadri	29	54	239
Nicolas Roy	44	75	96
Noah Juulsen	47	108	29
Parker Kelly	64	174	99
Sam Malinski	101	49	172
Vinnie Hinostroza	14	29	45

Dobber Advanced... AVALANCHE



Observation: MacKinnon, Necas, Toews, Lehkonen, and Makar dominate the top-right quadrant, shouldering heavy minutes and receiving significant offensive-zone starts against varied competition.

Fantasy Impact: These are the primary engines of the Avalanche's even-strength attack. They are converting their opportunity into elite, sustainable production. Makar, Necas, and Lehkonen show orange bubbles, with Makar unusually dark orange—normally his bubble is dark blue. Since he is too young and too elite to be declining, something was likely affecting him—perhaps playing through a minor injury or not being in peak form. He ended the season with five points in 11 games, which is very un-Makar-like.

Observation: Valeri Nichushkin (now with Columbus) and Nelson operated in the center quadrant against the toughest quality of competition, maintaining strong possession metrics despite heavy responsibility.

Fantasy Impact: These two faced the toughest lines in both zones when needed, freeing up the majority of offensive-zone starts for the big guns.

Observation: Landeskog is receiving balanced deployment while maintaining strong possession metrics, acting as the team's reliable top-six glue.

Fantasy Impact: After his time off, the Avs weren't going to throw him to the wolves, but he still wasn't sheltered—and he held his own. Landeskog remains a versatile piece who provides steady scoring and reliable category coverage, making him a "hold" or strategic draft target in deep-roster leagues. He's back.

Observation: Manson, Kulak, and Burns occupy the neutral zone, managing difficult competition while providing essential defensive stability.

Fantasy Impact: Don't expect major point spikes here. These players are the "real hockey" anchors that allow the

offensive weapons to flourish. Their fantasy value is limited to leagues that track peripherals like Hits and blocks, or if you need a veteran stabilizer for plus/minus.

Observation: Roy appears as a distinct outlier on the left side of the chart, handling defensive-zone-heavy, high-leverage minutes with both Toronto and Colorado.

Fantasy Impact: Roy is a “real hockey” specialist with little value in points-only leagues. His deployment shows he was the team’s primary defensive-zone pivot, which caps his offensive upside. His bubble sits far left largely because of Toronto’s heavy defensive-zone usage. A full season in Colorado likely brings him closer to the 40% range. Him taking those faceoffs frees Nelson and MacKinnon for offensive-zone draws.

Observation: Brindley, Jack Drury (now with Nashville), and Ivan Ivan (BOS) operated in sheltered, lower-leverage minutes as depth pieces.

Fantasy Impact: These are “watch list” assets. Their deployment showed the coaching staff was still evaluating their NHL readiness. They didn’t offer immediate fantasy value, but monitor them for late-season waiver potential—if their bubbles shift rightward, it signals growing trust and possible scoring responsibility.

Observation: Zakhar Bardakov (now back in Europe) faced the lowest competition on the team by a wide margin—possibly in the entire league. In that very basic, very sheltered role with limited minutes, his possession metrics were barely “okay.”

Fantasy Impact: Bardakov has modest points potential but real multi-category appeal in Hits and blocks. Just 7:12 of ice time limited his numbers across the board. He will need to round out his game to earn the trust required for more minutes. At 25 years old and no longer in North America, you can close the book on this guy.

● NOTIFICATIONS

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Avalanche by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>NATHAN MACKINNON</u>	C	80	65.6	1052	0.93	12.2	57.4	78.9	75.1	77	69.8	4.3	24	32.4
<u>MARTIN NECAS</u>	R	78	62.1	1053	0.929	12.4	55.9	74.9	67.1	70.4	58.5	3.6	27	43.5
<u>CALE MAKAR</u>	D	75	62.3	1034	0.929	10.5	54.4	75.3	57.2	52.6	70.7	2.5	26	44.1
<u>BROCK NELSON</u>	C	81	51.2	1010	0.917	9.3	57.2	60.3	59.1	61.3	52.9	2.4	16	50
<u>VALERI NICHUSHKIN</u>	R	72	49.1	1001	0.906	9.5	57.5	35.6	63.6	69.2	36.4	2.3	20	62.5
<u>ARTTURI LEHKONEN</u>	L	70	58.1	1053	0.933	12	55.2	43.1	55.2	61.3	16.7	2.2	8	29.6
<u>GABRIEL LANDESKOG</u>	L	60	53	1030	0.93	10	55.5	45.3	45.5	49.2	31.3	2.1	14	66.7
<u>PARKER KELLY</u>	L	82	43.5	1005	0.912	9.3	56.1	0.9	77.8	81.4	0	2	8	57.1
<u>NAZEM KADRI</u>	C	16	63.6	969	0.897	7.2	52.4	76.6	64.9	68.9	59.4	1.9	1	20
<u>SAM MALINSKI</u>	D	82	51.2	1035	0.939	9.6	58.6	4.4	52.6	52.7	100	1.7	13	40.6
<u>NICOLAS ROY</u>	R	15	34.7	1020	0.919	10.1	47.2	25.5	53.2	56.4	28.6	1.5	0	0
<u>GAVIN BRINDLEY</u>	R	56	50.1	1001	0.899	10.2	53.6	18.3	52	52	0	1.5	4	57.1
<u>BRENT BURNS</u>	D	82	48.3	1020	0.919	10.1	55.6	12.4	40.7	41	50	1.4	10	43.5
<u>JACK DRURY</u>	C	82	44.8	996	0.916	8	57.3	4	58.7	61.4	0	1.4	7	41.2
<u>JOSH MANSON</u>	D	79	45.6	1012	0.91	10.2	56.9	1.2	36	36.5	0	1.3	13	50
<u>DEVON TOEWS</u>	D	68	60.4	1025	0.92	10.5	57.1	25.4	27	27.1	33.3	0.9	12	57.1

- Kadri saw a large share of available PP time after he arrived, yet Nelson maintained most of his portion. This was possible because, between Nelson and Makar, enough games were missed due to injury for Kadri to fill in. Kadri himself also missed the final five games. In the playoffs, it was clearly Kadri on the top unit, bumping Nelson to the second unit. This is a major reason Nelson managed just three points in 13 playoff games—none on the power play.
- Nichushkin and Lehkonen were very poor contributors on the man advantage, suggesting they won't receive first-unit looks anytime soon. Nichushkin may get another chance with Columbus, however.
- Lehkonen's 12.0% 5-on-5 S% was the highest of his career. That said, the entire NHL saw elevated 5-on-5 shooting percentages, and playing alongside MacKinnon makes the number less concerning. Still, without meaningful PP production, it's difficult to expect any uptick in his scoring regardless of linemates.
- Kadri's 7.2% 5-on-5 S% is driven largely by his stint with the low-scoring Flames. These reports pull full-season numbers and do not separate by team. Even so, it's reasonable to expect a bump in his even-strength production, given he finished with only 34 points last season (down from 45 the year before).
- Nelson, Nichushkin, and Landeskog each posted a high proportion of secondary assists, indicating likely regression. With Nelson expected to lose his spot on the first PP unit, several signs point toward an overall decline in his production.

Key departures	Ross Colton (NSH), Jack Drury (NSH), Valeri Nichushkin (CBJ), Nick Blankenburg (UFA)
Arrivals	Jaden Schwartz (SEA), Zachary L'Heureux (NSH), Fyodor Svechkov (NSH), Fabian Lysell (BOS), Noah Juulsen (PHI), Georgii Merkulov (BOS)

Columbus BLUE JACKETS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Kirill Marchenko	80	28	76	23	Adam Fantilli	83	29	79	28	Valeri Nichushkin	69	27	53	23
Cole Sillinger	77	13	35	40	Sean Monahan	74	19	44	14	Kent Johnson	79	20	45	21
Dmitri Voronkov	72	19	41	57	Charlie Coyle	84	21	46	26	Conor Garland	80	18	42	41
Miles Wood	57	7	12	51	Luca Del Bel Belluz	71	9	23	11	Mathieu Olivier	68	13	24	106
Ryan Lomberg	73	4	10	67	Isac Lundestrom	45	3	7	4	Danton Heinen	68	10	18	26
					Luca Pinelli	5	0	2	0	Mikael Pyhtia	25	3	4	2
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Zach Werenski	77	22	82	24	Damon Severson	71	8	30	49	Jet Greaves	55	25	2	2.70
Ivan Provorov	84	8	32	28	D Mateychuk	77	13	35	23	Elvis Merzlikins	25	11	1	3.35
Jake Christiansen	34	0	3	6	Dante Fabbro	75	6	14	37	Pheonix Copley	5	2	0	3.25
Jackson Smith	11	0	2	2	Erik Gudbranson	46	2	7	35					

Restricted Free Agents: Fantilli, Sillinger

What to look for in camp: How is Johnson doing? A year ago, he reportedly lost 12 pounds. Not from illness or anything—he's just one of those people who has trouble holding weight. As a result, he was pushed off the puck easily. He had been working on strengthening his upper body last summer. This year, the team is working with him on a high-calorie diet and packing on the pounds, focusing on leg and core strength. How does this look in training camp? Is he putting up solid preseason points? Is he getting a lot of rope? A lot of PP time? Look for signals of a bounce-back. The team believes he has "elite" upside.

Future Fantasy Stud: Mateychuk is tracking nicely to be one of the better puck-moving defensemen in the league. The only drawback is he's behind one of the best in Werenski. But Werenski made it very clear that next summer he will not sign an extension. Werenski has two years left on his contract, but there is a strong likelihood that he is traded within the next year. That opens the door wide for Mateychuk.

- The further the season went along, the more it became clear that Johnson was regressing, not progressing. And the PPTOI was gradually shifted to Coyle, as well as the offensive duties (even though one is a center and one is a wing). Coyle had 33 points in his last 38 games after starting with 25 in 44. It's fair to say that Johnson gets his job back to start, but if he is still last year's version of himself, then the offense will swing back to Coyle.

- Getting a jump start on his breakout threshold (BT) season, Fantilli ended last campaign with 29 points in 32 games after starting the year with 30 in 50.

- Mult-cat stud alert: Between January 28 and March 28, just before getting injured, Olivier had 11 goals, 15 points, 45 SOG, 34 PIM and 65 Hits in just 22 games. He definitely has his moments.

- Monahan started the season getting 2:44 of PPTOI and 18:24 TOI overall in the first quarter. That went down a little next quarter, and again the next quarter. In the final quarter (21 games), his PPTOI was 1:12 and TOI was 15:58. He had just one point in his last 14 games.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Zach Werenski	93	78	Luca Del Bel Belluz	70%		
Adam Fantilli	105	75	Jackson Smith	40%		
Kirill Marchenko	85	75	Mikael Pyhtia	30%		
Kent Johnson	75	58	Luca Pinelli	10%		
Valeri Nichushkin	75	55				
Dmitri Voronkov	65	52				
Oscar Hemming	73	52				
Sean Monahan	70	50				
Cole Sillinger	68	50				
Cayden Lindstrom	83	50				
Denton Mateychuk	68	48				
Charlie Coyle	60	48	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Conor Garland	62	48	Kent Johnson	65	20%	
Jackson Smith	70	45	Valeri Nichushkin	65	20%	
Luca Del Bel Belluz	70	43	Cole Sillinger	50	15%	
Jordan Dumais	72	43	Denton Mateychuk	45	15%	
Ivan Provorov	50	37				
Damon Severson	45	35				
Dante Fabbro	38	35				

- You'd think that Garland getting a fresh start after seemingly being held back in Vancouver would be a good thing. But his usage, deployment and ice time actually went down even further upon arriving in Columbus. His TOI and PPTOI dropped to 13:01 and 1:02 respectively, and he only managed seven points in 21 games with the Jackets.

- Del Bel Belluz now needs to clear waivers to be sent down, so he will almost certainly crack the roster opening day. But how long he stays depends on him. He would probably need to knock Lundestrom off the roster.

Injuries:

A report out of Sweden in early July stated that Lundestrom has torn his Achilles. Assuming that is true, he is expected to be out until around December... Nichushkin (lower body) missed the final game of the playoffs for Colorado, with no further news reported... Olivier was sidelined with an upper-body injury in late March, but he said he would have been ready had Columbus made the playoffs... Voronkov (hand) missed nearly all of the final quarter... Severson underwent shoulder surgery in early April, and it is unclear whether he will be ready for the start of the season...**Merzlikins underwent shoulder surgery on August 20 and should miss the start of the season.**

Dobber's Band-Aid Boys: Lundestrom, Wood, Nichushkin, Severson, Fabbro, Olivier.

Breakout Threshold:

Fantilli has played 213 career games and is primed for a big season. He makes a fantastic offseason acquisition or draft-day steal. It's worth noting that last year was supposed to be Johnson's BT year. It obviously didn't happen.

Goalies:

In his first full NHL season, Greaves grabbed the starting job away from Merzlikins, appearing in 55 games and making 35 quality starts (fifth in the NHL). The Jackets never seem to rise to the upper echelons of the league, which might limit Greaves' upside somewhat. Meanwhile, Merzlikins simply hadn't gotten the job done, with a goals-against average above 3.00 for five consecutive seasons and a save percentage below 0.900 for four consecutive seasons. The Jackets have decided to stick with Elvis's \$5.4 million cap hit for one more season rather than buying him out. Make no mistake: Greaves is the goalie of the present and likely the future... The Jackets also have Pheonix Copley in the system, and he could push for playing time if Greaves is injured. **Dobber's confidence that Greaves is the starter: 99%**

Contract Year:

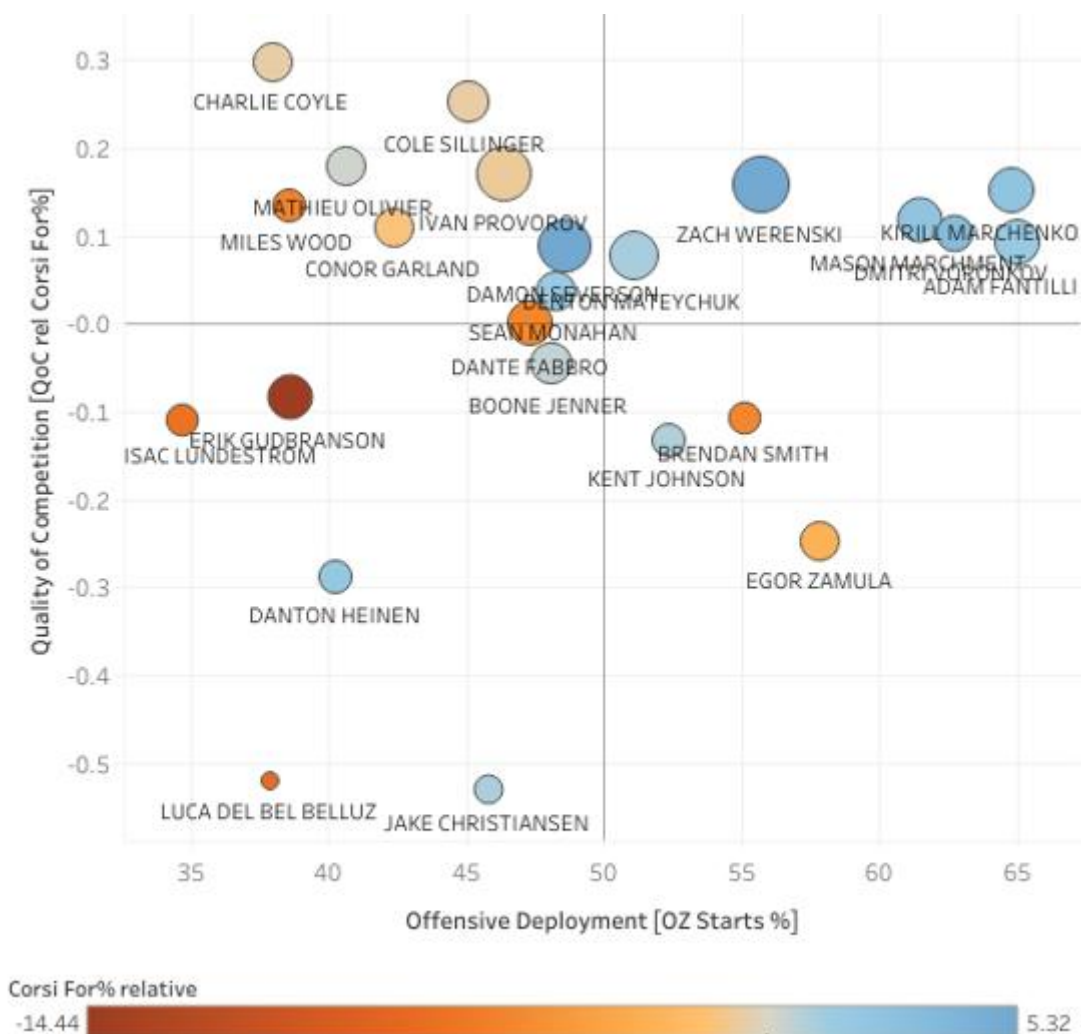
The Blue Jackets will need to take care of potential future No. 1 center Fantilli and potential No. 1 goalie Greaves before shifting their focus to 2027 free agents. With the recent Leo Carlsson contract, the price has increased on Fantilli... There's a lot to think about in 2027, too. On a club that has had its share of players not wanting to stay, Marchenko is the latest to be in the trade rumor mill. The Jackets have stated they do not plan to trade him and instead will try to sign him. Voronkov, Johnson, and Mateychuk are also talented players the Jackets will try to take care of after Fantilli and Marchenko... Merzlikins' time in Columbus might finally be up soon. Declining play combined with the emergence of Greaves could mean Elvis is traded before the deadline, especially if the Jackets are not in the playoff race.

2027 RFA: Voronkov, Marchenko, Johnson, Del Bel Belluz, Mateychuk

2027 UFA: Lundestrom, Gudbranson, Christiansen, Merzlikins, Copley, Heinen

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Adam Fantilli		
Boom or bust	Sean Monahan		
Multicategory / Banger	Mathieu Olivier		
Salary cap bargain	Kirill Marchenko		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adam Fantilli	54	133	224
Charlie Coyle	51	105	143
Cole Sillinger	42	104	138
Conor Garland	36	56	160
Damon Severson	89	43	93
Dante Fabbro	124	67	83
Denton Mateychuk	99	34	123
Dmitri Voronkov	36	109	130
Erik Gudbranson	73	59	37
Isac Lundestrom	36	40	58
Ivan Provorov	134	29	143
Kent Johnson	36	16	142
Kirill Marchenko	41	60	239
Luca Del Bel Belluz	50	21	92
Mathieu Olivier	51	230	88
Miles Wood	23	71	68
Ryan Lomberg	22	146	58
Sean Monahan	37	37	133
Valeri Nichushkin	28	55	173
Zach Werenski	104	25	263

Dobber Advanced... BLUE JACKETS



Observation: Fantilli, Marchenko, Mason Marchment (now with San Jose), and Voronkov dominated the right-hand side of the chart, receiving significant offensive-zone starts against varied competition.

Fantasy Impact: These are the foundational building blocks of the Blue Jackets' offense. Fantilli is the "must-own" cornerstone, and this deployment is explicitly designed to maximize his point-producing ceiling. Marchenko and Voronkov have proven they can leverage this usage to tilt the ice. Their deployment signals that the coaching staff is funneling all even-strength offensive opportunity through them.

Observation: Coyle and Sillinger were handling a high quality of competition in the upper-left quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: While their possession metrics show marginal orange (reflecting the difficulty of their matchups), they are the "real hockey" workhorses. They won't provide explosive scoring, but their ability to handle the toughest minutes allows the organization to keep the younger stars (Fantilli/Marchenko) in protected roles. Both still managed to produce despite the defensive deployment—and would likely score more if not for the burden they carry.

Observation: Werenski operated in a high-offensive-zone role while maintaining excellent possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: Werenski is your elite, cornerstone defenseman. He is one of the few players on the roster who can translate high-leverage offensive usage into sustainable, high-end fantasy production. He is a "set-and-forget" blueliner; his efficiency confirms he is the primary engine of the Columbus power play and even-strength attack. But we already knew that.

Observation: Johnson received sheltered offensive minutes but hovered near the neutral line in possession efficiency.

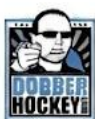
Fantasy Impact: Johnson remains a developmental asset. The coaching staff sheltered his minutes despite his strong possession numbers in tough situations in 2024–25. His inability to drive dominant possession relative to his linemates suggests he is still finding consistency. He is a high-upside stash in dynasty formats, but in standard leagues he remains a secondary option until he proves he can tilt the ice in his favor.

Observation: Olivier, Wood, and Lundestrom occupy the middle-left of the chart, characterized by harder matchups and/or lower offensive deployment.

Fantasy Impact: These players are "do not draft" candidates in points-only leagues. Their usage dictates a role focused on defensive responsibility, checking, and grinding out minutes, which severely caps their offensive ceiling. They are structural depth, not scoring engines. Garland was in a similar role, and until he returns to the usage he had in previous seasons, he is also a "do not draft."

Observation: Mateychuk and Severson are seeing balanced deployment and showing reliable possession metrics.

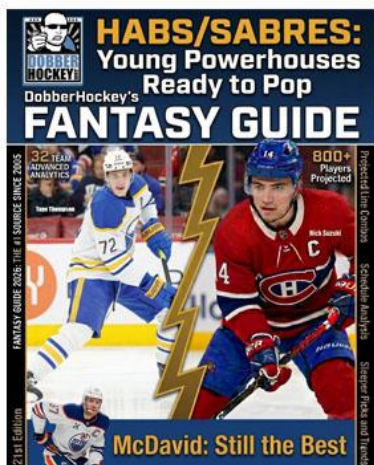
Fantasy Impact: These two are your stability plays on the blue line. While Werenski handles the high-octane offensive starts, Mateychuk and Severson take on the heavy lifting in more neutral settings and hold their own. They are excellent targets if you need reliable depth defenders who won't hurt your ratios, with Mateychuk being an intriguing buy-low candidate if you believe his development will lead to increased power-play time.



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Blue Jackets by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
MASON MARCHMENT	L	39	61.4	1044	0.933	11.1	51.2	66.6	66.2	71.7	46.7	2.8	7	41.2
KIRILL MARCHENKO	L	76	64.8	1023	0.93	9.3	52.9	73.2	71.3	72.1	71.9	2.8	20	50
ZACH WERENSKI	D	75	55.7	1005	0.906	9.9	53.8	76.9	63.8	61.5	72.4	2.4	31	52.5
CHARLIE COYLE	C	82	37.9	1023	0.921	10.2	50.5	49.2	69	72.6	68.4	2.3	12	31.6
ADAM FANTILLI	C	82	64.9	982	0.896	8.6	52	63.5	64.1	70.8	48.1	2.3	18	51.4
DMITRI VORONKOV	L	63	62.7	1014	0.92	9.4	53.1	51.1	59.3	62.2	52.9	2.2	6	40
BOONE JENNER	C	67	48	1003	0.907	9.6	51.4	19.7	76	73.9	100	2.1	8	32
MATHIEU OLIVIER	R	61	40.6	1029	0.929	10	50.8	0.7	57.8	57.8	0	1.8	5	45.5
SEAN MONAHAN	C	78	48.2	989	0.907	8.2	52.8	46.8	49.3	48.1	58.8	1.6	11	47.8
DANTON HEINEN	R	33	40.2	1011	0.915	9.6	53.6	0.1	52.2	52.2	0	1.6	2	40
COLE SILLINGER	L	81	45	992	0.903	8.9	50.4	6.9	55.9	56.1	50	1.6	12	48
CONOR GARLAND	R	21	42.4	978	0.912	6.6	48	23.1	67.3	71.9	66.7	1.5	0	0
DAMON SEVERSON	D	71	48.5	1002	0.908	9.4	54.3	27.7	40	37.8	80	1.3	12	50
MILES WOOD	L	54	38.5	969	0.891	7.8	45.4	1	63.6	61.9	0	1.3	3	50
KENT JOHNSON	R	76	52.3	975	0.892	8.3	52.1	38.6	44.9	57.1	14.3	1.3	7	46.7
DENTON MATEYCHUK	D	75	51.1	1005	0.908	9.7	52.1	13.5	46.3	44.4	100	1.3	7	38.9
MASON MARCHMENT	L	39	61.4	1044	0.933	11.1	51.2	66.6	66.2	71.7	46.7	2.8	7	41.2
KIRILL MARCHENKO	L	76	64.8	1023	0.93	9.3	52.9	73.2	71.3	72.1	71.9	2.8	20	50

- Johnson's 5-on-5 S% was too high in 2024–25 at 13.3. But the pendulum swung too far the other way last season, dropping to 8.3. The year was so rough for Johnson that there's really nowhere to go but up.
- Marchment (SJS) and Coyle were the only two players above the NHL norm of 10.0% for 5-on-5 S%. Most would agree that, since joining Columbus, their production inflated a little. Beyond Johnson, both Garland and Fantilli are notable players who should have seen better even-strength production.
- The top PP unit began with Marchenko, Werenski, Fantilli, Voronkov, and Monahan. But by the midpoint, Monahan was bumped for Coyle, and Voronkov was later bumped for Marchment. Johnson occasionally received looks there, but with a 14.3 PP IPP, he could never secure a foothold.
- Marchment and Fantilli were not strong on the power play, each contributing to fewer than 50% of the PPG scored while they were on the ice.
- Mateychuk saw only 41 minutes of PP time in total. The team scored three times during those minutes—and he was in on all three, playing with the second-unit group.
- Monahan's sharp decline is difficult to explain using these metrics. Puck luck accounts for part of it, but his even-strength IPP was below 50, which simply shouldn't happen—not for a skilled player coming off a season in which he exceeded a point per game. That number is a career low by a wide margin. His teammates were getting points without him, even when he was on the ice.

Key departures	Boone Jenner (WSH), Mason Marchment (SJS), Yegor Zamula (UFA)
Arrivals	Valeri Nichushkin (COL), Ryan Lomberg (CGY), Phoenix Copley (LAK)

Dallas STARS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Jason Robertson	84	39	109	25	Wyatt Johnston	84	37	88	29	Mikko Rantanen	77	30	86	69
Justin Hryckowian	83	13	37	42	Roope Hintz	72	25	59	24	Tyler Seguin	50	17	37	14
Jamie Benn	74	17	36	55	Matt Duchene	80	24	64	15	Colin Blackwell	61	6	12	24
Sam Steel	78	9	29	29	Radek Faksa	69	4	17	23	Joel Kiviranta	64	7	11	14
Oskar Back	73	5	14	6	Arttu Hyry	15	2	4	2					
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Miro Heiskanen	72	8	60	28	Esa Lindell	83	5	26	16	Jake Oettinger	55	34	3	2.65
Thomas Harley	78	12	42	21	Nils Lundkvist	62	6	18	21	Casey DeSmith	30	13	1	2.60
Lian Bichsel	68	6	14	40	Tyler Myers	76	4	16	70					
Kyle Capobianco	37	1	5	9										

Restricted Free Agents: none

On the hot seat: He was here a year ago, and here he is again. The seat is still hot! Now 26, Lundkvist is coming off his fourth consecutive injury-filled campaign. He never had a chance. Five NHL seasons and just 235 total games, sporadically spaced out, stifling development. And now, of course, gaining fantasy appeal is a massive long shot. At this point, just get to 70 games and approach 30 points, and then we can regain hope for his potential.

What to look for in camp: Hryckowian got better as the season wore on, showing surprising offense at the pro level and winning faceoffs like a veteran (55.1%). If he's used on the power play in camp, it would boost him into fantasy-worthy status in points-only leagues.

- Duchene missed nearly two months with an injury, and when he returned, he understandably started slow. But he finished the season with 34 points in 31 games. He may be 35, but there's still gas in the tank.

- When Duchene was hurt, Steel was promoted to the top six and started out looking promising, at one point tallying five points in five games. He then faded. Ironically, he found his groove later by lining up with Duchene and picked up 19 points in 28 games before he, himself, got hurt (hip).

- Hryckowian saw almost zero PP time in the first half, but by the final 20 games he was averaging 90 seconds per game. He had 17 points in the second half. However, in the playoffs he was down to 30 seconds PPTOI.

- Rantanen suffered two injuries in the second half which were likely the cause for his late-season slowdown. He had just 15 points in the last 19 games after starting with 62 in 45 games.

- When Rantanen was sidelined for 16 games in February and March, Robertson and Johnston had 21 and 19 points respectively, and Duchene had 17. Their production wasn't slowed one iota by the loss of Rantanen.

- Five Stars players tallied six or more points in the postseason (six games): Duchene leading with nine, followed by Robertson, Rantanen, Heiskanen and Johnston. In other words, the usual suspects. Harley and Benn had zero. Lack of depth scoring was exposed—with Hintz out, the rest of the team combined for eight points.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Mikko Rantanen	110	97	Arttu Hyry	45%	
Jason Robertson	110	93	Emil Hemming	25%	
Wyatt Johnston	95	87			
Roope Hintz	88	72			
Miro Heiskanen	75	65			
Matt Duchene	77	57			
Thomas Harley	70	55			
Tyler Seguin	67	50			
Brandon Gorzynski	65	42			
Justin Hryckowian	67	38			
Arttu Hyry	58	38			
Cameron Schmidt	78	37	Sleeper	Pts	%
Emil Hemming	70	37	Justin Hryckowian	50	10%
Sam Steel	53	32	Nils Lundkvist	30	10%
Jakub Vanecek	45	32			
Nils Lundkvist	48	30			
Tristan Bertucci	52	30			
Aram Minnetian	40	30			
Lian Bichsel	40	28			

Injuries:

Hintz (hamstring) was believed to be close to returning during the playoffs. His season had ended in early March... Seguin underwent season-ending surgery for a torn ACL in December. He expects to be ready for training camp... Hyry (lower body) missed the Stars' final game of the playoffs... Lundkvist (face) missed the Stars' last two games of the playoffs. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** *Faksa, Seguin, Heiskanen, Lundkvist.*

Breakout Threshold:

Only Lundkvist is inside that BT window, and he's taking a second crack at it, with last year's injury keeping his games down enough to keep him eligible.

Goalies:

This situation remains unchanged from last season. Oettinger has appeared in at least 50 games in each of the last four campaigns, and he has earned at least 30 wins in each of the last five seasons. He's as much of a "set and forget" goalie option as there is, and he should be a top-five goalie drafted in single-season leagues again. DeSmith will be his backup again for his third season with the Stars, making him a streaming play when it's his turn to start. Don't expect him to appear in more than 30 games. Remi Poirier is the most likely call-up should either Oettinger or DeSmith be injured. DeSmith has proven he can handle a short-term starter's workload in the event of an injury or the other goalie slumping, though. Under normal circumstances, there should be zero doubt about who starts.

Dobber's confidence that Oettinger is the starter: 99%

Contract Year:

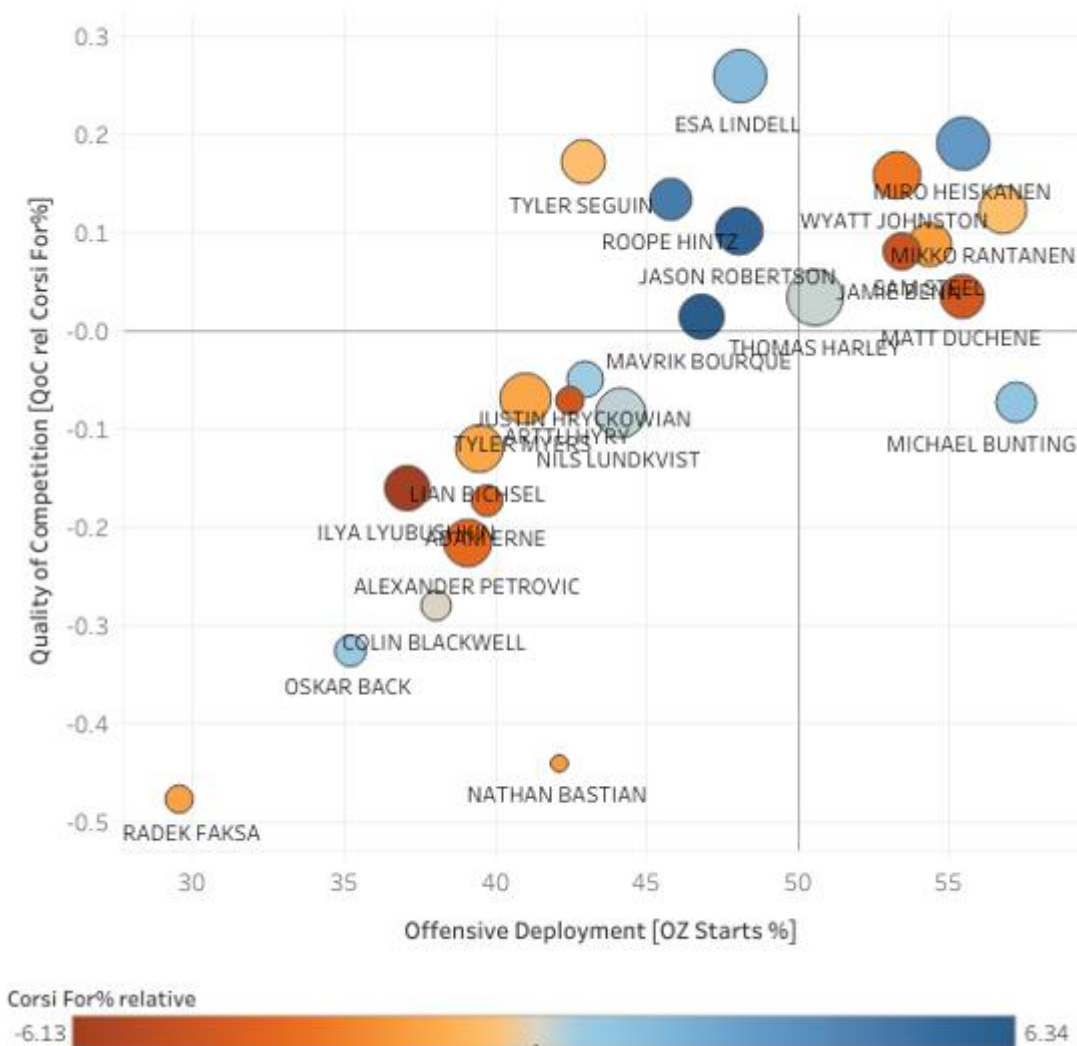
With the Stars being a veteran team, Bichsel is the only 2027 RFA... Long-time veterans Seguin and Benn are in the final year of their contracts. Seguin's nearly \$10 million cap hit coming off the books would go a long way in clearing room for Robertson (who is on a one-year deal), and his injury status could mean that his career won't last much longer. Benn may simply be in his final year.

2027 RFA: *Bichsel*

2027 UFA: *Seguin, Steel, Kiviranta, Benn, Blackwell, Back, Myers, DeSmith, Robertson*

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Justin Hryckowian		
Boom or bust	Tyler Seguin		
Multicategory / Banger	Tyler Myers		
Salary cap bargain	Matt Duchene		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Colin Blackwell	31	92	61
Esa Lindell	175	42	92
Jamie Benn	22	89	104
Jason Robertson	34	59	286
Joel Kiviranta	29	90	70
Justin Hryckowian	50	134	91
Kyle Capobianco	29	14	22
Lian Bichsel	69	204	61
Matt Duchene	24	32	144
Mikko Rantanen	39	54	193
Miro Heiskanen	122	22	151
Nils Lundkvist	60	37	68
Oskar Back	37	29	51
Radek Faksa	49	90	49
Roope Hintz	36	65	158
Sam Steel	31	68	94
Thomas Harley	171	47	148
Tyler Myers	118	83	91
Tyler Seguin	15	37	100
Wyatt Johnston	55	55	218

Dobber Advanced... STARS



Observation: Heiskanen, Johnston, and Rantanen are being fed heavy offensive-zone starts (55%+) against elite competition, all while maintaining their efficiency.

Fantasy Impact: These are the primary engines of the Stars' attack. They are converting their opportunity into elite, sustainable production. Heiskanen was by far the best of the group in terms of pushing possession forward. It was surprising to see Johnston and Duchene show such a shade of orange/brown. Duchene can perhaps be excused, returning from a long absence, but Johnston appears to need a bit more sheltered deployment.

Observation: Lindell handled the toughest quality of competition on the team, often facing opposing top lines in more balanced zone deployment.

Fantasy Impact: This opened the door for Heiskanen—and even Harley—to receive better offensive deployment. Lindell won't blow you away with point production, but his ability to drive play and mitigate damage against elite lines makes him extremely reliable in leagues that track plus/minus or value defensive floor. He provides the structural stability that allows the rest of the team to play more aggressively.

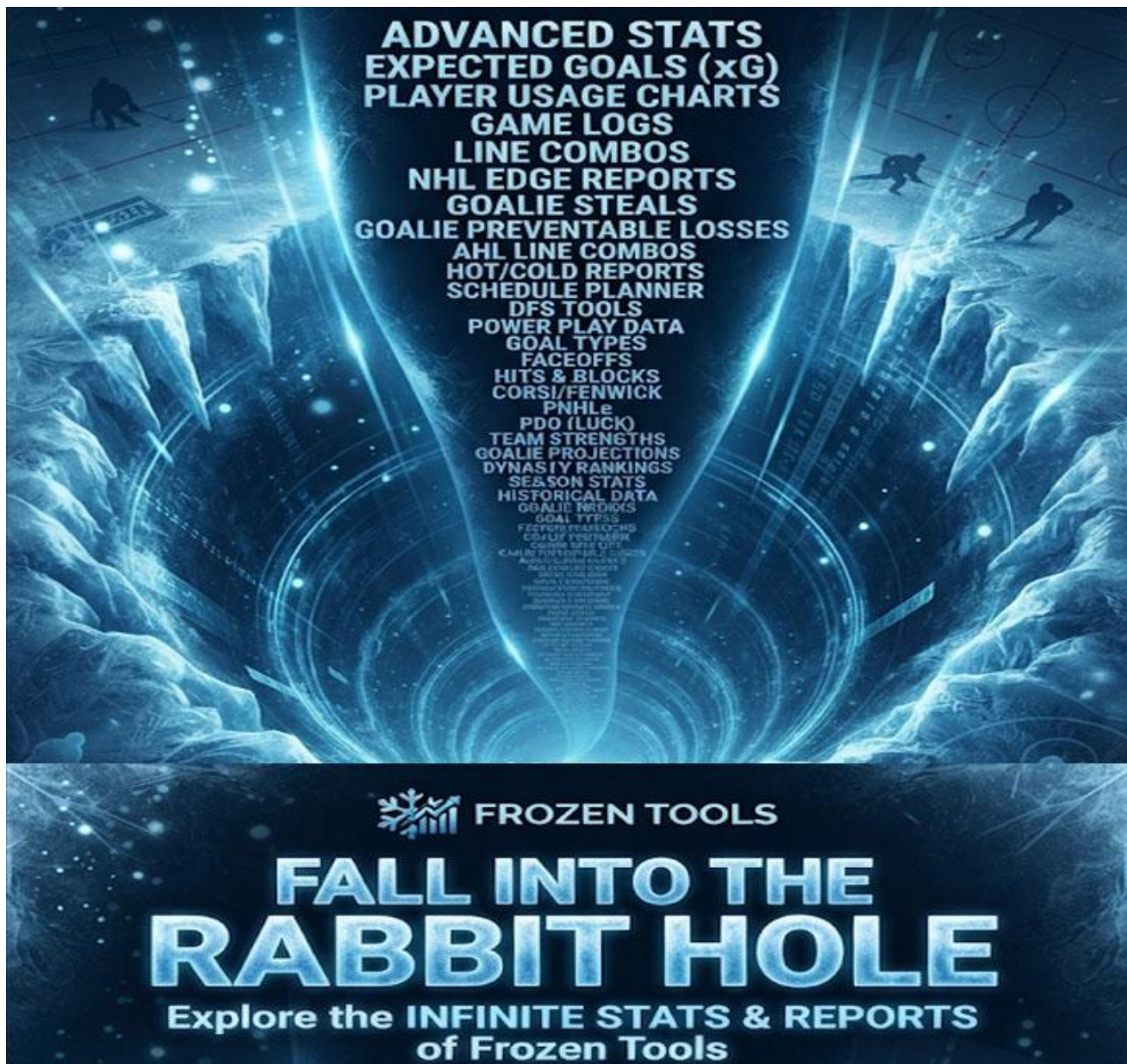
Observation: Robertson, Mavrik Bourque (now with Nashville), and Hintz were the best possession drivers on the team.

Fantasy Impact: They didn't receive the offensive-zone starts that the top line did, but if they did, the potential for significantly better numbers is obvious. Even with more defensive-zone starts, they tilted the ice more often than not. It doesn't appear that Rantanen, Johnston, Duchene, Steel, or Benn can replicate this.

Observation: Harley operated in middle-ground deployment, facing moderate competition while maintaining steady possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: Unless Heiskanen gets hurt, Harley currently provides "stability" on the blue line. He is an interesting

Fantasy Impact: Now 37, Benn is coming off another 50-point-pace season. But it doesn't look like he'll be able to exceed that, and he should receive more sheltered deployment wherever he signs next.



Stars by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>MIKKO RANTANEN</u>	R	64	56.8	1044	0.927	11.7	45.3	84.7	74.8	78.2	70.8	3.6	21	38.2
<u>JASON ROBERTSON</u>	L	82	48	1034	0.926	10.8	50.7	80.7	66.2	67.1	65.1	3.5	27	52.9
<u>WYATT JOHNSTON</u>	C	82	53.2	1025	0.922	10.3	45.4	73.3	67.7	65.7	70	3.1	17	41.5
<u>MATT DUCHENE</u>	C	57	55.4	1019	0.894	12.5	45.1	48.9	61.6	63.3	58.3	2.9	8	27.6
<u>ROOPE HINTZ</u>	C	53	45.8	1049	0.928	12.1	49.5	68.2	51.8	52.1	51.4	2.9	11	37.9
<u>JAMIE BENN</u>	R	60	53.4	1038	0.909	12.9	45	31.7	65.5	75	40	2.7	9	42.9
<u>TYLER SEGUIN</u>	C	27	42.9	1075	0.943	13.2	44.2	41.3	58.6	61.9	50	2.3	3	30
<u>MAVRİK BOURQUE</u>	R	82	46.8	995	0.896	9.9	51.4	23.5	63.1	64.3	55.6	1.9	8	38.1
<u>MIRO HEISKANEN</u>	D	77	55.5	1016	0.911	10.5	48.9	72	47.7	47.3	50	1.9	33	61.1
<u>JUSTIN HRYCKOWIAN</u>	L	81	42.9	1005	0.9	10.5	47.8	13.1	68.2	65.8	83.3	1.7	7	43.8
<u>SAM STEEL</u>	L	73	54.3	1023	0.918	10.5	46.2	9.6	70.2	73.2	50	1.7	11	52.4
<u>RADEK FAKSA</u>	C	58	29.5	1005	0.923	8.2	44	0.4	94.4	100	0	1.5	6	40
<u>THOMAS HARLEY</u>	D	70	50.6	1009	0.91	9.9	47.2	33	43.4	43.3	50	1.3	15	50
<u>NATHAN BASTIAN</u>	R	36	42.1	1040	0.934	10.6	45.4	0.3	58.3	58.3	0	1.3	0	0
<u>ARTTU HYRY</u>	C	20	42.4	1008	0.91	9.8	46.8	0.9	62.5	71.4	0	1.3	1	50
<u>COLIN BLACKWELL</u>	R	70	38	993	0.896	9.7	47.1	0.2	62.5	65.2	0	1.1	3	27.3

- After two consecutive seasons in which 10 Dallas Stars reached a Pts/60 of 2.1 or higher, the 2025–26 season saw only seven players hit that mark. That said, having five players at 2.9 or higher is extremely impressive.
- The Stars had a clear-cut top power-play unit: Rantanen, Robertson, Johnston, Hintz, and Heiskanen, all of whom saw at least 68% of the season's PP time. That left very little for the second unit of Duchene, Benn, Seguin, Bourque, and Harley. Among that group, Benn, Seguin, and Heiskanen had the lowest impact.
- Hryckowian is an interesting case. He saw very little PP time—about 38 seconds per game, or 13.1% of available minutes—yet still picked up five PPPTS. One would think he'll become a more regular part of that second unit to see what shakes out. In the final quarter of the season, he received consistent second-unit time and added three PPPTS.
- Benn's PP results versus Bourque's (or Hryckowian's) hint at the possibility of Johnston cannibalizing some of his power-play time.
- Both Benn and Seguin (in just 27 games) had high 5-on-5 S% numbers. Given their age, it seems likely their production will slip. Nobody on the team had a significantly low 5-on-5 S%.
- Robertson's secondary-assist ratio is a little high for a forward. However, historically he has hovered in that range (four times in the last five years he has been between 50% and 55%), so it isn't concerning. He simply makes things happen and benefits from "setting up the setup."
- Looking at the IPPs (both ES and PP) of Heiskanen and Harley, it appears that new Coach Glen Gulutzan favored running offense through his forwards. Both defensemen are held down slightly in this system (i.e., instead of 63 points, maybe Heiskanen gets 73; instead of 36 points, perhaps Harley gets 50). As long as Gulutzan is behind the bench, their upside will likely remain capped.

Key departures	Mavrik Bourque (NSH), Michael Bunting (UFA), Ilya Lyubushkin (NSH)
Arrivals	Joel Kiviranta (COL)

Detroit RED WINGS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Alex DeBrincat	83	40	90	28	Dylan Larkin	77	33	72	44	Lucas Raymond	77	27	78	22
Emmitt Finn timer	83	15	33	8	Andrew Copp	73	11	33	20	Viktor Arvidsson	69	20	49	28
Nate Danielson	66	7	20	20	J.T. Compher	80	13	27	29	Keegan Kolesar	83	10	21	58
John Leonard	20	3	7	4	Marco Kasper	81	14	26	28	Mason Appleton	75	9	17	32
Carter Mazur	18	0	5	10	Michael Rasmussen	74	9	18	27	M Br-Nygaard	41	6	10	12
										Dominik Shine	6	1	1	2
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Simon Edvinsson	75	8	28	66	Moritz Seider	84	10	54	51	John Gibson	54	28	3	2.80
Albert Johansson	74	3	9	16	Justin Faulk	75	11	31	39	Daniil Tarasov	30	15	2	2.95
Ben Chiarot	82	5	13	68	A Sandin-Pellikka	65	8	25	14					
Jacob Bryson	47	2	6	10	Jacob Bernard-Docker	60	2	8	23					
William Wallinder	47	2	7	10										

Restricted Free Agents: Edvinsson

Camp battle: Brandsegg-Nygaard will be battling for a roster spot, and he could be up against journeyman minor-leaguer Leonard. Why would this be a battle? Well, Leonard was a top prospect at one point and never panned out. Now 28, he's long been written off. But he had an excellent season with Grand Rapids and when he was recalled, he had a very impressive 11 games. He wasn't sheltered, posted four points in 11 games with limited ice time and no tangible puck luck. It was good enough to get signed to an extension right away. And MBN still probably needs about a half season in the AHL yet. For those reasons, this becomes an interesting battle.

Future Fantasy Stud: Some of the Detroit blogs have been a little hard on Sandin-Pellikka, but before you give up on him, just remember that he's only 21—and last year was his first season outside of Sweden. Let's take a breath here. He has elite upside, probably shouldn't have made the team (he did make the team, which was unexpected, and that's a positive not a negative!). He could use a couple dozen games in the AHL, dominate that league offensively while logging big minutes. Either way, he's going to be a fantasy stud. Just wait a couple of years.

- Arvidsson had a surprising 41 points in his last 39 games with Boston last season. He really clicked on a line with Pavel Zacha and Casey Mittelstadt. Losing that chemistry could hurt.

- DeBrincat got better as the season went along, beginning with a solid 43 points in 45 games and finishing with 42 in 37. He played the last three-quarters of the season with Patrick Kane (now with Chicago) and Copp. That being said, his best quarter was the first one, thanks to the power play when he had nine PPPts (just four or five per quarter after that).

- Raymond hit a bit of a wall after the Olympic break. He had just 11 points in 20 games to end the season after starting it with 65 in 60. His linemates were pretty stable, playing with Larkin and Finn timer most of the campaign.

- Speaking of Finn timer, he had 19 points in the first half and 14 in the second. Drafted 201st overall in 2023, he wasn't expected to make the team straight out of junior hockey like that. It's very rare for a late draft pick to transition so quickly like that. Not only did he make the team, but he started off with eight points in nine games before coming down to earth.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Lucas Raymond	92	80	Nate Danielson	90%	
Alex DeBrincat	92	78	Axel Sandin-Pellikka	50%	
Dylan Larkin	85	75	John Leonard	50%	
Moritz Seider	73	57	M Brandsegg-Nygaard	45%	
M Brandsegg-Nygaard	70	53	William Wallinder	45%	
Emmitt Finn timer	68	52	Carter Mazur	40%	
JP Hurlbert	75	52			
Carter Bear	72	50			
Axel Sandin Pellikka	72	48			
Viktor Arvidsson	60	48			
Marco Kasper	65	45			
Nate Danielson	65	45	Sleeper	Pts	%
Max Plante	78	42	Marco Kasper	45	20%
Victor Plante	78	40	Emmitt Finn timer	55	10%
Michael Rasmussen	65	38	Carter Bear	40	10%
Simon Edvinsson	57	38			
J.T. Compher	53	38			
Andrew Copp	50	35			
Justin Faulk	43	35			

- When Larkin was sidelined for seven games in March, it hurt his linemates quite a bit. Raymond and Finnie had just three points each. The offense was all on the DeBrincat line, with him getting 10 points and Kane picking up eight.

- When Kane was sidelined with an injury, DeBrincat slipped a tad, posting 12 points in 15 games. Given the season that he had overall, that's notable. Especially with Kane not returning. Leonard replaced the latter and impressed.

- When Edvinsson was out of the lineup, his D partner Seider tallied eight points in nine games.

Injuries:

Larkin missed the final game of the season due to an undisclosed injury. The focus of his offseason news has been on his trade request... Arvidsson missed his last two playoff games with a rib injury. That did not seem to affect him signing as a free agent with Detroit... Appleton missed the final seven games of the regular season with an upper-body injury... Rasmussen missed the final four games of the season due to a lower-body injury... **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Appleton, Arvidsson, Gibson.

Breakout Threshold:

Edvinsson is only 25 games away from hitting 200, but as a 6-6 player, he most definitely fits our 'big man' model. So, his target is 400 games. Kasper has played 159 career NHL games and, if he stays healthy, would hit the BT in January. We're just hoping for any kind of rebound season at all from him.

Goalies:

Gibson was acquired a year ago to fix the Wings' unstable goalie situation. He managed to do that to some degree, performing at an elite level during the second and third quarters after a slow start. Tarasov was signed for one year to be Gibson's backup after appearing in a career-high 33 games for Florida. He has shown well at times but lacks the overall consistency to be an NHL starter. The Wings traded former first-round pick Sebastian Cossa to Utah because they are well-stocked in the pipeline with both Trey Augustine and Michal Postava. Twenty-one-year-old Augustine is more of the blue-chip option, but 24-year-old Postava started during the AHL playoffs and may be more NHL-ready. Either way, both Gibson and Tarasov have only one year left on their contracts, so either Augustine or Postava could be given an NHL look if they are playing well and the Wings are out of the race. **Dobber's confidence that Gibson is the starter: 90%**

Contract Year:

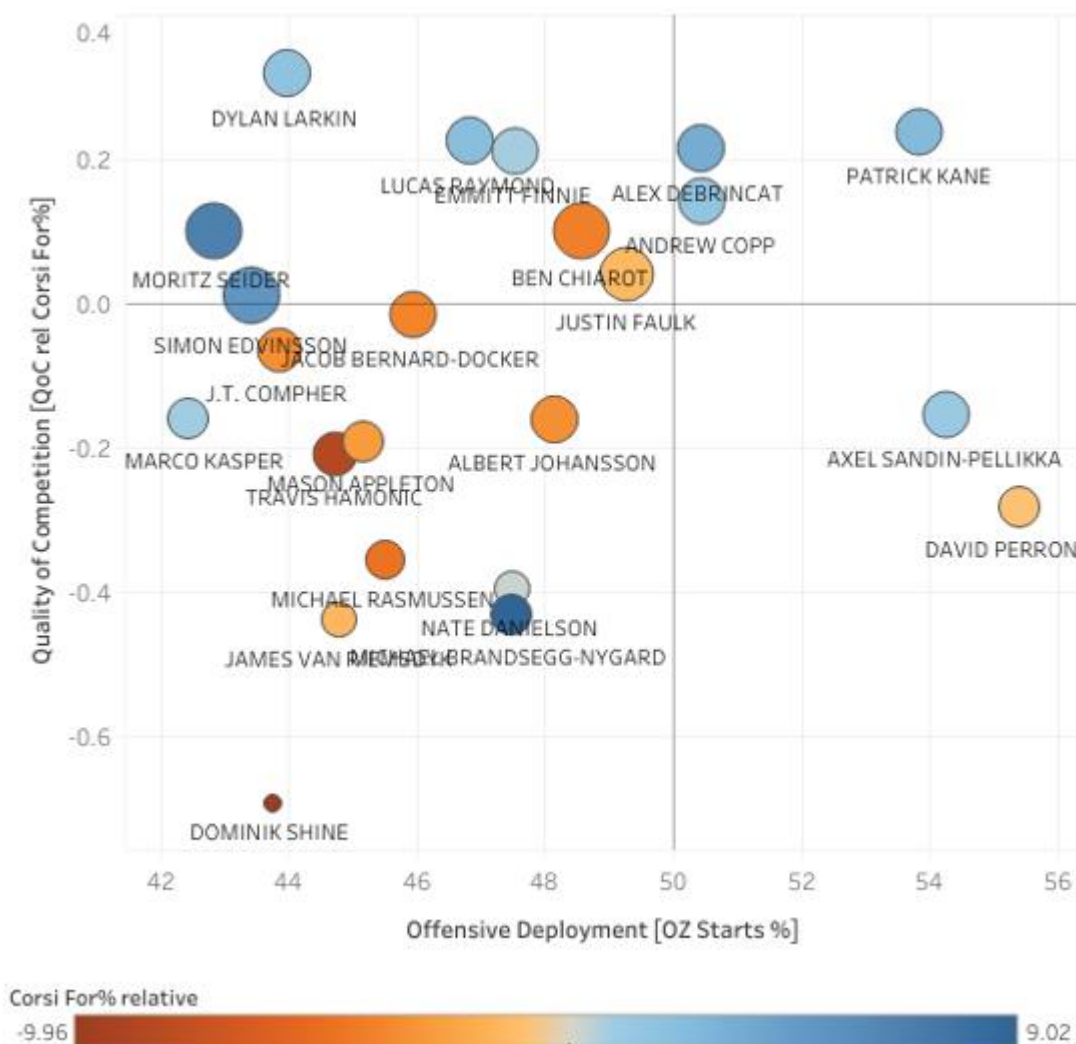
The Red Wings still need to sign Edvinsson... If the Wings are forced to accept futures for Larkin, DeBrincat could be the next one to go. DeBrincat will be 29 years of age, and he may not fit into the Wings' plan if they go the rebuild route... The Wings will also have some decisions to make in net with both goalies on expiring contracts. Gibson will be 34 next offseason, so a rebuild might not be for him either. However, the Wings may need a veteran goalie to bridge the gap if Augustine or Postava are not NHL-ready... Kasper is an important part of the Wings' future and is still in his early 20s, so expect his signing to be prioritized.

2027 RFA: Kasper, Johansson

2027 UFA: DeBrincat, Copp, Appleton, Faulk, Bryson, Gibson, Tarasov 2026

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Marco Kasper		
Boom or bust	Justin Faulk		
Multicategory / Banger	Moritz Seider		
Salary cap bargain	Emmitt Finnie		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Albert Johansson	90	65	59
Alex DeBrincat	38	33	283
Andrew Copp	48	29	103
Arttu Hyry	5	22	19
Ben Chiarot	144	157	98
Dylan Larkin	35	46	239
Emmitt Finnie	42	149	141
J.T. Compher	60	32	104
Justin Faulk	120	73	143
Keegan Kolesar	47	268	75
Kyle Capobianco	29	14	22
Lucas Raymond	31	41	176
Marco Kasper	57	178	146
Mason Appleton	30	93	82
Michael Rasmussen	69	93	81
Moritz Seider	180	151	202
Nate Danielson	25	23	86
Simon Edvinsson	158	93	98
Tyler Seguin	15	37	100
Viktor Arvidsson	35	31	166

Dobber Advanced... RED WINGS



* Most of the zone starts were in the defensive zone, which means Detroit struggled to generate positive, offense-driving possession. This handcuffed most of the secondary players, though a few still managed to earn offensive deployment thanks to the work of the rest.

Observation: Larkin and Raymond operate in the top-left quadrant against the toughest quality of competition, while Seider is tasked with heavy defensive-zone minutes.

Fantasy Impact: These are your "real hockey" engines. They are the players tasked with driving the bus against the league's best. Larkin and Raymond face the primary offensive catalysts, while Seider's usage as a defensive anchor—despite the lack of offensive-zone starts—underscores his value as a high-floor defenseman in leagues that reward defensive-zone stability and tough matchups.

Observation: DeBrincat and Kane (CHI) received favorable, offense-heavy deployment and successfully tilted the ice, with possession metrics firmly in the blue.

Fantasy Impact: These are primary "system beneficiaries" who thrive when matchups are managed correctly. They convert their opportunity into tangible, high-end production. They are your ceiling-based fantasy targets; just keep in mind that Kane's even-strength production in Chicago will be tied to this specific usage.

Observation: Kasper leads the team in defensive-zone start percentage, effectively acting as the shutdown pivot.

Fantasy Impact: Kasper is a "real hockey" specialist currently capped by his defensive usage. Without meaningful power-play time, he is not a fantasy target for points until his deployment shifts.

Observation: Copp is receiving a lopsided amount of offensive-zone starts and is driving possession against tough QoC.

Fantasy Impact: Normally a checking-line player, centering DeBrincat and Kane has its benefits—that's the only reason

he is getting these zone starts. His 43 points tied his second-highest career total, and that's why. As soon as Danielson or Kasper are ready for second-line usage, Copp will return to the third line and his usual 35-point range.

Observation: Brandsegg-Nygard (MBN) shows the darkest blue bubble on the chart, indicating elite possession efficiency despite sheltered usage.

Fantasy Impact: This is the most important "must-add" signal on the chart. MBN is performing at a high level relative to his deployment, the classic indicator that a player has earned more ice time and tougher minutes. He is a primary candidate to make the team this season; monitor him closely, especially if he earns a top-six promotion.

Observation: Finnie is receiving productive, middle-tier deployment and demonstrating solid possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: Finnie's surprising season was not a mirage. He is showing he can handle a standard load without being a possession liability—a rare trait for a younger player. He is an emerging depth-to-middle-six asset proving he belongs on the NHL roster. In deep leagues, he is a speculative add based on his ability to drive play more efficiently than peers in similar minutes.

Observation: Shine operates with heavy defensive-zone usage and is shielded from top-tier competition, functioning as a depth checker.

Fantasy Impact: Shine is a "do not draft" asset. His deployment is defensive, and he lacks the efficiency metrics to overcome that usage. He is a role player for the NHL club, not a fantasy contributor.

Observation: Sandin-Pellikka is being fed OZ starts against moderate competition and is maintaining neutral possession.

Fantasy Impact: He is a prime "force-fed" offensive prospect on the blue line, and he is handling it well at even strength. His usage is a direct signal of his future role. Once he finds his groove on the power play, he could become a force. He is a strong target in keeper/dynasty formats, as he is clearly being developed for the PP quarterback role.

Red Wings by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
ALEX DEBRINCAT	L	82	50.4	1008	0.911	9.7	51.6	67	69.1	79.5	51.1	3.4	20	45.5
LUCAS RAYMOND	R	80	46.8	998	0.896	10.2	51.4	65.6	69.1	70	67.5	3	17	33.3
PATRICK KANE	R	67	53.8	994	0.905	8.9	50.4	63	66.3	71.7	57.6	2.9	18	43.9
DYLAN LARKIN	C	74	43.9	986	0.906	8	51.4	66.2	65	71.7	58.5	2.7	17	51.5
JAMES VAN RIEMSDYK	L	72	44.8	998	0.921	7.7	46.8	37.8	66	87	45.8	2.2	8	50
ANDREW COPP	C	79	50.4	994	0.908	8.6	50.4	27.2	61.4	62.5	57.1	2	16	47.1
MORITZ SEIDER	D	82	42.8	997	0.905	9.2	53.2	64.4	42.9	33.3	65.1	1.7	24	48
JUSTIN FAULK	D	17	49.2	994	0.902	9.2	47.3	25.4	50	47.6	64.3	1.4	2	66.7
NATE DANIELSON	C	28	47.4	956	0.904	5.2	47.7	30.7	50	66.7	37.5	1.4	2	40
EMMITT FINNIE	L	82	47.5	986	0.9	8.6	50.5	28.1	53.6	51.2	61.5	1.4	8	47.1
J.T. COMPHER	C	82	43.8	977	0.887	9	46.9	13.4	57.1	57.4	50	1.3	5	29.4
A SANDIN-PELLIKKA	D	68	54.2	962	0.884	7.8	50.3	34.6	47.7	43.8	58.3	1.1	7	50
MICHAEL RASMUSSEN	C	64	45.5	979	0.918	6.1	44.5	4.7	68.4	72.2	0	1	2	28.6
MASON APPLETON	R	65	45.1	988	0.918	7	46.9	1.4	56	54.2	0	1	3	37.5
MARCO KASPER	C	81	42.4	963	0.904	5.9	49.8	15.5	55.9	53.3	66.7	1	2	20
SIMON EDVINSSON	D	72	43.4	990	0.901	8.9	51.5	4.8	32.5	31.9	50	0.9	7	43.8

- Kane, now 37, is showing he still has gas in the tank. At least offensively. His 2.9 Pts/60 ranked top-three on the team, and his ES IPP reflected a line driver—not a passenger. He’s in Chicago now.

- Notables with a low 5-on-5 S%: Kasper, Rasmussen, Sandin-Pellikka, Danielson (in just 28 games), and even Larkin’s 8.0% is too low. Better puck luck is coming for those five, but the team as a whole struggled to convert at even strength compared to the rest of the league. Only Raymond posted a reasonable, “normal” 5-on-5 S%.

- The Wings had a set first PP unit: DeBrincat, Raymond, Kane, Larkin, and Seider. The next group consisted of JVR, Finnie, ASP, Copp, and Danielson. Faulk—still signed for another season—is a threat to ASP’s power-play time, which could push his fantasy-relevant breakout back a year. It’s not a major threat, but it exists. Faulk was effective with the man advantage and is a proven 40-point defenseman. If MBN makes the team, he could bump Danielson or Copp from the second unit.

- Raymond slipped slightly to 76 points, but he wasn’t inflating his totals with secondary assists. He had 17 (33.3%), down from 25 (47.2%) in 2024–25.

- ASP finished at minus-20, which was rough. But his possession metrics were fine, and his PDO was extremely low—not just the 5-on-5 S% component, but also a 5-on-5 SV% of just 0.884, the lowest on the team. It was bad puck luck across the board.

Key departures	Patrick Kane (CHI), David Perron (UFA), James Van Riemsdyk (UFA), Sebastian Cossa (UTA), Cam Talbot (UFA)
Arrivals	Viktor Arvidsson (BOS), Keegan Kolesar (VGK), Jacob Bryson (WPG), Daniil Tarasov (FLA)

Edmonton OILERS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Matt Savoie	70	18	45	22	Connor McDavid	77	36	131	38	Zach Hyman	72	36	59	37
R Nugent-Hopkins	78	19	56	27	Leon Draisaitl	74	44	106	47	V Podkolzin	84	21	42	55
Mattias Janmark	62	3	10	29	Jason Dickinson	70	11	21	35	Kasper Kapanen	62	8	20	15
Isaac Howard	65	10	18	12	Trent Frederic	73	9	21	59	Colton Dach	65	5	17	52
Connor Clattenburg	7	1	2	11	Josh Samanski	67	7	14	40	Mathieu Joseph	63	4	14	30
Max Jones	35	3	8	21						Quinn Hutson	5	1	1	2
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Mattias Ekholm	77	8	33	37	Evan Bouchard	84	18	89	32	Frederik Andersen	30	16	0	3.00
Jake Walman	62	10	23	33	Connor Murphy	69	3	16	58	Devon Levi	32	22	2	2.80
Ryan Shea	70	5	24	20	Ty Emberson	70	2	12	18	Tristan Jarry	24	11	0	3.60
Shakir Mukhamadullin	70	6	18	29	Spencer Stastney	70	4	10	18					
Atro Leppanen	19	0	5	10	Alec Regula	6	0	1	2					

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: Savoie played the final quarter of the regular season and much of the playoffs on a line with McDavid. If this continues through camp, you can conclude that he'll start the season on that unit. In which case, obviously, you can consider him a very strong sleeper pick that you could perhaps reach for in a round higher than what you have on your list. His BT is still another year and a half away, so temper expectations.

On the hot seat: Levi's place as the starting goalie is not assured. He has a good team in front of him and he should pick up a lot of W's regardless of how he plays (see Jarry, Tristan), but there is pressure. Hopefully, veteran Andersen's presence relieves enough of that to ease Levi in. A successful season for Levi would be 20–25 wins, a save percentage of 0.900 or better. That would be a foundation to build on for 2027–28 as an outright starter. As for Jarry, his NHL career is riding on bouncing back—but that's unlikely given the other two goalies on the team now.

- After the Olympic break, Savoie had nine goals and 19 points in 24 games. That included 59 SOG (2.5/game) and a plus-8 rating. That's obviously playing with McDavid, but it shows what he can do even now, when it's very early in his career. **UPDATE 2: New details in late August indicate that Savoie will miss the first four weeks of the season, give or take. That means about 13 games.**

- Bouchard, Bouch-Bomb, tallied 57 points in the second half after 38 in the first half. That's quite the jump, and it was mostly at even strength. He had the same partner throughout (Ekholm).

- Draisaitl's injury in mid-March opened the door for Savoie to see some time on the top PP unit. He picked up two PPPTs in those 14 games, but his scoring three GWG was impressive. Podkolzin, Draisaitl's frequent linemate, had seven points in those 14 games. His production wasn't affected because he was moved to the McDavid line.

- When Nugent-Hopkins was injured in November, his most frequent linemate Hyman slowed to just two points in six games.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Connor McDavid	160	135	Josh Samanski		60%	
Leon Draisaitl	145	112	Isaac Howard		55%	
Evan Bouchard	95	85	Connor Clattenburg		20%	
Ryan N-Hopkins	85	62	Quinn Hutson		20%	
Zach Hyman	72	58	Atro Leppanen		10%	
Matt Savoie	80	58				
Tommy Lafreniere	72	45				
Malcom Gastrin	70	45				
Vasily Podkolzin	67	43				
Isaac Howard	70	40				
Colton Dach	65	38				
Josh Samanski	58	38	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Jake Walman	50	37	Matt Savoie	65	20%	
Mattias Ekholm	45	37	Vasily Podkolzin	55	15%	
Atro Leppanen	50	36	Isaac Howard	40	10%	
Viljami Marjala	68	35	Josh Samanski	35	10%	
David Lewandowski	67	35	Atro Leppanen	35	10%	
Kasper Kapanen	50	30				
S Mukhamadullin	42	30				

- When Walman missed time to end 2025, his regular defense partner Darnell Nurse (now with San Jose) had seven points in 23 games—i.e., no impact. Walman's PP time went to Nurse (zero PPPTs) and Bouchard saw more of an uptick. For what it's worth, during those 23 games Bouchard had a whopping 29 points.

Injuries:

Janmark (undisclosed – possibly shoulder) underwent season-ending surgery in March...**Savoie, Janmark, Regula and Andersen are going to miss training camp, per an Oiler's announcement in late August. Savoie and Andersen (both late October) are rehabbing injuries sustained in offseason workouts. Regula and Janmark are still recovering from last season's surgeries. *Dobber's Band-Aid Boys: Walman, Dickinson, Kapanen, Draisaitl, Janmark, Murphy, Joseph.***

Breakout Threshold:

Nobody on the Oilers is entering their BT season. Well, Bouchard is. At 6-3, he fits our 400-game mold. But it's safe to say he's already broken out. If he breaks out again, we're talking a Paul Coffey-esque 120 points!

Goalies:

Even if the Oilers win a whole bunch of games, it is not recommended that you draft one of their goalies early. Fresh off a Stanley Cup run with Carolina, Andersen is likely the opening-night starter, but health is a major concern and the likely reason they will need to carry three goalies. Jarry has by far the highest cap hit, but his struggles in Pittsburgh have now shifted to Edmonton. He may also have trouble staying healthy all season. Enter Levi, acquired from Buffalo in the offseason. Now 24, Levi has seen his AHL numbers regress a bit, but he could receive a golden opportunity to take the starter's job and run with it. Whether any Oilers goalie has success could depend on whether the Oilers' defense has improved this offseason and whether Mike Babcock makes a difference as the new coach. ***Dobber's confidence that Levi is the starter: 55%***

Contract Year:

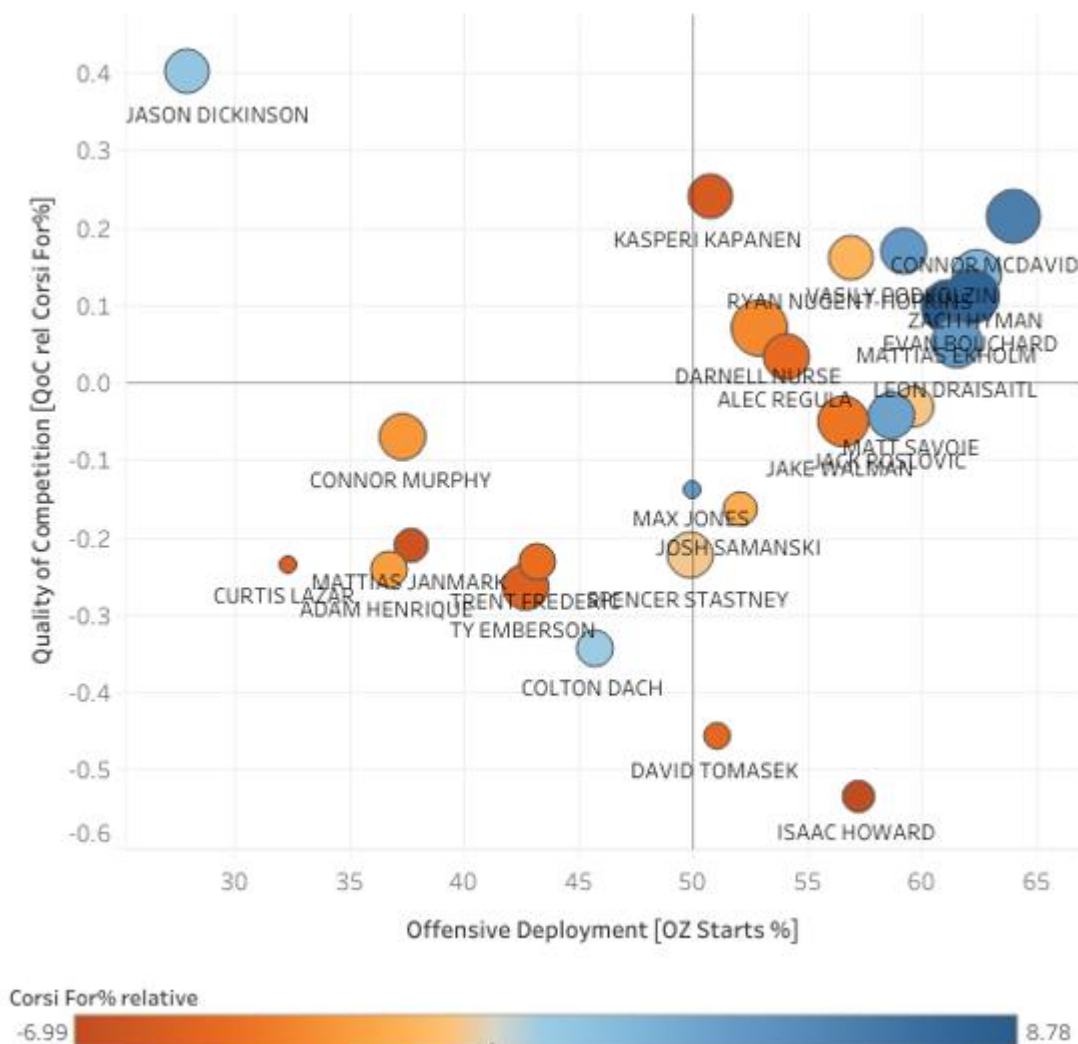
At this time last year, the Oilers had to worry about the McDavid extension. Nothing that earth-shattering this year... Savoie will attempt to build on his first full NHL season with an RFA year ahead... With a big season, Levi could set himself up well to be the Oilers' starting goalie for the future heading into an arbitration-eligible RFA season... Speaking of goaltending, Andersen was able to secure a one-year contract thanks to a strong Stanley Cup performance. He will hope to stay injury-free to extend his career even further.

2027 RFA: Savoie, Levi

2027 UFA: Kapanen, Janmark, Joseph, Stastney, Emberson, Andersen

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Matt Savoie		
Boom or bust	Frederik Andersen		
Multicategory / Banger	Vasily Podkolzin		
Salary cap bargain	Connor McDavid		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Colton Dach	33	228	65
Connor McDavid	27	42	277
Connor Murphy	114	86	76
Evan Bouchard	99	31	234
Isaac Howard	13	20	85
Jason Dickinson	62	88	84
Josh Samanski	40	84	40
Leon Draisaitl	22	37	223
Mathieu Joseph	41	135	69
Matt Savoie	42	17	158
Mattias Ekholm	108	58	131
Mattias Janmark	20	20	40
Ryan Nugent-Hopkins	35	23	148
Ryan Shea	86	35	77
Shakir Mukhamadullin	91	56	84
Spencer Stastney	75	15	56
Trent Frederic	29	188	88
Ty Emberson	98	109	49
Vasily Podkolzin	54	231	151
Zach Hyman	23	69	203

Dobber Advanced... OILERS



Observation: McDavid, Hyman, and Draisaitl anchor the right side of the chart, receiving significant offensive-zone starts and carrying the team's primary offensive load—as always.

Fantasy Impact: These are the core engines of the Oilers' attack. They consistently convert their opportunities into elite, sustainable production.

Observation: Podkolzin sits in the high-offensive-zone quadrant with strong possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: Podkolzin's impressive blue bubble is a direct result of riding shotgun with Draisaitl. He is the quintessential *beneficiary* asset; as long as he remains tethered to a superstar, his efficiency and scoring will stay elevated. He has shown he can thrive in that spot.

Observation: Kapanen, Janmark, and Henrique are deployed in the middle ground with moderate offensive-zone starts. Kapanen faced very high quality of competition.

Fantasy Impact: Kapanen is a fascinating case—while the coaching staff uses him as a checker, his underlying metrics suggest he's miscast. Keep in mind he essentially played only the second half last season. For the purposes of this chart, lining up with Draisaitl upon returning, and then Dickinson after the acquisition, meant he faced tougher lines. Janmark and Henrique are depth players with fading value even in "real" hockey.

Observation: Dickinson is a severe outlier in the top-left quadrant, shouldering the toughest competition on the team.

Fantasy Impact: Dickinson is a "real hockey" specialist who provides little value in points-only leagues. His bubble's extremity is amplified by his previous heavy usage in Chicago, where he faced elite competition in defensive-zone starts. In Edmonton, he remained the primary defensive-zone pivot, effectively capping his offensive upside. Do not draft him expecting points.

Observation: Bouchard dominates the high-offensive-zone quadrant, maintaining elite possession efficiency. He even led the team in relative CF%, surpassing McDavid.

Fantasy Impact: Bouchard is the rare defenseman who delivers forward-level offensive output. His deployment reflects his role as the primary power-play quarterback. He is an elite, must-own cornerstone whose production is highly sustainable because he drives both the power play and the team's even-strength transition.

Observation: Walman and Nurse (SJS) operated in middle-ground deployment, managing difficult competition while trying to maintain steady possession.

Fantasy Impact: Most competition against the Oilers' top guns was of lesser quality, and because this chart measures against quality of competition, it shifts players lower. Walman and Nurse appear low compared with other charts, but they actually faced the toughest matchups—though in offensive-zone situations they were secondary options behind Ekholm and Bouchard. They were the “real hockey” anchors enabling the team's offensive weapons to flourish. Their fantasy value is limited as a result.

Observation: Savoie was deployed similarly to the top-six veterans. He performed reasonably well, unlike fellow top offensive prospect Howard.

Fantasy Impact: Savoie has clearly won the race for “next man up.” Despite being a rookie, he faced tougher lines and held his own. He should only improve from here. Howard, meanwhile, performed poorly despite being as sheltered as it gets. Howard managers should be very concerned.

Oilers by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
CONNOR MCDAVID	C	82	64	991	0.889	10.2	53.9	86.4	80.7	79.8	84.4	4.4	33	36.7
LEON DRAISAITL	C	65	61.5	998	0.885	11.3	53.2	85.4	71.9	69.6	77.8	4.2	22	35.5
EVAN BOUCHARD	D	82	62.2	996	0.888	10.8	55.1	87	54.3	54.5	53.2	2.8	41	55.4
ZACH HYMAN	R	58	62.4	1001	0.894	10.7	52.1	85.3	45.2	53.6	32.6	2.7	8	38.1
R NUGENT-HOPKINS	L	72	56.9	975	0.891	8.4	49.3	82.6	49.6	48.1	50	2.4	15	41.7
JACK ROSLOVIC	R	69	58.6	969	0.881	8.8	52.3	28.5	60	63.8	46.2	2	7	46.7
VASILY PODKOLZIN	L	82	59.2	1001	0.9	10.1	53.4	11.1	54.4	54	60	1.8	8	44.4
MATT SAVOIE	L	82	59.6	994	0.895	9.9	49.4	19.9	56.9	57.7	70	1.8	10	52.6
KASPERI KAPANEN	R	41	50.7	1009	0.914	9.5	47.1	6	70.8	70.8	0	1.7	1	11.1
MAX JONES	L	21	50	1021	0.909	11.2	53.2	0.4	62.5	62.5	0	1.7	0	0
MATTIAS EKHOLM	D	82	61.1	994	0.886	10.8	55.6	12	37.3	36.9	75	1.5	21	60
JAKE WALMAN	D	53	56.5	956	0.868	8.8	48.1	17.1	42.6	46.2	33.3	1.2	5	41.7
ADAM HENRIQUE	C	65	36.7	942	0.882	6	48	14.9	62.5	55.6	75	1	2	16.7
ISAAC HOWARD	L	29	57.2	943	0.875	6.8	43.2	11.9	55.6	55.6	0	1	1	33.3
CURTIS LAZAR	R	45	32.3	990	0.911	7.9	45.8	0.2	54.5	54.5	0	0.9	0	0
MATTIAS JANMARK	L	43	37.7	946	0.898	4.8	45.7	0.3	80	77.8	0	0.9	4	57.1

- Ekholm posted the highest 5-on-5 shooting percentage of his career. Given that he's now 36, it's reasonable to expect his production to decline slightly, even while locked in as Bouchard's partner.
- The top five names on the chart were indeed the members of the first power-play unit. They were used extremely heavily, with each receiving more than 82.5% of available power-play time. That's massive, and it leaves very little for the secondary group led by Savoie. Jack Roslovic's PPTOI (now with TOR) vanished when Hyman returned. Walman managers are cringing.
- Despite limited power-play usage, Savoie still made the most of it, factoring in on seven of the 10 power-play goals scored while he was on the ice. On the flip side, Hyman was the lowest contributor on the top unit, with just a 32.6 PP IPP. Hyman isn't slowing down yet at age 34, but as Savoie develops, he will begin to push.
- Edmonton's goaltending woes are well known, so you'll likely get a chuckle scrolling down the 5-on-5 save-percentage column and seeing all those 0.8xx numbers.
- Howard's CF% is absolutely terrible. You could see it coming after reviewing his usage chart. He needs a complete one-eighty to get back on track this season.

Key departures	Kris Knoblauch (Coach), Jack Roslovic (TOR), Adam Henrique (UFA), Curtis Lazar (UFA), Darnell Nurse (SJS), Connor Ingram (UFA)
Arrivals	Mike Babcock (Coach), Mathieu Joseph (STL), Ryan Shea (PIT), Shakir Mukhamadullin (SJS), Devon Levi (BUF), Frederik Andersen (CAR)

Florida PANTHERS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Brady Tkachuk	73	31	73	124	Sam Bennett	76	25	56	93	Matthew Tkachuk	72	28	81	84
Carter Verhaeghe	80	26	59	39	Aleksander Barkov	75	23	78	18	Sam Reinhart	77	41	78	22
Eetu Luostarinen	80	11	33	29	Anton Lundell	76	19	52	40	Brad Marchand	70	27	58	61
Jonah Gadjovich	42	2	9	79	Lars Eller	79	9	16	27	Garnet Hathaway	71	5	9	82
Sandis Vilmanis	21	2	5	2	Sam Lafferty	42	3	4	19	Cole Schwindt	54	7	13	4
Cole Reinhardt	37	4	7	12	John Beecher	38	4	7	19	Jack Devine	8	0	2	0
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Gustav Forsling	82	7	28	38	Seth Jones	63	8	35	25	Jacob Markstrom	50	31	3	2.95
Dmitry Kulikov	65	1	16	44	Aaron Ekblad	67	4	28	59	Akira Schmid	34	15	1	2.85
Niko Mikkola	77	4	14	64	Radko Gudas	70	3	12	96					
Uvis Balinskis	64	4	15	27	Donovan Sebranko	50	1	9	52					
Tobias Bjornfot	18	1	3	4	Alexander Petrovic	20	1	3	17					

Restricted Free Agents: Schmid

What to look for in camp: With Barkov back, there's really no question that Bennett is off the first PP unit. But the addition of Brady Tkachuk probably knocks Marchand to the second unit. What we have are two very strong units, and it will be interesting to see if they spread the wealth and roll both units equally, or load up PP1 and give them most of the PPTOI.

On the hot seat: Lundell had a golden opportunity last season and, while he showed flashes, he never seized it. Getting injured didn't help. But with Barkov out for the season, the world was Lundell's oyster. Top center on a Stanley Cup team? With those wingers? His points-per-game average was a career-best 0.69, but that was far below expectation. Staying healthy and topping 50 points for the first time in his career would keep him relevant in fantasy. He's still only 24.

- Forsling's points-per-game average, year over year, since 2021-22: 0.52, 0.50, 0.49, 0.39, 0.35.

- Lundell actually started pretty well, posting 27 points in his first 33 contests. He struggled in January and then injuries impacted the rest of his season.

- When Ekblad was out for the final eight games of the campaign, Jones of course led the D in PP ice time (as always). But Jones missed four games during that span as well, and the PP time went to Mike Benning (now with Calgary). The point is—Paul Maurice seems very reluctant to give Forsling power-play time.

- Marchand, now 38, started off last season with 46 points in 39 games. He's hanging in there as well as Sidney Crosby! Injuries slowed him at that point and eventually ended his season, though he still topped a point-per-game average (54 in 52).

- Verhaeghe managed just eight points in the first 18 games of the season and a lot of fantasy owners were worried. Typically, in that 15-20-game range, there are four or five players around the league who have owners panicking enough to email, post or ask us if they should be worried. Last season, Verhaeghe was one of those players. But it was nothing to worry about. Yes, no Barkov hurt at first, but he figured it out, posting 47 in his next 59.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Matthew Tkachuk	110	85	Cole Schwindt	55%		
Sam Reinhart	100	87	John Beecher	40%		
Brady Tkachuk	97	82	Sandis Vilmanis	40%		
Aleksander Barkov	100	80	Jack Devine	5%		
Anton Lundell	82	62				
Carter Verhaeghe	72	60				
Brad Marchand	80	60				
Sam Bennett	70	53				
Seth Jones	60	45				
Aaron Ekblad	52	45				
John Beecher	58	40				
Eetu Luostarinen	55	38	Sleeper	Pts	%	
V Lukashevich	45	38	Seth Jones	60	15%	
Shea Busch	70	38	John Beecher	35	10%	
Simas Ignatavicius	65	37				
Gustav Forsling	45	35				
Gracyn Sawchyn	70	34				
Jack Devine	70	32				
Ludvig Jansson	38	30				

- Also missing Barkov was Reinhart, who started with just eight points in 15 games. He, too, figured it out with his new linemates, posting 53 in 49. Regardless, Barkov is back and healthy—Reinhart and Verhaeghe will be, too.

Injuries:

After missing the entire regular season with a torn ACL/MCL, Barkov played at the World Hockey Championship. He will be ready for 2026-27... The Panthers shut down numerous players late last season, including Marchand (lower body), Verhaeghe (lower body), Reinhart (foot), Lundell (ribs), Bennett (lower body), and Forsling (undisclosed). None of these injuries appear to be serious, so all of these players should be ready for training camp... Mikkola (knee) was expected to miss 4–6 weeks in late March... Jones broke his foot near the end of the season... Ekblad said in late June that his finger injury has healed... Gudas (ankle) missed nearly all of two rounds of the playoffs with the Ducks. **UPDATE: Marchand had to undergo surgery and will likely miss the start of the season. Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Barkov, Gudas, Jones, B. Tkachuk, M. Tkachuk, Ekblad, Hathaway, Marchand.

Breakout Threshold

Given the team's depth, it's doubtful that he'll make the team let alone land a good role, but Beecher has played 165 career games. The 6-3 forward would hit his BT at 400. As with many big players, Beecher has taken a long time to acclimate himself to pro hockey, so while he may have carved himself an NHL job – you may be looking at another three full seasons before he reaches decent numbers. His metrics last year over 35 games looked pretty good. He's still only 25.

Goalies:

After missing the playoffs, the Panthers took the opportunity to completely turn over their goaltenders, replacing Sergei Bobrovsky and Daniil Tarasov with Markstrom and Schmid. Markstrom had a rough 2025-26 with a 3.07 GAA and 0.883 SV%, but the hope is that a reloaded Panthers squad will insulate his numbers and that he doesn't have to steal games for the Panthers to win. At the very least, Markstrom should be an "empty calorie" option for wins without strong ratios. Schmid also fits the Panthers' plan, as he was the caretaker starter in Vegas for a stretch in 2025-26. If Markstrom's struggles continue in Florida, Schmid seems capable of forcing a timeshare. The Panthers' other goalie options are still a long way from the NHL. **Dobber's confidence that Markstrom is the starter: 95%**

Contract Year:

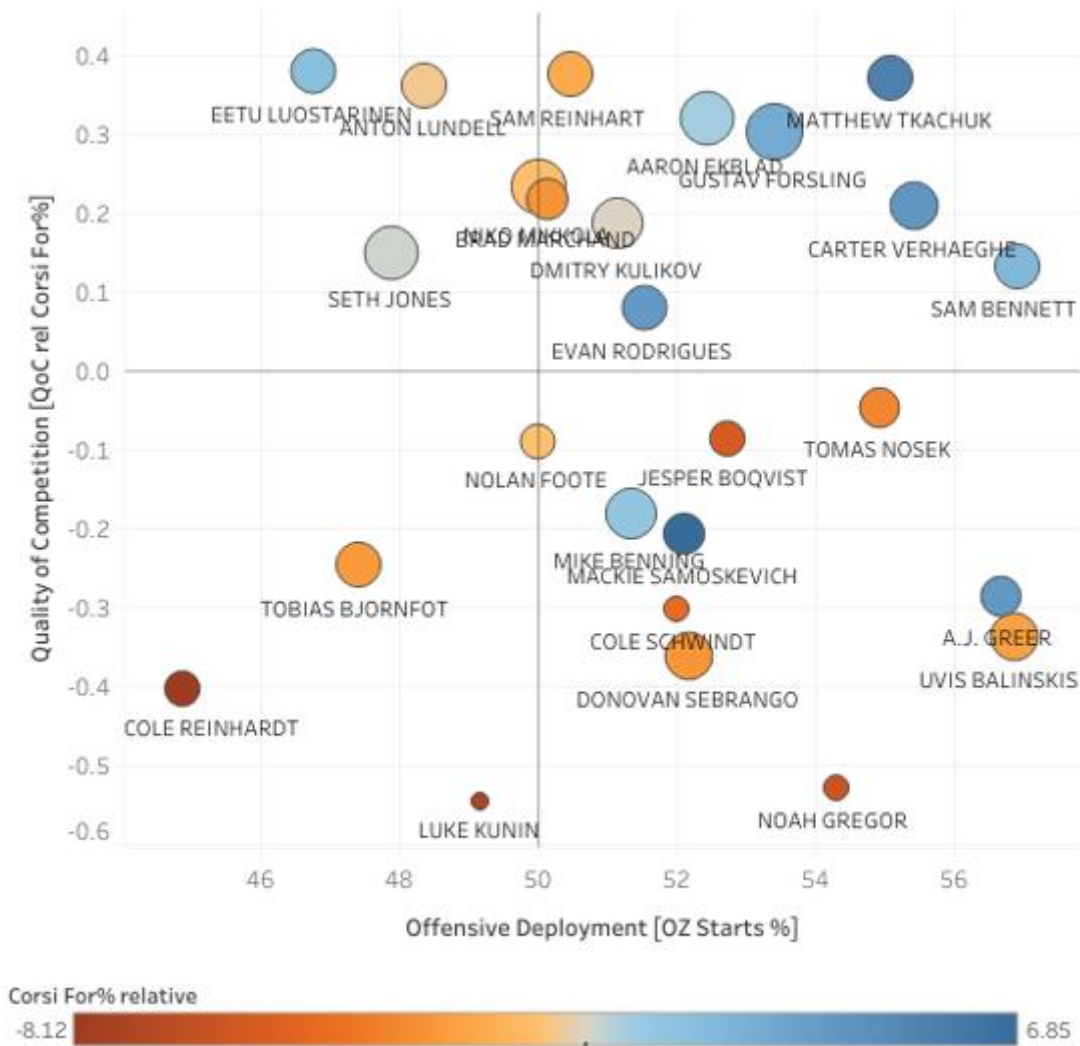
The Panthers have their entire core locked up for at least two more years, so the free agents are all pieces around the edges... Eller and Hathaway are offseason acquisitions, while Reinhardt was acquired last season, so all will try to establish a role in the Panthers' bottom six or at least make enough of an impression to attract other teams' interest.

2027 RFA: none

2027 UFA: Hathaway, Eller, Reinhardt

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Akira Schmid		
Boom or bust	Brad Marchand		
Multicategory / Banger	Brady Tkachuk		
Salary cap bargain	Brady Tkachuk		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Aaron Ekblad	87	87	94
Aleksander Barkov	53	90	165
Anton Lundell	45	97	159
Brad Marchand	25	54	180
Brady Tkachuk	29	217	263
Carter Verhaeghe	20	64	200
Cole Schwindt	22	76	43
Dmitry Kulikov	68	98	59
Donovan Sebrango	42	101	45
Eetu Luostarinen	60	148	112
Garnet Hathaway	57	256	43
Gustav Forsling	102	65	131
Lars Eller	35	55	79
Matthew Tkachuk	17	90	209
Niko Mikkola	93	135	93
Radko Gudas	111	209	77
Sam Bennett	38	129	204
Sam Reinhart	54	73	208
Seth Jones	78	62	113
Uvis Balinskis	54	77	83

Dobber Advanced... PANTHERS



Observation: Tkachuk, Reinhart, Ekblad, Verhaeghe, and Forsling anchored the top-right quadrant, shouldering heavy minutes against elite competition.

Fantasy Impact: These were the primary engines of the team. Tkachuk and Reinhart remain “must-own” offensive cornerstones, consistently converting their opportunities into elite production. Ekblad and Forsling are the elite blue-line anchors; their possession dominance makes them exceptionally safe, high-end assets.

Observation: Samoskevich, now with Seattle, showed the darkest blue bubble on the chart.

Fantasy Impact: This is the most critical “must-add” signal. With sheltered deployment, he was driving elite possession efficiency. He clearly earned more trust than his current ice time suggests, making him a breakout candidate to monitor closely. He should do well with more ice time with the Kraken.

Observation: Luostarinen operated as the team's top shutdown forward, handling the toughest defensive minutes.

Fantasy Impact: He is a “real hockey” specialist whose usage is strictly defensive. He provides little value in points-only leagues, as his deployment is designed to suppress offense rather than generate it. His role allows the top six to enjoy more offensive-zone starts.

Observation: Jones and Mikkola were tasked with tougher minutes, taking more faceoffs in the defensive zone.

Fantasy Impact: These two absorb the hard work that allows the offensive stars to thrive at even strength. This suppresses their fantasy output, but Jones's spot on the top power-play unit helps offset some of that limitation.

Observation: Benning, Bogvist, and Foote saw sheltered deployment in the neutral-to-offensive zone.

Fantasy Impact: These players were given “training wheels” by the coaching staff. Benning and Boqvist, in particular, are still in a developmental phase. They lack the trust required for significant offensive responsibility and are not yet viable fantasy targets.

Observation: Marchand was used for both defensive-zone and offensive-zone draws.

Fantasy Impact: Marchand is an effective two-way player who can produce offensively while defending well. He is trusted at both ends of the ice, though he doesn't receive as many prime offensive deployments as Tkachuk.

Observation: Lundell saw a lopsided number of defensive-zone starts, even though Barkov was injured all season and the expectation was that he would fill that role.

Fantasy Impact: That didn't happen, underscoring that Lundell is still viewed as a defense-first forward despite his upside. He can begin changing the coach's mind by producing regardless of deployment, but that hasn't happened yet—at least not to a mind-changing extent.



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Panthers by the Metrics...

	<i>Pos</i>	<i>GP</i>	<i>ZS%</i>	<i>PDO</i>	<i>5on5 SV%</i>	<i>5on5 S%</i>	<i>CF%</i>	<i>%PP</i>	<i>IPP</i>	<i>ES IPP</i>	<i>PP IPP</i>	<i>PTS/60</i>	<i>Sec Asst</i>	<i>Sec Asst %</i>
MATTHEW TKACHUK	R	31	55	982	0.889	9.3	55.8	77.4	82.9	87.5	76.5	3.6	9	42.9
BRAD MARCHAND	R	52	50.1	991	0.885	10.6	49.6	61.5	73	77.3	66.7	3.5	13	48.1
SAM REINHART	R	64	50.4	977	0.899	7.8	51.2	71.1	71.8	83.3	65.8	2.7	12	37.5
SAM BENNETT	C	76	56.8	1006	0.895	11.1	52.9	59.2	60.4	66.7	46.7	2.5	13	40.6
CARTER VERHAEGHE	L	77	55.4	992	0.896	9.6	54.6	48.4	62.5	69.8	44	2.4	14	46.7
ANTON LUNDELL	C	64	48.3	991	0.902	8.9	51.9	46.3	58.7	60	60	2.2	14	53.8
A.J. GREER	R	78	56.6	1014	0.895	11.9	54.6	2.2	61.5	60.8	100	2	5	33.3
M SAMOSKEVICH	L	77	52.1	988	0.911	7.7	56.6	38.6	60.4	59.5	62.5	1.7	6	30
SETH JONES	D	52	47.8	1008	0.911	9.7	51.6	63.6	45.7	37.2	66.7	1.6	14	56
EVAN RODRIGUES	C	69	51.5	950	0.875	7.5	54.3	34	59.6	68.4	38.5	1.6	9	45
EETU LUOSTARINEN	C	73	46.7	994	0.883	11.1	52.3	20.9	58.9	59.6	33.3	1.6	9	40.9
NOAH GREGOR	R	37	54.3	952	0.863	8.9	48	5	75	72.7	100	1.5	0	0
SANDIS VILMANIS	L	19	65.9	978	0.892	8.6	54.9	4.5	71.4	71.4	0	1.5	2	100
COLE SCHWINDT	C	29	52	1012	0.87	14.2	48.6	4.3	50	53.8	0	1.4	0	0
MIKE BENNING	D	18	51.3	1003	0.883	12	51.2	25.4	40	35.7	100	1.2	2	50
AARON EKBLAD	D	72	52.4	991	0.895	9.6	52.3	39.4	32.1	30.3	33.3	1	9	40.9

- Marchand's Pts/60 was a four-year high. Now 38, he's still producing, though this was his third straight season with a CF% slightly below 50%.
- Bennett was the only fantasy-relevant player to post a notably high 5-on-5 shooting percentage. He also led the team in offensive-zone starts, so his career-high 58 points were somewhat artificially boosted.
- Goaltending was a major part of the team's letdown, which is evident from a quick scan of the 5-on-5 save-percentage column.
- Jones, Tkachuk, Marchand, Reinhart, and Bennett made up the top power-play unit. Bennett had the weakest PP IPP and is the most at risk of losing his spot. Ekblad, on the second unit, wasn't doing enough to pressure Jones.
- Samoskevich had the highest PP IPP on the second unit. His BT should hit around midseason, but it will be the Kraken (and his fantasy owners) who would reap the benefits of a bump if they do indeed play him on their PP1.
- Reinhart, Rodrigues, and Samoskevich all had significantly low 5-on-5 shooting percentages and should see at least a small bump in even-strength production.

Key departures	Evan Rodrigues (NJD), Jesper Boqvist (NJD), Mackie Samoskevich (SEA), A.J. Greer (ANA), Noah Gregor (WPG), Sergei Bobrovsky (TOR), Daniil Tarasov (DET)
Arrivals	Brady Tkachuk (OTT), Garnet Hathaway (PHI), Lars Eller (OTT), John Beecher (CGY), Radko Gudas (ANA), Jacob Markstrom (NJD), Akira Schmid (VGK)

Los Angeles KINGS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Artemi Panarin	82	37	94	21	Quinton Byfield	82	25	63	46	Adrian Kempe	82	33	76	57
Kevin Fiala	75	27	59	46	Erik Haula	77	15	34	54	Mats Zuccarello	68	16	57	25
Trevor Moore	76	20	36	17	Scott Laughton	77	13	30	45	Alex Laferriere	82	21	45	26
Joel Armia	73	13	21	27	Alex Turcotte	69	8	26	22	Corey Perry	71	17	29	64
Martin Chromiak	23	2	4	6	Samuel Helenius	70	6	13	34	Taylor Ward	28	3	6	4
Andre Lee	6	1	2	2	Kenny Connors	15	2	2	4	Jared Wright	55	4	9	4
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Mikey Anderson	79	4	18	23	Drew Doughty	69	8	25	39	Darcy Kuemper	50	25	3	2.65
Brian Dumoulin	83	4	15	19	Brandt Clarke	83	8	48	56	Anton Forsberg	34	14	3	2.70
Joel Edmundson	74	3	16	25	Cody Ceci	84	3	12	18	Erik Portillo	3	2	0	2.50
Erik Gustafsson	60	4	20	25	Kirill Kirsanov	18	1	2	4					
Angus Booth	4	0	1	2										

Restricted Free Agents: none

Future Fantasy Stud: Fantasy owners are giving up on Byfield, but it's way too soon for that. Heading into his NHL Draft, we said right off the hop that he would need several years to hit his peak, and that fantasy value would be minimal early on. He's a 6-5 forward and needs time. Now that Anze Kopitar has retired, Byfield becomes the No.1 center. For the first time ever, he will see more than 50% of available playing time on an NHL team. That means everything. The difference between playing with the best players on your team on the PP versus the next best is huge. Expect a step forward, but it will just be scratching the surface of what should come in the coming years.

Future Fantasy Stud: After two full seasons in the NHL, Clarke has shown steady improvement. His ice time and PP time are steadily increasing, and the torch is slowly being passed to him from Doughty. Now entering his Breakout Threshold season, he needs to take that next step—and he should. When he gets rolling, he'll be a Top 10 scoring defenseman in the league.

- Moore had 16 points in his last 21 games after starting the campaign with 16 in 47. This was due to his being moved to play with Byfield and Laferriere after the Fiala injury. With Fiala back healthy, Moore gets pushed back down to the third line. However, with the addition of Zuccarello, Laferriere (likely) gets pushed down as well.

- Fiala getting injured was at the same time (or immediately after) the Kings acquired Panarin, so in Fiala's absence a lot of players surged in production (due to Panarin, not because Fiala was gone): Kempe 27 points in 25 games, Byfield 19 in 24, Laferriere 18 in 26.

- Laferriere started the season with 15 points in 36 games playing mostly with Fiala and Byfield and seeing PP2 time. Again, a big part of that was the trickle-down effect of having Panarin in the lineup. Laferriere had 29 in 46 to end the season.

- Kempe had 37 points in 34 games to end the season (Panarin). The likely line of Byfield, Kempe and Panarin has potential to surprise this year.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Artemi Panarin	102	83	Jared Wright		60%	
Adrian Kempe	83	73	Taylor Ward		40%	
Quinton Byfield	90	68	Kenny Connors		30%	
Kevin Fiala	77	67	Kirill Kirsanov		15%	
Elton Hermansson	80	53	Andre Lee		10%	
Mats Zuccarello	65	52	Angus Booth		10%	
Alex Laferriere	68	50				
Brandt Clarke	72	48				
Jimmy Lombardi	65	43				
Alex Turcotte	65	42				
Trevor Moore	55	37				
Drew Doughty	57	35	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Scott Laughton	55	35	Brandt Clarke	55	20%	
Samuel Helenius	57	33	Quinton Byfield	80	10%	
Henry Brzustewicz	50	32				
Vojtech Cihar	72	32				
Kenny Connors	65	32				
Joel Armia	48	27				
Kirill Kirsanov	50	25				

- Haula had just nine points in 24 games (i.e., after the Olympic break) after tallying 29 in 57 before that. This was mainly due to the power-play success of Nashville's second unit early on, as he had nine PPPs in the first half. He'll see PP2 duties again with the Kings.

- Doughty started the season with 10 points in 21 games. An injury in November put him in a walking boot and kept him out for a month. But even in those 21 games, 10 points isn't great—and only one came on the power play. His PP time shifted to Clarke, and Doughty finished with just 13 points in his last 51 games. You have to think that some of that is perhaps him rushing back from his injury and playing with soreness. But at 36, he's probably not going to bounce back too much.

Injuries:

Fiala suffered a season-ending lower-leg fracture during the Olympics. He was expected to be evaluated after the season, although he should have enough recovery time to be ready for camp. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Zuccarello, Armia, Doughty, Moore, Turcotte.

Breakout Threshold:

Right around the time when Laferriere started increasing his production last season, his BT of 200 games hit. This year, the focus will be on Clarke, who has played 185 career NHL games. Things are really lining up nicely for him.

Goalies:

Kuemper crashed down to earth following a 2024-25 season in which he was nominated for the Vezina Trophy. The Kings are banking on the 36-year-old goalie rebounding. If not, the Kings will turn to Forsberg again, with a timeshare another possibility. Kuemper's performance gradually worsened during the season to the point where he was no longer reliable down the stretch. That meant Forsberg was the starter for the Kings' short playoff series against the Avalanche. This is probably Kuemper's net again because of the higher cap hit, but both goalies are in the final year of their contracts. If Portillo is recalled due to injury, he may have a chance at more than the backup role. Portillo has been successful at the AHL level and could be part of the goaltending plan in 2027-28 if the Kings move on from both Kuemper and Forsberg. **Dobber's confidence that Kuemper is the starter: 70%**

Contract Year:

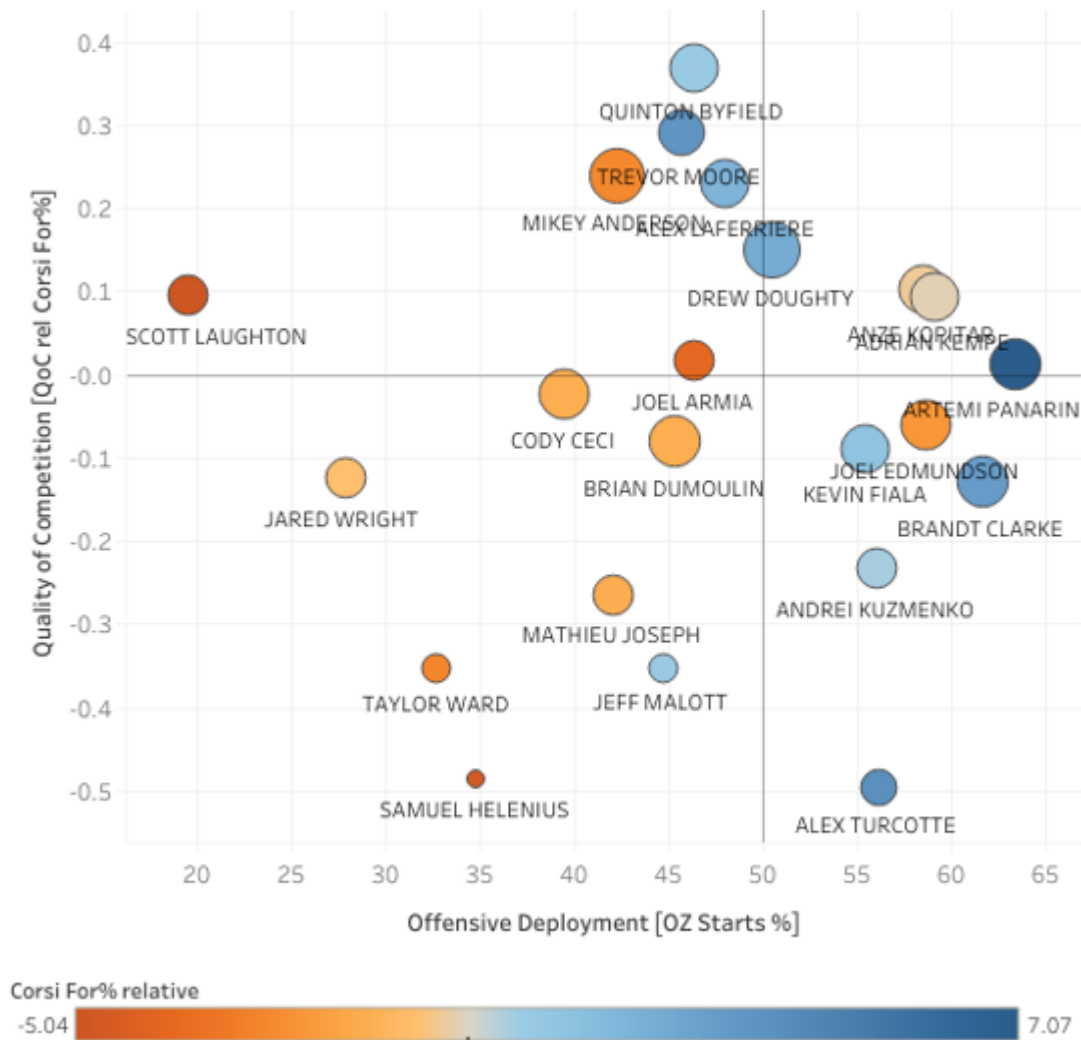
The Kings have their share of veterans, so there aren't a lot of upcoming RFA. Former first-round pick Turcotte is the most notable... The Kings have several UFA-eligible players who will be in the final year of their contracts. Franchise icon Doughty heads the list. His offense has really slipped, so it's not a given that he will be extended... Zuccarello is playing on a one-year deal and will try to keep his career going as he turns 39... Both Kuemper and Forsberg will also be in the final year of their contracts. The goalie who stands out could be re-signed.

2027 RFA: Wright, Turcotte

2027 UFA: Armia, Perry, Zuccarello, Doughty, Kuemper, Forsberg

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Brandt Clarke		
Boom or bust	Darcy Kuemper		
Multicategory / Banger	Brandt Clarke		
Salary cap bargain	Mats Zuccarello		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adrian Kempe	37	123	237
Alex Laferriere	53	267	213
Alex Turcotte	35	62	83
Artemi Panarin	16	16	230
Brandt Clarke	158	33	174
Brian Dumoulin	99	41	58
Corey Perry	21	28	107
Drew Doughty	83	41	90
Erik Gustafsson	49	40	66
Erik Haula	46	107	131
Joel Armia	40	81	95
Joel Edmundson	96	81	89
Kevin Fiala	26	49	195
Mats Zuccarello	27	14	135
Mikey Anderson	132	115	79
Quinton Byfield	49	72	197
Samuel Helenius	28	200	56
Scott Laughton	53	155	124
Taylor Ward	8	31	34
Trevor Moore	38	57	167

Dobber Advanced... KINGS



Observation: Byfield, Moore, Laferriere, and Anderson anchored the top-left quadrant, handling heavy defensive responsibility and high-quality competition.

Fantasy Impact: These were the “real hockey” engines of the Kings. Byfield, Laferriere, and Moore are proving they can handle top-line matchups without collapsing, while Anderson remains the steady defensive anchor. Points-only managers should note that their defensive deployment slightly limits their ceiling compared to the primary scorers. How the new coach deploys these players—particularly Byfield—will determine any potential production increase.

Observation: Kopitar, Kempe, Panarin, and Clarke occupy the top-right quadrant, benefiting from favorable offensive-zone starts and high-end deployment.

Fantasy Impact: This is expected. These were your “must-own” offensive cornerstones. Kopitar has retired, but Kempe and Panarin remain elite, efficient production engines, and Clarke’s usage as an offensive-leaning defenseman signals his fantasy ceiling. He is now the primary option to quarterback the power play and the most exciting asset on this blue line.

Observation: Fiala, Andrei Kuzmenko (now with Pittsburgh), and Turcotte received high offensive-zone starts (55%+) against moderate competition.

Fantasy Impact: This is the “gold” environment for offensive production. Fiala and Kuzmenko were the primary beneficiaries, positioned to inflate their scoring floor. Turcotte is the one to watch—his efficiency in these prime minutes suggests he is finally capitalizing on opportunities that eluded him in past seasons. He was the most sheltered player on the team and has shown he can handle tougher minutes.

Observation: Doughty operated in a neutral-to-offensive deployment, balancing difficult competition with high-end skill. He faced tougher competition at either end of the ice for faceoffs.

Fantasy Impact: Doughty remains the steady, reliable “system” defenseman. He isn’t as flashy as Clarke, but his usage

shows he is still a foundational piece who stabilizes the back end and contributes consistently in all three zones. He is a high-floor veteran anchor for any fantasy roster.

Observation: Armia, Ceci, and Dumoulin operated in the middle ground, facing moderate competition with neutral deployment.

Fantasy Impact: These are your "depth-to-middle-six" stability pieces. They don't offer much offensive ceiling, but they play steady minutes that bridge the gap between the top guns and the checking line. They are relevant only in very deep leagues where lineup security matters. Armia struggled in possession metrics and will need to improve to maintain a significant NHL role.

Observation: Laughton, Ward, and Helenius occupied lower-leverage or defensively heavy minutes.

Fantasy Impact: These are "do not draft" assets. Their usage is defined by structural and shutdown roles, which caps their offensive upside. They serve as secondary "real hockey" support and provide little to no value in points-only formats. Laughton's bubble was pushed further left by his stint in Toronto.



The advertisement features a dark red background with a subtle hockey rink pattern. On the left, there is a white goalie mask icon above the text "GOALIEPOST APP". Below this, a paragraph states: "Get confirmed starter alerts sent right to your phone. Never miss a i lineup change again." This is followed by a list of four features, each preceded by a yellow checkmark icon: "CONFIRMED STARTERS (Not Probables)", "BREAKING NEWS ALERTS", "PERSONALIZED TEAM TRACKING", and "INJURY & CALL-UP UPDATES". At the bottom left, a yellow button with black text reads "GET IT NOW ON THE APP STORE & GOOGLE PLAY". On the right side, a large QR code is displayed within a white-bordered square, which has a small black Twitter bird icon in the center. The background also includes a faint image of a hockey goalie in action.

GOALIEPOST APP

Get confirmed starter alerts sent right to your phone. Never miss a i lineup change again.

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GET IT NOW ON THE APP STORE & GOOGLE PLAY

Kings by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
ARTEMI PANARIN	L	26	63.4	1014	0.901	11.3	53.7	85.5	73	75.3	67.6	3	10	55.6
ADRIAN KEMPE	R	81	59.1	1028	0.924	10.4	52.1	66.9	73.7	81.9	46.2	2.8	14	37.8
KEVIN FIALA	L	56	55.5	982	0.918	6.4	54.1	68.1	74.1	76.7	70.8	2.2	10	45.5
QUINTON BYFIELD	C	79	46.3	992	0.907	8.5	53.4	47.8	58.3	59.7	52.4	1.9	9	36
ANDREI KUZMENKO	R	52	56.1	977	0.9	7.7	53.3	60.8	58.1	50	68.4	1.9	9	75
ANZE KOPITAR	C	67	58.5	1053	0.939	11.4	51.3	63.8	51.4	46.4	70.6	1.8	10	38.5
ALEX LAFERRIERE	R	82	48	1008	0.921	8.7	53.4	37.1	69.8	76.5	50	1.8	11	47.8
TREVOR MOORE	L	69	45.7	984	0.903	8.1	54.5	15.8	68.1	73.2	25	1.7	9	47.4
JOEL ARMIA	L	67	46.3	997	0.925	7.2	49.3	14.8	73.5	88.5	33.3	1.6	2	16.7
BRANDT CLARKE	D	82	61.7	1015	0.92	9.5	54.3	50.3	44.4	39.1	61.9	1.5	8	25
SCOTT LAUGHTON	C	21	19.5	996	0.921	7.5	44.4	25.5	66.7	72	66.7	1.4	1	33.3
ALEX TURCOTTE	C	62	56.1	953	0.888	6.5	54.5	6.4	66.7	66.7	0	1.3	7	63.6
SAMUEL HELENIUS	C	53	34.8	969	0.898	7.1	47.1	0.5	81.8	81.8	0	1.3	3	75
JEFF MALOTT	L	58	44.7	957	0.878	7.9	51.8	0.1	50	50	0	1.1	1	16.7
JOEL EDMUNDSON	D	82	58.6	1019	0.922	9.7	50.8	1.4	34.8	31.1	100	0.9	13	61.9
DREW DOUGHTY	D	72	50.5	1001	0.919	8.2	53.6	37.2	31.1	31.8	16.7	0.8	11	61.1

- In all fairness, former Coach Jim Hiller didn't have many offensive tools to work with, given Kopitar aging out and Clarke still being new. And just when Panarin arrived to reinvigorate the offense, Fiala got hurt. So, seeing only three players with a Pts/60 above 2.0 isn't a huge surprise. We were all disappointed in Byfield's lack of progress, but he actually finished fourth on the team.
- The good news is that Byfield's 5-on-5 shooting percentage was very low, and his secondary-assist ratio was also low. It's hard to accumulate those when nobody else is scoring. Byfield is only getting better, and the metrics here indicate he should improve.
- Kuzmenko had a very high secondary-assist rate, though his 5-on-5 shooting percentage was low. His next contract (\$5M with Pittsburgh) and the new coach will determine where things go, as these two metrics point in opposite directions. That kind of money should see to it that he gets reasonable usage.
- Fiala had one of the lowest 5-on-5 shooting percentages in the league at 6.4%. He had a terrible season, and with a new coach coming in, this is a strong "buy-low" opportunity. Turcotte and Doughty are other key names with luck metrics that are too low and should see a market correction.
- Last season marked the first time in his five-year career that Byfield's PP IPP exceeded 50%. His power-play ice time is rising, and with Kopitar gone it will now surge. Imagine the difference between getting 62% of available PP time on the top unit instead of his usual 47% on the second unit. That alone could mean 10-20 more points.
- The last time Doughty had a PP% as low as 37.2% was never. The last time it was below 53%... also never. Seeing just 37.2% was a major shift in his career trajectory. A new coach could change this, but the smart money says it only happens if Clarke gets injured or seriously stumbles.

Key departures	Anze Kopitar (Retired), Andrei Kuzmenko (PIT)
Arrivals	Peter Laviolette (Coach), Mats Zuccarello (MIN), Erik Haula (NSH), Corey Perry (TB)

Minnesota WILD

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Kirill Kaprizov	76	45	96	31	Ryan Hartman	75	19	36	67	Matt Boldy	80	38	89	44
M. Shabanov	67	17	39	12	Joel Eriksson Ek	66	20	45	39	Danila Yurov	78	10	33	30
Blake Coleman	78	20	35	55	Charlie Stramel	78	14	38	47	Bobby Brink	73	14	38	22
Nick Foligno	71	9	20	51	Nico Sturm	60	6	10	17	Marcus Foligno	65	11	15	69
					Michael McCarron	77	9	14	102	Yakov Trenin	80	8	18	45
					Hunter Haight	65	7	15	10					
Defense	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Defense	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Quinn Hughes	77	14	87	34	Brock Faber	82	14	49	30	Filip Gustavsson	32	19	3	2.90
Olli Maatta	66	3	17	12	Jared Spurgeon	73	4	20	14	Jesper Wallstedt	54	31	4	2.65
Jonas Brodin	60	5	16	18	Zach Bogosian	64	3	8	43					
Carson Lambos	23	1	4	6	Daemon Hunt	17	1	3	2					
Matt Kiersted	6	0	2	1	Viking G Nyberg	4	0	1	0					

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: Someone is going to be the new Mats Zuccarello, now in Los Angeles. The smart money is on Shabanov. He had a tough rookie year with the Islanders—very difficult minutes, minimal offensive-zone starts, and little PP time. But Brink could just as easily be that guy, especially if Shabanov gets hurt again—it happened a couple of times last year. Both are middle-six players, both on the smaller side, but both have the skill to keep up with a star. Other options: load up the top line and use Boldy (a fallback, since they like to split those two) and Yurov. A very longshot to consider is Coleman.

On the hot seat: Last season, Shabanov was a square peg Patrick Roy tried to push into a round hole. He's a Ferrari, and Roy wanted him plowing fields. If deployed properly alongside Kaprizov, he has the potential to really pop. But if he flounders again, it's doubtful he gets another NHL contract next summer. The pressure is on.

- If Stramel makes the team, he will eventually center Kaprizov—possibly even this season, depending on how quickly he adapts to NHL hockey. If that happens, swap him with Hartman on the depth chart.

- After Marco Rossi was traded to Vancouver last season, the team experimented with Yurov on the Kaprizov line. That move fell flat, so Coach John Hynes went back to the old reliable—Hartman. His production jumped: 35 points in 49 games after starting with eight in 27. To ease pressure off Stramel, Hartman likely starts the season on that unit. Give it a month, then trade him. Once he loses that spot, his numbers will fall off a cliff.

- Yurov had nine points in 11 games after the Rossi/Quinn Hughes deal, but then slowed and eventually lost his spot centering Kaprizov. His faceoff percentage (39.2%) is too low for another shot at that job. He'll need to improve his FO% before getting another opportunity. It's possible—maybe even likely—that he moves to wing this year.

- Faber's numbers before Hughes arrived: 15 points in 31 games, plus-2, four PPPTS. Faber's numbers after Hughes arrived: 36 points in 49 games, plus-16, seven PPPTS.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Kirill Kaprizov	120	92	Charlie Stramel	75%	
Quinn Hughes	103	88	Hunter Haight	65%	
Matt Boldy	97	87	Carson Lambos	35%	
Joel Eriksson Ek	75	60	Daemon Hunt	25%	
Brock Faber	62	55	Riley Heidt	20%	
Bobby Brink	70	53	Adam Benak	10%	
Danila Yurov	75	52	V Gustafsson Nyberg	10%	
Maxim Shabanov	73	50			
Charlie Stramel	75	50			
Adam Benak	80	47			
Riley Heidt	68	45			
Hunter Haight	62	43	Sleeper	Pts	%
Adam Andersson	67	40	Maxim Shabanov	57	20%
Lirim Amidovski	63	38	Charlie Stramel	50	15%
Ryan Hartman	55	35	Bobby Brink	60	10%
Blake Coleman	52	35	Danila Yurov	53	10%
Aron Kiviharju	52	30			
Yakov Trenin	42	28			
Jared Spurgeon	35	25			

• Hughes had 23 points in 26 games with Vancouver before the trade, so the move helped him just as much as it helped his new teammates. He had 53 points in 48 games after joining the Wild.

Injuries:

Eriksson Ek missed Minnesota's last five playoff games, while Brodin missed the Wild's last six playoff games. Both had broken bones in their feet... Gustavsson underwent offseason hip surgery. It is currently not known whether he will be ready to start the season, which may point to why the Wild signed Calvin Pickard. **Update: Gustavsson is out until at least November. Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Brodin, M. Foligno, Brink, Eriksson Ek, Spurgeon, Maatta.

Breakout Threshold:

Faber broke out nicely last season, right on BT schedule. This season only McCarron, age 31 and a definite late bloomer, enters a BT season. With a career high of 22 points, a breakout for him would be 28 or more. Certainly doable, but not overly impressive in fantasy circles. As a 6-6 player, it's no surprise the former first-round pick (25th in 2013) took so long to become a full-time NHLer.

Goalies:

This goaltending situation is a difficult one to project, although both goalies should be valuable to fantasy teams. Gustavsson underwent offseason hip surgery, with his availability for training camp not known. Meanwhile, Wallstedt is quickly demonstrating that he is an NHL-level goalie, starting for the Wild in the playoffs. Wallstedt might be the preferred goalie here based on the number of starts he could receive early in the season. However, Gustavsson shouldn't be ruled out at all, as the Wild have invested \$6.8 million per season for five more seasons of his services. Once both goalies are healthy, this could be a timeshare or simply decided by who plays better with the Wild competing to win it all. Pickard was signed as a free agent likely as goaltending insurance should Gustavsson have to miss time to start the season. **Dobber's confidence that Wallstedt is the starter: 65%**

Contract Year:

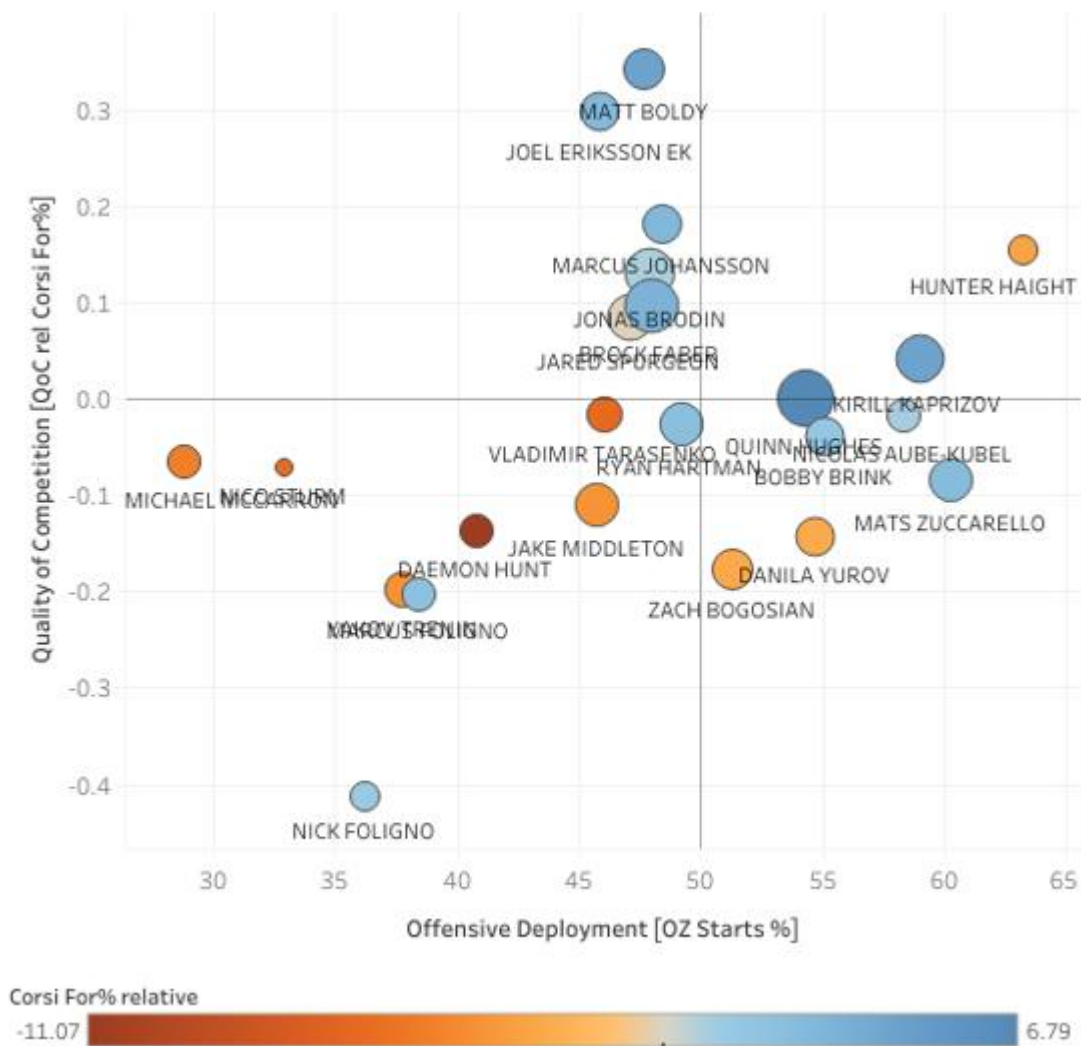
As he attempts to earn a greater share of the goaltending, Wallstedt will be playing in an arbitration-eligible contract season. The spotlight will be on him if Gustavsson misses games due to injury early in the season... After trading three promising young players and a draft pick to the Canucks for Hughes, the Wild will try to extend the high-scoring defenseman sooner rather than later. If Hughes is truly not interested in extending with Minnesota, the Wild may retain him for one more run as they go all in. Either he or Cale Makar should be the league's highest-paid defenseman with their next contract... The rest of the long list of Wild UFA aren't as much of a priority. Included on this list is team captain Spurgeon, who is now 36 years old.

2027 RFA: Brink, Shabanov, Haight, Wallstedt

2027 UFA: Hartman, Coleman, Sturm, Foligno, Hughes, Spurgeon, Bogosian, Hunt, Pickard

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Max Shabanov		
Boom or bust	Max Shabanov		
Multicategory / Banger	Michael McCarron		
Salary cap bargain	Jesper Wallstedt		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Blake Coleman	61	172	180
Bobby Brink	47	88	102
Brock Faber	148	37	172
Charlie Stramel	31	94	140
Danila Yurov	51	73	101
Hunter Haight	16	79	85
Jared Spurgeon	124	68	95
Joel Eriksson Ek	40	106	199
Kirill Kaprizov	33	48	266
Maksim Shabanov	24	41	114
Marcus Foligno	47	194	71
Matt Boldy	64	69	271
Michael McCarron	68	185	100
Nick Foligno	39	155	71
Nico Sturm	27	72	48
Olli Maatta	99	21	59
Quinn Hughes	84	11	207
Ryan Hartman	71	68	173
Yakov Trenin	39	360	96
Zach Bogosian	64	68	45

Dobber Advanced... WILD



Observation: Boldy and Eriksson Ek anchored the top-left quadrant, facing the highest Quality of Competition on the team.

Fantasy Impact: These were the “real hockey” engines for Minnesota. Their ability to remain efficient despite such difficult deployment made them the most reliable assets on the roster. They were the primary catalysts, and their usage formed the backbone of the team’s defensive structure. Easier minutes would boost their offense, but they’re still doing an impressive job generating chances and driving possession in this role.

Observation: Kaprizov and Zuccarello were deployed in the high-offensive-zone quadrant (nearly 60%).

Fantasy Impact: These were the primary offensive beneficiaries. They were tasked with generating the team’s scoring, and their favorable deployment was designed to maximize production.

Observation: Johansson, Faber, Spurgeon, and Brodin operated in the neutral-to-offensive zone, handling stronger competition while maintaining positive possession metrics.

Fantasy Impact: These were reliable “glue” assets. They provided high-floor value and acted as secondary drivers, keeping the team competitive when the top lines were off the ice. Once the team acquired Hughes, Faber became his partner and his bubble began shifting further right.

Observation: McCarron and Sturm occupied the lower-left, defensive-leaning zone.

Fantasy Impact: These are “do not draft” candidates for points-only leagues. Their deployment was strictly structural, designed to suppress the opposition rather than generate offense. They provided little to no fantasy utility and functioned purely as depth.

Observation: Hughes dominated the right side of the chart, maintaining elite possession efficiency even while handling significant ice time.

Fantasy Impact: This matches the eye test. Hughes is a stud. His ability to drive play from the back end, combined with heavy usage, made him the primary engine for the team's transition game and power-play success. He delivered high-ceiling production that was highly sustainable due to his role as the team's primary puck-mover.

Observation: Jake Middleton (now with Calgary) and Bogosian were deployed in the middle ground, managing weaker competition but losing relative possession.

Fantasy Impact: These were the defensive anchors who handled the "dirty work" against lesser lines. While their possession metrics were neutral-to-negative, their usage allowed offensive-leaning defensemen (Faber/Hughes) to flourish. They offered minimal fantasy value in points-only formats and served strictly as structural support.

Observation: Hunt, Yurov and Trenin operated in more sheltered, neutral deployment.

Fantasy Impact: Hunt's possession metrics were abysmal, which isn't surprising for a borderline NHLer. Yurov received sheltered deployment and performed reasonably well. His position on the right side of the chart supports the organization's vision of him eventually becoming a contributing top-six forward.

Observation: Haight, in his nine games, faced strong competition and a high percentage of offensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: The QofC suggests the organization sees him as a potential checking forward. The high zone-start rate was simply caution—they weren't sheltering him, but rather easing him into that role with reduced risk.

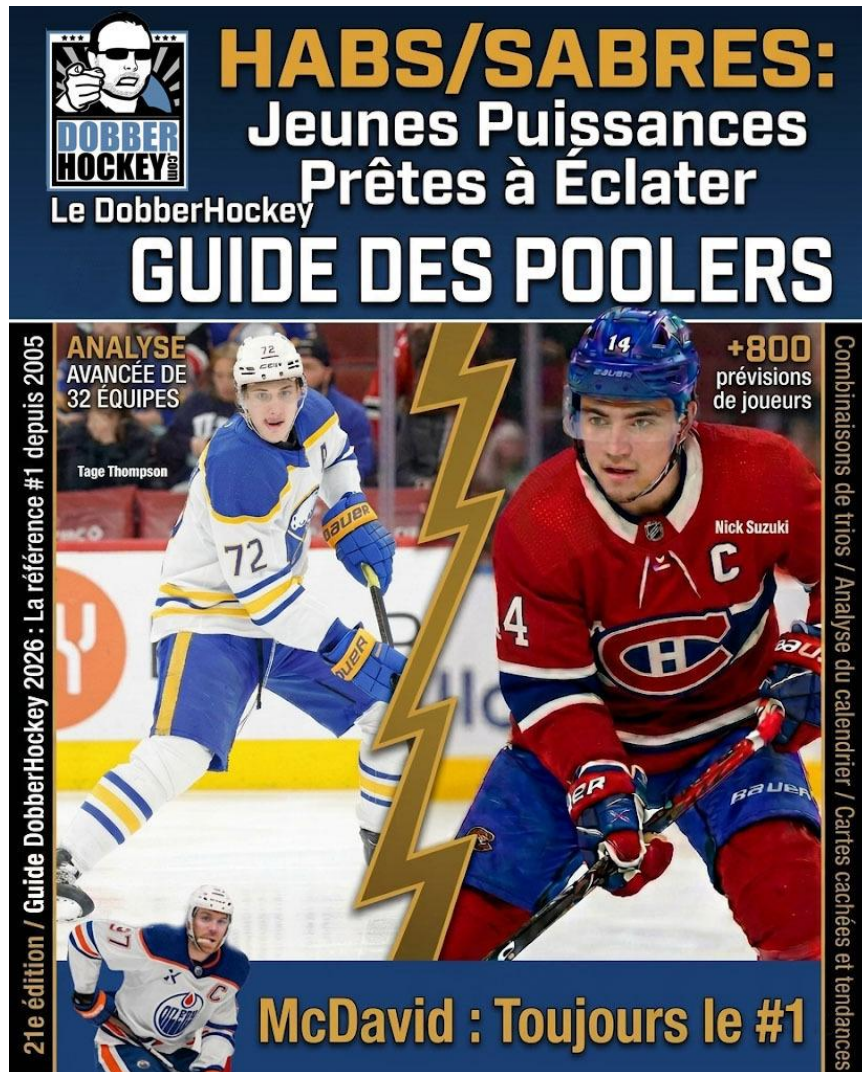
Wild by the Metrics...

	<i>Pos</i>	<i>GP</i>	<i>ZS%</i>	<i>PDO</i>	<i>5on5 SV%</i>	<i>5on5 S%</i>	<i>CF%</i>	<i>%PP</i>	<i>IPP</i>	<i>ES IPP</i>	<i>PP IPP</i>	<i>PTS/60</i>	<i>Sec Asst</i>	<i>Sec Asst %</i>
<u>MATT BOLDY</u>	L	76	47.7	1030	0.923	10.7	51.7	75.6	71.4	78.6	68.2	3.3	20	46.5
<u>KIRILL KAPRIZOV</u>	L	78	58.9	1013	0.912	10.1	50.8	77.3	67.4	68.7	66.7	3.1	17	38.6
<u>MATS ZUCCARELLO</u>	R	59	60.2	997	0.898	9.9	49.6	74.1	69.2	75	63.6	2.9	19	48.7
<u>MARCUS JOHANSSON</u>	L	75	48.4	1034	0.923	11.1	51.2	24.2	64.5	63.9	75	2.5	13	38.2
<u>VLADIMIR TARASENKO</u>	R	75	46	1010	0.922	8.8	45.3	44.7	77	85	61.9	2.5	8	33.3
<u>QUINN HUGHES</u>	D	48	54.3	1000	0.89	11	53.1	81.7	52.8	42.9	75.6	2.4	23	47.9
<u>JOEL ERIKSSON EK</u>	C	70	45.8	1036	0.926	11	50.1	67.4	49	57.6	40	2.2	16	51.6
<u>RYAN HARTMAN</u>	R	76	49.2	999	0.918	8.1	50	33.9	62.3	73.5	35	2	6	30
<u>DANILA YUROV</u>	R	73	54.7	998	0.903	9.5	47.2	12	60	63.2	42.9	1.7	10	66.7
<u>BROCK FABER</u>	D	80	47.9	999	0.902	9.7	50.2	20.9	44.3	40.6	84.6	1.5	17	47.2
<u>YAKOV TRENIN</u>	C	82	37.7	1039	0.934	10.5	45.8	1.7	48.9	52.3	0	1.3	5	29.4
<u>MICHAEL MCCARRON</u>	C	20	28.7	949	0.895	5.4	48.2	5.2	63	68	0	1.2	1	50
<u>NICO STURM</u>	C	49	32.9	983	0.92	6.3	43.9	0.3	68.8	73.3	0	1.2	4	66.7
<u>MARCUS FOLIGNO</u>	L	56	38.4	951	0.903	4.8	48.2	2.7	68.4	68.8	100	1.1	3	60
<u>JARED SPURGEON</u>	D	79	47.1	1003	0.931	7.2	47.9	28.4	35.5	34	42.9	0.9	8	50
<u>JONAS BRODIN</u>	D	62	47.9	1020	0.932	8.8	49	1.5	32.1	32.1	100	0.9	4	28.6

- Only Johansson posted a significantly high 5-on-5 shooting percentage. He clearly over-produced and is due for a drop in his even-strength output.
- Marcus Foligno—normally a 30-point-pace player—managed just 19 points last season. His 5-on-5 shooting percentage was extremely low, and he should rebound back into the 30-point range. Other notable low-shooting-percentage players included Hartman and, to a lesser extent, Tarasenko.
- The Wild leaned heavily on their top power-play unit: Hughes, Kaprizov, Zuccarello, Eriksson Ek, and Boldy. Of that group, everyone posted at least a 63% PP IPP except JEE, who sat at 40%.
- The second unit consisted of Faber, Tarasenko, Johansson, Hartman, and Spurgeon, with Faber serving as the focal point.
- Kaprizov's 38.6% secondary-assist ratio is low, but it's actually the highest of his career. This underscores how integral he is to the offense. Hughes' presence likely contributed to this slight increase.
- Eriksson Ek's IPP is on the low side at both even strength and on the power play. His IPP has declined in each of the last four seasons, likely due to the gradual uptick in skill across the roster. He's a two-way forward with upside, but he may have already reached it. As more skilled prospects filter into scoring-line roles, his usage may shift further toward the defensive side of the spectrum.

Key departures	Mats Zuccarello (LAK), Vladimir Tarasenko (UFA), Marcus Johansson (SHL), Robby Fabbri (UFA), Jake Middleton (CGY)
Arrivals	Blake Coleman (CGY), Maxim Shabanov (NJD), Olli Maatta (CGY), Calvin Pickard

Édition en français



Disponible le 31 juillet

Ici pour plus d'infos

Montreal CANADIENS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Cole Caufield	84	48	90	14	Nick Suzuki	84	31	96	25	Juraj Slafkovsky	83	28	80	52
Alex Newhook	76	19	44	22	Oliver Kapanen	83	14	36	25	Ivan Demidov	82	28	75	22
Zachary Bolduc	79	16	35	32	Phillip Danault	80	9	25	24	Kirby Dach	58	12	26	43
Alexandre Texier	55	9	20	26	Jake Evans	79	11	27	21	Josh Anderson	79	13	19	87
Florian Xhekaj	7	0	1	4	Owen Beck	56	4	17	22	Brett Berard	65	4	17	52
Jared Davidson	12	1	1	4	Sasha Pastujov	20	2	4	7	Samuel Poulin	6	0	2	2
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Lane Hutson	84	6	79	34	Alexandre Carrier	77	5	20	40	Jakub Dobs	54	34	2	2.85
Mike Matheson	82	8	34	49	Noah Dobson	79	11	47	34	Sam Montembeault	16	6	0	3.30
Kaiden Guhle	57	4	15	50	David Reinbacher	40	3	19	34	Jacob Fowler	20	12	1	2.75
Jayden Struble	59	2	11	58	Adam Engstrom	37	3	8	8					
Arber Xhekaj	62	2	5	109										

Restricted Free Agents: Bolduc, Xhekaj

Camp battle: Montembeault's \$3.15M is a tough contract to bury, and Fowler's development is better served by starting 55 games in the AHL rather than 30 in the NHL. But the contract is only for one year, and if Montembeault plays poorly enough, they'll send him to the minors if they have to—they've done it before. Fowler is only 21, which is very young for an NHL goalie, but he has already proven capable. If he's lights-out in camp and Montembeault implodes, Fowler could win the job, in which case Montembeault's projected starts would shift to him.

On the hot seat: Dach has appeared in this section often enough. Time to call a spade a spade: he's a Band-Aid Boy. So instead, Newhook becomes the better candidate. He looked good last season alongside Demidov, but an injury threw a wrench into things. Now entering his sixth NHL season, if he can't establish himself as a top-six forward here and now, then he never will. Alexander Zharovsky and Michael Hage are on the way, and Newhook needs a big season (60+) to secure his place or risk being a checking-line player permanently.

- Another slow starter drawing plenty of X posts and emails early on was Slafkovsky. As you can see—he'll be fine. But on November 26, he had just 10 points in 22 games. A "bust," one impatient owner called him. "Overrated," said another. Patience is crucial with bigger players, and 22 games can turn around quickly. Slafkovsky had 63 points in 60 games after that. People literally won their fantasy leagues after acquiring him in late November in a "buy low" trade.

- Chicken or egg? Slafkovsky caught fire, and linemates Suzuki and Caufield surged. Or was it the other way around? Either way, the trio is seriously clicking. Suzuki had 46 points in 42 games to start, and 55 in 40 to finish. Caufield had 40 in 42, then 47 in 39.

- Despite maintaining the same ice time, the same PP time, and the same defense partner in Matheson, Dobson hit a wall offensively down the stretch, posting just two points in 14 games before taking a slapshot off his left hand on April 11. When he returned for the playoffs—likely early—he had just one point in 13 games. That's three points in 27 contests overall. He had 45 points in 66 games before that.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Nick Suzuki	105	93	Owen Beck	65%	
Cole Caufield	98	90	David Reinbacher	65%	
Lane Hutson	95	80	Brett Berard	60%	
Ivan Demidov	110	80	Jacob Fowler	45%	
Juraj Slafkovsky	93	80	Adam Engstrom	45%	
Alexander Zharovsky	80	60	Sasha Pastujov	30%	
Noah Dobson	75	57	Samuel Poulin	10%	
Michael Hage	77	52	Florian Xhekaj	10%	
Alex Newhook	68	50	Jared Davidson	10%	
Zack Bolduc	67	50			
Kirby Dach	68	48			
Gleb Pugachyov	73	45	Sleeper	Pts	%
Oliver Kapanen	65	43	Alex Newhook	60	10%
Sasha Pastujov	70	43	Kirby Dach	45	10%
Mike Matheson	57	38			
Jake Evans	50	37			
David Reinbacher	43	35			
Owen Beck	65	35			
Bryce Pickford	62	32			

- Looking deeper into Demidov's game logs, his second quarter was his best, with 21 points in 22 games. This coincided with Newhook being sidelined and Slafkovsky moving to Demidov's line. There's a major swing in what Demidov can do this season depending on how much time Slafkovsky spends on his line.

- Kapanen surprised everyone with 16 goals by January 8 (44 games), but managed just six in 38 games afterward. The slump carried into the playoffs, where he was often a healthy scratch. There's some risk here. Long-time fantasy owners may remember how his father, Sami, was extremely streaky and often unreliable. Is that genetic?

- When Newhook was sidelined from mid-November through late February, Texier benefited the most, collecting 18 of his 21 points during the 31 games he played in that stretch.

Injuries:

No notable injuries. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Dach, Guhle, Newhook, Texier.

Breakout Threshold:

Slafkovsky is 6-3 and right on the border of "big man" status for BT theory. He started last season 200 games in and broke out in a big way. Had he not, there would have been no panic—400 games would have been the target. Fortunately, it's irrelevant now. Guhle and Bolduc enter their BT seasons. Guhle would be a surprise, given his role and tendency toward injury. Bolduc is interesting, but would need an upgrade in linemates. It could happen.

Goalies:

Montembeault's disastrous season opened the door for Dobes to take over as the unquestioned starter around the trade deadline. Dobes delivered, taking the Canadiens to the conference final while finishing second in the playoffs in quality starts (11). Dobes has a limited track record as a starter, which is why he's not totally stable. But the Habs have invested over \$5 million per season in Dobes for three years starting in 2027-28, so they believe he is the guy. Fowler is still waivers-exempt, but he has impressed in the AHL. He is only 21 years old, so it's entirely possible that he is back in the AHL with Montembeault backing up Dobes. This could ultimately be a situation where the Habs ride the hot hand because they have options. That would not be ideal for fantasy teams. **Dobber's confidence that Dobes is the starter: 90%**

Contract Year:

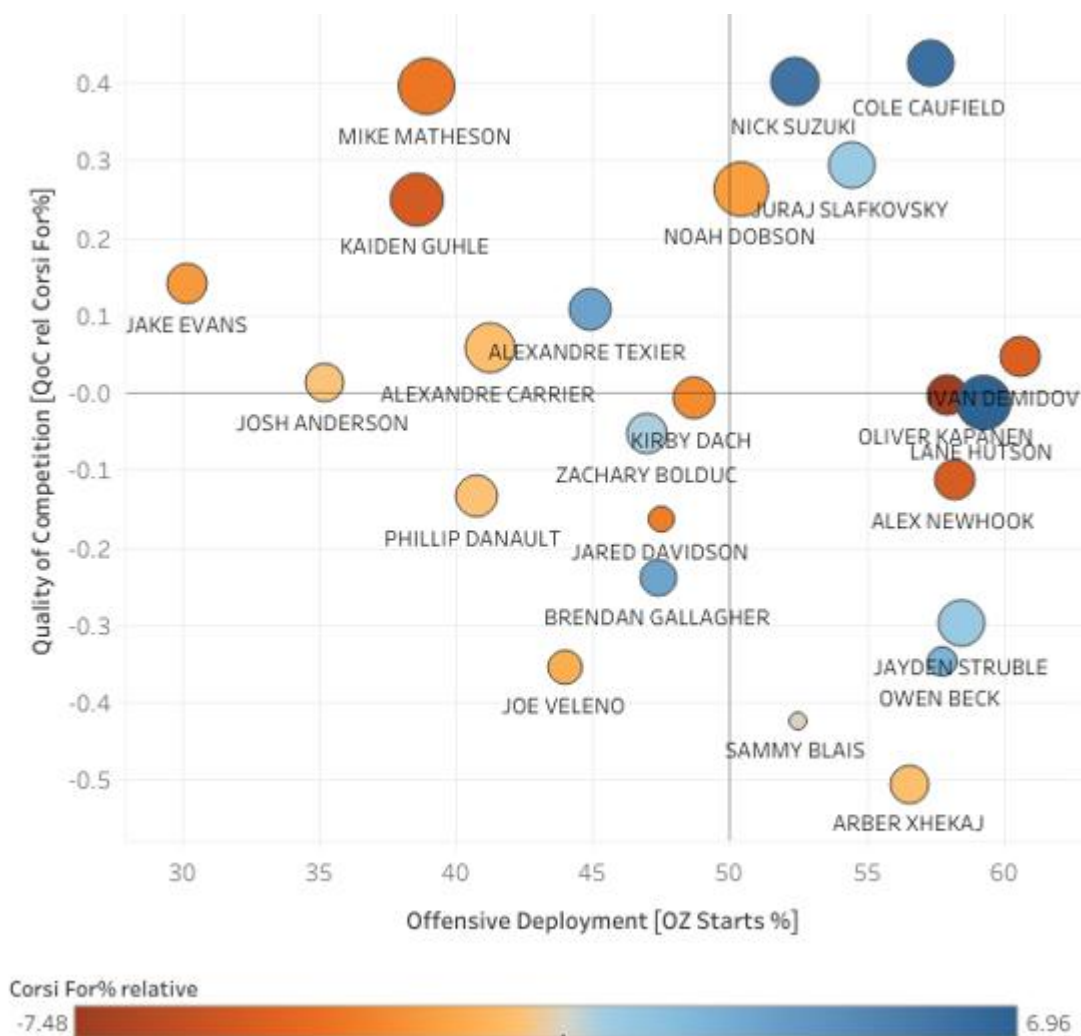
In late July, the Habs still needed to take care of Bolduc and Xhekaj with just under \$10 million in cap space... Newhook heads the list of available RFA. He has yet to really take that next step with the Canadiens, so maybe a contract year will enable that if he can stay healthy... Dach is in the same boat as Newhook, only as a UFA. That means it will be easier for the Habs to walk away if he has another injury-filled season without showing the upside that made him a high first-round pick... With three goalies now in the mix, Montembeault will be in tough to earn starts, let alone receive a contract offer from the Habs. Like Dach, this will be a make-or-break season for him as far as his future goes.

2027 RFA: Newhook, Kapanen, Berard, Struble

2027 UFA: Danault, Anderson, Dach, Carrier, Montembeault

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Ivan Demidov		
Boom or bust	Alex Newhook		
Multicategory / Banger	Arber Xhekaj		
Salary cap bargain	Ivan Demidov		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Alex Newhook	30	84	114
Alexandre Carrier	164	46	69
Arber Xhekaj	43	167	49
Brett Berard	39	95	85
Cole Caufield	25	57	284
Ivan Demidov	29	32	156
Jake Evans	61	102	87
Jayden Struble	44	109	41
Josh Anderson	43	142	95
Juraj Slafkovsky	75	125	191
Kaiden Guhle	96	105	68
Kirby Dach	35	93	81
Lane Hutson	126	37	134
Mike Matheson	148	62	131
Nick Suzuki	59	66	185
Noah Dobson	165	63	165
Oliver Kapanen	66	39	133
Owen Beck	34	97	45
Phillip Danault	54	78	104
Zachary Bolduc	47	190	119

Dobber Advanced... CANADIENS



Observation: Suzuki, Caufield, and Slafkovsky occupied the high-leverage, offensive-leaning quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: These were the primary offensive engines of the team. Their deployment was designed to maximize scoring potential against challenging competition. They were "must-own" offensive cornerstones whose consistent production stemmed directly from this trust and opportunity. They drove possession against the toughest lines the opposition could offer.

Observation: Demidov, Hutson, Kapanen, and Newhook were deployed with significant offensive-zone starts (55%+).

Fantasy Impact: These were the primary offensive beneficiaries. Demidov and Hutson, in particular, were placed in prime scoring environments to drive play. Hutson excelled, leading the entire team in relative CF%. Kapanen posted the lowest relative CF% on the roster—he was a scoring revelation, but it came at a heavy cost, and his role may decline next season. It's possible he even dragged down Demidov's impact. Kapanen is a risky hold in keeper leagues.

Observation: Dach, Bolduc, Texier, and Brendan Gallagher (now with Vancouver) occupied the neutral-to-offensive deployment zone, handling modest competition. Gallagher saw the most sheltered deployment of the group.

Fantasy Impact: These were depth contributors. They provided a stable floor, though their deployment did not offer the explosive offensive ceiling available to the top-line stars.

Observation: Evans and Anderson operated in more defensive-leaning roles.

Fantasy Impact: These were structural pieces. Their deployment focused on maintaining defensive integrity rather than generating offense, which suppressed their individual point totals. They hold minimal value in standard points-only formats.

Observation: Matheson and Guhle anchored the top-left quadrant, shouldering the most difficult Quality of Competition on the roster. They lost relative possession, with Guhle performing slightly worse than Matheson.

Fantasy Impact: These were the "real hockey" anchors of the blue line. While their deployment limited their

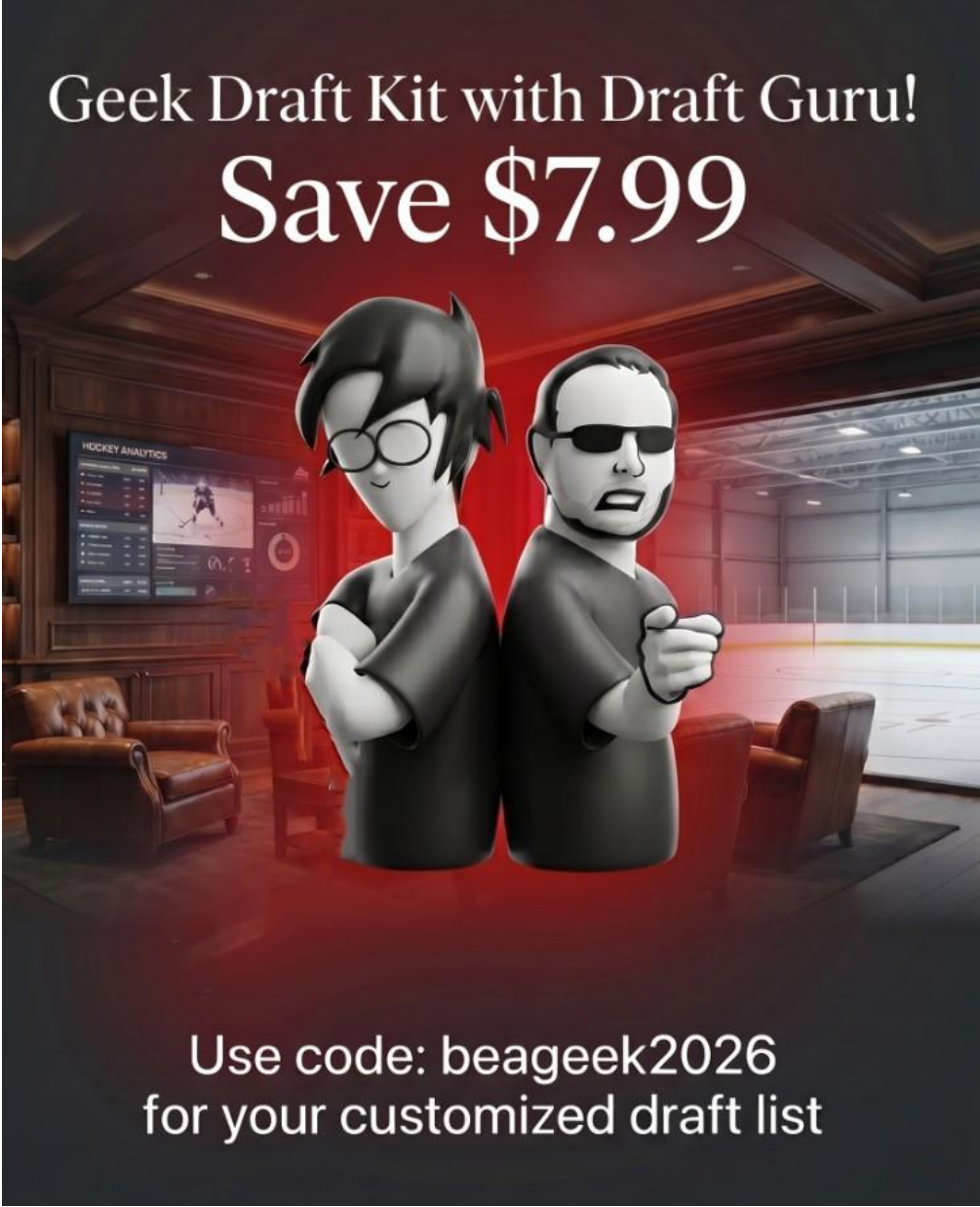
even-strength scoring ceiling, their usage established them as the team's primary defensive stalwarts. They absorbed the toughest defensive-zone starts, freeing Dobson and Hutson for more offensive deployment.

Observation: Dobson operated in the middle-to-high quadrant, managing tougher competition.

Fantasy Impact: Dobson served as a critical hybrid defender who bridged the gap between the shutdown pairings and the offensive driver (Hutson). His deployment allowed him to contribute in all three zones, making him a reliable, high-floor fantasy asset.

Observation: Xhekaj and Struble were utilized in sheltered, offensive-leaning minutes.

Fantasy Impact: These players received the most protection on the back end. Their usage minimized defensive risk while allowing them to transition the puck in the offensive zone. They remain developmental assets with room to grow, but they are not yet relied upon for heavy defensive duties. Xhekaj showing a shade of orange with such sheltered usage suggests a risk of losing his roster spot.



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The advertisement features two cartoon characters standing back-to-back in a hockey arena. The character on the left has black hair and glasses, while the character on the right has a beard and sunglasses. They are both wearing dark t-shirts. In the background, there is a hockey rink with a red glow, a leather armchair, and a screen displaying 'HOCKEY ANALYTICS' with various charts and graphs.

Canadiens by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>COLE CAUFIELD</u>	L	81	57.3	1041	0.915	12.6	52.3	69.2	69.3	72.8	63	3.6	14	37.8
<u>NICK SUZUKI</u>	C	82	52.4	1044	0.92	12.4	52.1	73.2	69.2	61.7	84.3	3.5	27	37.5
<u>JURAJ SLAFKOVSKY</u>	R	82	54.4	1039	0.921	11.8	48.4	68	59.3	59.2	59.6	2.9	17	39.5
<u>IVAN DEMIDOV</u>	R	82	60.5	1042	0.897	14.5	45.4	62.3	59.6	66.7	48.8	2.9	17	39.5
<u>ALEX NEWHOOK</u>	L	42	58.2	1076	0.904	17.2	44.9	20.2	65.8	66.7	75	2.5	4	33.3
<u>LANE HUTSON</u>	D	82	59.2	1043	0.907	13.6	52.3	68.2	51.3	54.7	43.5	2.4	35	53
<u>ALEXANDRE TEXIER</u>	L	43	44.9	1033	0.933	10	51.6	21.9	70	74.1	50	2	6	50
<u>OLIVER KAPANEN</u>	C	82	57.9	1041	0.901	14	43.3	19.9	60.7	60.7	33.3	1.9	7	46.7
<u>KIRBY DACH</u>	R	37	48.6	995	0.876	11.9	46.7	25.6	55.6	59.1	40	1.8	4	57.1
<u>ZACHARY BOLDUC</u>	L	78	47	1003	0.903	10	48.6	34.3	58.8	63.2	46.2	1.7	8	44.4
<u>NOAH DOBSON</u>	D	80	50.4	1013	0.902	11.1	47	31.2	49.5	48.1	70	1.6	17	48.6
<u>BRENDAN GALLAGHER</u>	R	77	47.4	1001	0.907	9.4	50	29	51.1	48.6	62.5	1.5	11	68.8
<u>JOSH ANDERSON</u>	R	72	35.2	976	0.882	9.4	46.7	1.6	60.5	61.8	0	1.4	4	44.4
<u>JAKE EVANS</u>	C	68	30.1	982	0.902	8	46.6	0.8	77.4	82.8	0	1.4	7	58.3
<u>MIKE MATHESON</u>	D	78	38.9	1010	0.91	10	45.8	5.7	42.5	45.5	50	1.2	17	56.7
<u>PHILLIP DANAULT</u>	C	45	40.7	984	0.912	7.2	49.3	1.2	39.5	43.2	0	1.1	1	16.7

- Elite-level Pts/60 numbers for Caufield and Suzuki, with Slafkovsky and Demidov well on their way to reaching that tier as well.
- Seeing Newhook's name above Hutson's certainly grabs attention. Given his rebound in production, his age (right in his prime), and his linemates/spot in the lineup, he could be a sneaky dark-horse acquisition.
- That said, his 5-on-5 shooting percentage was astronomically high, indicating a market correction is likely. These two contradicting indicators suggest his production will depend heavily on whether he plays with Demidov again.
- Demidov, Kapanen, and Hutson also posted high 5-on-5 shooting percentages. Hutson is fine given his skill level. Kapanen, like Newhook, will lean heavily on whether he plays with Demidov. And Demidov needs to ensure he progresses in his sophomore season and doesn't pull a Matvei Michkov—who regressed last year in his own sophomore campaign.
- The first unit was set in stone—and will remain set in stone: Caufield, Suzuki, Slafkovsky, Demidov, and Hutson. Dobson, Bolduc, Newhook, Texier, Kapanen, Gallagher, and Dach rotated through the second unit. Of that group, Kapanen was the weakest link, with a PP IPP of 33.3. He is in danger of losing his power-play time.
- It is surprising to see Hutson post such a low PP IPP. No real impact—he's a stud and his spot on the top unit is secure. Just noteworthy.

Key departures	Brendan Gallagher (VAN), Joe Veleno (NYR)
Arrivals	Brett Berard (NYR)

Nashville PREDATORS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Filip Forsberg	84	39	78	41	Ryan O'Reilly	83	24	67	22	Mavrik Bourque	83	21	47	25
Steven Stamkos	83	36	64	48	Vitali Pinchuk	74	19	36	22	J Marchessault	74	19	41	36
Ross Colton	73	15	28	32	Jack Drury	83	11	28	31	Matthew Wood	74	19	36	16
Reid Schaefer	80	8	16	48	Alexander Kerfoot	78	13	25	25	Joakim Kemell	35	4	7	18
Nils Hoglander	65	8	19	31	Adam Edstrom	34	5	6	11	Ozzy Wiesblatt	43	2	6	39
					Brady Martin	9	0	4	6					
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Roman Josi	70	14	52	32	Brady Skjei	83	8	29	42	Juuse Saros	57	27	2	3.05
Nicolas Hague	70	3	15	45	Nick Perbix	79	4	17	17	Justus Annunen	29	11	1	2.80
Adam Wilsby	62	2	14	18	Justin Barron	68	4	11	24					
Ilya Lyubushkin	51	1	6	32	Ryan Ufko	60	3	36	14					
Tanner Molendyk	12	1	2	2										

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: Pinchuk is this year's potential fantasy stud, signed as a free agent out of Europe. There is a full profile of him in the Fantasy Prospects Report. What you're watching for in camp is how quickly he's pushed into the top six, as well as his power-play usage. Last year's supposed big ticket, Max Shabanov, was a bust thanks to poor deployment (little power-play time, more defensive-zone starts). We don't want a repeat of that with Pinchuk. Pinchuk is bigger and more of a sniper who relies on linemates to set him up, whereas Shabanov is smaller and expected to drive plays. Pinchuk could even end up in a checking role, something Shabanov doesn't really fit.

On the hot seat: Marchessault was disappointing in his first season with the Preds and a disaster in his second, playing much of the year injured. At 35, with new additions such as Bourque, losing his PP1 spot would make regaining fantasy relevance nearly impossible. His contract—three more years at \$5.5M—is the main thing keeping him in the mix, though that number doesn't carry the weight it used to.

- In Dallas, Bourque started last season with Wyatt Johnston and Jason Robertson but wasn't ready and was bumped to the bottom six by late November. He earned another look in the second half and clicked, going from 14 points in 42 games to 27 in his final 40. Lots of potential.

- Josi started slowly due to injury and weaker pairings (Wilsby, Perbix). Once paired with Skjei in the second half, he erupted for 37 points in 39 games after just 18 in his first 29. At 36, he still has plenty left.

- Forsberg posted 31 points in the first half and 44 in the second, driven by Nashville's power play finally clicking. He had 18 PP points in the second half versus eight in the first. Josi's early injury hurt production.

- The contrast in goal scoring from Stamkos was remarkable. He was about as written off as a player could get, managing just four goals in 22 games. More than a quarter of the season had passed and he was barely on track for 15 goals. He ended up scoring 42—that's 38 goals in 60 games.

- Newcomer Drury from Colorado is a defense-first checking-line center with heavy defensive-zone usage and nearly half of the PK workload (likely even more now in Nashville). Upside remains minimal.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Filip Forsberg	95	75	Vitali Pinchuk	99%	
Steven Stamkos	67	58	Reid Schaefer	90%	
Mavrik Bourque	78	58	Ryan Ufko	80%	
Brady Martin	72	58	Joakim Kemell	55%	
Wyatt Cullen	75	57	Brady Martin	45%	
Matthew Wood	70	53	Tanner Molendyk	35%	
Egor Surin	75	53			
Ryan O'Reilly	78	52			
Roman Josi	68	48			
J Marchessault	63	48			
Teddy Stiga	78	42			
Jack Drury	58	40	Sleeper	Pts	%
Thomas Bleyl	65	40	Ryan Ufko	45	20%
Cameron Reid	60	40	Mavrik Bourque	60	20%
Ryker Lee	72	40	Brady Martin	45	15%
Aiden Fink	75	40	Matthew Wood	55	20%
Vitali Pinchuk	70	38	Vitali Pinchuk	55	15%
Joakim Kemell	68	37			

• Schaefer did not appear in this year's Fantasy Prospects Report because he played too many games, but he's still close to prospect status (just 47 games). He does have upside as a former first-round pick (32nd overall in 2022). However, he's a 6-5, 226-pound giant, and even though he's 23, he will likely still need three years to reach his peak. He is currently being groomed as a third-line, two-way player with a stronger focus on defense. His upside—if he shows more scoring touch—is that of a second-liner in the mid-60s for points, though that is unlikely. His 3YP is 35. He has a fairly high floor and will likely settle into a consistent range of 30 to 55 points, with 200+ Hits and 100+ PIM. That's just low enough to keep him off the 3YP chart, which is why he's mentioned here.

Injuries:

Hoglander did not compete at the World Championship after the NHL season due to an undisclosed injury... Marchessault and Josi missed the last game of the season due to undisclosed injuries... Hague (upper body) missed the last six games of 2025-26. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Josi, Hague.

Breakout Threshold:

Hague has played 426 career NHL games and he is 6-6, meaning he is entering his BT season. Last year, he posted his highest points-per-game average in four years, but he hasn't stayed healthy. He needs two things to happen to reach 35 points: a pairing with Josi, and a full, uninterrupted season. Barron has been underwhelming since joining Nashville, but he has played 208 career games, so if he ever finds his mojo, this season is the most likely time. Bourque has played 156 career games, meaning his BT will hit in January, setting up a possible second-half spike.

Goalies:

Saros continues to be a high-volume goaltender, finishing with at least 58 games played in each of his last five seasons. No goalie has appeared in more games during that span. Unfortunately, his numbers have gradually worsened over those five years. He can still provide a decent number of wins based on volume, but a less-than-ideal goals-against average and save percentage are hurting your fantasy team. Unless Nashville turns it around, expect similar results in 2026-27. There is an argument that Annunen should appear in at least 30 games and possibly even challenge for the starting job, as his ratios were better than those of Saros. Still, the wide difference in cap hit will likely mean Saros remains the starter for a while. The only other option in net is Matt Murray, who will simply provide goaltending depth. **Dobber's confidence that Saros is the starter: 100%**

Contract Year:

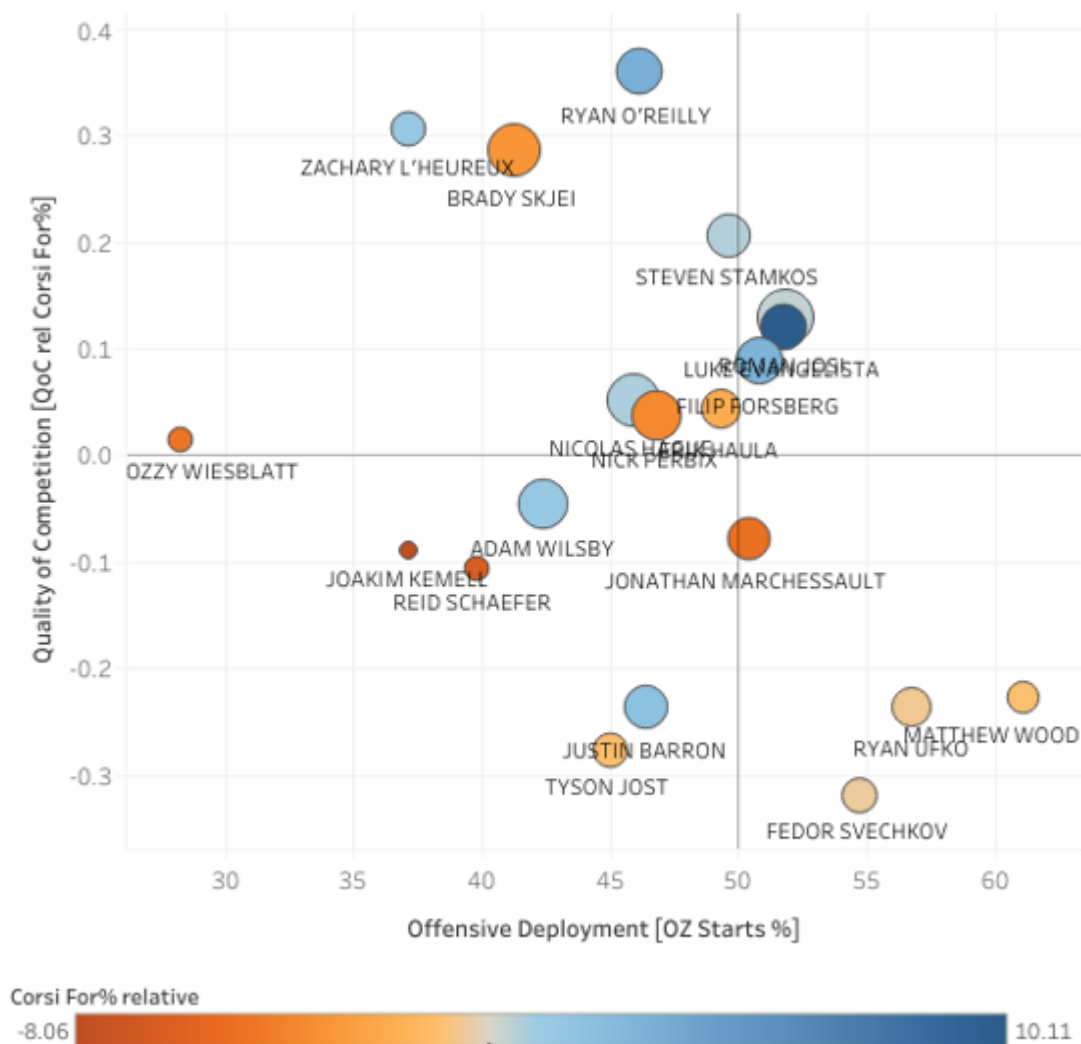
Evangelista is the most recognizable RFA. He is arbitration-eligible, but he does not become a UFA until 2029-30... Wood will try to build on an underrated rookie season as he moves on from his entry-level contract... O'Reilly is the UFA to watch for the Predators. His name will definitely be on the trade block if the Preds fall out of the playoff race. He may show interest in staying in Nashville, so the incentive for the next contract is there. The rest of the UFA are supporting players.

2027 RFA: Evangelista, Pinchuk, Edstrom, Wood, Barron, Wilsby

2027 UFA: O'Reilly, Colton, Lyubushkin, Perbix

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Mavrik Bourque		
Boom or bust	Vitali Pinchuk		
Multicategory / Banger	Reid Schaefer		
Salary cap bargain	Matthew Wood		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adam Wilsby	55	35	68
Alexander Kerfoot	62	64	94
Brady Skjei	92	65	133
Filip Forsberg	42	134	260
Jack Drury	58	54	116
Jonathan Marchessault	19	87	163
Justin Barron	84	58	61
Matthew Wood	30	67	126
Mavrik Bourque	31	87	166
Nick Perbix	94	39	87
Nicolas Hague	77	84	70
Nils Hoglander	20	82	72
Reid Schaefer	51	200	72
Roman Josi	101	28	181
Ross Colton	44	176	154
Ryan O'Reilly	62	21	149
Ryan Ufko	48	34	72
Steven Stamkos	33	80	191
Vitali Pinchuk	22	44	133

Dobber Advanced... PREDATORS



* The Predators had more defensive-zone starts than offensive ones, limiting the amount of sheltered deployment they could give the players who needed it.

Observation: O'Reilly, L'Heureux, and Skjei anchored the top-left quadrant, handling high Quality of Competition with low offensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: This was a structural "production inhibitor." The coaching staff used these players to suppress opposing stars, effectively sacrificing their individual offensive ceilings for team stability. L'Heureux, despite low ice time, was tasked with heavy defensive lifting rather than offensive creation. He was a non-factor in points-only formats because his role was purely "real hockey" defensive maintenance. O'Reilly, however, still managed his best offensive totals in nearly a decade. How he wasn't a Top-5 Selke pick is baffling (he finished 17th in voting).

Observation: Stamkos, Evangelista, and Forsberg occupied the high-leverage, offensive-leaning quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: These players faced difficult competition but were given the offensive-zone starts (as available) needed to capitalize on their skill. Evangelista was especially impressive, leading the entire team in relative CF% and posting better possession numbers than Forsberg. He has proven himself as a true top-six forward and erased any lingering doubts from last season.

Observation: Marchessault, Svechkov, Ufko, and Wood operated in the bottom-right quadrant with high offensive-zone starts against weaker competition.

Fantasy Impact: These were the primary "deployment beneficiaries." For Ufko, Svechkov, and Wood, this usage is appropriate—they are prospects just breaking in, and careful deployment is typical. Marchessault wasn't sheltered nearly as much, yet he posted some of the weakest possession metrics on the team. He's signed for three more seasons, but another year like this and a buyout next summer becomes a real possibility.

Observation: Josi (overlapped by Evangelista's bubble) and Hague operated in the neutral zone, balancing competition level with steady usage.

Fantasy Impact: Josi's deployment wasn't strictly sheltered, nor was he buried in the defensive zone. Given the team's lack of offensive-zone starts, the coach did what he could. Josi remains the most reliable, high-floor asset on the blue line. Hague saw more defensive-zone starts and handled them well, suggesting he could take on additional responsibility.

Observation: Perbix, Haula, and Wilsby handled middle-tier competition with neutral deployment.

Fantasy Impact: They served as the team's "gap-fillers." They didn't receive the heavy usage of Josi or Hague, nor were they protected like the offensive-zone specialists. They offered little fantasy value, lacking both the elite deployment needed for offense and the heavy defensive minutes that would have freed up the top line.

Observation: Wiesblatt was isolated in the defensive-leaning, low-offensive-start zone.

Fantasy Impact: He was the most buried player on the roster. With that deployment, he had no pathway to sustainable scoring. He functioned as a defensive specialist with zero fantasy upside in standard formats—but he performed adequately in his role.

Observation: Kemell and Schaefer were positioned far on the left side of the chart.

Fantasy Impact: Both are expected to be offensive players if and when they become NHL regulars (Schaefer already is). Seeing them used in mostly defensive-zone starts is concerning, as it would cap their future roles as third-liners rather than offensive contributors.

Predators by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>FILIP FORSBERG</u>	L	82	50.8	1015	0.923	9.2	51.3	63.8	73.5	77.8	66.7	2.9	11	31.4
<u>STEVEN STAMKOS</u>	L	82	49.6	1002	0.906	9.6	49.7	67.2	64.7	66.7	61.9	2.7	13	54.2
<u>RYAN O'REILLY</u>	C	81	46.1	1023	0.916	10.7	51.7	61.2	67.3	75.7	55.6	2.7	17	34.7
<u>RYAN UFKO</u>	D	18	56.7	1031	0.912	11.9	44	35.5	78.6	81.8	66.7	2.6	6	66.7
<u>LUKE EVANGELISTA</u>	R	81	51.7	992	0.902	9	56	45.6	61.5	65	54.8	2.5	17	38.6
<u>MATTHEW WOOD</u>	C	71	61.1	1016	0.904	11.2	48.3	33.5	54.5	56.4	53.3	2.1	3	23.1
<u>ROMAN JOSI</u>	D	68	51.8	993	0.897	9.6	49.2	68.5	51.4	43.7	68.6	2	23	54.8
<u>ERIK HAULA</u>	C	81	49.3	974	0.905	6.9	48.3	31.2	62.9	59.5	76.5	1.7	17	68
<u>J MARCHESSAULT</u>	R	62	50.4	1003	0.905	9.8	46	57.2	49.2	60.5	30.4	1.7	7	38.9
<u>FEDOR SVECHKOV</u>	C	70	54.7	993	0.903	9	49.5	5.2	54.8	56.7	0	1.2	6	46.2
<u>TYSON JOST</u>	R	69	45	944	0.887	5.7	48.3	0.5	66.7	75	0	1.1	5	62.5
<u>JOAKIM KEMELL</u>	R	16	37.1	1045	0.936	10.9	39.8	11.2	42.9	50	0	1.1	0	0
<u>REID SCHAEFER</u>	L	47	39.7	964	0.907	5.7	41.6	0.2	88.9	88.9	0	1.1	1	50
<u>ADAM WILSBY</u>	D	58	42.4	993	0.914	7.9	50.1	0.7	41	43.2	0	1	8	53.3
<u>ZACHARY L'HEUREUX</u>	L	25	37.1	1029	0.959	7	45.8	9.8	55.6	50	100	0.9	0	0
<u>BRADY SKJEI</u>	D	82	41.2	1003	0.91	9.3	47.6	23.6	30.6	30.6	33.3	0.8	10	43.5

- It was only 18 games, but that's still a reasonable sample size—and Ufko managed 2.6 Pts/60, topping Josi's number. His 5-on-5 shooting percentage was high, but not excessively so. A very promising start to his young career, even if some of it was boosted by luck.
- Wood played 71 games, which is a much stronger sample size, and his 5-on-5 shooting percentage of 11.2 was high. He may not deliver the second-year improvement we're hoping for. But as a bigger player (6-4), he's already ahead of schedule according to our template.
- For a team that didn't score much, Coach Andrew Brunette certainly stuck to his guns with the first power-play unit: Forsberg, Stamkos, O'Reilly, Josi, and Marchessault. But not only did Marchessault have a bad year—his PP IPP was just 30.4. By midseason he should have been demoted to the second unit, if not sooner.
- Meanwhile, on the second unit, Haula was surprisingly proficient—as was Ufko. Youngsters Evangelista and Wood were merely "okay."
- Kemell played only 16 games, and as you can see, he was given just 37.1% offensive-zone starts. Nonetheless, his 39.8 CF% is a poor look for a high-drafted player who should be in the NHL by now.
- Erik Haula (now with Los Angeles) had his highest point total in three years (39), but 17 of his 25 assists were secondary.

Key departures	Erik Haula (LAK), Tyson Jost (UFA), Zachary L'Heureux (COL), Fyodor Svechkov (COL)
Arrivals	Mavrik Bourque (DAL), Ross Colton (COL), Jack Drury (COL), Alex Kerfoot (UTA), Nils Hoglander (VAN), Adam Edstrom (NYR), Ilya Lyubushkin (DAL)

New Jersey DEVILS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Jesper Bratt	84	23	80	14	Jack Hughes	68	29	87	14	Luke Evangelista	80	14	61	24
Timo Meier	77	28	50	43	Nico Hischier	79	31	69	21	Anthony Mantha	74	27	52	35
Arseny Gritsyuk	76	16	38	30	Evan Rodrigues	79	13	34	38	Dawson Mercer	84	21	41	27
Jesper Boqvist	76	11	17	15	Cody Glass	72	12	28	31	Connor Brown	78	14	38	16
Lenni Hameenaho	70	8	21	18	Amadeus Lombardi	65	11	21	26	Nick Bjugstad	67	10	16	36
Stefan Noesen	60	10	21	37										
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Jonas Siegenthaler	78	1	12	45	Dougie Hamilton	73	13	40	45	Jake Allen	37	17	1	2.80
Luke Hughes	76	8	47	26	Johnathan Kovacevic	68	3	13	58	Nico Daws	35	18	2	2.85
Brenden Dillon	82	4	13	85	Brett Pesce	66	2	12	20	David Rittich	17	7	0	3.05
Declan Chisholm	64	3	14	17	Seamus Casey	38	4	10	8					
Vladislav Kolyachonok	20	2	6	6	Topias Vilen	7	0	2	0					

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: GM Sunny Mehta had a lot of nice things to say about Lombardi, and he was aggressive in acquiring him (gave up a fourth-rounder). He has to clear waivers to be sent down, so he'll get a long look. That said, it only matters in fantasy if he can sneak onto the second PP unit or play well with decent linemates. For now, consider him a depth player for the season ahead, but keep your finger hovering over the waiver-claim button if you like what you see in camp.

Camp Battle: Hamilton is a year older (now 33), a year further past his prime. L. Hughes is a year older (now 23), a year closer to the start of his prime. Last season, the two saw fairly equal PP use. Will the scales start to tilt toward the younger player? In Luke's favor is the fact that his brother Jack is on PP1. Being a part of PP1 means everything.

- The bad news is that Jack Hughes missed another 21 games. The good news? He did not get hurt on the ice, playing the full season without an on-ice injury. Hey, let's take the positives when we can get them! An accident in the kitchen at a team dinner cost him those games, and when he returned from the Olympics he finished second in league scoring (to Connor McDavid) with 41 points in 25 games. Mark this down: If Jack can play a full 84-game schedule, he'll be a Top 3 player.

- Finally playing a healthy season, Hamilton bounced back in a big way, though it took him until midseason to get going. He had 30 points in his last 38 contests after starting with just nine in 39. A lot of that was his improvement on the power play, with 10 of the 30 points coming with the man advantage.

- Glass finished very strong with 12 goals and 17 points in the final 37 games, as well as winning 54.8% of faceoffs during that span. A big reason was line chemistry, and it happened after Hameenaho was called up and plunked on a line with Glass and Gritsyuk. Adding Rodriguez complicates things, but if this line gets reunited it will provide decent secondary offense.

- Brown was put on a line with Bratt and Jack down the stretch and popped off with 17 points in the last 20 games. That's possibly the best run of his entire career. When he was brought into Edmonton, he was coming off missing a full

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Jack Hughes	125	105	Nico Daws	99%	
Jesper Bratt	105	90	Lenni Hameenaho	85%	
Nico Hischier	88	75	Amadeus Lombardi	80%	
Luke Evangelista	73	63	Seamus Casey	45%	
Timo Meier	75	57			
Anthony Mantha	67	53			
Luke Hughes	70	52			
Dawson Mercer	70	52			
Alexander Command	70	52			
Dougie Hamilton	63	45			
Seamus Casey	60	43			
Arseniy Gritsyuk	72	42	Sleeper	Pts	%
Connor Brown	52	42	Dougie Hamilton	60	20%
Amadeus Lombardi	68	37	Luke Hughes	65	15%
Lenni Hameenaho	70	35	Dawson Mercer	55	5%
Evan Rodrigues	48	35	Jack Hughes	120	10%
Anton Silayev	40	35	Amadeus Lombardi	40	10%
Nikita Shcherbakov	50	35			
Matias Vanhanen	65	35			

season with injury. He couldn't get himself up to speed in time to really get going with Connor McDavid. But he's definitely in top form now and is a dark horse if he can secure a spot on that line again.

- When Jack was sidelined from the kitchen incident, no Devil averaged a point per game. Hischier led the team with 16 points in 18 games, followed by Bratt with 13 and Luke with 10. No other player had even 10 points. It cost New Jersey a playoff spot. Jack Hughes is everything to this team.

- Gritsyuk missed the last 12 games with injury, and his linemates Glass and Hameenaho each slowed quite a bit, managing just four points (Glass) and two points (Hameenaho).

Injuries:

Rodrigues' season in Florida ended in late March due to a broken finger... Gritsyuk (upper body) underwent surgery in early April... Noesen underwent season-ending knee surgery in January, with no word on his status for the coming season... L. Hughes underwent a procedure in April but should be ready for training camp... Siegenthaler didn't participate in the World Hockey Championship due to an injury. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Pesce, J. Hughes, Bjugstad, Glass, L. Hughes, Hamilton.

Breakout Threshold:

Because of his injury last season, Luke's BT year has been pushed back and is now... well, now. He has played 223 career NHL games, and a breakout for him would mean 59 or more points.

Goalies:

New Devils GM Sunny Mehta was able to move 36-year-old Jacob Markstrom and his \$6 million cap hit to Florida. Assuming a trade for a more expensive goalie isn't completed, that leaves the Devils with only \$3.9 million in cap space for three goalies. Among these bargain-basement netminders, Allen is the most likely to be the starter. He has both the highest cap hit (\$1.8 million) and the longest term (four years remaining). Allen's downside is that he has reached 40 games in a season just once since 2018-19, the year in which he was replaced by Jordan Binnington in St. Louis. Meanwhile, Daws is no longer waivers-exempt, while the Devils have also signed veteran Rittich. Daws and Rittich will be a training camp battle to watch, as Daws has had plenty of AHL seasoning and may be NHL-ready. **Dobber's confidence that Allen is the starter: 80%**

Contract Year:

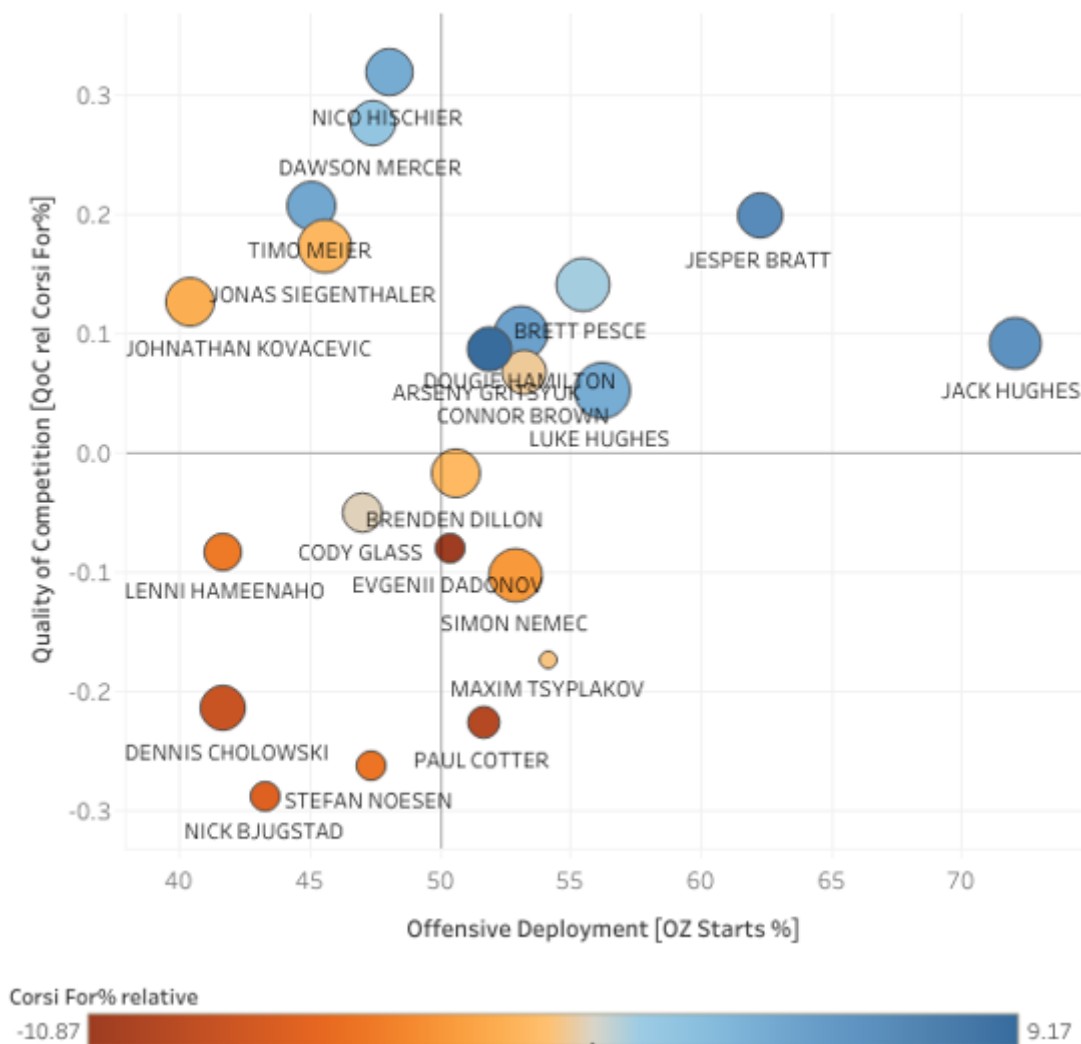
Mercer has shown signs of breaking out, but over time he has not proven to be a reliable fantasy option. Perhaps an RFA arbitration-eligible contract year will be what he needs. He is only 24 but has already appeared in five full NHL seasons... If the Devils fall out of the playoff race again, they have several inexpensive depth options to sell to teams. Rodrigues offers secondary scoring and championship experience from his time in Florida. If Daws emerges as an NHL-level goalie, Rittich could be on the move before the deadline, if not sooner.

2027 RFA: Mercer

2027 UFA: Rodrigues, Noesen, Glass, Bjugstad, Boqvist, Dillon, Chisholm, Rittich

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Nico Daws		
Boom or bust	Anthony Mantha		
Multicategory / Banger	Brenden Dillon		
Salary cap bargain	Jack Hughes		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Anthony Mantha	33	51	141
Arseny Gritsyuk	23	74	175
Brenden Dillon	107	188	58
Brett Pesce	125	20	86
Cody Glass	42	48	101
Connor Brown	35	23	109
Dawson Mercer	52	36	168
Dougie Hamilton	76	80	197
Evan Rodrigues	28	79	182
Jack Hughes	34	7	258
Jesper Boqvist	34	155	84
Jesper Bratt	38	80	192
Jonas Siegenthaler	130	105	70
Lenni Hameenaho	40	50	101
Luke Evangelista	21	27	184
Luke Hughes	64	21	182
Nick Bjugstad	33	104	94
Nico Hischier	58	50	198
Stefan Noesen	25	71	108
Timo Meier	50	130	263

Dobber Advanced... DEVILS



Observation: Hischier, Mercer, and Meier anchored the top-left quadrant, handling high Quality of Competition with low offensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: These three were tasked with the hardest defensive assignments on the team, effectively sacrificed so the rest of the lineup could thrive. Hischier remains the “real hockey” engine, but his fantasy value was suppressed by this heavy defensive workload. Anyone expecting 90+ points was likely disappointed; his value is tied entirely to real-life utility, not fantasy ceiling. The sooner you accept that, the sooner you can move on.

Observation: Jack Hughes and Bratt occupied the high-leverage, offensive-leaning quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: These were the team’s primary offensive drivers. Hughes, in particular, received an enormous amount of offensive-zone starts (70%+), making him the team’s primary “beneficiary” of coaching protection. Because the shutdown line (Hischier/Mercer/Meier) absorbed the toughest matchups, Hughes and Bratt could feast on lesser competition. They are “must-own” assets, serving as the main engines of the team’s transition game and scoring.

Observation: Cotter, Dadonov, Glass, and Noesen operated in the bottom-middle quadrant, handling weaker competition with neutral deployment. Other than Glass, they did not perform well.

Fantasy Impact: These were depth players. They provided baseline value, though Glass specifically showed strong point-per-game efficiency relative to his usage. He was a sneaky play in deeper leagues and should remain one, provided he keeps his lineup spot.

Observation: Bjugstad was isolated in the defensive-leaning, low-offensive-start zone—but only against the weakest competition.

Fantasy Impact: This indicates a steep decline in his NHL stature. Two years removed from his career season, he is clinging to an NHL job. He is still signed for next season but is a cheap buyout candidate.

Observation: Hamilton, Pesce, and Luke Hughes operated in the offensive quadrant.

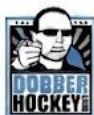
Fantasy Impact: Hamilton was given the deployment needed to drive offense (52% OZ starts) against respectable competition. He wasn't sheltered—he was trusted—making him a high-end, reliable fantasy asset. Pesce and Luke Hughes acted as capable supporting pieces, benefiting from the same offensive-leaning environment, which boosted their efficiency. Luke Hughes received a lot of criticism in fantasy circles, but this chart doesn't support that narrative. And he's only 22.

Observation: Kovacevic and Siegenthaler occupied the top-left quadrant alongside the defensive forwards.

Fantasy Impact: Just as the Hischier line took the hard forward minutes, these two absorbed the hard defensive minutes. Their work made it possible for Hamilton and the other offensive defensemen to maximize their offensive-zone deployment.

Observation: Gritsyuk led the team in possession metrics, finishing first in relative CF%.

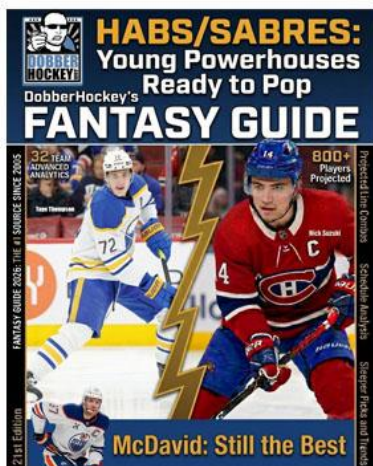
Fantasy Impact: The rookie adapted quickly to the NHL, and his roster spot is secure. His bubble sits on the right side of the chart, indicating the organization views him as a top-six forward. An increase in production in his second year is a safe expectation. If he maintains this level of possession, he may eventually move to the Hischier line as a checker, freeing up Mercer or Meier—but that's a longer-term possibility.



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REVIEW**

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Devils by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>JACK HUGHES</u>	C	61	72.5	966	0.883	8.3	55	74.3	81.1	85.5	74.2	3.6	17	34
<u>JESPER BRATT</u>	L	82	62.5	951	0.877	7.4	55.8	70.9	71.3	78.5	58.8	2.8	20	40
<u>NICO HISCHIER</u>	C	82	48.4	965	0.905	6	54.4	73	67.3	72.4	62.2	2.3	15	39.5
<u>CONNOR BROWN</u>	R	75	53	982	0.895	8.7	50.9	35.7	61.4	68.6	47.1	2	11	44
<u>TIMO MEIER</u>	L	77	45.5	958	0.894	6.4	54.1	48.6	62	63	58.8	1.9	8	40
<u>ARSENY GRITSYUK</u>	L	66	52.4	977	0.893	8.4	57.2	24.7	58.5	60.5	50	1.9	5	27.8
<u>CODY GLASS</u>	C	70	46.9	1005	0.906	9.9	50.7	9.1	60.5	60	66.7	1.6	2	28.6
<u>DAWSON MERCER</u>	R	82	47.7	977	0.908	6.9	52.4	38.5	58.6	68	43.8	1.6	8	38.1
<u>DOUGIE HAMILTON</u>	D	77	53.4	973	0.906	6.7	53.8	49.8	43.2	40	56	1.4	16	61.5
<u>LUKE HUGHES</u>	D	68	56.4	981	0.907	7.4	53.4	49.4	46.7	40	72.2	1.3	17	58.6
<u>SIMON NEMEC</u>	D	68	52.9	975	0.887	8.8	49.4	30.1	40.6	42.9	28.6	1.2	6	40
<u>LENNI HAMEENAH</u>	L	33	41.7	1001	0.912	8.9	48.8	11.4	53.3	53.3	0	1.2	1	16.7
<u>PAUL COTTER</u>	L	79	51.7	943	0.892	5.1	44.9	4.2	75	73.7	100	1.1	4	66.7
<u>STEFAN NOESEN</u>	L	38	47.9	954	0.92	3.4	47.1	38.8	53.8	66.7	42.9	0.9	2	50
<u>COLTON WHITE</u>	D	23	52.2	1014	0.936	7.8	48.6	0	40	40	0	0.9	3	75
<u>J KOVACEVIC</u>	D	34	40.4	983	0.899	8.4	51	0.9	30.8	32	0	0.8	6	75

- Only four players topped the 2.0 Pts/60 mark, and one of them was Brown. Yes, things were dire for New Jersey—as always seems to be the case when Jack Hughes is sidelined.
- The entire roster suffered from very poor puck luck—the second-worst 5-on-5 shooting percentage in the league (only the Flames were worse). On a broad scale, everyone should improve. It won't work out perfectly that way, but statistically, each individual should see at least some rebound. The stars are the ones to watch first: Hughes (both), Bratt, Hirschier, Meier, Mercer, and Hamilton.
- The top three players on this chart were on the top power-play unit throughout the season. After that, the remaining spot rotated between Hamilton, Luke Hughes, and Meier. The second unit consisted of Brown, Mercer, Noesen, Gritsyuk, and Nemec.
- Brown, Mercer, and Simon Nemec (now with Calgary) did not contribute well to the power-play point totals, with each posting below a 50.0 PP IPP. Interestingly, Luke Hughes was more effective than Hamilton at even strength (and they were equal at 40.0).
- None of the key players had a high percentage of secondary assists. That said, a healthy Jack Hughes would mean a higher-scoring team, which in turn would create more secondary assists to go around. A rising tide lifts all boats—and Hughes is that tide.

Key departures	Jacob Markstrom (FLA), Paul Cotter (VAN), Maxim Tsyplov (CGY), Zach MacEwen (TOR), Evgenii Dadonov (UFA), Simon Nemec (CGY)
Arrivals	Anthony Mantha (PIT), Evan Rodrigues (FLA), Jesper Boqvist (FLA), Declan Chisholm (WSH), David Rittich (NYI)

New York ISLANDERS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Mathew Barzal	79	20	69	47	Bo Horvat	79	32	62	32	Kyle Palmieri	72	22	48	21
Matias Maccelli	76	13	42	12	Brayden Schenn	83	18	41	63	Emil Heineman	83	21	39	21
Anthony Duclair	62	17	31	19	Casey Cizikas	80	9	16	32	Calum Ritchie	71	14	39	14
Ondrej Palat	78	10	19	22	J-G Pageau	80	15	32	14	Simon Holmstrom	78	19	41	13
Kyle Maclean	57	4	8	22						Victor Eklund	73	11	49	22
										Mitchell Chaffee	14	1	2	4
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Matthew Schaefer	84	23	62	42	Ryan Pulock	71	4	21	15	Ilya Sorokin	59	32	6	2.70
Adam Pelech	69	4	16	37	Tony Deangelo	75	7	35	41	Vitek Vanecek	12	3	0	3.00
Alexander Romanov	66	3	19	19	Scott Mayfield	64	2	10	64	Semyon Varlamov	18	9	0	2.70
Isaiah George	21	0	4	4	Matthew Kessel	26	1	3	10					
Marshall Warren	10	0	3	2										

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: The Islanders are in need of offense and are likely to take one, two, or even all three of Eklund, Eiserman, and Aitcheson. In the cases of the latter two, on most teams they would be given another year to develop. But look for their performance in camp. The Islanders could use an injection of skill of the caliber of Barzal and Schaefer. Eklund has a strong likelihood of making it, and for now the other two are long shots. But monitor the situation because Eiserman and Aitcheson will have a fantasy impact when they arrive.

On the hot seat: Maccelli is a skilled player, but at 25 he needs to establish to the league that he is a top-sixer and not a tweener. With Eklund and Eiserman on the way, and Heineman and Ritchie on the rise, Maccelli's window to make an impact is now.

- DeAngelo averaged six points per quarter, except in the third quarter when he had 15. Why the jump? He started seeing ice time with Schaefer. Not a lot, and not primarily. But some. Digging deeper—last season, DeAngelo played 57.1% of his ES shifts with Pelech and 13.1% with Schaefer. Despite that vast difference, he had eight ES points while on the ice with Pelech and six while with Schaefer.

- Duclair is quite a wildcard. He took time off in 2024-25 for personal reasons. Last season, he missed time for a lower-body injury (in March, at times) and was a healthy scratch sprinkled in all season long. Yet despite that, he had a five-point game on January 6 (after being scratched) and a run of 13 points in 13 games before suffering the injury, and then when he returned, he was getting scratched again. His coach, Patrick Roy, was since fired, so that probably helps. But he's a definite wildcard who wouldn't surprise if he ended the season with 15 points or with 60. It's always easier (and better) to bet on the lower number. A waiver-wire pick.

- In the 25 games to end the season, Duclair only got into eight of them, and when he played it was just 11:49 in average ice time. During that stretch, it's worth noting that Ritchie had 15 points.

- Ritchie started off very slowly. He had an injury at the end of preseason, and when he was healthy again, he went to the AHL for a three-game rehab stint (three points). Upon returning, he had eight points in 28 games. Then he settled

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Mathew Barzal	90	72	Victor Eklund	70%	
Matthew Schaefer	82	70	Isaiah George	45%	
Bo Horvat	78	63	Marshall Warren	40%	
Victor Eklund	78	58	Cole Eiserman	25%	
Calum Ritchie	75	53	Kashawn Aitcheson	20%	
Cole Eiserman	80	52	Alex Jefferies	10%	
Matias Maccelli	70	48			
Emil Heineman	67	48			
Simon Holmstrom	62	43			
Brayden Schenn	62	42			
Kashawn Aitcheson	60	42			
Danny Nelson	65	40	Sleeper	Pts	%
Kyle Palmieri	55	38	Victor Eklund	55	20%
Alexander Romanov	50	35	Emil Heineman	55	15%
Jean-Gabriel Pageau	50	35	Matias Maccelli	60	10%
Anthony Duclair	57	35			
Tony DeAngelo	53	33			
Quinn Finley	68	33			
Malte Gustafsson	42	32			

down and tallied 22 in 37, helped along by the aforementioned Duclair scratches.

- Schenn saw only a small uptick in production upon joining the Islanders, but it was an uptick nonetheless. He had 28 points in 61 contests with St. Louis and then 11 in 19 with the Islanders. He'll start the season off as the second-line center and should rebound a little, but temper expectations. He's 35 and winding down his career.

- Holmstrom started shooting the puck more in the second half and it paid dividends. He had 23 points in the last 38 games (11 goals) after starting the season with 18 in 41. A lot of that had to do with increased playing time alongside Anders Lee (now with Utah). Lee is the master of one-timing rebounds; he had 35 shots off a rebound last season. Next highest on the team was Horvat with 19.

- Barzal worked best with Horvat. In the first quarter, he had 16 points. Second quarter: 16 points. Third quarter: 24. Fourth quarter: 16. The third quarter was the only one in which he primarily played with Horvat. He played with Horvat approximately 16.5% of his ES shifts—but had 42% of his ES points.

- Toronto (former) Coach Craig Berube had little patience for Maccelli, trying him initially on the John Tavares line, and when that didn't work after a few games, he played with Dakota Joshua and Nicolas Roy. When that didn't work, he was press-box bound. Two thoughts: a new line often takes a while. If he stuck with Tavares for 15 games, maybe things would be different. And secondly, not many people are going to impress playing with Roy and Joshua. It's top six or bust for him. He was back with Tavares later and it was a lot better. he wound up tallying 24 points in his last 41 games.

Injuries:

Barzal didn't play in the World Hockey Championship due to a minor injury... Engvall (hip/ankle) missed the entire season... Palmieri (knee) told reporters in April that he should be ready for training camp after his season ended in late November... Romanov (shoulder) was also injured in November, but he may have been able to return during the postseason had the Islanders made it... Varlamov missed the entire season due to a knee injury. He was returned from a conditioning loan in the AHL in April. His status for the season is still up in the air. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys: Romanov, Duclair, DeAngelo.**

Breakout Threshold:

Nobody.

Goalies:

This is one of the most certain goaltending situations in terms of who the starter will be. Sorokin has appeared in at least 55 games in each of the past four seasons, finishing with between 25 and 31 wins. He is a proven and reliable starter and could even be a top-5 goalie in upcoming fantasy drafts. Beyond that, the Islanders have signed Vanecek to a one-year contract, quite possibly to be Sorokin's backup. Varlamov did not play in 2025-26, and it is unknown whether he will return for 2026-27. Vanecek seems like the better bet to be the backup, although it's unlikely that he appears in more than 30 games barring injury. The 38-year-old Varlamov will be in the final year of his contract, so it's possible that we've seen the last of him in the NHL. **Dobber's confidence that Sorokin is the starter: 99%**

Contract Year:

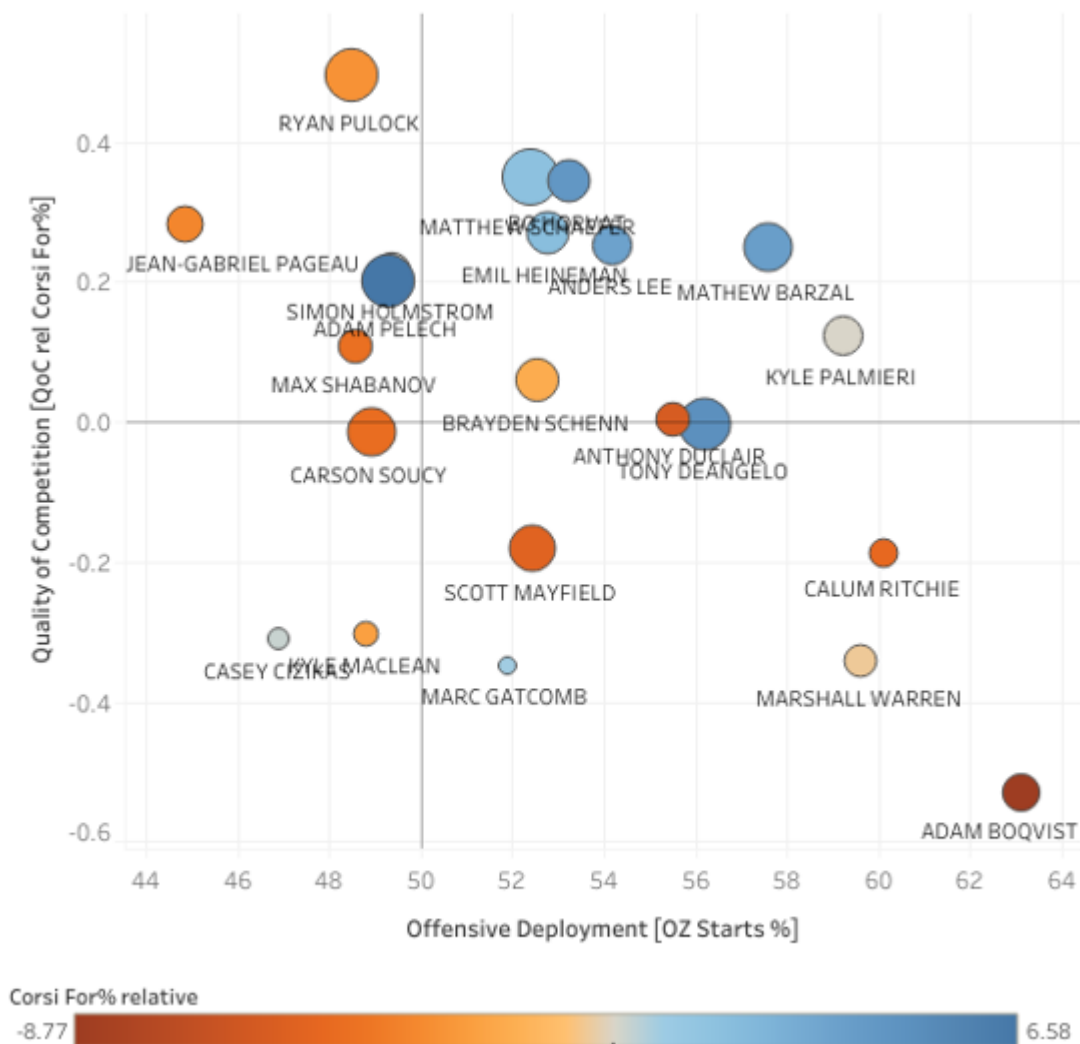
The Islanders have a few players entering an important RFA season that could dictate the direction their career takes. One example is Maccelli, who could score for the Arizona Coyotes but wasn't quite what Toronto hoped for. He's on a one-year prove-it deal with the Islanders... If they fall out of the playoff race, the Isles have several veterans who could help playoff-bound teams in depth roles. Palat and Palmieri stand out as potential secondary scorers, although Palat's \$6 million cap hit might be difficult to move. He also has a no-movement clause on top of that... If Varlamov turns out to be 100% healthy, it's possible that either he or Vanecek is traded sometime during the season.

2027 RFA: Holmstrom, Maccelli, Heineman

2027 UFA: Palat, Palmieri, Cizikas, MacLean, Kessel, Varlamov, Vanecek

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Calum Ritchie		
Boom or bust	Matias Maccelli		
Multicategory / Banger	Alexander Romanov		
Salary cap bargain	Matthew Schaefer		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adam Pelech	103	62	96
Alexander Romanov	152	139	99
Anthony Duclair	37	31	86
Bo Horvat	41	59	244
Brayden Schenn	50	200	142
Calum Ritchie	39	23	107
Casey Cizikas	56	143	72
Emil Heineman	50	270	183
Jean-Gabriel Pageau	52	112	104
Kyle Maclean	23	125	46
Kyle Palmieri	36	51	173
Mathew Barzal	53	36	190
Matias Maccelli	19	27	114
Matthew Schaefer	119	45	235
Ondrej Palat	59	119	86
Ryan Pulock	136	57	86
Scott Mayfield	77	68	51
Simon Holmstrom	47	21	110
Tony Deangelo	68	34	135
Victor Eklund	37	37	110

Dobber Advanced... ISLANDERS



Observation: Horvat, Barzal, Lee, and Heineman occupied the high-leverage, offensive-leaning quadrant and drove possession well relative to strong competition.

Fantasy Impact: These were the team's offensive engine up front. Unlike some teams where offensive deployment is purely sheltered, this group faced skilled competition while still receiving high offensive-zone starts. Barzal and Horvat remained the primary possession drivers; their production was sustainable because they dictated the pace of play. They are the only true "must-own" forwards on this roster. Heineman's bubble is especially impressive—he was a solid possession player last year with Montreal, and the team clearly views him as one of their offensive weapons.

Observation: Pageau, Holmstrom, and Shabanov were in the top-left quadrant, handling higher Quality of Competition with low offensive-zone starts—particularly Pageau, who was used almost exclusively as a defensive specialist. Holmstrom posted the best relative possession of the three.

Fantasy Impact: Holmstrom could have handled Pageau's tougher assignments, but this also shows he received a bit of offensive support. The main takeaway here is Shabanov: the fact that he was an offensive star in the KHL yet landed this far left on the chart (second-highest defensive-zone start percentage among forwards) is surprising and explains why his numbers fell short of expectations. Minnesota, where he signed, will certainly use him properly.

Observation: Duclair and Ritchie were positioned deep in the offensive-deployment zone (right side of the chart), yet both displayed dark-orange bubbles.

Fantasy Impact: These players were given significant offensive-zone starts, but their possession metrics were among the worst on the team. Despite favorable deployment, they were "usage sinks"—they received prime ice time but failed to convert it into positive relative possession. They are high-risk fantasy options whose value is capped by their inability to capitalize on the coaching staff's willingness to give them offensive opportunities. Ritchie gets more leash because he was a rookie.

Observation: Pulock and Pelech anchored the top-left quadrant, shouldering the most difficult Quality of Competition among defensemen with minimal offensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: These two were the undisputed “real hockey” anchors of the blue line. Their deployment limited their even-strength scoring ceiling, but their usage confirmed their status as the team’s primary defensive stalwarts. They were essential to the team’s structure—Schaefer doesn’t get those quality offensive-zone starts without their work.

Observation: Schaefer saw offensive-zone starts, but the rookie-of-the-year didn’t win the Calder solely for his offense. He faced very tough competition and still generated positive possession. DeAngelo saw better minutes—less difficult competition and more offensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: Both were deployed effectively, maximizing their offense. Schaefer is too important as an all-around player to be sheltered. He’ll still put up huge points, as he just showed—but imagine how much higher he could go if he were sheltered. Won’t happen.

Observation: Boqvist was as sheltered as a player can be in terms of deployment—and he performed terribly.

Fantasy Impact: If you were holding out hope that Boqvist still carried even the faintest flicker of potential, you can safely assume it’s extinguished.

The banner is split into two main sections. The left section has a blue and red background with a hockey player in a blue jersey. The right section has a green and yellow background with a hockey player in a green jersey. Both sections include a call to action button.

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Frozen Tools

Islanders by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>MATHEW BARZAL</u>	C	81	57.5	1005	0.913	9.2	51.6	71.3	64.3	65	62.5	2.6	22	41.5
<u>BO HORVAT</u>	C	68	53.2	990	0.903	8.7	52.6	68.9	64.8	66.1	64	2.4	16	61.5
<u>KYLE PALMIERI</u>	R	25	59.2	999	0.927	7.2	49.6	65.4	75	92.9	55.6	2.3	7	58.3
<u>CALUM RITCHIE</u>	R	65	60.1	971	0.912	5.9	45.4	43.5	76.9	79.2	73.3	2.1	3	17.6
<u>BRAYDEN SCHENN</u>	L	19	52.5	971	0.887	8.4	47.7	60.7	60.9	65.2	50	2	2	40
<u>ANDERS LEE</u>	L	82	54.1	1006	0.911	9.5	51.3	35.9	57.5	56.7	61.5	2	7	30.4
<u>ANTHONY DUCLAIR</u>	L	62	55.4	1032	0.936	9.6	44	26.4	64.3	70	50	2	6	40
<u>SIMON HOLMSTROM</u>	R	79	49.3	1012	0.907	10.5	49.6	28.5	64.1	67.3	57.1	1.9	9	40.9
<u>JG PAGEAU</u>	C	74	44.8	1004	0.909	9.5	46.5	7.6	72.9	75	100	1.8	8	44.4
<u>MAX SHABANOV</u>	L	44	48.5	1011	0.9	11.1	45	32.9	56.3	52	71.4	1.8	5	38.5
<u>MATTHEW SCHAEFER</u>	D	82	52.3	1009	0.914	9.5	50.5	67.7	48	44.6	62.1	1.7	19	52.8
<u>TONY DEANGELO</u>	D	76	56.2	987	0.907	8	52.3	32.3	52.2	48.3	77.8	1.4	12	40
<u>EMIL HEINEMAN</u>	R	82	52.7	978	0.91	6.8	50.1	35.4	51.7	60	26.7	1.4	6	66.7
<u>CASEY CIZIKAS</u>	C	81	46.9	975	0.907	6.8	48.7	0.9	64.3	68	0	1.1	0	0
<u>RYAN PULOCK</u>	D	76	48.4	1016	0.922	9.4	46.9	2.7	41.5	42.4	100	1	13	54.2
<u>ONDREJ PALAT</u>	L	29	49	970	0.884	8.6	49.1	14.8	31.9	31.7	33.3	0.8	2	50

- Barzal's 2.6 Pts/60 wouldn't have cracked the top three on most other teams, yet he led the Islanders. On a positive note, seven different players reached 2.0 Pts/60—and Schaefer wasn't one of them.
- Holmstrom and Shabanov were the only regulars with a 5-on-5 shooting percentage above the NHL average, and even then, only slightly. On the other end, Ritchie and Heineman are two key names who posted extremely low 5-on-5 shooting percentages and should see a correction in their even-strength production. With Heineman, this shouldn't be surprising: he had 22 goals and just nine assists. It's hard to rack up assists when your teammates shoot 6.8% while you're on the ice.
- How solid was Sorokin? The only players with a 5-on-5 save percentage below 0.900 were the two who joined the team late in the season (this stat covers the full year).
- Top power-play unit: Barzal, Horvat, Palmieri (when healthy), Schenn, and Schaefer. The second unit was a rotating cast of Lee, Ritchie, Duclair, Holmstrom, Shabanov, DeAngelo, and Heineman.
- By the end of the season, Ritchie was on the top unit—and he was very effective on the power play. Shabanov was as well (71.4% PP IPP). DeAngelo played a major role on the second unit.
- Heineman was by far the weakest contributor on the power play, posting a 26.7 PP IPP.
- Horvat had a 61.5% secondary-assist rate, which is quite high—easily a career best. In practice, this would only cost him two or three assists in a typical season. Heineman was at 66.7%, but given he had only nine assists total, it's not really an issue.

Key departures	Anders Lee (UTA), Carson Soucy (UFA), Adam Boqvist (UFA), David Rittich (NJD)
Arrivals	Matias Maccelli (TOR), Matthew Kessel (STL), Vitek Vanecek (UTA)

New York RANGERS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Gabe Perreault	79	20	52	24	Mika Zibanejad	83	27	74	23	A Lafreniere	84	34	72	33
Eeli Tolvanen	82	21	43	26	J.T. Miller	76	25	70	50	P Dorofeyev	83	33	64	26
Will Cuyll	84	19	41	67	Noah Laba	76	10	26	38	O Bjorkstrand	82	17	40	16
Taylor Raddysh	70	9	21	16	Joe Veleno	70	6	11	20	Tye Kartye	76	11	29	44
Matt Rempe	30	2	4	53	Juuso Parssinen	21	3	4	8	Jaroslav Chmelar	30	3	6	4
Adam Sykora	45	8	18	14										
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Vladislav Gavrikov	82	8	31	36	Adam Fox	73	13	67	32	Igor Shesterkin	59	30	2	2.60
Marcus Pettersson	83	4	21	51	Sean Durzi	69	7	33	55	Joonas Korpisalo	21	8	1	3.00
Urho Vaakanainen	53	1	10	20	Braden Schneider	83	5	20	20	Dylan Garand	8	4	0	2.75
Matthew Robertson	75	6	18	34	Scott Morrow	42	4	16	29					
Drew Fortescue	11	0	2	6	Vincent Iorio	24	0	3	6					

Restricted Free Agents: Iorio

Camp battle: Garand had the backup job handed to him. And then he suddenly didn't. The Rangers acquired Korpisalo despite the fact that Garand has been dominant in the AHL and exceptional in three games with the Rangers last year. He is also 24, a prime age for a goalie to graduate. Oh, and he is no longer exempt from waivers—he'll never clear them; he'll for sure get claimed. How he does in camp will determine if the Rangers risk losing him on waivers or roll with three goalies. If they go with the latter option, it is likely that if Garand does well over the first couple of months, they'll make a move with Korpisalo.

Future fantasy stud: Perreault brings the team a mix of skill and youth that the organization desperately lacks. He has star-power upside and is already tracking for a first-line role. He just needed a quarter of a season to show he's already beyond the AHL.

- Kartye is an interesting case. He made a big splash in Seattle; his tenacity and energy forced his way onto the team and he showed offensive potential. He fell out of favor and started getting scratched last season before being traded to NYR. His ice time increased to 14 minutes and he had 14 points, 17 PIM, and 75 Hits in 24 games. He's not getting PP time, so there is a cap on his ceiling, but he's a potential multi-cat stud.

- By midseason, many of the final Lafreniere holdouts had given up. Not me. And the Artemi Panarin trade was exactly what he needed. His TOI shot up to 18:43 (from 17), his PP time shot up to 3:21 (from two minutes). He had 25 points in 26 games, including nine PPTs, and has become the go-to star we had been waiting for five years. Do not sleep on Lafreniere.

- Another sleeper pick is Miller. Coming off his least productive season since he was with Tampa Bay in 2019, coupled with the fact that he is 33, has most poolies thinking he's done. Not so. He suffered a groin injury in training camp last year and missed most of camp as a result. He played through the pain early on until an upper-body injury in December forced him out of the lineup. That UBI turned out to be a blessing because it allowed him to properly rest his groin. From January 14 onward, Miller had 29 points in 30 games, which is much more in line with a player of his caliber seeing a gradual aging decline. He is most certainly not a 53-point player.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Adam Fox	90	72	Dylan Garand	60%	
Alexis Lafreniere	85	70	Scott Morrow	50%	
J.T. Miller	90	68	Cole Beaudoin	40%	
Pavel Dorofeyev	75	68	Liam Greentree	35%	
Mika Zibanejad	75	67	Vincent Iorio	35%	
Gabe Perreault	82	60	Adam Sykora	25%	
Liam Greentree	83	52	Drew Fortescue	15%	
Will Cuyll	67	48	Alberts Smits	15%	
Tomas Chrenko	77	48	Jaroslav Chmelar	10%	
Sean Durzi	58	47			
Alberts Smits	60	43			
Scott Morrow	53	40	Sleeper	Pts	%
Oliver Bjorkstrand	65	38	Alexis Lafreniere	80	15%
Cole Beaudoin	65	38	Gabe Perreault	65	15%
Juuso Parssinen	62	35	Eeli Tolvanen	50	10%
Noah Laba	60	35	Sean Durzi	45	10%
Malcolm Spence	67	35	Tye Kartye	42	10%
Jacob Battaglia	65	35			
Adam Sykora	60	33			

- It's become an annual tradition for Zibanejad to have a slow start. You could set your watch to it. A good strategy would be to not draft him and then make inquiries in late November, see if you can pry him loose for a younger player on a 65-point pace. Last season, Zibanejad had 64 points in his last 59 games.

- In the 27 games that Fox missed, Gavrikov (his D partner) had 10 points and Robertson had nine—no other team defenseman had even seven points. Morrow was given a shot at helping, since 24 of his 29 games played were without Fox in the lineup, but he only contributed five points.

- Durzi returned from a lengthy absence in late November and took a few games to get rolling. But in the end, despite secondary PP time, he had 25 points in his last 50 games with Utah. Now if Fox gets hurt, they have Durzi as a nice fallback.

Injuries:

Rempe underwent a procedure on his thumb in February and didn't return. Assume that he should be ready for training camp. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Fox, Durzi, Miller, Kartye.

Breakout Threshold:

Schneider is 6-3, just making the BT cutoff for 400 games. He's played 368. That being said, he's being used primarily for defense, and a breakout for him would be just 27 points. Kartye doesn't get any PP time, which puts a cap on any kind of breakout. But he's played 204 career games, and a breakout for him would exceed 35 points. Couple that with his potential for Hits and he offers potential in some leagues.

Goalies:

Like their cross-town rivals on Long Island, the Rangers have a clear starter. Shesterkin is one of the league's most talented goalies, but wins might be harder to come by with the Rangers potentially heading toward a rebuild. That might mean Shesterkin is not one of the first five goalies chosen in fantasy drafts this coming season. Korpisalo could be okay as a backup, but his addition means the Rangers are now spending \$14.5 million on goalies. Garand will push for the backup role, but the fact that the Rangers traded for Korpisalo might mean they don't trust Garand yet, if at all. In the event of a Shesterkin injury, Korpisalo hasn't been reliable enough to be counted on as a true No. 1, so that could be Garand's opportunity. The Rangers also have veteran Spencer Martin in the system.

Dobber's confidence that Shesterkin is the starter: 100%

Contract Year:

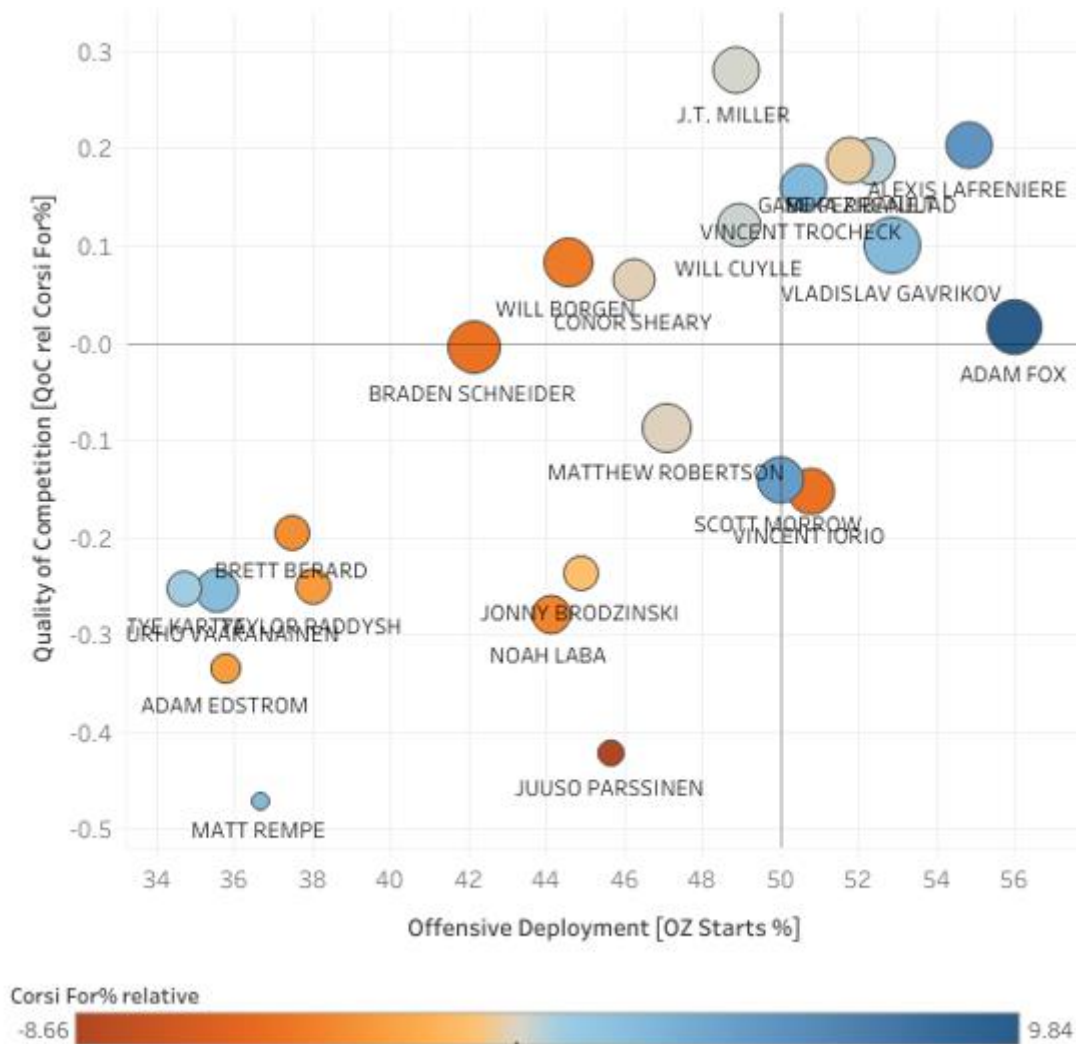
The Rangers are in a retool, which means that Cuyllé and Perreault have a chance to emerge in the top six and become an important part of this club's future... If the Rangers become sellers again this season, Bjorkstrand seems like a perfect trade piece. Signed to a one-year contract, Bjorkstrand could provide a nice return of futures given his ability to contribute on the power play... Veleno is on a one-year make-or-break contract with the Rangers. This will be an important season for his NHL future.

2027 RFA: Cuyllé, Kartye, Rempe, Laba, Chmelar, Perreault, Schneider

2027 UFA: Bjorkstrand, Raddysh, Veleno, Vaakanainen, Robertson

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Alexis Lafreniere		
Boom or bust	Tye Kartye		
Multicategory / Banger	Will Cuyllé		
Salary cap bargain	Gabe Perreault		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adam Fox	102	37	131
Adam Sykora	37	74	63
Alexis Lafreniere	42	94	218
Braden Schneider	143	163	108
Eeli Tolvanen	82	217	149
Gabe Perreault	40	44	134
J.T. Miller	42	151	182
Joe Veleno	36	172	70
Marcus Pettersson	132	87	74
Matthew Robertson	75	122	90
Mika Zibanejad	52	68	208
Noah Laba	49	125	91
Oliver Bjorkstrand	33	77	156
Pavel Dorofeyev	34	28	249
Scott Morrow	44	17	50
Sean Durzi	97	46	104
Taylor Raddysh	42	51	63
Tye Kartye	44	215	84
Vladislav Gavrikov	107	49	115
Will Cuyllé	67	301	167

Dobber Advanced... RANGERS



Observation: Vincent Trocheck (now with Utah), Lafreniere, Perreault, and Zibanejad occupied the high-leverage, offensive-leaning quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: Lafreniere received the highest percentage of offensive-zone starts and has become *the man* for the Rangers now that Artemi Panarin (LAK) is out of the picture. This suggests Lafreniere is a strong bet for a career year and may finally become the player many expected five years ago. This also indicates, along with Perreault, that his future lies firmly in the top six—and that he hasn’t needed sheltered deployment, which is an excellent sign for his long-term success.

Observation: Cuyllle and Miller served as the shutdown forwards against tough competition. Miller, in particular, faced the highest Quality of Competition.

Fantasy Impact: Miller is the forward they lean on, and this usage will cap his ceiling. He’ll produce, but not at the level he would with more offensive deployment. Cuyllle is in a similar situation, though he isn’t yet facing the toughest lines. As he gains experience, that shift appears likely.

Observation: Rempe, Edstrom, Kartye, Raddysh, and Berard were relegated to the low-usage, low Quality-of-Competition zone.

Fantasy Impact: These players were used in a “maintenance” or “energy” capacity. The coaching staff kept them away from tough competition but also away from offensive opportunity. Rempe, in particular, remained a specialized Hits/PIM asset with no sustainable path to meaningful offensive production. Kartye has potential as a shutdown forward if he eventually faces tougher competition.

Observation: Fox occupied the extreme right, handling moderate competition with heavy offensive deployment. He led the team in relative CF%.

Fantasy Impact: Fox continued to be the Rangers’ primary offensive catalyst on the blue line. His usage—high

Observation: Morrow, Robertson, and Iorio handled middle-tier competition with slightly sheltered deployment.
Fantasy Impact: Of the three, only Morrow carries fantasy upside. He received sheltered usage but didn't need it, driving possession effectively. This bodes well for his NHL trajectory and suggests he could soon become the secondary offensive puck-moving defenseman behind Fox.



Rangers by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>MIKA ZIBANEJAD</u>	C	81	52.3	1001	0.909	9.2	49	76.3	70.9	69.4	77.8	2.8	15	34.1
<u>TYE KARTYE</u>	L	24	34.7	998	0.889	10.9	47.9	1.4	73.3	73.3	0	2.5	3	33.3
<u>ADAM FOX</u>	D	55	56	1018	0.92	9.8	54.7	79.4	58.9	50.9	70.6	2.4	27	61.4
<u>ALEXIS LAFRENIERE</u>	R	82	54.8	1014	0.911	10.3	52.1	55.8	58.8	65.6	45.5	2.4	15	45.5
<u>J.T. MILLER</u>	C	68	48.8	967	0.882	8.5	49.4	71.2	67.1	67.3	65.5	2.3	19	52.8
<u>VINCENT TROCHECK</u>	C	67	50.5	1021	0.904	11.7	49.4	71.8	56.4	69.8	41	2.3	18	48.6
<u>GABE PERREAULT</u>	L	49	51.7	1017	0.917	10	47.6	29.9	62.8	65.6	54.5	2.1	4	26.7
<u>JONNY BRODZINSKI</u>	R	55	44.8	1004	0.925	7.9	47.4	15	80	77.8	100	1.6	5	50
<u>WILL CUYLLE</u>	L	82	48.9	1012	0.918	9.4	48.8	33.7	63.3	63.8	66.7	1.6	3	16.7
<u>TAYLOR RADDYSH</u>	L	68	38	1029	0.938	9.1	46.6	9.3	65.5	72	50	1.4	3	30
<u>NOAH LABA</u>	C	74	44.1	1026	0.931	9.5	45.9	13	68.6	63.3	100	1.4	8	53.3
<u>CONOR SHEARY</u>	R	62	46.2	1005	0.928	7.7	49.4	20.6	58.1	66.7	40	1.2	6	54.5
<u>VLADISLAV GAVRIKOV</u>	D	82	52.9	996	0.914	8.2	49.5	23.6	43.8	43.1	54.5	1.1	12	57.1
<u>JUUSO PARSSINEN</u>	C	20	45.6	1103	0.963	14	42.3	0	42.9	42.9	0	1	1	100
<u>M ROBERTSON</u>	D	72	47.1	1002	0.904	9.8	48.8	1.4	37.5	38.3	0	0.9	7	58.3
<u>SCOTT MORROW</u>	D	29	50	977	0.913	6.4	50.9	32.6	35.3	30.8	50	0.8	3	50

- Interesting to note that, despite the defensive-zone starts, Kartye was the second-most productive Ranger after being acquired (24 games with the team). We've seen flashes like this from him before, so it's best to wait and see if it continues before pouncing.
- Lafreniere was tied for fourth on the team in Pts/60, but keep in mind he didn't truly take off until the Panarin trade.
- Trocheck and Kartye were the only regular Rangers with a high 5-on-5 shooting percentage. It's the second straight season in which this stat has been high for Trocheck, and given his age (33) and his low PP IPP, there should be concern that his career decline is approaching. That thought likely played a role in his trade to Utah!
- Miller, Conor Sheary (now with Buffalo), and Morrow are the key names to focus on for a positive market correction, as their 5-on-5 shooting percentages were too low. For Miller, it was his second-lowest result in the last 12 years.
- The top power-play unit was Zibanejad, Fox, Lafreniere, Miller, and Trocheck. Lafreniere only joined after the Panarin trade. Notably, in the first three quarters of the season, Lafreniere had six PPPTs (61 games). In the final quarter alone, on the top unit, he had nine PPPTs (21 games). His PP IPP was trending upward and should continue to do so.
- The other weak link on the chart regarding the first PP unit was Trocheck at 41%. Now that Trocheck is gone (UTA), the spot is almost certainly Perreault's
- Cuyllé's 5-on-5 shooting percentage was slightly low, but the stronger indicator of upcoming improvement is his assist profile: 15 primary assists and just three secondary assists. That's nine fewer secondary assists than the season prior. Adding nine points to his total would have put him at a respectable 47 points in 2025-26.

Key departures	Vincent Trocheck (UTA), Adam Edstrom (NSH), William Borgen (BOS), Jonny Brodzinski (WSH), Jonathan Quick (Retired)
Arrivals	Pavel Dorofeyev (VGK), Oliver Bjorkstrand (TB), Cole Beaudoin (UTA), Joe Veleno (MTL), Marcus Pettersson (VAN), Sean Durzi (UTA), Joonas Korpisalo (BOS)

Ottawa SENATORS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
William Eklund	80	18	57	31	Tim Stutzle	81	30	87	39	Drake Batherson	83	31	78	36
Andre Burakovsky	77	10	33	16	Dylan Cozens	83	25	61	58	Claude Giroux	84	16	46	23
Warren Foegele	79	18	30	30	Shane Pinto	70	20	46	31	Fabian Zetterlund	84	19	32	21
Ridly Greig	78	14	39	72	Stephen Halliday	67	8	27	18	Michael Amadio	77	13	33	18
Nick Cousins	72	8	19	71	Xavier Bourgault	18	1	3	0	Kasper Halttunen	8	1	1	2
Sammy Blais	39	3	13	14						Philip Tomasino	39	4	10	12
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Jake Sanderson	78	13	61	14	Artem Zub	71	4	28	42	Linus Ullmark	52	31	3	2.70
Thomas Chabot	65	8	34	24	Jordan Spence	77	8	35	17	Samuel Ersson	30	13	1	3.05
Tyler Kleven	76	3	14	53	Carter Yakemchuk	69	12	40	28	Leevi Merilainen	6	2	0	3.15
Jorian Donovan	8	0	1	0	Nikolas Matinpalo	59	0	6	22					

Restricted Free Agents: none

Camp Battle: With Sanderson locking up the top PP QB role, it's the second unit that's up for grabs. And there are three great candidates. Chabot is the experienced and proven vet, but Spence keeps knocking down every obstacle put in front of him and he just signed a four-year, \$20M contract. And then there's Yakemchuk, the "Next One" who dominated junior hockey and then waltzed into the AHL and dominated that league, too. And then he got two points in four games with Ottawa. Welcome to pro hockey, Carter. This is something that won't be settled in camp, but there will be some jockeying and it will be interesting to look at things come January.

Future Fantasy Stud: Eklund has already proven to be a fantasy asset, but he has another gear. If he finds chemistry with Stutzle and stays on that line, he'll find that gear. It will mean a big step this year, and a bigger one next. He's looking like an underrated investment for dynasty owners.

- Ullmark left the team last season for personal issues. He returned, but note that the team has made a few moves that, intended or not, should make him feel at home. They brought in fellow Swede Ersson to be his backup, and another countryman in Eklund. They need his head in the right place, because when he's on, he is a top goaltender in the league.

- After a career season in Edmonton (41 points), Foegele topped that in 2024-25 in Los Angeles with 46 points. The trajectory was steadily upward. But then he had some struggles with his shoulder that cost him some time, and he likely played through much of it. His production declined and so did his ice time. The trade to Ottawa helped a bit, but nowhere near expected. Count on a bit of a rebound with a full summer to recover. But not too much—he's more of a waiver pickup.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Tim Stutzle	108	90	Carter Yakemchuk	95%		
Drake Batherson	87	75	Stephen Halliday	60%		
William Eklund	82	70	Leevi Merilainen	45%		
Dylan Cozens	83	65	Kasper Halttunen	40%		
Jake Sanderson	75	65	Xavier Bourgault	35%		
Shane Pinto	70	52	Jorian Donovan	20%		
J Lagerberg Hoen	73	50				
Blake Vanek	67	50				
Adam Nemec	68	50				
Carter Yakemchuk	65	48				
Jaxon Cover	70	48				
Oskar Holmertz	72	48	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Thomas Chabot	63	45	William Eklund	70	20%	
Ridly Greig	65	45	Carter Yakemchuk	50	10%	
Kasper Halttunen	67	45	Jordan Spence	50	10%	
Andre Burakovsky	62	43				
Jordan Spence	60	42				
Xavier Bourgault	65	40				
Stephen Halliday	68	38				

- Sanderson, still only 24, is still on the rise. He did have an injury that sidelined him for most of March, but nonetheless he finished the season with 28 points in his last 30 games.

- More on Spence: For some reason, Coach Travis Green kept scratching him early in the season. And every time he got back into the lineup, he got points. Scratched the first two games, returned and posted four points in four games. Scratched again for five games, then he returned for a game and got an assist. Scratched again for two games, and two games into his return he scored and added an assist. At this point, he had seven points in seven games and had been

scratched nine times. Injuries started hitting, with key defensemen Chabot and Sanderson going down at different times, and Spence just kept doing his thing. His xG numbers were an amazing 62.5 at even strength, his possession metrics were excellent, and he managed 31 points despite minimal PP time and all those early scratches. That big new contract was well deserved. And with that in his back pocket, the healthy scratches are a thing of the past.

- Batherson had a drop in his numbers in the second half, only partially explained by a weird TOI drop. He had 38 points in 37 games to start, and then 33 in 42 to finish. His second-quarter TOI was 18:48, then 16:53 in the third quarter, and finally 16:11. In that final quarter, he did have 10 PPPts, but just seven ES points.

- Not sure why the Senators took Burakovsky off Chicago's hands. Fans really didn't like him, and for good reason. Despite playing with Connor Bedard, he managed just 33 points. His metrics weren't horrible, nor were they good. But with a career-high 61.9% OZ%, they should have been much better. And on a team that didn't have many offensive-zone starts to give, that was hard for the fans to swallow. Now 31, it's hard to imagine that Burakovsky is anything but on the decline.

Injuries:

Greig will be suspended for the first two games of the regular season for an incident during the playoff series against Carolina... As of April, Zub (lower body) was still a month away from being fully fit... Sanderson suffered a concussion during a playoff game in late April. He should be ready for camp unless the symptoms persist. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Pinto, Chabot.

Breakout Threshold:

At 6-3, Cozens fits into our "exceptional size" category and he has played 444 career games. He did have a 68-point season several years ago, so a breakout for him would be 85 points. Possible, but seems unlikely.

Goalies:

Ullmark will try to put last year's drama behind him while the Senators focus on life after Brady Tkachuk (now with Florida). At least Ullmark should have very little competition for the starting job. The Sens traded for Ersson, who will try to rebound after a below-average season in Philadelphia. Ersson has handled a heavy workload before, so he seems like the potential starter should Ullmark be injured. After a brief run of success in 2024-25 as a minor-league call-up, Merilainen didn't prove to be the answer as the backup to Ullmark, with the Sens having to sign veteran James Reimer as a midseason stopgap. Merilainen could be back in the AHL, but he will need to clear waivers. In terms of cap hit, Ersson earns double (\$2.2 million) what Merilainen earns (\$1.1 million). **Dobber's confidence that Ullmark is the starter: 100%**

Contract Year:

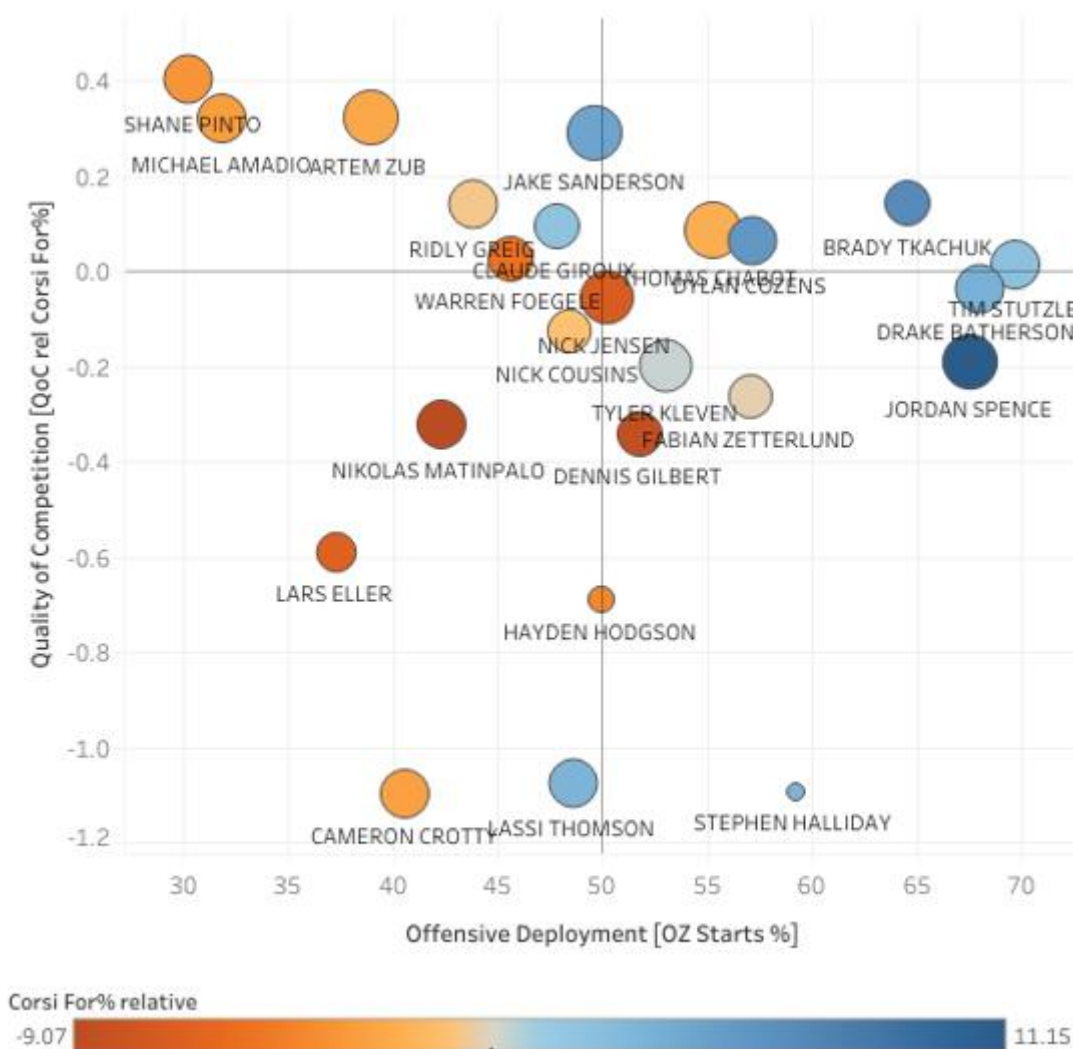
Merilainen will be an arbitration-eligible RFA. He will need to make the most of his opportunity as the likely third-string goalie... Even with the Senators possibly taking a step back by dealing Tkachuk, Batherson is still a core top-six piece and seems likely to be re-signed. But if not, he will generate interest... Now 38, Giroux has shown loyalty to his teams throughout his career. But if the Sens are not in the playoff race, perhaps he is asked to waive his no-movement clause.

2027 RFA: Kleven, Merilainen

2027 UFA: Burakovsky, Batherson, Foegele, Amadio, Giroux, Zub, Matinpalo

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	William Eklund		
Boom or bust	Andre Burakovsky		
Multicategory / Banger	Dylan Cozens		
Salary cap bargain	Carter Yakemchuk		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Andre Burakovsky	27	19	100
Artem Zub	111	64	78
Carter Yakemchuk	76	35	117
Claude Giroux	25	59	134
Drake Batherson	29	125	191
Dylan Cozens	29	208	199
Fabian Zetterlund	42	151	143
Jake Sanderson	154	37	179
Jordan Spence	69	64	123
Michael Amadio	50	108	85
Nick Cousins	36	135	72
Nikolas Matinpalo	65	48	53
Ridly Greig	50	109	140
Shane Pinto	53	102	161
Stephen Halliday	20	74	87
Thomas Chabot	118	44	129
Tim Stutzle	45	122	194
Tyler Kleven	106	129	99
Warren Foegele	28	86	143
William Eklund	48	81	193

Dobber Advanced... SENATORS



Observation: Tkachuk (FLA), Stutzle, Batherson, and Giroux occupied the high-leverage, offensive-leaning half. They drove possession but were not specifically focused on either weak or strong competition.

Fantasy Impact: These are the primary engines of the Senators' offense. Tkachuk and Stutzle were clearly *the guys*—they received the highest volume of offensive-zone starts against both quality and weaker competition, solidifying them as must-start fantasy cornerstones. Their ability to maintain this deployment without needing shelter confirmed the core of the team was built around, and their fantasy output should remain elite and consistent.

Observation: Pinto and Amadio served as the shutdown forwards against tough competition. Both faced significant Quality of Competition. Although their bubbles were orange, the shade wasn't overly dark considering the difficulty of their minutes.

Fantasy Impact: Pinto and Amadio are the forwards the coaching staff leans on for defensive accountability. This usage inevitably suppresses their offensive ceilings compared to the top-six core. They will get their points, but they are being used as structural anchors rather than primary scorers, which limits their upside in points-heavy formats. Greig is in a similar situation, acting as a defensive stabilizer, but his relative inexperience is likely why he's being eased into the role.

Observation: The depth group (Eller, Cousins, and similar energy-line players) were relegated to the low-usage, low-Quality-of-Competition zone.

Fantasy Impact: These players were used in a "maintenance" or "energy" capacity. The coaching staff kept them away from tough competition but also away from offensive opportunity. They are specialized assets—potentially useful for Hits or PIM in deep leagues, but they have no sustainable path to meaningful offensive production in this deployment model.

Observation: Sanderson and Chabot leaned toward the right side, handling moderate (Chabot) to high (Sanderson) competition. Chabot received heavy offensive deployment, while Sanderson was used in a two-way role. Considering his

usage, Sanderson's possession numbers were excellent.

Fantasy Impact: These two are clearly the Senators' primary offensive catalysts on the blue line. Their usage was designed to maximize transition and playmaking, though Sanderson was also deployed in shutdown situations and often sent out against opposing top lines. They remain fantasy locks, functioning as the primary engines for the power play and transition game.

Observation: Zub sat firmly on the defensive side of the chart, with high Quality of Competition.

Fantasy Impact: Zub is a classic shutdown defenseman who draws assignments against strong competition. His orange bubble is expected given his defensive-first usage. This deployment stifles his offensive upside; he is a valuable real-hockey asset who likely won't move the needle for fantasy managers needing points.

Observation: Spence led the team by a wide margin in relative possession.

Fantasy Impact: Spence continues to be underrated and underused, consistently stuck behind the "Golden Boys" who are already established as elite. He was sheltered—given extreme offensive-zone starts and subpar Quality of Competition—but he can clearly handle more. If he ever lands on a team without an elite power-play quarterback already in place, he would be one to watch.

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Senators by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>BRADY TKACHUK</u>	L	60	64.6	967	0.884	8.3	57	61.7	72.8	83	60.6	3.5	11	29.7
<u>DRAKE BATHERSON</u>	R	79	67.9	973	0.88	9.3	55.4	60.5	73.2	80.4	65.2	3.1	18	47.4
<u>TIM STUTZLE</u>	C	80	69.7	994	0.878	11.6	53.8	65.1	68	75	61.7	3.1	23	46.9
<u>STEPHEN HALLIDAY</u>	C	30	59.2	996	0.91	8.6	57.1	33.6	68.8	88.9	42.9	2.6	2	28.6
<u>DYLAN COZENS</u>	C	82	57.1	972	0.89	8.2	56.5	59.9	62.8	63.8	61.7	2.5	17	54.8
<u>CLAUDE GIROUX</u>	R	82	47.8	1008	0.9	10.8	54	41.1	55.7	56.3	56.5	2.2	14	40
<u>WARREN FOEGELE</u>	L	21	45.6	1009	0.935	7.4	48.6	23.4	51.5	57.1	25	2	2	100
<u>SHANE PINTO</u>	C	72	30.3	989	0.883	10.6	49.7	34.7	63.9	70.9	38.5	2	7	30.4
<u>FABIAN ZETTERLUND</u>	R	82	57	988	0.887	10.1	51.8	22	60	55.6	80	1.9	6	37.5
<u>JAKE SANDERSON</u>	D	67	49.6	997	0.902	9.5	55.2	62.4	47.8	47.1	52.4	1.9	23	57.5
<u>MICHAEL AMADIO</u>	R	81	31.9	989	0.889	10	50.5	1.6	55.6	56.7	0	1.6	7	35
<u>RIDLY GREIG</u>	L	77	43.8	993	0.891	10.2	52.4	18.8	50	54.2	37.5	1.6	10	45.5
<u>NICK COUSINS</u>	L	81	48.4	1005	0.913	9.2	51.3	1	63.9	63.9	0	1.5	8	57.1
<u>THOMAS CHABOT</u>	D	57	55.2	992	0.862	13	51.9	42.6	38.8	34.8	58.3	1.4	10	41.7
<u>JORDAN SPENCE</u>	D	73	67.5	992	0.9	9.2	59.8	24.2	46.3	45.9	50	1.4	16	66.7
<u>LARS ELLER</u>	C	68	37.3	1023	0.916	10.7	46.9	9.3	46.9	51.7	0	1.2	3	30

- The loss of Tkachuk will hurt. He led the Senators in Pts/60 by a fairly wide margin. Of course, he brought more to the game than just points, but his production has been star-level.
- Of interest, though, is the production from Halliday despite limited ice time over his 30 games. He has earned an NHL roster spot and clearly has some potential, given that his Pts/60 ranked fourth on the team.
- Stutzle, Giroux, and Chabot had high 5-on-5 shooting percentages. Stutzle gets a pass because he's a star who will naturally post strong numbers playing with the team's best. Chabot's number is far too high, though. He has been steady around the 0.55 points-per-game mark, so despite his 13.0% 5-on-5 shooting percentage, he should be fine. At 29, he's too young to be entering a decline.
- On the lower end of the 5-on-5 shooting-percentage spectrum, Foegele (who came over from the Kings) and Cozens stand out as candidates to increase their even-strength production this season due to better bounces.
- The top power-play unit was ironclad: Tkachuk, Batherson, Stutzle, and Sanderson. All four contributed at similar PP IPP levels, though Sanderson was slightly lower and the weakest link. The fact that nobody dominated with 70%+ PP IPP suggests Sanderson was fine.
- On the second power-play unit, both Foegele and Pinto were less effective than their teammates. They are the two most at risk of losing PPTOI.

Key departures	Brady Tkachuk (FLA), Lars Eller (FLA), Nick Jensen (ANA), James Reimer (UFA)
Arrivals	William Eklund (SJS), Andre Burakovsky (CHI), Samuel Ersson (PHI)

Philadelphia FLYERS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Trevor Zegras	71	25	64	57	Christian Dvorak	79	17	50	22	Travis Konecny	80	27	70	61
Matvei Michkov	83	23	68	54	Sean Couturier	79	12	31	34	Porter Martone	81	26	62	51
Tyson Foerster	74	25	46	41	Noah Cates	75	16	39	20	Owen Tippett	81	27	50	21
Alex Bump	65	12	34	20	Noel Acciari	69	8	15	18	Denver Barkey	73	9	35	27
Nikita Grebenkin	50	2	13	26	Jett Luchanko	6	0	1	2	Carl Grundstrom	53	7	12	19
										Zachary Aston-Reese	38	1	6	14
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Travis Sanheim	83	10	34	37	Rasmus Ristolainen	61	2	17	24	Daniel Vldar	52	29	1	2.65
Cam York	76	6	29	34	Jamie Drysdale	74	9	36	26	Joseph Woll	37	14	1	2.95
Nick Seeler	78	3	11	52	David Jiricek	53	2	10	29	Aleksei Kolosov	3	1	0	3.00
Simon Benoit	74	1	7	53	Oliver Bonk	42	3	6	17					
Ty Murchison	6	0	1	3	Hunter McDonald	3	0	1	4					

Restricted Free Agents: Grebenkin

What to look for in camp: Zegras keeps getting tried at center, but he can't win faceoffs and is then moved to the wing. If he's on the wing, Dvorak is his center and the other wings get knocked down a notch. But if he's at center, the wingers move up. Foerster, for example, gets into the top six. Bump gets into the top nine (or Barkey). Watch where Zegras plays, as it will have a domino effect.

On the hot seat: Drysdale has played 295 games now. The Flyers gave up Cutter Gauthier to acquire him, and the best Drysdale has done for them is 32 points. Now with a new contract, it's time to put up or shut up. Another 32-point season will have the Flyers finding another solution next summer, and Drysdale could be permanently pushed back to secondary PP duties.

- Reports had Michkov attending training camp out of shape in 2025, which caused a (very) slow start, seeing him follow up his 63-point rookie campaign with just nine points in the first 19 games. He finished the campaign with 18 points in the last 16 games, clicking with Barkey and Cates, plus seeing a small (20-second) uptick in PP time.

- Dvorak is a player every fantasy owner is curious about. His career high is 38 points and he gets hurt a lot. So how did he suddenly get 51? Dvorak, once upon a time, was a top high-scoring prospect. He had 109 and then 121 points for the OHL London Knights back in the day. He kept getting injured and was never able to develop that offense at the pro level. However, he became a very solid and valuable third-liner. The Flyers desperately need a center and he was put there by default because he can win draws and does have skill. The gamble worked. And if the Flyers don't get a legit top pivot, he could actually build on last year. Their failed attempt to land Leo Carlsson in the summer with an offer sheet shows that Dvorak's status on the top line is tenuous. But centers don't grow on trees, and odds are the Flyers won't find a replacement. If he can improve on last season and top 60, he'll hold value in future years even if he gets bumped to the second unit. Until then: tenuous, as the team will always be looking to upgrade there.

- Zegras's fantasy value tumbled for two years as he struggled to stay healthy in Anaheim. A new lease on life in Philadelphia brought him good health and good results. He stormed out of the gate with 39 points in 38 games. He

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Travis Konecny	90	80	Porter Martone	100%		
Matvei Michkov	105	75	Alex Bump	90%		
Trevor Zegras	87	72	Denver Barkey	90%		
Porter Martone	90	70	David Jiricek	70%		
Tyson Foerster	75	60	Oliver Bonk	50%		
Owen Tippett	73	58	Jett Luchanko	40%		
Denver Barkey	77	53	Ty Murchison	20%		
Jett Luchanko	70	53	Hunter McDonald	20%		
Jack Nesbitt	68	48				
Jamie Drysdale	68	47				
Alex Bump	70	42				
Noah Cates	57	42	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Sean Couturier	65	40	Matvei Michkov	80	20%	
Cam York	50	38	Trevor Zegras	80	20%	
Nikita Grebenkin	63	38	Porter Martone	70	20%	
Jack Berglund	70	37	Tyson Foerster	60	20%	
Travis Sanheim	50	35	Alex Bump	45	15%	
David Jiricek	47	32	Jamie Drysdale	50	10%	
Maksim Sokolovskii	40	30				

slowed after that as the magic with Dvorak and Konecny faded (just 11 points in 21 games). Things picked up again with new linemates Tippett and Foerster, as he finished with 17 in his last 20.

- Martone, profiled extensively in the Fantasy Prospects Report, only played nine regular-season games, but he still managed four PPPts. Everyone on that top unit benefits from him being out there.

- Foerster has been stuck the last couple of years on the third line with Bobby Brink (now with Minnesota) and Cates. But last season he did get PP time, sometimes on the first unit (Martone's arrival nixes that now). He has also seen improving points-per-game averages of 0.43, 0.53 and 0.59 the last three seasons. He'll be first man up if there's an injury (or if Zegras moves to center).

Injuries:

Grebenkin (upper body) may not be ready for the start of the season. His injury didn't seem serious at first, but it didn't improve. The Flyers were evaluating treatment options as of May... No other Flyers are in danger of missing the start of the season, according to GM Danny Briere... Tippett was dealing with several injuries during the playoffs, including a sports hernia. He is expected to be ready for training camp... Cates had a foot injury during the playoffs, but he didn't need a procedure on it after the season. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Woll, Ristolainen, Zegras, Grundstrom, Drysdale, Grebenkin, Aston-Reese.

Breakout Threshold:

Another reason to like Foerster is that he has played 195 career NHL games and is entering his BT season. Michkov has played 161 career games and will hit his BT around midseason. If he has another slow start, it might be a good idea to go after him in late November.

Goalies:

The Flyers might still be looking for a first-line center, but at least they know who their goalies will be. Vladar had a better-than-expected first season in Philadelphia, although it was his first season appearing in more than 30 games. So instead of showing complete faith in Vladar, the Flyers acquired Woll from Toronto. Woll has been a decent goalie for the most part, but he has had issues remaining healthy. It's possible that Woll could force a timeshare or even win the starting job outright, but Vladar is still the favorite because of last season's performance and Woll's injury history. In the end, this could be a reliable tandem... Kolosov should provide goaltending depth, but he needs more time in the AHL and seems unlikely to push either Vladar or Woll for starts if one is injured. **Dobber's confidence that Vladar is the starter: 90%**

Contract Year:

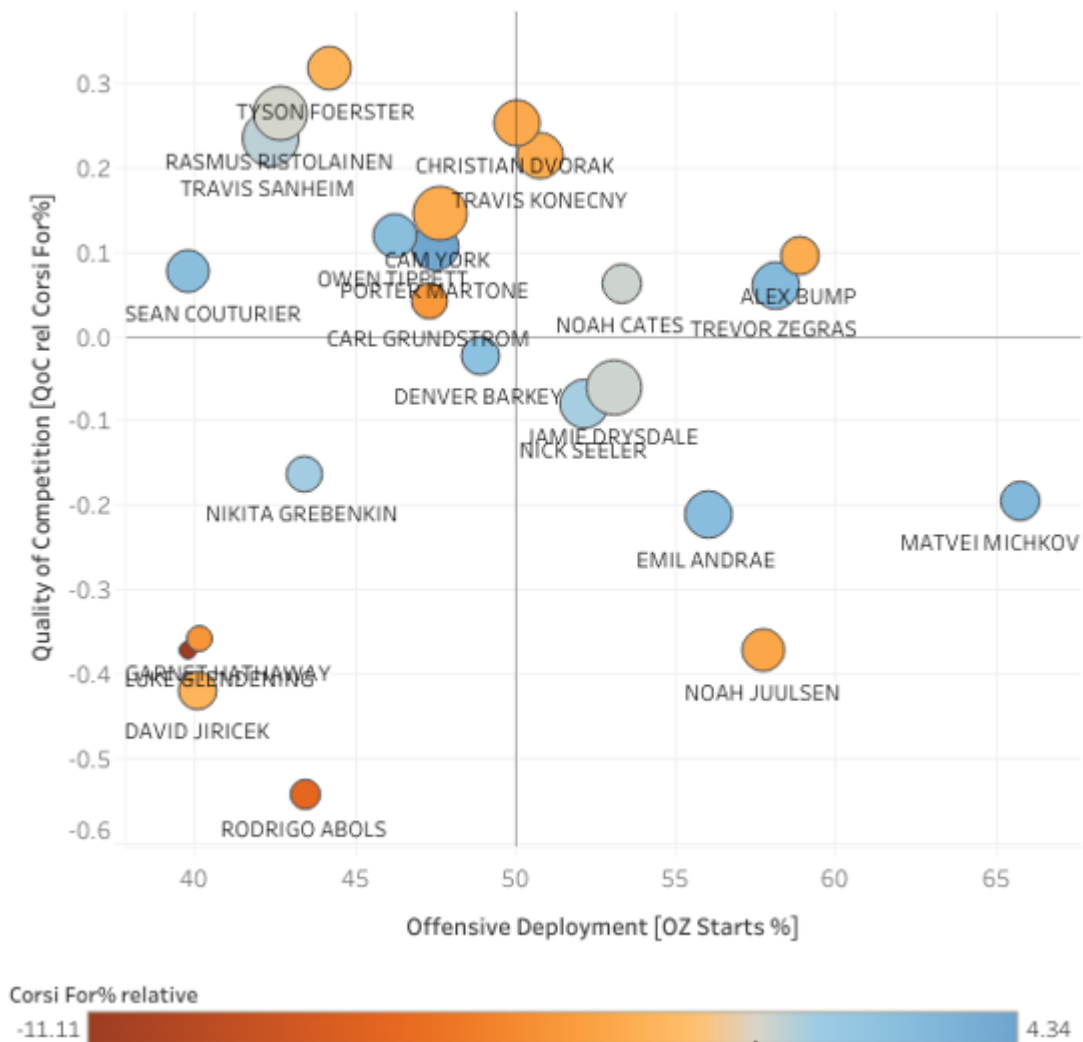
Grebenkin is dealing with an injury while waiting for his new contract... Michkov will be one to watch here. His production has been inconsistent while his usage has been subject to debate. His offseason training is expected to ramp up as he gets ready to complete the final year of his entry-level deal... If the Flyers are not a playoff team, Ristolainen's name will appear in trade rumors. Always an injury risk, the 31-year-old Ristolainen has something to prove as he hopes to extend his career.

2027 RFA: Michkov

2027 UFA: Grundstrom, Ristolainen, Benoit

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Matvei Michkov		
Boom or bust	Christian Dvorak		
Multicategory / Banger	Porter Martone		
Salary cap bargain	Porter Martone		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Alex Bump	27	67	98
Cam York	153	34	99
Carl Grundstrom	24	148	69
Christian Dvorak	55	36	142
David Jiricek	47	31	48
Denver Barkey	32	80	88
Jamie Drysdale	98	19	104
Matvei Michkov	25	37	190
Nick Seeler	133	117	86
Noah Cates	50	102	128
Noel Acciari	62	74	76
Owen Tippett	55	147	210
Porter Martone	20	142	227
Rasmus Ristolainen	85	61	79
Sean Couturier	40	72	126
Simon Benoit	112	206	59
Travis Konecny	40	100	185
Travis Sanheim	164	58	117
Trevor Zegras	28	39	156
Tyson Foerster	52	81	163

Dobber Advanced... FLYERS



Observation: Ristolainen, Sanheim, and Foerster were situated in the upper-left quadrant, where they faced the highest quality of competition while receiving minimal offensive-zone deployment.

Fantasy Impact: These players functioned as your primary defensive anchors. They were tasked with the hardest minutes, which suppressed their scoring ceiling, making them low-upside options in points-only leagues despite their real-world reliability. Foerster, who played just 29 games, has shown signs of being too valuable offensively and could force himself onto a different line. But this is how their usage looked last season.

Observation: Konecny and Dvorak were positioned near the center-right axis, where they faced high-quality competition but maintained neutral offensive-zone deployment.

Fantasy Impact: These were your most reliable, matchup-proof engines. Because they were trusted to drive offense even against the opposition's top lines, they lost relative possession. A true top-six two-way player would help relieve some of this pressure. Foerster, for example, may be groomed to become that player.

Observation: Tippett, York, and Martone were located in the middle-left quadrant, indicating they handled tougher-than-average defensive assignments with only moderate offensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: This group served as the secondary offense. With the Flyers, offensive-zone starts weren't as plentiful as on other teams, so players didn't receive as many OZ opportunities as they normally would. As a result, the bubbles for the second line and second pairing were stuck on the left side. A full season with Martone should have a positive effect on more than a few players.

Observation: Michkov, Bump, and Emil Andrae (now with Toronto) occupied the offensive-right quadrant, receiving high offensive-zone deployment while facing softer competition.

Fantasy Impact: This "sheltered" usage is typical for rookies—or, in Michkov's case, sophomores who still require rookie-level sheltering. Generally, when a rookie has low quality of competition in the offensive zone, the team believes

his long-term potential lies in offense. In Bump's case, seeing higher QofC indicates early trust and bodes well for him, even if his bubble was shaded orange. Andrae was technically not a rookie, but he was only 17 games above qualifying as one.

Observation: Cates, Drysdale, Seeler, and Barkey were clustered near the center axis, operating in a neutral zone where they were neither heavily targeted by top competition nor explicitly sheltered.

Fantasy Impact: Seeing Drysdale as one of the few players to the right of the axis is unsurprising, as he is being groomed as their go-to puck-moving defenseman. But seeing Cates receive that usage is surprising, given the stronger offensive weapons in the lineup. It would have been less surprising if Barkey and Cates had swapped bubble locations. This explained why Cates set a career high of 47 points. With Barkey, Foerster, and Martone each expected to produce more offense, you'll likely see Cates drift further left. More on Cates in the next section.

Observation: Hathaway, Glendening, Jiricek, Abols, Juulsen, Ginning, and Grebenkin were located in the low-usage zones, consistently receiving limited offensive opportunity.

Fantasy Impact: These players are effectively non-factors for offensive fantasy production. They should generally be excluded from your roster unless your league heavily weighs peripheral categories like Hits or penalty minutes. Grebenkin is showing the aptitude to potentially become a shutdown forward. The big surprise is Jiricek's bubble location—not because of the low QofC (he's a prospect, so that's expected), but because his offensive-zone starts were just 40%. However, 99% of his chart data comes from his Minnesota days, where the team had a heavily lopsided number of defensive-zone starts.

Flyers by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>TRAVIS KONECNY</u>	R	77	50.8	1032	0.919	11.3	46.5	57.4	73.9	75.7	70	2.8	17	41.5
<u>TREVOR ZEGRAS</u>	C	81	58.1	1015	0.9	11.5	49.2	61.4	68.4	64.7	76.7	2.7	14	34.1
<u>MATVEI MICHKOV</u>	R	81	65.7	1000	0.893	10.7	50.2	47	71.8	73.6	66.7	2.5	12	38.7
<u>ALEX BUMP</u>	L	17	58.8	1030	0.935	9.5	44.6	18.9	100	100	0	2.5	4	100
<u>OWEN TIPPETT</u>	L	81	46.2	988	0.888	10	48.9	45.6	68	77.2	50	2.2	11	47.8
<u>NOAH CATES</u>	C	82	53.3	1026	0.922	10.4	47.6	42.8	63.5	70.4	52.9	2.1	10	34.5
<u>CHRISTIAN DVORAK</u>	C	80	50	1026	0.906	12	45.8	34.5	60.7	62.5	45.5	2.1	10	30.3
<u>TYSON FOERSTER</u>	L	29	44.2	1066	0.942	12.4	46.3	50	54.8	65	36.4	2	2	50
<u>DENVER BARKEY</u>	C	43	48.8	971	0.876	9.5	48.9	33.1	63	59.1	80	1.8	2	16.7
<u>SEAN COUTURIER</u>	C	78	39.7	978	0.888	9	50	18.1	70.6	74.5	25	1.7	15	62.5
<u>CARL GRUNDSTROM</u>	L	47	47.3	1046	0.922	12.4	45.5	0.6	56.5	57.1	0	1.4	3	75
<u>RODRIGO ABOLS</u>	C	42	43.4	997	0.913	8.4	43	0.8	71.4	75	0	1.4	3	42.9
<u>NIKITA GREBENKIN</u>	L	55	43.4	975	0.892	8.3	47.2	3.9	70	70	0	1.4	4	40
<u>JAMIE DRYSDALE</u>	D	78	53.1	1009	0.912	9.7	47.7	47.1	39.5	35.4	56.3	1.1	18	75
<u>TRAVIS SANHEIM</u>	D	81	42.3	1006	0.896	11	48.4	22.6	38.5	38.6	33.3	1.1	13	50
<u>CAM YORK</u>	D	74	47.6	1006	0.896	11	47.1	33.3	31.7	29.2	53.8	0.9	11	50

- Nobody on the Flyers achieved a Pts/60 above 3.0. Martone did, but he only played nine games and didn't qualify for this chart. One has to believe that not only will he do it this season, but he'll also bring a couple of other players up with him. The Flyers are definitely on the upswing.
- Top-line players Konecny, Dvorak, and Zegras had high 5-on-5 shooting percentages, as did Michkov, Foerster, and Grundstrom. Of these players, Dvorak is the one I'd be concerned about. That said, as long as he remains a first line center, any decline shouldn't be significant. Foerster should see an even strength decline, but he didn't play many games and his own shooting percentage heavily influenced that 5-on-5 number. He shot 21.3%, which is an unsustainably high rate. However, he only had four assists in 29 games—and just three at even strength. To me, nothing in this stat suggests Foerster's points rate will decline (only his goals rate).
- On the low side, only Grebenkin stands out with his 8.3% 5-on-5 shooting percentage. It's not terribly low, and given his bubble's placement on the PUC chart, there isn't much room for his offense to improve.
- Coach Rick Tocchet didn't settle on a set power play unit outside of Konecny and Zegras. After those two, the remaining spots rotated—mostly between Michkov and Drysdale, but Tippet and Cates saw nearly as much time as Michkov. Drysdale led the defensemen in PPTOI, but Sanheim and York also saw their share; even Andrae received time.
- Barkey saw minutes on the second power play unit, but his PP IPP led the team. If he sneaks onto the top unit on a regular basis, it would inject a huge number of points into his totals this season.
- Overall, Konecny and Zegras were the primary drivers of the power play, with Michkov also performing well. Drysdale has yet to find his groove in that role and remains significantly behind other highly touted young defensemen around the league.
- Players struggling with the man advantage included Bump (limited time, though) and Foerster. Tippet and Sanheim also underwhelmed on the power play

Key departures	Garnet Hathaway (FLA), Luke Glendening (UFA), Rodrigo Abols (NL), Emil Andrae (TOR), Samuel Ersson (OTT),
Arrivals	Noel Acciari (PIT), Zach Aston-Reese (CBJ), Simon Benoit (TOR), Joseph Woll (TOR)

Pittsburgh PENGUINS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Rickard Rakell	72	26	56	15	Sidney Crosby	79	31	81	39	Bryan Rust	73	30	64	23
Egor Chinakhov	71	21	51	9	Ben Kindel	79	16	41	20	Evgeni Malkin	71	22	56	59
Andrei Kuzmenko	65	15	34	14	Tommy Novak	74	17	37	13	N Robertson	77	17	41	14
Connor Dewar	77	11	23	23	Blake Lizotte	61	9	21	24	Ville Koivunen	68	6	31	20
Hendrix Lapierre	76	6	21	30	Filip Hallander	35	4	10	18	Justin Brazeau	55	12	22	12
Elmer Soderblom	66	9	24	26	Tristan Broz	6	1	2	0	Rutger McGroarty	20	3	6	4
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Samuel Girard	71	3	22	17	Erik Karlsson	82	13	57	29	Arturs Silovs	49	24	2	3.00
Kris Letang	79	7	31	52	Trevor van Riemsdyk	75	2	13	24	Sergei Murashov	40	20	2	2.90
Owen Pickering	26	3	5	8	Kaedan Korczak	76	3	18	46					
Ryan Graves	53	2	4	24	Ilya Solovyov	60	3	13	29					
Declan Carlile	57	2	10	50	Harrison Brunicke	47	5	13	24					

Restricted Free Agents: none

Camp battle: Once again, for the umpteenth straight season, a Kyle Dubas team has too many NHLers at most positions. This time, it's mainly wingers, with 14 NHL-proven or NHL-ready wingers for nine spots. This could mean McGroarty gets cut (waivers-exempt), Hallander (injured last year, now perhaps his window is closed), Koivunen (see [Koivunen note at the bottom of this section](#)), and Brazeau and Soderblom aren't secure either. Only big contracts are secure, so Robertson is safe. That said, with the number of bodies Dubas brought in, Robertson will need to unseat someone just to get into the top nine.

On the hot seat: Robertson got a big \$3.25M contract and has two years to show that not only is he worth it, but he's worth a raise. And he has to battle through a multitude of other wingers to do it. To get any kind of point totals on this team, you have to somehow crack that top PP unit. For years, those spots have been set in stone. That means that any injury that opens the door, Robertson must pounce.

- Chinakhov was the 21st overall draft pick in 2020 and made the NHL just a year later. So, people had high hopes for him (both Columbus and his fantasy owners). But injury after injury stopped his roll every time he got going. He averaged 36 games missed per year. Then he got traded to Pittsburgh, where magically he stayed healthy—and we got to see the real him. He had 36 points in 43 games with the Pens. But factor in the first few games needed to learn the system, and Chinakhov got 32 points in 33 contests. If he can a) stay healthy and b) take a PP1 spot, he'll get 65 points.

- Kuzmenko has a habit of making a big splash when he joins a new team. But the productivity never lasts beyond a couple of months. He's a very streaky player who can't seem to figure out the NHL unless it's on the power play. More than a third of his career points have come with the man advantage. For that stat to become meaningful, he needs to be on PP1 or he's not going to do much.

- Karlsson had 27 points in his last 19 games, finishing with 66 when he had been on pace for 52. The reason for the surge? The Penguins' power play got hot. But Karlsson was at his hottest in mid-March when he had eight multi-point games out of 11, and then after going pointless in three he had a four-point game to make up for it.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Sidney Crosby	90	75	Sergei Murashov	95%	
Bryan Rust	73	63	Rutger McGroarty	75%	
Rutger McGroarty	70	58	Ville Koivunen	45%	
Erik Karlsson	73	57	Harrison Brunicke	30%	
Liam Ruck	82	57	Tristan Broz	10%	
Yegor Chinakhov	72	53			
Benjamin Kindel	75	53			
Evgeni Malkin	73	53			
Rickard Rakell	67	52			
Nicholas Robertson	73	47			
Ville Koivunen	70	47			
Markus Ruck	73	47			
William Horcoff	67	45	Sleeper	Pts	%
Tommy Novak	58	40	Yegor Chinakhov	65	25%
Justin Brazeau	55	40	Benjamin Kindel	55	15%
Tomas Galvas	50	40	Nicholas Robertson	55	10%
Andrei Kuzmenko	57	38	Ville Koivunen	50	10%
Filip Hallander	63	38			
Bill Zonnon	70	38			

- Malkin exploded out of the gate with 16 points in 10 games, and although he slowed, he didn't slow by much. That initial surge, though, came from a line that just dominated opponents. The 6-5 Malkin, Brazeau (6-6) and Anthony Mantha (6-5, now with New Jersey) unit started off unbeatable before the inevitable injury happened. This one was to Brazeau, and as soon as he came back, Malkin went down that very game. It was January 8 before they could possibly get reunited. By that point, the team had acquired Chinakhov, whom they wanted with Malkin.

- There were five games in March in which neither Crosby nor Malkin were in the lineup. Top scorers: Chinakhov (seven points), Rust, Mantha and Rakell (six), Novak (four) and Koivunen (two).

- Brazeau had 12 points in 12 games to start the season, on the aforementioned trio with Malkin. Talk about terrible timing for an injury. He may never become a productive player now, and who knows if it would have happened had that line kept going? He had 22 points in 52 games after he returned.

- Koivunen was signed to a shocking, massive eight-year contract worth \$4M per season in early August. After fewer than 50 NHL games and not really being treated like a top prospect. This has several implications. Let's start with the smallest one: the contract is waiver-proof. No longer exempt from waivers, Koivunen would have certainly been claimed. Given the crowd of forwards who are NHL-ready, he may have been waived to start the season. But now, what team is going to claim that kind of contract on an unproven player? If the Penguins don't clear out enough of the crowd, they'll need Koivunen down in the minors until they can get that sorted out. The main thing to take from this contract is that GM Kyle Dubas believes in him. Dubas is a big analytics guy, and Koivunen's analytics were fantastic, even if the offense wasn't (at least at the NHL level). He sees a player that he believes with high certainty will be at least a bottom-line regular. In a rising cap world, that's probably a \$1.5M to \$2.3M price tag. That's the floor (if he stays healthy it's the floor – if he runs into injury problems then obviously the floor becomes much worse). The contract becomes equal value if he slots in as a third-line, 40-point contributor for years to come. The big swing that Dubas is taking is the upside. How brilliant would he look if Koivunen becomes a star? What if he contributes well as a middle-sixer for a couple of seasons and then when he hits his breakout year he ascends as a star? In a rising cap world, his \$4M AAV would seem like pennies on the dollar. And let me tell you—all managers, fantasy and real, love to look like geniuses. This contract means that they will be grooming Koivunen for success. His odds of becoming fantasy-relevant just went up by *a lot*.

Injuries:

No injuries to report (a surprise given the injury history for this team). **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Kuzmenko, Lizotte, Chinakhov, Brazeau, Girard, Rust, Malkin, Rakell, Novak, van Riemsdyk.

Breakout Threshold:

Lizotte has played 434 career games. He doesn't have much offensive upside and he's buried deep in the lineup, but worth mentioning. He's a 5-9 player, which is "exceptionally sized" by our definition. He did have 10 points in 23 games in the second half, after nine points in 32 games in the first half. So, he did pick it up some. Chinakhov is the big name here, and a BT season for him would mean at least a 60-point season.

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Egor Chinakhov		
Boom or bust	Andrei Kuzmenko		
Multicategory / Banger	Kaedan Korczak		
Salary cap bargain	Ben Kindel		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Andrei Kuzmenko	20	23	91
Ben Kindel	55	34	166
Blake Lizotte	36	60	55
Bryan Rust	58	44	175
Connor Dewar	50	131	92
Egor Chinakhov	32	57	149
Elmer Soderblom	23	119	86
Erik Karlsson	77	20	180
Evgeni Malkin	18	25	163
Hendrix Lapierre	30	57	61
Ilya Solovyov	77	81	54
Kaedan Korczak	88	114	68
Kris Letang	94	94	126
Nicholas Robertson	37	85	139
Rickard Rakell	47	87	195
Rutger McGroarty	27	80	109
Samuel Girard	89	36	85
Sidney Crosby	31	62	181
Tommy Novak	33	9	118
Trevor Van Riemsdyk	105	11	53

Goalies:

Just getting out of Tristan Jarry's contract is a win, but it also means the Penguins have a whole lot of inexperience in net. Silovs took a big step forward as an NHL goalie in 2025-26, appearing in 39 games. He can step up when the games matter most, but he has yet to prove himself as an NHL starting goalie. Murashov's AHL numbers last season (2.20 GAA, 0.919 SV%) were impressive, but at age 22 he is very young for an NHL goalie. Blomqvist's AHL numbers (2.40 GAA, 0.913 SV%) were nearly as good as Murashov's, so this could be a training camp battle unless the Penguins sign an experienced goalie (Cam Talbot? Connor Ingram?) to back up Silovs or even be a 1B. Silovs is the most likely starter because of experience, but that won't necessarily be the case long term. ***Dobber's confidence that Silovs is the starter: 90%***

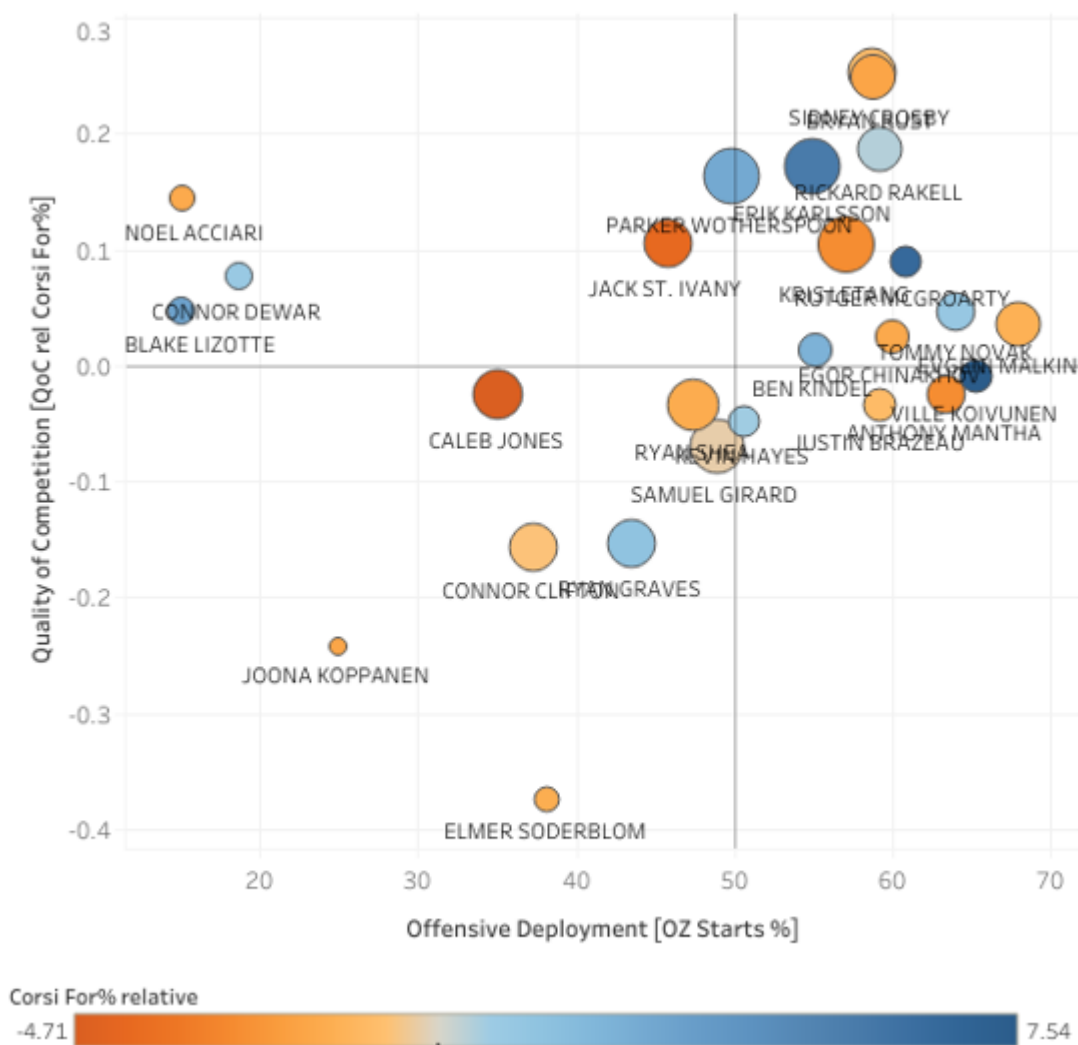
Contract Year:

Young goalies Silovs and Murashov are both expiring RFA, which could make for a competitive crease if the Penguins don't acquire a veteran there... After the 2025-26 season, Crosby stated that he has no plans to retire but instead is thinking on a year-to-year basis. Crosby has had an \$8.7 million cap hit since way back in 2007, so his only incentive is to keep it that way and simply keep playing... On a one-year contract, Malkin is truly on a year-to-year basis. A resurgence in 2025-26 means he could keep going, although he has not reached 70 games in a season over the past two campaigns... Karlsson has largely remained productive over the past few seasons and likely has at least one more contract in him despite some wear and tear.

2027 RFA: Soderblom, Silovs, Murashov

2027 UFA: Crosby, Malkin, Kuzmenko, Brazeau, Karlsson, Girard

Dobber Advanced... PENGUINS



* That's Crosby and Rust with overlapping bubbles in the top right.

Observation: Crosby, Malkin, Letang, Karlsson, Rust, and Rakell were all clustered in the high-offense, high-competition quadrant, effectively monopolizing the heavy-lifting minutes for the team.

Fantasy Impact: This is the definition of a top-heavy system. The coaching staff is placing full trust in the veteran core to drive offense against the toughest matchups. If you're looking for high-floor stability, these are the only players providing it.

Observation: McGroarty, Novak, Chinakhov, Kindel, and Koivunen also appeared in the high-offense quadrant despite being younger or newer additions.

Fantasy Impact: This is the most exciting takeaway from the chart. The Penguins are throwing their young players directly into meaningful minutes with strong offensive-zone deployment and respectable competition—a sink-or-swim approach. While this often leads to defensive growing pains, the fantasy ceiling is enormous. In dynasty or keeper formats, these players are breakout candidates because they're being handed premium opportunity alongside the superstars. McGroarty and Koivunen stand out with the darkest blue bubbles (in limited games), and Kindel, at just 18, was not sheltered yet still drove positive possession.

Observation: Mantha, Hayes, and Brazeau were positioned in the center-right, receiving solid offensive deployment but facing slightly more manageable competition than the top-tier core.

Fantasy Impact: This usage fits them perfectly. They are secondary scorers who should produce steady complementary offense. Hayes' fading NHL status and occasional healthy scratches make him irrelevant for fantasy purposes, but Chinakhov and Brazeau are trending upward. They are ideal watch-list candidates if the top-line veterans struggle or injuries open up prime offensive minutes.

Observation: Acciari, Dewar, and Lizotte were isolated in the upper-left quadrant, facing high-quality competition but receiving minimal offensive-zone usage.

Fantasy Impact: This is pure shutdown deployment. They are being used as defensive specialists to neutralize opposing stars and bleed time off the clock. Their fantasy value is negligible in points-only formats, though they may have niche utility in leagues rewarding heavy defensive-zone starts or shot-blocking. Their presence, however, enables the top six to enjoy more offensive-zone starts.

Observation: Parker Wotherspoon (now with Vegas) faced high-quality competition, received balanced zone starts, and drove possession.

Fantasy Impact: Wotherspoon finally earned a real NHL opportunity at age 28 and made the most of it. He gained legitimate multi-category value, and his possession metrics suggest he'll most likely continue receiving around 20 minutes per game. He's in a strong position to repeat—or even improve—last season's numbers.

Observation: Koppanen and Soderblom were firmly planted in the low-usage, low-competition quadrant with minimal offensive opportunity.

Fantasy Impact: These players functioned as fringe or organizational depth options. They were not trusted with meaningful responsibility in either zone. They should be avoided in fantasy formats unless you're in an extremely deep league and see a significant, sustained change in their deployment.

Penguins by the Metrics...

	<i>Pos</i>	<i>GP</i>	<i>ZS%</i>	<i>PDO</i>	<i>5on5 SV%</i>	<i>5on5 S%</i>	<i>CF%</i>	<i>%PP</i>	<i>IPP</i>	<i>ES IPP</i>	<i>PP IPP</i>	<i>PTS/60</i>	<i>Sec Asst</i>	<i>Sec Asst %</i>
<u>EVGENI MALKIN</u>	R	56	67.9	1033	0.912	12.1	48.5	71.3	69.3	69.6	68.8	3.7	16	38.1
<u>SIDNEY CROSBY</u>	C	68	58.6	1015	0.895	12	50.4	70.7	71.2	71.8	69.7	3.4	17	37.8
<u>EGOR CHINAKHOV</u>	L	43	59.9	1015	0.904	11.1	49.5	39.8	73.7	80	50	3.2	11	61.1
<u>ANTHONY MANTHA</u>	R	81	63.4	1030	0.897	13.3	47.9	49.2	66.7	72.9	50	3.1	15	48.4
<u>BRYAN RUST</u>	R	72	58.7	1019	0.889	13	48.9	69.9	56.5	55.6	60	2.7	16	44.4
<u>RICKARD RAKELL</u>	L	60	59.2	1017	0.903	11.4	50.2	68.9	55.8	58.5	51.6	2.5	10	41.7
<u>ELMER SODERBLOM</u>	L	20	38.2	1003	0.923	8	47.4	7.4	65	65	0	2.5	1	20
<u>JUSTIN BRAZEAU</u>	R	64	59.2	1024	0.898	12.6	48.3	22	68	67.4	71.4	2.5	6	35.3
<u>ERIK KARLSSON</u>	D	75	55	1016	0.9	11.6	53.3	70.9	52	48.2	61.9	2.2	28	54.9
<u>TOMMY NOVAK</u>	C	82	64	1006	0.893	11.3	50.8	25.3	61.8	63.6	53.8	2.2	9	34.6
<u>BEN KINDEL</u>	C	77	55	982	0.895	8.7	52.5	38.1	55.6	58.5	50	1.8	4	22.2
<u>CONNOR DEWAR</u>	L	78	18.7	1029	0.915	11.4	50	0.6	58.8	60.4	0	1.7	7	43.8
<u>NOEL ACCIARI</u>	R	67	15	1036	0.918	11.8	48.5	1.5	59.5	62.5	0	1.6	5	41.7
<u>BLAKE LIZOTTE</u>	C	55	15	992	0.913	7.9	52.1	1.4	65.5	67.9	0	1.5	6	50
<u>RYAN SHEA</u>	D	80	47.4	1039	0.909	13	49.1	3.6	39.3	40.2	0	1.4	9	31
<u>KRIS LETANG</u>	D	74	57	1002	0.904	9.8	48.8	32.6	37.8	32.4	62.5	1.3	15	48.4
<u>RUTGER MCGROARTY</u>	L	24	60.8	947	0.854	9.3	57.7	3.5	50	50	0	1.3	2	66.7

- Malkin posted his highest Pts/60 in seven years, and four Penguins surpassed the 3.0 mark—including Sid the Kid. Remarkably, Crosby has never dipped below 3.1 Pts/60 at any point in his career.
- Mantha's and Chinakhov's production is the real fantasy storyline. Both players have dealt with injuries and untapped potential, yet after arriving in Pittsburgh, both stayed healthy and finally produced at a level that reflects their skill.
- Mantha, Rust, and Brazeau had the most concerning 5-on-5 shooting percentages, all on the high side. Each should see a modest decline in even-strength scoring as those percentages regress.
- Crosby, Rust, Malkin, Rakell, and Karlsson operated almost exclusively on the top power-play unit. All logged more than 68% of available PP time, leaving limited opportunity for Chinakhov, Mantha, Kindel, Novak, and Letang. Given Chinakhov's trajectory, it's reasonable to expect him to challenge Rakell for that spot—possibly as early as this season. His upcoming contract will offer insight into how the Pens value him relative to Rakell (who carries a \$5.0M AAV).
- Chinakhov was involved in 80% of all even-strength goals scored while he was on the ice. Although he recorded a high number of secondary assists, he still contributed to more goals than his usual linemate, Malkin. The secondary-assist rate suggests he relies somewhat on his linemates for production, so his continued progress may depend on how consistently he remains attached to Malkin.
- Kindel and McGroarty were among the few players in the minus column for plus/minus. However, the 5-on-5 save-percentage data shows that the goaltending behind them allowed more goals than average during their shifts, which heavily influenced those results.

Key departures	Anthony Mantha (NJD), Noel Acciari (PHI), Kevin Hayes (UFA), Ryan Shea (EDM), Parker Wotherspoon (VGK), Connor Clifton (BOS), Jack St. Ivany (WPG), Stuart Skinner (WPG)
Arrivals	Andrei Kuzmenko (LAK), Nicholas Robertson (TOR), Hendrix Lapierre (WSH), Kaeden Korczak (VGK), Trevor van Riemsdyk (WSH), Declan Carlile (TB)

San Jose SHARKS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Igor Chernyshov	77	17	55	35	Macklin Celebrini	78	39	112	35	Will Smith	74	26	69	18
Ivar Stenberg	79	17	65	16	Michael Misa	74	19	56	30	Tyler Toffoli	81	24	49	13
Mason Marchment	72	22	47	56	A Wennberg	81	14	47	16	Kiefer Sherwood	75	18	37	43
Collin Graf	80	16	38	13	Zack Ostapchuk	62	4	7	46	Adam Gaudette	52	10	18	12
Barclay Goodrow	82	5	9	77	Ty Dellandrea	54	2	11	36	Brett Leason	17	1	4	6
Alex Barre-Boulet	15	2	8	4	Filip Bystedt	24	2	4	6	Ethan Cardwell	9	1	1	2
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Darnell Nurse	82	9	30	87	Jacob Trouba	78	8	24	62	Yaroslav Askarov	49	24	2	3.25
Dmitry Orlov	82	5	31	37	Michael Kesselring	67	6	26	76	Alex Nedeljkovic	42	17	1	3.05
Sam Dickinson	68	4	25	20	Eric Pohlcamp	39	6	13	20					
Luca Cagnoni	7	0	2	4										

Restricted Free Agents: Graf

Future Fantasy Stud: With all the Stenberg fuss and Chernyshov hype, it seems like Misa is hardly mentioned anymore in online fantasy circles. But make no mistake: the guy will be a stud. Tremendous upside, arguably higher than Stenberg's (though he doesn't have Stenberg's high floor). He's ready for a big step this year, with more to come. One of the stronger sleeper picks out there.

On the hot seat: Toffoli has been a steady and consistent goal scorer. But he slipped to just 19 goals last year, and he's 34 on a team full of kids. Highly skilled kids. His PPTOI has been slowly slipping, and if one of these stud prospects knocks him off PP1, the decline will continue. He needs to score early and often to secure his role.

- Marchment had 32 points in 39 games after joining Columbus, including 11 points in nine games after arriving. He played with their top players (Kirill Marchenko and Adam Fantilli). Given that track record, he may play the first part of the season on the Celebrini line, which would knock Chernyshov down to the third unit.

- Wennberg had 55 points last season, the second highest of his career and the most he's had in nine years. He had steadily averaged in the mid-30s in points over the prior four years. He's 32, so it's hard to imagine this being the new him. Consider it a one-off, now that the Sharks have a couple of legit top-sixers graduating to the big club.

- Celebrini had an astonishing 70 points in just 44 games to start last season. Not that 45 in 38 (the rest of the way) is bad by any means, but think about how good he'll be when he can keep that up for a full season.

- The above note is primarily why we're so bullish on Chernyshov, who was placed on Celebrini's line when he was first called up and promptly posted eight points in his first seven NHL games. Chernyshov slowed down, with 11 in his next 21, but he's 20 and it was to be expected. It would have been shocking had he kept up the pace. Don't be discouraged if he starts on the third line, or even if he gets sent down. A demotion would be super temporary, and he has the skill to overtake anyone above him rather quickly.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Macklin Celebrini	125	112	Ivar Stenberg		98%	
Ivar Stenberg	95	77	Igor Chernyshov		95%	
Michael Misa	97	73	Sam Dickinson		75%	
Will Smith	88	70	Eric Pohlcamp		30%	
Igor Chernyshov	85	65	Luca Cagnoni		25%	
Tyler Toffoli	72	53	Filip Bystedt		10%	
Mason Marchment	68	50				
Collin Graf	63	50				
Alexander Wennberg	57	48				
Sam Dickinson	70	48				
Quentin Musty	72	47				
Keaton Verhoeff	58	45	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Kiefer Sherwood	53	40	Igor Chernyshov	65	20%	
Filip Bystedt	70	40	Michael Misa	70	15%	
Leo Sahlin Wallenius	57	40	Mason Marchment	65	15%	
Ryan Lin	57	40	Michael Kesselring	35	10%	
Cameron Lund	57	38				
Luca Cagnoni	52	37				
Michael Kesselring	42	35				

- Smith was sidelined with an injury from mid-December through mid-January. His main linemates—Celebrini, Graf and Toffoli—each saw a production increase as a result. Celebrini had 24 points in 13 games, while Graf had 11 and Toffoli had 10. There are scouts who feel he tops out as a second-line player. Keep an open mind for now. Let's get him past his breakout season (2027-28) before passing judgment.

- Orlov, then 34, set a career high with 37 points. That was due to 18 PPPs and about 2.5 minutes of PP time per game. The Sharks often went with a five-forward system, but when they included a defenseman and it wasn't John Klingberg (when he played), it was Orlov. Although Klingberg is gone now via free agency, the Sharks have a couple of elite forward prospects joining, and it's hard to imagine the team using a defenseman on PP1. Kesselring was given a big contract (three years at \$4.5M AAV), and there is a good chance he gets a shot there as well. Proceed with caution when it comes to Orlov, as it's unlikely that he will match what he did last season.

Injuries:

No injuries to report. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Marchment, Sherwood, Kesselring.

Breakout Threshold:

Marchment is 6-5 and has played 370 career games, putting him at his BT sometime in the middle of the season. A breakout for him would see him at a point-per-game pace. He's injury prone, so that might only mean 60 points in 60 games. Numbers like that would obviously hinge upon how often he plays with Celebrini.

Goalies:

Askarov has a very promising long-term outlook with the Sharks about to climb up the standings. However, thinking he will be a top-10 goalie in 2026-27 is a reach. Among goalies with at least as many starts as Askarov (47), only Kevin Lankinen had a worse GAA than Askarov (3.60). Askarov should be the starter again, but he could be pushed by Nedeljkovic for starts more than you think. Nedeljkovic had a better GAA (2.87) and SV% (0.896 to 0.884) while appearing in 40 games. The 2025-26 campaign was Askarov's first full season as an NHL goalie, and remember that goalies take time to develop... Eric Comrie has been signed to provide goaltending depth, although he is best served as a low-volume backup and not someone who can challenge for the starting job. **Dobber's confidence that Askarov is the starter: 80%**

Contract Year:

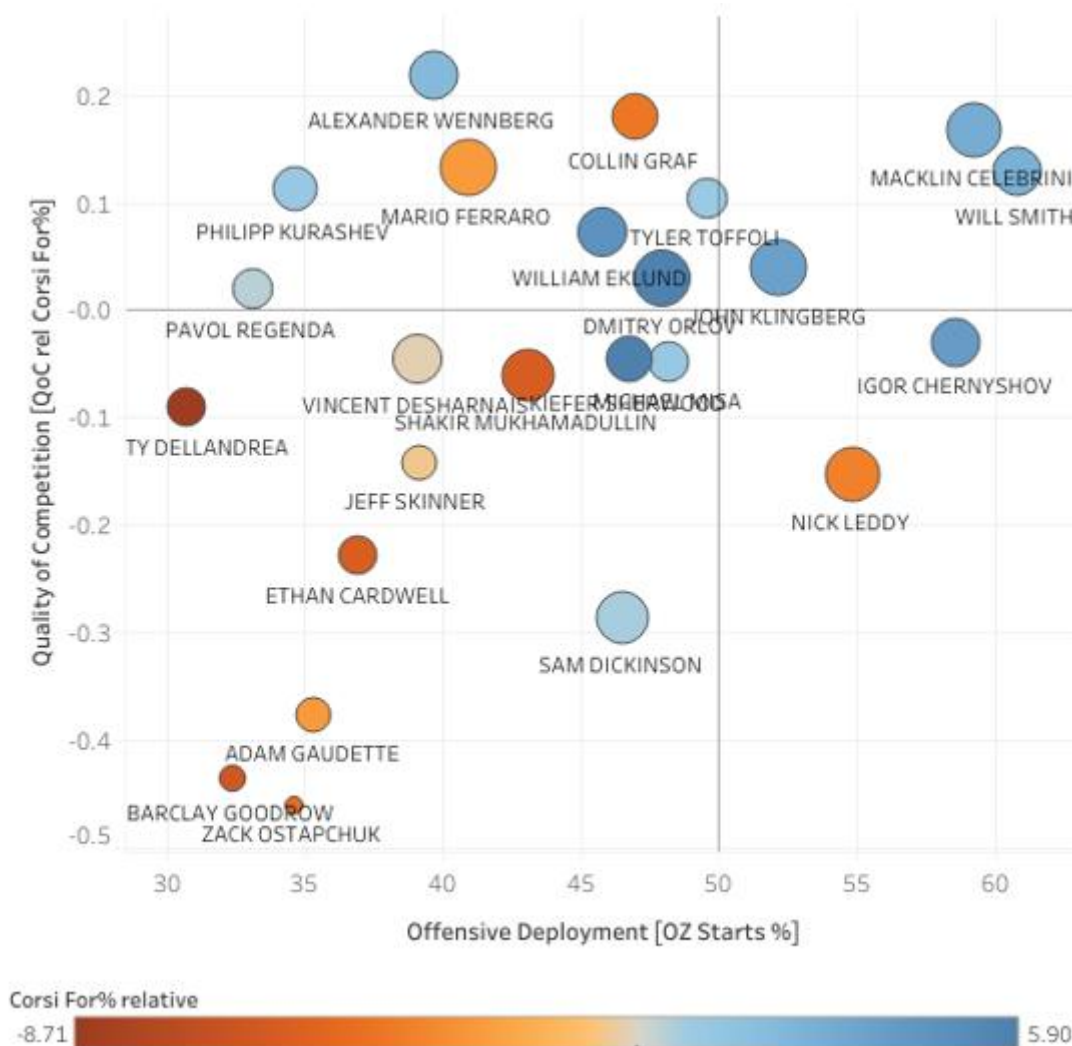
2027 is a big year for the RFA. Celebrini in particular will be the one to watch, as last season's performance as one of the NHL's elite players should make him one of the highest-paid forwards. If Leo Carlsson is worth \$18 million, how much is Celebrini worth? The Sharks will also need to leave significant room for Smith and Askarov, who are also core pieces... The Logan Couture contract will finally come off the books, although it will very likely be moved to LTIR again. Orlov's contract coming off the books will likely make room for the RFA. Hopefully signing Trouba and trading for Nurse will not complicate things.

2027 RFA: Smith, Cagnoni, Askarov

2027 UFA: Couture, Goodrow, Gaudette, Orlov

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Igor Chernyshov		
Boom or bust	Collin Graf		
Multicategory / Banger	Jacob Trouba		
Salary cap bargain	Macklin Celebrini		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adam Gaudette	23	42	67
Alexander Wennberg	84	24	89
Barclay Goodrow	56	131	57
Collin Graf	48	96	120
Darnell Nurse	163	147	188
Dmitry Orlov	70	116	98
Eric Pohlcamp	40	59	66
Igor Chernyshov	39	52	139
Ivar Stenberg	24	63	126
Jacob Trouba	132	130	140
Kiefer Sherwood	30	336	149
Macklin Celebrini	55	55	281
Mason Marchment	31	94	130
Michael Kesselring	80	73	101
Michael Misa	41	26	111
Sam Dickinson	73	77	88
Ty Dellandrea	41	141	59
Tyler Toffoli	28	48	169
Will Smith	18	22	191
Zack Ostapchuk	32	155	50

Dobber Advanced... SHARKS



* San Jose, as a team, did not push possession, taking far more faceoffs in their own zone. There weren't many offensive-zone starts to divvy out, so any player receiving that usage required the rest of the roster to eat a heavy load of defensive-zone starts.

Observation: Toffoli, Eklund, and Graf were positioned in the high-competition quadrant, tasked with driving offense while facing the opponent's toughest matchups.

Fantasy Impact: These were the most reliable assets on the team. Because they were trusted to generate offense even against top lines, they functioned as matchup-proof engines with consistent value in all fantasy formats. Toffoli and Eklund posted strong relative possession metrics, while Graf's bubble was dark orange. In fairness, Graf faced the second-highest quality of competition on the team. The level of trust placed in him shows he has established himself as an NHLer. At this stage he could go either way—a tweener who becomes a top-six scorer or a middle-six checker. As the team matures, more offensive-zone starts will be available, which should help their possession numbers.

Observation: Celebrini, Smith, and Chernyshov occupied the high-offensive, moderate-competition quadrant, receiving significant offensive-zone deployment, often against tougher competition—though Chernyshov was somewhat sheltered.

Fantasy Impact: This setup maximizes scoring potential. None of them truly needed sheltering; they drove possession against all comers. Chernyshov thriving against middling competition is extremely impressive and suggests he's ready for a full season on the big line.

Observation: Wennberg, Ferraro, and Kurashev were situated in the high-competition, low-offensive-deployment quadrant, indicating they were used primarily as defensive anchors to neutralize opponents. Wennberg led the team in quality of competition faced.

Fantasy Impact: This is an unusual spot for Kurashev, who is typically viewed as an offensive complementary piece. Yet

he performed well in the role from a possession standpoint. Their offensive ceilings were heavily suppressed by these demanding assignments, offering very little value in points-only leagues.

Observation: Misa, Orlov, Shakir Mukhamadullin (now with Edmonton), Sherwood, and Regenda resided near the center axis on the left side, operating in a neutral zone where they were neither heavily targeted nor explicitly sheltered.

Fantasy Impact: These players functioned as the "streamer" tier. Without a defined high-leverage role, their production was volatile and tied more to overall team performance than individual usage advantages, making them easy to rotate in and out. Sherwood and Orlov excelled in this role and demonstrated they could handle even tougher deployment.

Observation: Leddy and Dickinson drifted into the moderate-usage, lower-competition zone, seeing decent ice time but kept away from the highest-stakes defensive assignments.

Fantasy Impact: Leddy, often a scratch, struggled despite being sheltered. At 35, he appears to be winding down a career that spanned more than 1,000 games. Dickinson could have benefited from Leddy's usage. He is an offense-first player, yet he received more defensive-zone starts than offensive ones. Whenever possible, he was kept off the ice against opposing stars.

Observation: Dellandrea was deployed as a purely defensive forward, and he struggled in the role. Skinner, attempting to revive his career, wasn't given ideal minutes to support that effort.

Fantasy Impact: Dellandrea hasn't been good enough to earn a top-six role, and he isn't the answer defensively. His future may ultimately lie in Europe or the AHL. Skinner was placed on waivers, released from his contract, and unable to secure another. If he chooses to continue playing, a PTO is likely the only path available at age 34.

Sharks by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>MACKLIN CELEBRINI</u>	C	82	59.2	1035	0.908	12.7	49.4	71.2	84.6	87.2	78.6	3.9	24	34.3
<u>WILL SMITH</u>	R	69	60.7	1031	0.919	11.2	48.9	64.4	67	73.7	54.8	2.8	15	42.9
<u>IGOR CHERNYSHOV</u>	L	28	58.6	1000	0.866	13.4	52.3	25	59.4	58.3	62.5	2.7	1	10
<u>TYLER TOFFOLI</u>	R	79	49.5	1006	0.9	10.6	47.1	57.3	62	72.3	46.9	2.5	13	43.3
<u>WILLIAM EKLUND</u>	L	78	45.7	969	0.875	9.4	49.9	56.3	59.6	62.7	53.3	2.2	12	31.6
<u>MICHAEL MISA</u>	C	45	48.2	995	0.893	10.2	49.1	24.7	67.7	65.4	80	2.2	9	75
<u>COLLIN GRAF</u>	L	81	46.9	1023	0.915	10.8	44.6	9.6	78	83	33.3	2.1	11	44
<u>A WENNBORG</u>	C	80	39.6	979	0.89	8.9	48.1	64.5	60.4	70.9	42.9	2	13	35.1
<u>ADAM GAUDETTE</u>	R	66	35.3	998	0.897	10.1	44.3	18.5	71.4	67.9	85.7	2	5	62.5
<u>PAVOL REGENDA</u>	L	24	33.1	977	0.873	10.4	48.9	26.9	45.5	42.9	50	1.9	0	0
<u>PHILIPP KURASHEV</u>	C	43	34.6	1023	0.9	12.3	45.6	31.7	57.1	62.1	33.3	1.8	3	23.1
<u>KIEFER SHERWOOD</u>	R	28	46.7	968	0.879	8.9	53.7	29.3	55.4	54.5	63.2	1.7	5	71.4
<u>JOHN KLINGBERG</u>	D	56	52.2	1006	0.89	11.6	48.3	56.9	39.1	34	56.3	1.4	13	76.5
<u>DMITRY ORLOV</u>	D	82	47.9	976	0.888	8.8	50.5	48.1	41.1	32.8	56.3	1.3	16	47.1
<u>TY DELLANDREA</u>	R	46	30.6	953	0.882	7.1	38.8	2.7	68.8	71.4	0	1	2	22.2
<u>BARCLAY GOODROW</u>	L	82	32.3	970	0.91	6	42.3	1.1	63.2	63.2	0	0.8	4	57.1

- His numbers really stood out last year compared to his teammates, and that becomes even clearer when looking at his Pts/60. Celebrini's production was more than one-third higher than the next-closest Shark. Nine players on the team reached the 2.0 mark.
- Chernyshov slotting in at third on the team (2.7 Pts/60) is a massive statement about both his impact and potential. He did have the highest 5-on-5 shooting percentage on the team, so that's worth monitoring. But that number is going to sit above 11–11.5% on Celebrini's line regardless. His low secondary-assist ratio helps counter some of the concern.
- Celebrini's puck luck was high, but it's Celebrini—there's no reason to expect a major drop-off. Kurashev and Klingberg also posted elevated numbers in this category, but they aren't particularly relevant for fantasy purposes.
- On the lower side, Wennberg and Sherwood could have used a few more bounces. Eklund's 5-on-5 shooting percentage was noticeably lower than the rest of the team. In the end, though, we're talking about only a small correction—just a couple of points.
- The top power-play unit consisted of Celebrini, Smith, Toffoli, Eklund, and Wennberg, with Klingberg subbing in when needed. No defensemen. Chernyshov and Misa were on the second unit, along with several miscast players. Expect major changes in 2026–27, because both Chernyshov and Misa belong on the top unit. Wennberg would be the first to lose his spot, and Toffoli likely the second.
- Dickinson was frozen out for reasons that aren't clear. Not shown on this chart, his PP% was just 6.0. Given his junior scoring and overall pedigree, it's a shock. Fantasy managers can't explain it—you'd have to ask the coach. If he makes the team (he's now AHL-eligible), you'd expect him to finally get some power-play usage.

Key departures	William Eklund (OTT), Philip Kurashev (UFA), Pavol Regenda (UFA), Ryan Reaves (UFA), Mario Ferraro (WPG), Vincent Desharnais (WSH), Shakir Mukhamadullin (EDM), Nick Leddy (UFA), John Klingberg (UFA)
Arrivals	Ivar Stenberg (Draft), Mason Marchment (CBJ), Darnell Nurse (EDM), Jacob Trouba (ANA), Michael Kesselring (BUF), Eric Comrie (WPG)

Seattle KRAKEN

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Jared McCann	76	25	61	21	Matty Beniers	83	21	58	20	Kaapo Kakko	76	16	53	28
Bobby McMann	79	24	49	46	C Stephenson	80	16	51	22	Jordan Eberle	79	20	50	23
M Samoskevich	78	17	41	29	Berkly Catton	72	13	24	36	Shane Wright	77	22	41	13
Jani Nyman	44	8	15	13	Frederick Gaudreau	74	9	24	11	Ryan Winterton	73	5	19	14
Curtis Douglas	32	1	3	74	Ben Meyers	30	2	7	9	Jacob Melanson	43	2	6	34
Jake O'Brien	3	0	1	0	Oscar Fisker Molgaard	15	2	3	2	Jagger Firkus	18	2	4	4
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Vince Dunn	76	13	46	62	Adam Larsson	84	7	25	44	Joey Daccord	46	19	2	3.05
Ryan Lindgren	77	3	13	47	Brandon Montour	72	12	34	55	Philipp Grubauer	34	15	1	2.90
Ryker Evans	76	9	22	39	Ty Nelson	58	2	11	12	Nikke Kokko	8	3	0	3.00
Joshua Mahura	21	1	3	10	Tyson Jugnauth	32	3	7	11					
Cale Fleury	15	1	2	4										

Restricted Free Agents: Melanson

Camp Battle: With Chase Reid committed to Michigan State, the window is a small one (i.e. this season only) for a prospect defenseman to make an impact. Ty Nelson, Tyson Jugnauth and Lucas Dragicevic are solid defensemen with upside and one needs to make a mark. As of the end of July, the Kraken have not yet signed a veteran defenseman to fill the sixth nor seventh D slots. Dragicevic is a right-shot defenseman, the other two are lefties. But Dragicevic is also the one who is least ready. Perhaps camp will change some minds, but Nelson has the inside edge.

On the hot seat: Fantasy owners have seen nothing but disappointment from Wright. He was supposed to be the first overall pick. Then he wasn't. He was supposed to make the team right away. Then he didn't. In his second year after being drafted, he was finally supposed to make the team. Didn't happen. Then in year three he had 44 points, which showed promise. But another step back (to 27) last season again spoiled his outlook. Poolies need to see another step forward. Entering his breakthrough threshold (BT) season, Wright needs at least 50 points to get back to being an appealing fantasy option. He can't win faceoffs to save his life, so he'll be a winger—and there are a lot of bodies ahead of him there.

- Kakko mostly played with Eberle and Beniers, but in terms of driving possession and creating chances, he was most successful alongside Wright and Catton. With the new additions, it will be interesting to see if that line gets another run. It would help all three. Kakko started slowly but finished with 37 points in his last 51 games, which is a 50-point pace, and 16 in his last 17.

- Catton, the eighth overall pick in 2024, has a pedigree of putting up big numbers, having topped 100 points twice in the WHL. Last season was a learning experience, easing into the NHL with careful, low-intensity minutes. He started out in the 12–13 TOI range, but in the last quarter he was up to 14. He ended with 12 points in his last 39 games (up from six in 27 before that). Coach Lane Lambert's system is not a run-and-gun, lots-of-leash style, so patience is required with these high-upside prospects. A coaching change would absolutely inject fantasy relevance into these guys.

- After arriving in Seattle and finally getting his visa issues sorted out (cost him three games), McMann was a house on fire, posting 11 points in eight games, including seven goals. It earned him a massive six-year deal at \$5.75M per

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Matty Beniers	78	67	Jani Nyman	60%	
Jared McCann	73	65	Jacob Melanson	55%	
Kaapo Kakko	80	60	Ty Nelson	55%	
Berkly Catton	93	60	Tyson Jugnauth	50%	
Mackie Samoskevich	72	57	O Fisker Molgaard	45%	
Vince Dunn	70	55	Jake O'Brien	40%	
Shane Wright	83	55	Lukas Dragicevic	25%	
Bobby McMann	63	55	Jagger Firkus	20%	
Chandler Stephenson	65	52	Chase Reid	0%	
Jagger Firkus	77	50			
Jani Nyman	72	48			
Jordan Eberle	65	45	Sleeper	Pts	%
Jake O'Brien	82	45	Kaapo Kakko	63	20%
Viktor Fyodorov	65	45	Berkly Catton	45	15%
Ryker Evans	57	43	Chase Reid	45	15%
Chase Reid	70	42			
Brandon Montour	55	40			
Carson Rehkopf	70	40			
Eduard Sale	72	37			

season. Not bad for an undrafted player who six years ago couldn't even get an NHL contract out of college, instead getting an AHL deal and actually starting in the ECHL. Never give up on your dreams, kids. In all seriousness, do not overrate him. McMann was removed from the first PP unit and his production slipped to three points in 10 games after that. He was hot and cold, just like he was with Toronto.

- McCann missed 30 games last season with several injuries. His linemates were mostly Beniers and Eberle. Beniers had 17 points in those 30 games (0.57) and 33 in 52 with McCann (0.63). Eberle also had 17 in 30 without McCann, and 38 in 50 with him (0.76).

- Speaking of Beniers, as a second overall pick who had 57 points in his rookie season and has now played 331 career games, fantasy owners are left wondering why he hasn't had even a 51-point season since. "Coaching system" is only part of the story. Truly great players, elite first liners, can work around that (Mathew Barzal with the NY Islanders comes to mind). So, while a new coach would obviously help, it seems unlikely that he can be a point-per-game player. Catton may be a better bet down the road, becoming the top center with Beniers moving to Line 2.

- Samoskevich, 23, is a skilled player with second-line upside. Many believe that the trade to Seattle will finally open things up for him. But the reality is, he averaged over two minutes of PP time last season thanks to all the injuries in Florida, and 14:28 of TOI. With Seattle, he may push that up to 15:30 and have slightly better linemates, but his PPTOI will likely decline. The uptick in his numbers will probably not be as strong as expected.

Injuries:

McCann underwent a procedure in April for a lower-body injury. He said he would be 100 percent ready for opening night... Grubauer and Daccord were both shut down a few games before the end of the regular season because of lower-body injuries. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Dunn, Kakko, Winterton, Montour.

Breakout Threshold:

McCann, Evans and Wright each hit their BT season. Evans has a shot at breaking out if Reid doesn't make the team and Dunn gets injured, but otherwise it will be tough. Wright has a lot riding on any kind of step forward, but we know he has the ability. If McMann can smooth out the streakiness, he could break out. The good news for Samoskevich owners is that he has only played 156 NHL games, putting his BT around the midpoint of the season. Bottom line for these younger players is that they need to be leaned on for PP time and offensive situations, rather than trotting out the likes of Eberle and Stephenson.

Goalies:

The Kraken not buying out Grubauer last offseason turned out to be a smart move, as he ended up being the better goalie of the Seattle tandem. Grubauer bounced back in his fifth Seattle season, posting his first 0.900+ save-percentage campaign as a member of the Kraken. Daccord, who has four years left on his contract, simply wasn't as sharp as he had been in prior seasons. As a result, this one might be tough to call. The Kraken have more invested in Daccord, as Grubauer is in the final season of the six-year contract he signed in 2021. This might be a perfect time for Kokko or Victor Ostman to make some hay. The 22-year-old Kokko seems like the goalie of the future, but the 25-year-old Ostman might be the more likely call-up based on experience. **Dobber's confidence that Daccord is the starter: 60%**

Contract Year:

Wright has requested a trade, as he is unhappy with his lack of ice time in Seattle. He probably won't live up to the hype he once had as a blue-chip prospect, but he seems eager to prove that he can be a team's top-six forward... McCann is the Seattle franchise's all-time leader in goals and points. He has stood out in a sea of middle-six forwards, so it would make sense if the Kraken incentivize his signing... The same goes for Dunn, who is the franchise's all-time leader in assists. But if the Kraken wanted to reinvent themselves after remaining stagnant during their five NHL seasons, one or both may not be signed and could even be traded by the deadline if the team is below the playoff bar.

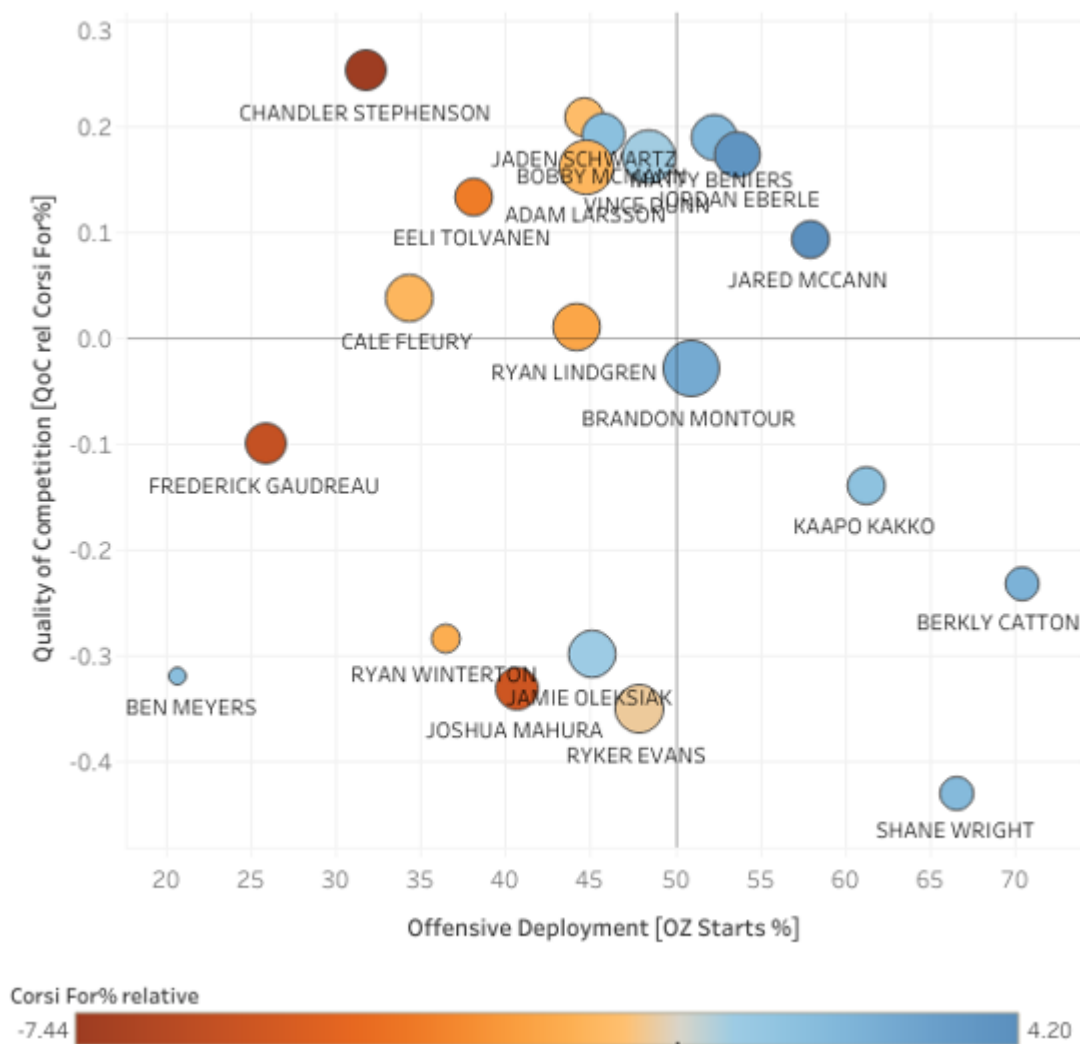
2027 RFA: Nyman, Wright, Evans

2027 UFA: McCann, Dunn, Mahura, Fleury, Grubauer

On the fantasy radar

Top breakout candidate	Kaapo Kakko		
Boom or bust	Shane Wright		
Multicategory / Banger	Bobby McMann		
Salary cap bargain	Chase Reid (if signed)		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
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Chase Reid	83	60	98
Curtis Douglas	10	52	19
Frederick Gaudreau	52	36	74
Jacob Melanson	17	215	43
Jani Nyman	15	40	62
Jared McCann	37	47	182
Jordan Eberle	39	39	158
Kaapo Kakko	23	39	114
Mackie Samoskevich	39	133	172
Matty Beniers	74	42	158
Ryan Lindgren	115	61	54
Ryan Winterton	36	85	95
Ryker Evans	94	68	91
Shane Wright	65	58	116
Vince Dunn	86	30	160

Dobber Advanced... KRAKEN



Observation: Stephenson was situated in the high-competition quadrant with the lowest offensive deployment among the top-tier forwards and the highest QoC on the team. He also had the lowest relative CF% on the roster.

Fantasy Impact: He was tasked with the heaviest defensive lifting. This extreme usage significantly suppressed his offensive production, making him a high-risk asset in points-only formats, as he was rarely placed in positions to generate scoring chances at even strength. He wasn't great in the role, but the Kraken had no other options. If they were to add a true defense-first center, it would likely mean a substantial boost to Stephenson's production.

Observation: Jaden Schwartz (now with Colorado), McMann, Beniers, Eberle, Dunn, and Larsson were situated in the high-competition quadrant with moderate-to-high offensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: These were the primary engines of the Kraken's offense. Because they consistently faced the opponent's best competition, they were the most matchup-proof assets on the roster and represented the safest bets for high-floor, reliable production.

Observation: Kakko occupied a distinct position with high offensive-zone deployment and lower quality of competition.

Fantasy Impact: Kakko was utilized as an offensive specialist, consistently placed in favorable situations to maximize his scoring potential. This role made him an ideal target for fantasy managers seeking a "streamer" who could capitalize on weak opposition, as his environment was specifically engineered to avoid defensive matchups. He has always had strong possession metrics, but this deployment represents the highest OZ% of his career.

Observation: Wright and Catton were located in the extreme offensive-deployment zone while facing some of the lowest competition on the ice.

Fantasy Impact: This usage was a classic development strategy, as the coaching staff prioritized scoring confidence and high-upside opportunities for these young prospects. For Catton, this deployment was expected, and the results were excellent. For Wright... seeing some of the lowest QoC in the league in what was his second full year—when he was a

top-five draft pick—is not a great sign. His bubble was blue, which is good, but why won't the coach trust him with more? There may be something we're not seeing, and if this treatment continues, it may be time to write him off. But let's see how this, his Breakout Threshold season, plays out.

Observation: Gaudreau and Fleury (limited games) were positioned in the high-competition, low-offensive-deployment area, indicating they were utilized almost exclusively for defensive shutdown duties.

Fantasy Impact: Their offensive ceilings were severely capped by these assignments. They offered minimal value in points-only leagues, though they maintained niche utility in deep formats that rewarded heavy defensive-zone usage or blocked shots.

Observation: Lindgren and Montour were clustered near the center axis, operating in a neutral zone where they were neither heavily targeted by top competition nor explicitly shielded.

Fantasy Impact: These players functioned as steady, reliable secondary assets. Their fantasy value was less dependent on favorable zone starts and more tied to their individual ability to drive play, making them consistent but rarely explosive contributors. Montour, though barely to the right of the axis, was actually the defenseman with the highest offensive-zone start percentage.

Observation: Mahura, Jamie Oleksiak (now with Vancouver), Evans, Winterton, and Meyers were located in the lower-usage, lower-competition zones, consistently receiving limited offensive opportunity.

Fantasy Impact: These players were primarily used for energy management and defensive maintenance. They were effectively non-factors for offensive fantasy production and generally did not warrant a roster spot in standard formats.



The advertisement features a dark red background with a subtle texture. On the left, there is a white hockey helmet icon above the text "GOALIEPOST APP". Below this, a white text box contains the message: "Get confirmed starter alerts sent right to your phone. Never miss a i lineup change again." To the right of this text is a list of four features, each preceded by a white checkmark icon: "CONFIRMED STARTERS (Not Probables)", "BREAKING NEWS ALERTS", "PERSONALIZED TEAM TRACKING", and "INJURY & CALL-UP UPDATES". At the bottom of this list is a white button with the text "GET IT NOW ON THE APP STORE & GOOGLE PLAY". On the right side of the advertisement is a large QR code with a Twitter bird logo in the center. The background also features a faint image of a hockey goalie in action.

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Kraken by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
JARED MCCANN	L	52	57.9	996	0.9	9.6	50	59.7	74.1	77.1	68.4	2.8	6	30
KAAPU KAKKO	R	65	61.2	1055	0.935	12	47.3	33.9	72.7	72.7	72.7	2.6	13	48.1
BOBBY MCMANN	L	18	45.8	1004	0.904	10	47.4	43.5	68.7	67.8	75	2.6	3	75
JORDAN EBERLE	R	80	53.7	1026	0.928	9.8	48.8	60.6	59.8	60.9	57.1	2.2	11	37.9
JADEN SCHWARTZ	R	50	44.6	1036	0.929	10.7	45.2	36.4	66.7	71.9	50	1.9	7	46.7
C STEPHENSON	C	80	31.8	1008	0.924	8.4	41	60.4	64.5	68.9	55.2	1.9	19	57.6
MATTY BENIERS	C	82	52.2	1016	0.912	10.4	47.3	60.3	54.3	60	40.7	1.9	11	36.7
EELI TOLVANEN	L	78	38.1	991	0.912	7.9	43.2	41.6	62.1	57.9	73.7	1.7	9	37.5
SHANE WRIGHT	C	74	66.5	1021	0.939	8.2	46.3	35.4	56.3	61.8	42.9	1.6	5	33.3
VINCE DUNN	D	81	48.4	1010	0.913	9.7	46.1	62	48.4	36.5	75	1.5	15	45.5
BEN MEYERS	C	52	20.6	974	0.867	10.7	46.4	1.4	68.2	68.2	0	1.4	3	37.5
JANI NYMAN	L	28	68.9	978	0.919	5.9	46.4	19.2	70	71.4	66.7	1.4	1	33.3
FREDERICK GAUDREAU	C	68	25.8	1015	0.922	9.3	42.3	6.8	60	58.3	75	1.3	6	35.3
BRANDON MONTOUR	D	64	50.9	982	0.913	6.9	48.3	40.3	55.2	54.5	61.5	1.3	9	42.9
RYAN WINTERTON	R	68	36.5	1019	0.913	10.6	44.7	0.8	60	60	0	1.3	3	21.4
BERKLY CATTON	L	66	70.4	993	0.912	8.1	47.5	19.6	50	51.7	40	1.2	8	80

- On a team that I often note on social media as “full of second-liners,” the Pts/60 distribution is pretty much filled with players in that range: seven players between 1.9 and 2.8, and zero players above that.
- The only player on the high side of the 5-on-5 S% stat was Kakko, coming in at 12.0. Throughout his career, he has generally been much lower than the NHL average in this category. The fact that his teammates were actually scoring when he was on the ice was a nice justification of his talent.
- The key names on the low end of the 5-on-5 S% included Tolvanen, Nyman, Catton, Wright, and Stephenson. All five are capable of more production, and odds are that at least three of them will get a good bump at even strength.
- The first-unit power play consisted of McCann, Eberle, Stephenson, Beniers, and Dunn. That unit was not as heavily used as with other teams, so the second unit saw a lot of action: Kakko, McMann, Schwartz, Tolvanen, Wright, and Montour. Of the two units, Beniers and Stephenson (first unit), and Stephenson and Wright (second unit), were the weaker contributors.
- With that said, the strongest PP IPP on the second unit—and the players who could sneak onto the top unit and bump one of the weaker guys there—are Kakko (strongest likelihood), McMann, and newcomer Samoskevich.

Key departures	Jaden Schwartz (COL), Eeli Tolvanen (UFA), Jamie Oleksiak (VAN), Matt Murray (UFA),
Arrivals	Mackie Samoskevich (FLA), Curtis Douglas (VAN)

St. Louis BLUES

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Dylan Holloway	71	27	67	24	Robert Thomas	74	27	80	32	Jimmy Snuggerud	73	22	57	20
Pavel Buchnevich	81	21	50	33	Mason McTavish	77	21	53	59	C McMichael	82	25	58	39
Jake Neighbours	78	20	43	41	Dalibor Dvorsky	83	17	35	31	Jonatan Berggren	64	11	31	15
Dillon Dube	65	13	20	20	Pius Suter	73	15	31	19	Alexey Toropchenko	78	7	17	28
Otto Stenberg	74	8	25	10	Jack Finley	63	4	10	50	Oskar Sundqvist	65	7	19	31
Ross Johnston	60	2	7	102	Aleksanteri Kaskimaki	7	0	2	0	Nathan Walker	57	6	13	38
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Philip Broberg	79	8	35	16	Logan Mailloux	74	9	31	53	Joel Hofer	46	24	5	2.70
Cam Fowler	79	6	32	18	Colton Parayko	76	10	23	20	Jordan Binnington	43	16	1	3.05
Theo Lindstein	79	9	18	10	Brandon Carlo	73	2	10	40					
Tyler Tucker	67	4	12	90	Adam Jiricek	12	0	4	2					

Restricted Free Agents: none

On the hot seat: Once a highly touted prospect, Berggren faded off the depth chart in Detroit and was subsequently placed on waivers. The Blues gave him a second chance and, to their credit, they played him and did what they could to put him in a situation to succeed. The result was hit and miss. He did show signs of being a potential top-sixer, but couldn't string together a consistent showing. Now the Blues are even deeper, and it will be a lot harder to take that next step. He's 26 now, so if he ever gets an opportunity via an injury to someone in the top six, he absolutely needs to make an impression.

Camp Battle: We're leaning McTavish here, but the battle is actually wide open for that last PP1 spot between him, McMichael and Dvorsky. Even Buchnevich, who was on PP1 last year, will have a say. But McTavish signed a nice new contract at \$7M AAV, McMichael signed one as well at \$6.5M AAV, and Dvorsky is the Golden Boy and a key piece of their future. Camp will determine who gets first dibs.

- Two very important changes were made by Coach Jim Montgomery to the roster after the Olympics. The first was moving Mailloux to partner with Broberg. The result was instantaneous, and it made both players far more productive. Mailloux had been partnered with Fowler all season, Montgomery figuring Fowler would make a great mentor. But Fowler ended up covering for Mailloux, and it dragged his production down. They just didn't mesh. Mailloux was stuck with just three points in 44 games. After the change, he jumped to 10 points in 23 games. And after Justin Faulk was traded to Detroit, Mailloux actually got some PP time as well.

- Broberg, for his part, had 15 points in 23 games (five on the PP, thanks to Faulk leaving), after starting with 19 in 58.

- The other change wasn't so much a coach's call as it was finally getting everyone healthy. But Thomas, Holloway and Snuggerud were put on a line together and absolutely took off. Thomas had 31 points in 22 games, Holloway had 30 in 23, and Snuggerud had 27 in 23. These guys need to stay healthy and in the lineup at the same time, and they could be a top-five unit in the entire league. It would mean the difference between St. Louis getting into the playoffs and not.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Robert Thomas	100	80	Theo Lindstein	90%	
Dylan Holloway	85	72	Otto Stenberg	80%	
Connor McMichael	78	65	Adam Jiricek	40%	
Mason McTavish	73	57	Justin Carbonneau	15%	
Tynan Lawrence	73	55			
Pavel Buchnevich	70	53			
Jimmy Snuggerud	75	53			
Dalibor Dvorsky	75	52			
Jake Neighbours	70	48			
Otto Stenberg	70	48			
Justin Carbonneau	75	45			
Dillon Dube	65	42	Sleeper	Pts	%
Pius Suter	55	42	Dylan Holloway	77	15%
Dmitri Buchelnikov	70	40	Dalibor Dvorsky	60	10%
Maddox Dagenais	65	40	Dillon Dube	42	10%
Logan Mailloux	57	38	Logan Mailloux	42	10%
Adam Jiricek	53	38			
Philip Broberg	55	37			
Jonatan Berggren	65	37			

- After December 12, Tucker was moved to pair with Faulk (and then Fowler, after the Faulk trade). After that date, Tucker had 13 points in 41 games, 68 Hits and 42 PIM. A multi-cat dark horse.

- When Pierre-Luc Dubois returned to Washington's lineup last year, McMichael's production surged to end the season. He finished with 11 points in his last 10 games. If this lineup stays healthy, McMichael is in a good spot playing with quality linemates.

- Fowler also benefited when he was moved away from Mailloux, posting 12 points in his last 23 games while being paired with Tucker. His PP time was cut almost down to zero, but he was much more effective at even strength. He had 18 points in 59 games before that.

Injuries:

Carlo (lower body) missed the last few games of the regular season. He was acquired by the Blues in the offseason, so assume he does not have any lingering injury issues. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Thomas, Holloway, Sundqvist, Broberg, Suter, Tucker.

Breakout Threshold:

Holloway, thanks to missing time with an injury last year, is now smack dab in the middle of his BT season. He has now played 225 games and, if he can stay healthy, he is arguably our favorite breakout candidate in this entire document. Berggren has played 205 career games. He is running out of chances and has to make something happen with virtually no runway or help at all in terms of quality ice time. A long shot for sure.

Goalies:

Can we still call Binnington the Blues' starter? In 2025-26, Hofer played in more games than Binnington (46 to 41) while posting considerably better numbers. After reversing course in 2023-24 and 2024-25, Binnington's numbers continued their downward trajectory in 2025-26. Although Binnington looked fine in the Olympics, there was a ton of second-guessing about his selection as Canada's starter. Both goalies are in the final year of their contract, and it's more likely that the Blues will extend the 25-year-old Hofer than the 33-year-old Binnington. This might be the season where you start to see Hofer receive the bulk of the starts, even though Binnington has the equity of being a big-game goalie. If the Blues are out of the race, Binnington's name might appear in trade rumors. Hofer and Binnington likely won't face a lot of internal competition. **Dobber's confidence that Hofer is the starter: 55%**

Contract Year:

A few prominent members of St. Louis's younger core will be due for RFA contracts. Snuggerud will complete his entry-level contract. If he builds on his successful rookie season, he should be set for a major payday—maybe even \$10 million plus... Both goaltenders have expiring contracts. Hofer is the more likely of the two to be extended because of his age and RFA status. If Binnington has another subpar season, the Blues may decide to move on from him. He could even be traded before the deadline if the Blues are out of the playoff picture.

2027 RFA: Neighbours, Berggren, Snuggerud, Mailloux, Hofer

2027 UFA: Suter, Dube, Krug, Carlo, Tucker, Binnington

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Jimmy Snuggerud		
Boom or bust	Jonatan Berggren		
Multicategory / Banger	Logan Mailloux		
Salary cap bargain	Jimmy Snuggerud		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Alexey Toropchenko	62	171	78
Brandon Carlo	132	99	81
Cam Fowler	87	8	87
Colton Parayko	160	95	115
Connor McMichael	43	53	164
Dalibor Dvorsky	31	99	125
Dillon Dube	16	78	91
Dylan Holloway	46	157	185
Jake Neighbours	48	164	125
Jimmy Snuggerud	44	81	190
Logan Mailloux	68	111	104
Mason McTavish	39	82	169
Oskar Sundqvist	29	79	46
Otto Stenberg	38	102	89
Pavel Buchnevich	36	36	154
Philip Broberg	103	40	111
Pius Suter	32	51	109
Robert Thomas	47	13	155
Theo Lindstein	71	41	103
Tyler Tucker	59	107	60

Dobber Advanced... BLUES



Observation: Thomas, Buchnevich, Drouin, and Neighbours were situated in the high-offensive, high-competition quadrant, where they were tasked with driving the offense while facing the opponent's toughest matchups. All four did well with it (Drouin mostly with the Islanders).

Fantasy Impact: These were the primary engines of the Blues' attack. Because they consistently faced top-tier competition while being deployed in the offensive zone, they were the most reliable, matchup-proof assets on the roster and represented the safest bets for high-floor, consistent production. Drouin's production may have dipped, but he is still an asset.

Observation: Broberg and Parayko were positioned in the high-competition, low-offensive-deployment area, indicating they were utilized as the primary defensive anchors.

Fantasy Impact: Their offensive ceilings were severely capped by these demanding assignments. While they provided real-world value as eraser defensemen, they offered limited upside in points-only fantasy formats, functioning better in leagues that rewarded Hits, blocks, or general defensive usage. Broberg is progressing quickly and is now appealing in keeper formats. But he'll never be a stud puck-mover. He's too valuable as a shutdown guy, which is a role the other puck-movers can't fill.

Observation: Jordan Kyrou (now with Washington) saw the highest offensive-zone start percentage and led the team in relative possession as a result.

Fantasy Impact: He'll have a similar role with the Capitals. He was (and will be) in the best spot to create offense. He had a down year dealing with injuries. This deployment gives him the best chance of bouncing back.

Observation: Mailloux and Fowler occupied the moderate-to-high offensive-deployment zone while facing manageable competition.

Fantasy Impact: This was the sweet spot for fantasy value. They received sufficient offensive-zone starts to generate

points without being overwhelmed by the opposition's shutdown units. This usage made them ideal candidates for consistent secondary scoring and breakout potential. When this pairing was separated, Mailloux's numbers increased (you saw this down the stretch).

Observation: Dvorsky, Holloway, and Berggren received slightly sheltered minutes. They did okay (light blue bubbles, with Dvorsky more of a neutral color).

Fantasy Impact: All three are seen as potential top-sixers (Holloway is already there). For Berggren, he is running out of chances. For Dvorsky, he was a rookie and the location of his bubble was expected.

Observation: Stenberg and Suter were clustered near the center axis, operating in a neutral zone where they were neither heavily targeted by top competition nor explicitly shielded.

Fantasy Impact: These players functioned as middle-six placeholders. Their fantasy production was volatile and highly dependent on team-wide success or injuries to the top-line core, making them reliable streamers rather than week-to-week starters.

Observation: Toropchenko, Sundqvist, Walker, and Finley were located in the low-usage, low-competition zone, consistently receiving limited offensive opportunity. Finley was sheltered much more than the others.

Fantasy Impact: These players were primarily used for energy management and defensive maintenance. They were effectively non-factors for offensive fantasy production and generally did not warrant a roster spot in standard formats. Their bubbles were darker brown, but given their deployment, it's not so bad.

Observation: Lindstein and Tucker were grouped in the neutral-usage (both zones) sector, operating mostly against softer competition with varying degrees of offensive-zone starts. Lindstein faced lowish QoFC but did very well in that role. Tucker was extremely sheltered.

Fantasy Impact: Lindstein is looking like the real deal, and it is likely his bubble will shift upward toward Parayko's over the next couple of seasons. Tucker, a potential asset in peripherals, needs to be trusted with more responsibility or he'll be forever a fringe player.

Observation: Snuggerud saw tough QoFC, leaning toward the offensive side, and had neutral possession metrics here.

Fantasy Impact: Already getting treated like a first-line regular, even though he was a rookie. I'd say that's a good sign for his future.



Blues by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>ROBERT THOMAS</u>	C	64	53.6	1043	0.913	13	51.4	58.9	72.7	75.4	70	3.2	16	41
<u>DYLAN HOLLOWAY</u>	L	59	57.5	1030	0.904	12.6	50.3	52	70.8	74.1	57.1	2.8	17	58.6
<u>JIMMY SNUGGERUD</u>	R	70	52.1	1042	0.924	11.8	47.4	50.7	66.2	73.7	45	2.6	14	46.7
<u>JORDAN KYROU</u>	R	72	63.9	994	0.898	9.6	54.3	48.1	74.2	69.6	87.5	2.4	13	46.4
<u>JAKE NEIGHBOURS</u>	L	69	54.5	1004	0.885	11.9	49.3	46.5	53.7	63	33.3	2.1	7	33.3
<u>PAVEL BUCHNEVICH</u>	L	81	52.4	999	0.9	9.9	49.7	53.3	60.8	57.9	71.4	2	9	32.1
<u>JONATAN BERGGREN</u>	L	36	51.9	988	0.9	8.8	51.7	27.9	71	73.1	60	1.8	3	30
<u>PIUS SUTER</u>	C	64	43.1	1018	0.93	8.8	48.9	26.6	63	66.7	50	1.7	9	56.3
<u>OSKAR SUNDQVIST</u>	C	52	28.2	968	0.851	11.7	40.4	19.6	77.3	88.9	25	1.5	5	41.7
<u>OTTO STENBERG</u>	L	32	44	1029	0.948	8.1	46.8	6.2	76.9	75	0	1.4	3	42.9
<u>DALIBOR DVORSKY</u>	C	71	57.3	984	0.905	7.9	47.1	44	44.7	43.8	46.7	1.2	6	66.7
<u>NATHAN WALKER</u>	R	46	34.5	957	0.853	10.4	45.4	0.9	52.4	55	0	1.2	3	42.9
<u>PHILIP BROBERG</u>	D	81	45.1	1026	0.915	11.1	46.6	27.1	38.2	37.7	55.6	1.1	14	50
<u>TYLER TUCKER</u>	D	69	49.6	967	0.856	11.1	51	0.7	36.2	37.8	0	1	8	57.1
<u>CAM FOWLER</u>	D	82	53.2	991	0.904	8.7	49.1	35.6	37.5	31.3	60	1	10	38.5
<u>THEO LINDSTEIN</u>	D	17	47.1	1038	0.95	8.8	51.6	2.1	36.4	36.4	0	0.9	1	50

- Thomas and Holloway lead the charge in Pts/60. Both had to overcome injuries early on, but when they were both back at the same time, they really took off. A healthy year for both players, at the same time, will push this number higher.
- Surprising to see Berggren's Pts/60 number so much higher than Dvorsky's.
- Both Thomas and Holloway, as well as Neighbours and Snuggerud, saw high 5-on-5 S% stats. Even for first-liners, Thomas and Holloway should be closer to 11.5%. Neighbours' number is far too high and should dip a little at ES.
- On the low end—Stenberg and Dvorsky are the players to hone in on here. Low 5-on-5 S% numbers, especially when looking at this stat for the rest of the players on the roster. The next lowest guy, at 8.5, didn't make it into this chart: Mailloux.
- The Blues were fairly even with first PP unit versus second PP unit. Thomas led all players with 58.9% of available power-play time. Holloway, Snuggerud, and Buchnevich were each between 50% and 53.3%. No defenseman stood out as taking over the PP after Justin Faulk (DET) was traded. Fowler was at 35.6% and Mailloux was at 14%. Neighbours, Kyrou, and Dvorsky rotated into that other top-unit spot.
- Mailloux started getting PP time after the Faulk trade on the second unit. He assisted on both PP goals that were scored while he was on the ice.
- Neighbours had weak PP contribution numbers (33.3%). Don't expect an increase in his PPTOI.

Key departures	Jordan Kyrou (WSH), Jonathan Drouin (Buyout), Matthew Kessel (NYI)
Arrivals	Mason McTavish (ANA), Connor McMichael (WSH), Ross Johnston (ANA), Brandon Carlo (TOR)

Tampa Bay LIGHTNING

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Brandon Hagel	80	35	85	67	Anthony Cirelli	79	24	50	39	Nikita Kucherov	81	42	128	40
Jake Guentzel	78	36	87	37	Brayden Point	77	33	79	12	Gage Goncalves	76	12	39	34
Ilya Mikheyev	80	18	38	14	Yanni Gourde	79	9	28	65	Conor Geekie	73	11	22	44
Pontus Holmberg	74	12	23	29	Dominic James	70	10	24	21	Jeffrey Viel	68	4	14	122
Zemgus Girgensons	75	7	18	34	Ben Rautiainen	2	0	1	0	Jansen Harkins	32	1	4	15
Jakob Pelletier	18	1	4	0	Sam O'Reilly	8	1	2	0	Scott Sabourin	12	0	2	39
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
John Carlson	79	10	68	32	Victor Hedman	76	9	41	46	Andrei Vasilevskiy	59	39	2	2.40
C-E D'Astous	73	7	27	117	Ryan McDonagh	73	7	27	21	Dennis Hildeby	27	15	1	2.95
J.J. Moser	74	5	25	44	Erik Cernak	71	3	13	64	Jonas Johansson	1	0	0	3.00
Emil Lilleberg	65	2	14	73	Max Crozier	37	3	10	33					
Maxim Groshev	18	0	5	4										

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: Goncalves enjoyed the second half of last season because he became a fixture in the top six. He played with Point and Guentzel and tallied 17 points in his last 24 games, 23 at even strength. He added three more in seven playoff contests, but had been removed from that line. His production is highly dependent on his linemates, so let's see how committed Coach Jon Cooper is to keeping him there.

Future fantasy stud: We had Geekie here last year and we're sticking with that. As we noted, this is a marathon, not a sprint. He's a big player (6-4) and needs longer than most first-rounders. He's 22 now and this time should actually make the team. He may not need his full 400 NHL games to reach his breakout year, but he'll need at least three years anyway before putting up the points we think he can. Patience.

- Mikheyev was a promising player with good upside when he first arrived in Toronto. But year after year of injuries stunted his development, and after four years of it he was pigeonholed into the bottom six. Well, don't look now, but he's been healthy for three years, with last season setting a career high with 36 points (38 was his full-season pace). He had 26 of those points in the last 42 games, which is a 52-point pace. If someone is going to take Goncalves' spot, it could be Mikheyev. He's still only 31.

- James was a savvy pick in the sixth round in 2022, developing in the college circuit. He does not really have top-six upside, but he can put up nice middle-six numbers. His stint in the AHL was a short one (five points in four games), and he was a solid depth contributor for the Lightning. He has potential as a real solid faceoff man who can get 35-45 points and 150 Hits, contributing on PP2 and PK2.

- Cirelli finished the season with 24 points in 28 games, and was plus-11 with 21 PIM. He played the entire year alongside Kucherov and Hagel—obviously great linemates—but there was no obvious reason for the uptick. It just seemed to be a market correction, because he was on a 40-point pace before that and is more of a 55-point player.

- It's hard not to imagine Carlson taking the amazing production that Darren Raddysh (now with Toronto) had and putting it into hyperdrive. After arriving in Anaheim last year, he had 14 points in 16 games—and that's with Jackson Lacombe ahead of him. So don't worry about the presence of Hedman.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Nikita Kucherov	140	120	Dennis Hildeby	99%		
Jake Guentzel	95	87	Dominic James	75%		
Brandon Hagel	92	82	Conor Geekie	60%		
Brayden Point	92	78	Sam O'Reilly	40%		
Victor Hedman	67	55	Benjamin Rautiainen	35%		
Anthony Cirelli	70	55	Dylan Duke	10%		
John Carlson	70	52				
Conor Geekie	73	52				
Oleg Kulebiakin	78	50				
Sam O'Reilly	67	50				
Gage Goncalves	65	42				
Benjamin Rautiainen	82	40	Sleeper	Pts	%	
C-E D'Astous	45	35	Gage Goncalves	55	15%	
Ethan Gauthier	68	35	Conor Geekie	45	10%	
Yanni Gourde	55	35	Benjamin Rautiainen	40	10%	
J.J. Moser	45	33				
Ilya Mikheyev	58	33				
Dominic James	58	30				
Dylan Duke	62	30				

- After winning the NHL scoring title for two consecutive years, Kucherov began last season at a ridiculous pace, posting 59 points in 38 contests. Then he put that pace to shame by taking it to another level—71 points in 39 games! And after all that, he fell eight points short of Connor McDavid's 138. Reasons to believe Kucherov will finally start slipping a little: his S% was a career-high 19.0%, and his equal-strength S% of 14.0% was also a career high.

- Point is 30 and may be on a decline, but not that much of a decline. Last season's 50 points in 63 games was extremely low for him, even factoring in a modest decline. He shot at a 14.0% rate, which was the lowest of his entire career. You have to think that the lower-body injury that cost him nearly 20 games actually plagued him all season. His PP effectiveness was also severely hampered.

Injuries:

Holmberg sustained a fractured clavicle in early April... Hedman was activated from LTIR right after the season. He had rejoined the Lightning during the playoffs, although he did not appear in a playoff game. He admitted after the season that his personal leave was for mental health reasons. Hopefully he will be ready for training camp, but even more importantly, hopefully he is doing well. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys: Holmberg.**

Breakout Threshold:

The only player in the vicinity of a BT season is Holmberg, who is at 229 career games. He is outside of the top six, however, and probably 10th on the list of forwards likely to get PP time. That's a tough hill to climb.

Goalies:

Vasilevskiy continues to be one of the league's busiest goalies, averaging nearly 60 games played over the past five seasons. Once again, he should be one of the top five goalies drafted in single-season leagues—perhaps even the top goalie. Over the past five seasons, no goalie has more wins than Vasilevskiy, who has averaged 36 wins over that span. Johansson, who has another year left on his contract, should continue to be the little-used backup. Unlike past seasons, the Bolts have brought in some organizational depth in net with Hildeby and Mats Sogaard. If the unthinkable happens and Vasilevskiy is injured, Hildeby could push Johansson for starts. Hildeby is no longer waiver-exempt, so he may even be what the Bolts have in mind for a backup instead of Johansson. **Dobber's confidence that Vasilevskiy is the starter: 100%**

Contract Year:

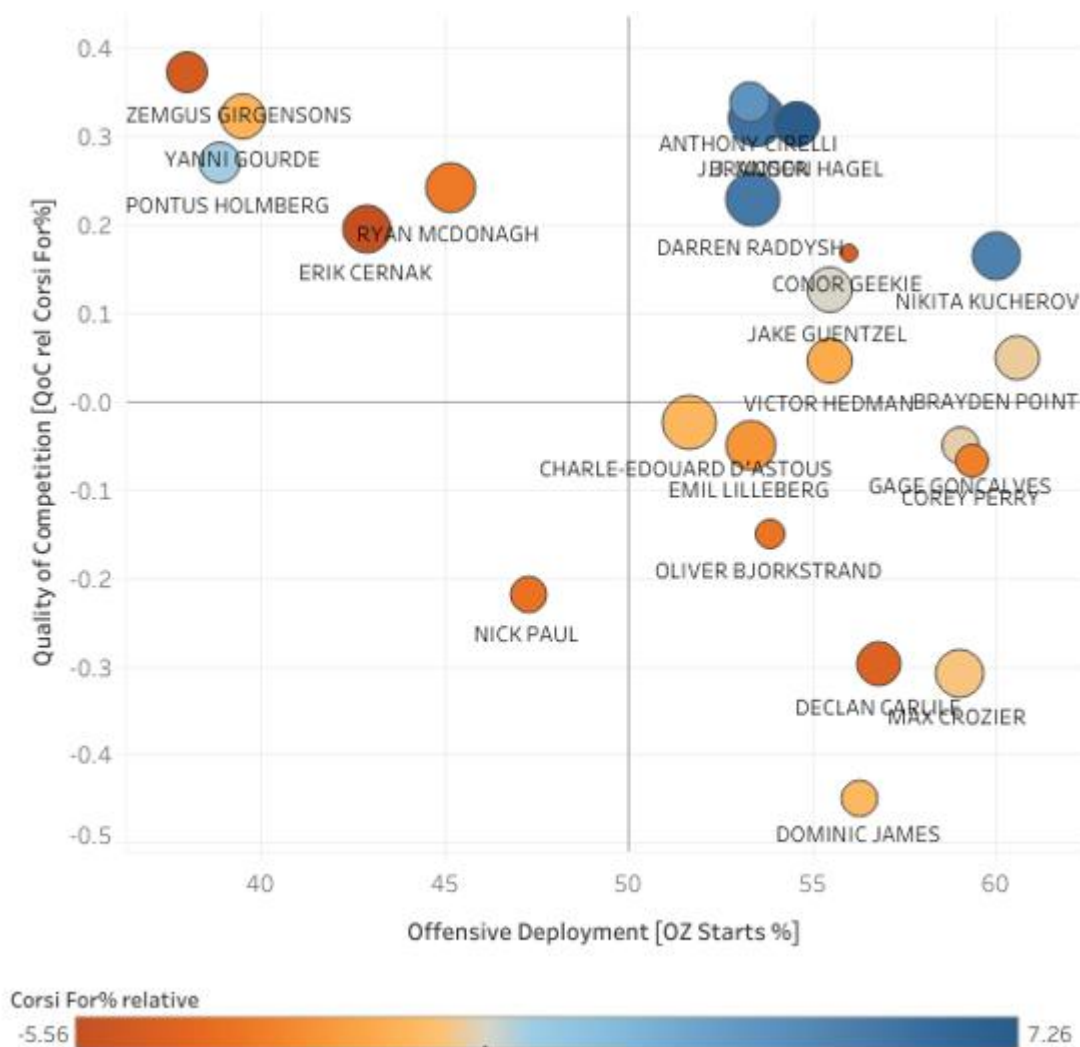
The Lightning aren't a young team, so the RFA are mainly depth players. If Goncalves can make good with opportunities in the top six, then the Bolts will have something to think about... It's far too early to panic about Kucherov, but the recent salary increases along with the Bolts' cap situation won't make things easy. Kucherov will be 34 when his contract expires next summer, but he is still one of the league's elite scorers. The Lightning don't have much else coming off the books, which further complicates an extension even with the rising cap.

2027 RFA: Goncalves, James, Geekie, Lilleberg

2027 UFA: Kucherov, Holmberg, Girgensons, D'Astous, Johansson

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Gage Goncalves		
Boom or bust	Victor Hedman		
Multicategory / Banger	C-E D'Astous		
Salary cap bargain	Brandon Hagel		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Anthony Cirelli	55	48	142
Brandon Hagel	48	54	233
Brayden Point	35	19	185
C-Edouard D'Astous	85	110	88
Conor Geekie	37	145	73
Dominic James	23	104	105
Emil Lilleberg	61	125	59
Erik Cernak	105	124	64
Gage Goncalves	34	95	84
Ilya Mikheyev	28	32	121
J.J. Moser	89	63	96
Jake Guentzel	42	31	211
Jeffrey Viel	31	184	88
John Carlson	111	36	175
Nikita Kucherov	32	35	258
Pontus Holmberg	37	67	96
Ryan McDonagh	110	26	66
Victor Hedman	106	46	152
Yanni Gourde	32	100	103
Zemgus Girgensons	45	165	75

Dobber Advanced... LIGHTNING



Observation: Girgensons, Gourde, Holmberg, McDonagh, and Cernak were situated in the high-competition, low-offensive-deployment quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: These players served as the team's primary defensive "eraser" unit. Because they were consistently tasked with shutting down the opposition's top lines while receiving minimal offensive-zone starts, they had very low offensive ceilings and were generally poor options for points-only fantasy leagues. Holmberg having a light blue shade with that deployment was quite impressive—he actually got a Selke vote.

Observation: Cirelli, Hagel, Raddysh (TOR), and Moser occupied the high-offensive, high-competition quadrant. And they absolutely dominated possession.

Fantasy Impact: This group handled the toughest two-way minutes on the roster. Their high usage against elite competition indicated that the coaching staff trusted them implicitly, making them reliable, matchup-proof assets in most fantasy formats. Hagel and Cirelli have always been fantastic possession players. Seeing Raddysh there as well should put Leafs fans at ease.

Observation: Kucherov, Point, Guentzel, and Hedman were positioned in the high-offensive-deployment zone while facing manageable, above-average competition.

Fantasy Impact: This was the "prime" usage quadrant for Tampa Bay's stars. The coaching staff consistently placed them in positions to dominate, effectively insulating them from the opponent's hardest shutdown pairs, which maximized their ceiling and made them elite, high-upside starters. They let the Hagel line tackle the toughest opposition, while Kucherov and friends got the second (weaker) wave.

Observation: Perry, Goncalves, D'Astous, and Lilleberg were clustered in the moderate-offensive, neutral-competition zone. None of them stood out as possession-positive.

Fantasy Impact: These players functioned as the backup scoring depth. They were not relied upon to drive play against

top lines, but they received enough offensive opportunities to be viable streamers or secondary pieces in deeper formats when the primary core faced tough matchups. Goncalves saw time with Kucherov in the second half, which pushed his bubble further right.

Observation: Crozier, Carlile, and James were situated in the bottom-right quadrant, where they received high offensive-zone deployment but faced the weakest quality of competition on the team.

Fantasy Impact: This usage suggested they were being carefully sheltered to build confidence and offensive rhythm. They hold no value in dynasty leagues, as their environment was specifically engineered to avoid defensive liabilities. James, in particular, was one of the most sheltered players in the entire league—yet his bubble was still not blue.

Observation: Nick Paul (now with Toronto) operated in a unique, isolated spot, receiving relatively low offensive deployment and facing lower-than-average quality of competition.

Fantasy Impact: Paul was given the easier role because he returned to the lineup from injury midseason and struggled to find his groove. A summer off should get him back to his old self for the fall. His bubble is usually in the top-left quadrant, not the bottom-left.

Observation: Oliver Bjorkstrand (now with NY Rangers) was located in the low-competition zone, consistently receiving safer offensive opportunity.

Fantasy Impact: Bjorkstrand was sheltered, but still didn't do well. His production has been steadily declining, and seeing a sheltered bubble like that with a dark orange shade is deeply concerning. Maybe a fresh start in New York will help, but don't hold your breath.

Lightning by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>NIKITA KUCHEROV</u>	R	77	60	1045	0.905	14	55.9	84.1	80.7	82.3	78.7	5	35	40.7
<u>JAKE GUENTZEL</u>	L	81	55.4	1023	0.895	12.8	53.3	81	66.7	69.9	66.7	3.2	21	42
<u>BRANDON HAGEL</u>	L	71	54.6	1031	0.914	11.7	58.2	45	69.2	73.8	57.1	3.2	12	31.6
<u>BRAYDEN POINT</u>	C	63	60.6	1055	0.902	15.3	52.2	74.7	52.6	60.9	35.5	2.6	13	40.6
<u>ANTHONY CIRELLI</u>	C	71	53.3	1050	0.926	12.4	55.7	24.4	58.4	60.5	44.4	2.5	14	48.3
<u>DARREN RADDYSH</u>	D	73	53.3	1016	0.905	11.1	56.7	74.4	54.3	50	63.4	2.5	24	50
<u>COREY PERRY</u>	R	22	59.3	1041	0.937	10.4	49.3	34.9	59.7	63.2	54.2	2	1	33.3
<u>GAGE GONCALVES</u>	L	74	59	1058	0.896	16.2	52.9	19.5	52.4	50.8	100	2	13	59.1
<u>OLIVER BJORKSTRAND</u>	R	80	53.8	984	0.904	8	50	62.4	50.8	64.3	40	1.8	5	25
<u>DOMINIC JAMES</u>	C	43	56.3	1014	0.918	9.6	53	13	65.2	75	0	1.7	1	12.5
<u>VICTOR HEDMAN</u>	D	33	55.5	1025	0.918	10.7	50.7	44	51.5	44	75	1.6	7	43.8
<u>RYAN MCDONAGH</u>	D	48	45.1	1018	0.907	11.1	50	2.8	46.7	50	0	1.4	6	40
<u>PONTUS HOLMBERG</u>	C	70	38.8	989	0.905	8.4	53.9	2.7	62.9	62.9	0	1.4	5	45.5
<u>YANNI GOURDE</u>	C	82	39.5	974	0.901	7.3	51.7	3.7	68.3	68.3	0	1.3	5	26.3
<u>NICK PAUL</u>	R	51	47.2	954	0.877	7.7	51.3	24.8	60	66.7	42.9	1.3	5	62.5
<u>C-E D'ASTOUS</u>	D	70	51.6	999	0.881	11.8	53	19.1	45.3	43.5	100	1.3	15	65.2

- Kucherov was the only player in the league to hit the 5.0 Pts/60 threshold. In fact, he was the only player to hit 4.5. Connor McDavid's stat was 4.4 (Nate MacKinnon 4.3). The gap between him and the next top producer on the team is the reason he won the Hart Trophy. Eight players had Pts/60 at or above 2.0.

- That being said, Kucherov had a high 5-on-5 S%. Even for him, it was high—easily his career high. He is generally in that 11% range. He's now 33 and coming off a career high for even-strength points with 93. Safe to assume the ES points will decline.

- Point, Cirelli, Guentzel, Goncalves, and D'Astous each enjoyed very good puck luck. Each should see a decline at even strength. Point, coming off his worst season since he was a rookie, had returned from injury and wasn't the same player. A healthy campaign from him would counter any market corrections this suggests. Fancy stats tell a story, but other factors always need to be considered.

- The first power-play unit pretty much hogged all the PP time: Kucherov, Guentzel, Point, and Raddysh were out there. And then—surprisingly—not Hagel, but Bjorkstrand. Given that Bjorkstrand's PP IPP was just 40.0, it's unlikely he would get PP1 time with New York.

- Impressive that a defenseman, Raddysh, had the points that he did and only half of his assists were secondary. He finished 10th in the entire league among defensemen for primary assists with 24.

Key departures	Nick Paul (TOR), Oliver Bjorkstrand (NYR), Corey Perry (LAK), Darren Raddysh (TOR), Declan Carlile (PIT),
Arrivals	Ilya Mikheyev (VAN), Jeffrey Viel (ANA), John Carlson (ANA), Dennis Hildeby (TOR), Jansen Harkins (ANA)

Toronto MAPLE LEAFS

Left Wing					Center					Right Wing				
GP	G	Pts	PIM		GP	G	Pts	PIM		GP	G	Pts	PIM	
Gavin McKenna	82	25	70	53	A Matthews	71	41	82	20	Jack Roslovic	77	21	41	15
Matthew Knies	81	24	69	40	John Tavares	81	32	69	36	W Nylander	79	38	91	23
Easton Cowan	76	13	40	55	Teddy Blueger	67	10	26	33	Nick Paul	72	17	32	31
Brandon Duhaime	83	6	12	84	Colton Sissons	75	9	16	30	Dakota Joshua	61	11	16	51
Steven Lorentz	65	5	11	12	Jacob Quillan	36	1	5	2	Max Domi	31	4	14	38
										Zack MacEwen	6	0	1	9
Defense					Defense					Goalies				
GP	G	Pts	PIM		GP	G	Pts	PIM		GP	W	SO	GAA	
O Ekman-Larsson	80	7	32	68	D Raddysch	78	13	61	37	Sergei Bobrovski	54	33	3	2.90
Morgan Rielly	79	8	28	26	Chris Tanev	73	2	13	22	Anthony Stolarz	35	16	2	2.95
Jake McCabe	75	5	23	55	Troy Stecher	63	2	11	27	Artur Akhtyamov	2	1	0	4.00
Emil Andrae	72	3	21	27	Philippe Myers	29	0	2	14					

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: Roslovic is a friend of Matthews and a Team USA teammate going back to their USNTDP days (U.S. National Team Development Program). It's hard not to see him getting first crack on a line with the big man. Double-check if that's true as camp progresses. It's no guarantee that it clicks and they last beyond camp, but they'll circle back to the duo several times this season before giving up. If it works, that gives the team two very strong lines and gives Cowan a nice pressure-free spot on the third unit to add supplemental scoring.

On the hot seat: Raddysch comes to his hometown with a huge long-term contract based on one massive season at the age of 30. The last time the Leafs brought in a hometown boy with a big long-term deal after he had a huge contract season (David Clarkson), it didn't work out so well. Don't expect another 70 points, but even if Raddysch can provide 55–65 points per year for even five of those eight seasons, he will enjoy his time there.

- Cowan improved with every quarter, posting a point every two games in the second half. In the last quarter, his PP time was a shade under two minutes per game and he had 10 points in 19 games. If Roslovic doesn't cut it in the top six, Cowan will immediately replace him.

- Matthews struggled with injuries through much of the season, and his numbers dipped in the second half to just 20 points in his last 25 games—absolutely related. All we can hope for is that a full summer of healing and recovery gets him back to his old self. It's a safe bet. Don't forget that he averaged over a point-per-game for eight consecutive seasons before last year.

- Knies had 28 points in the first 24 games of the season. After that, he was moved off the Matthews line and managed just 38 points in 55 games. And much of those points in the second half were on the power play. With Matthews. To break that down further, Knies had 26 even-strength points in the first 24 games and then 24 ES points in 55 games after that!

- So yeah, as Matthews goes, so go the Leafs. The entire Maple Leafs roster, with the exception of Cowan and Joshua, saw a second-half decline in their production. All of them. Nylander, Tavares, OEL—all of them.

- OEL took over the power play from Rielly when the latter wasn't doing anything with it (see the Advanced section). Ekman-Larsson's production did drop in the second half, but not for lack of PP time. All four of his points in the final

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Auston Matthews	105	92	Gavin McKenna	100%		
William Nylander	110	90	Jacob Quillan	40%		
Matthew Knies	85	73	William Villeneuve	15%		
Gavin McKenna	105	73	Ben Danford	10%		
Miroslav Holinka	68	40				
John Tavares	77	65				
Easton Cowan	75	60				
Darren Raddysch	74	53				
Nick Paul	57	42				
Jack Roslovic	62	42				
Emil Andrae	55	41				
Tinus Luc Koblar	65	40	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Max Domi	57	38	Easton Cowan	55	10%	
Morgan Rielly	53	35	Jack Roslovic	55	10%	
O Ekman-Larsson	45	35	Emil Andrae	35	10%	
Zach Olsen	65	35				
Jacob Quillan	62	32				
Alexander Bilecki	60	30				
William Villeneuve	47	30				

quarter came on the power play. It's a moot point, though, since Raddysh is the PP QB now and the team is likely grooming Andrae for that role as well.

- Andrae is a very smart, skilled player who sees the ice like not many players do. He can create on the power play or on the rush, and he can also kill penalties. He likes to throw Hits, too. The downside is he is just 5-9, and that always has coaches hesitate with him. He also takes some risks to make the play. But his talent level has overcome a lot of obstacles in his career. Even though he's starting the season as the No.7 defenseman, don't be surprised if he's No.5 by December and No.4 by February.

Injuries:

Matthews underwent MCL knee-repair surgery in March following a hit from Anaheim's Radko Gudas. He needed a 12-week recovery at the time, which should give him plenty of time to be ready for camp... Domi is out indefinitely following offseason surgery, the nature of which was not disclosed. He will be re-evaluated at the start of training camp. Until then, his status for the season is uncertain... Joshua was shut down in April, but didn't need surgery... Tanev underwent core-muscle surgery in March and is expected to be fully ready for camp... Stolarz has fully recovered from a groin injury and should also be ready for camp. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Matthews, Blueger, Roslovic, Stecher, Stolarz.

Breakout Threshold:

Both Knies and Raddysh had the BT season last year, and one could argue that both broke out. Knies probably has a bit more to give in terms of production, but a 25% increase (i.e., breakout) would mean a point-per-game. Knies has played 240 career games, so he straddled the BT last season and this season...

Goalies:

The Maple Leafs are hoping to squeeze a little more juice out of the nearly 38-year-old Bobrovsky, who signed a three-year, \$21 million contract on July 1. Bob just came off the worst season of his career, posting a poor 0.877 SV% in 2025-26. The Panthers were drained after three consecutive runs to the Stanley Cup Final, so there is hope for a bounce-back when also considering the Leafs' offseason additions. Stolarz had a 2025-26 season to forget, both in terms of performance and injury. He is likely the backup, but he could push Bobrovsky for starts. Stolarz has never played 35 games in a season, so don't expect him to take the starter job outright. Akhtyamov, who was the Calder Cup MVP, is the likely call-up in the event of injury. **Dobber's confidence that Bobrovsky is the starter: 90%**

Contract Year:

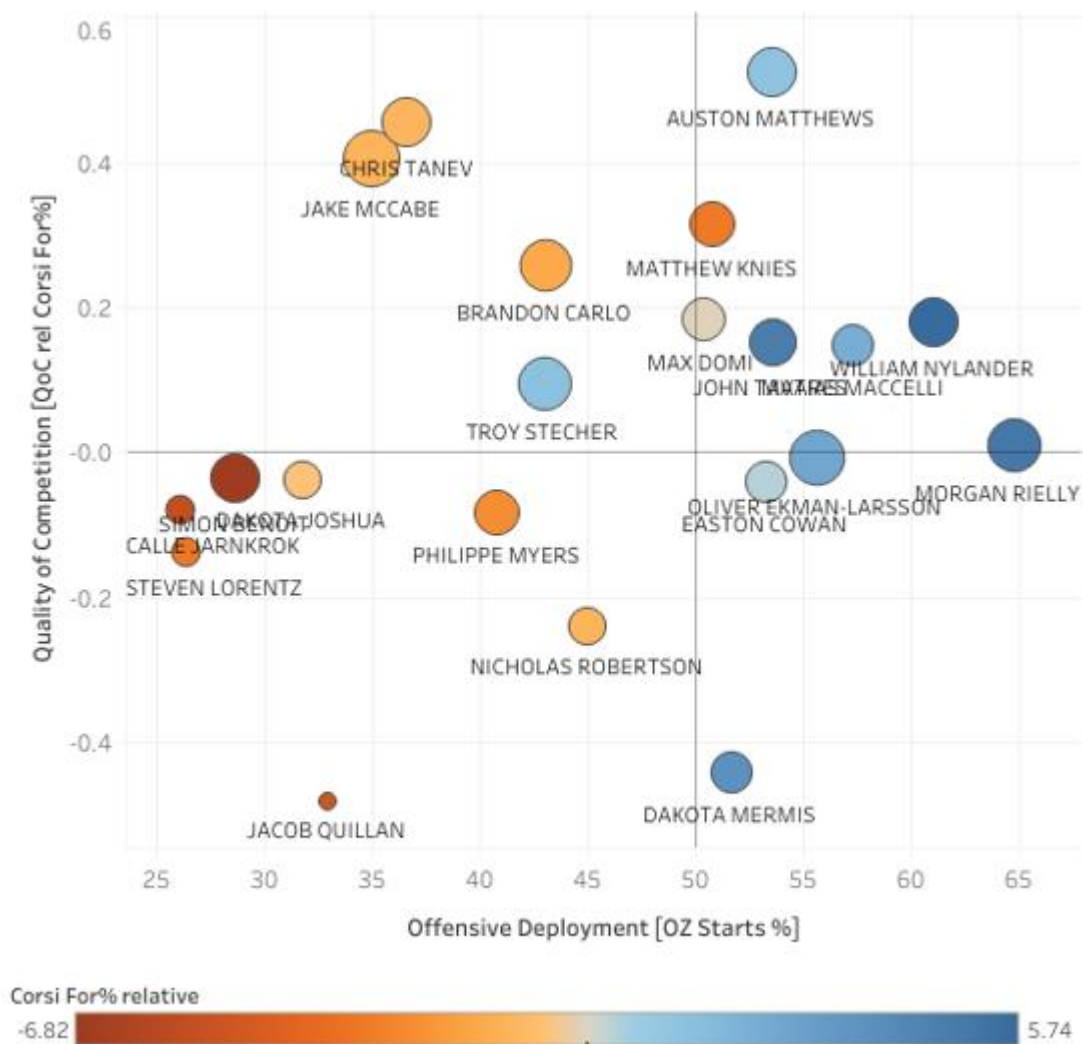
Surprisingly, every player projected to be on the Maple Leafs' roster is signed for at least two more years (until 2027-28).

2027 RFA: none

2027 UFA: none

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Jack Roslovic		
Boom or bust	Emil Andrae		
Multicategory / Banger	Brandon Duhaime		
Salary cap bargain	Gavin McKenna		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Auston Matthews	93	57	292
Brandon Duhaime	56	188	83
Chris Tanev	161	18	51
Colton Sissons	59	105	83
Dakota Joshua	34	207	55
Darren Raddysh	83	62	218
Easton Cowan	40	91	122
Emil Andrae	76	80	79
Gavin McKenna	21	16	180
Jack Roslovic	29	33	146
Jake McCabe	173	107	75
John Tavares	32	65	194
Matthew Knies	36	162	154
Morgan Rielly	111	32	143
Nick Paul	30	105	108
Oliver Ekman-Larsson	77	92	104
Steven Lorentz	46	146	59
Teddy Blueger	35	93	80
Troy Stecher	77	35	57
William Nylander	29	16	221

Dobber Advanced... MAPLE LEAFS



Observation: Tanev, McCabe, and Brandon Carlo (now with St. Louis) were situated in the high-competition, low-offensive-deployment quadrant, indicating they were utilized almost exclusively as the team's defensive shutdown core. With very light orange bubbles, they were actually pretty good in that role.

Fantasy Impact: These players were tasked with the hardest minutes, which severely suppressed their offensive ceilings. They were low-upside options in points-only leagues, though they provided real-world value for the team's defensive structure. Thanks to these guys, the offensive guns could see more time in the offensive zone. Without them, you could knock off 10% of Matthews'/Nylander's points easily.

Observation: Matthews, Nylander, Tavares, Rielly, Matias Maccelli (now with NY Islanders), and Knies occupied the high-offensive, neutral-to-high-competition zone.

Fantasy Impact: This was the heart of the Maple Leafs' offense. Because they were consistently deployed in the offensive zone and tasked with driving play, they were the "must-start" assets on the roster and represented the most reliable bets for high-floor production. Rielly was relatively lower in terms of QoC faced and the furthest to the right for zone starts—almost a sheltered situation. And that's how they got the most out of him—his relative CF% was second on the team. Nylander led the team.

Observation: Knies' bubble was in the orange.

Fantasy Impact: He struggled against the top skilled lines that opponents rolled out there. This could be blamed on youth and inexperience, or maybe he's not as strong two-way as we would like. Time will tell.

Observation: Domi was positioned in the neutral zone, where he faced above-average competition with neutral-zone deployment.

Fantasy Impact: Domi functioned as a steady, secondary offensive asset. He was not relied upon to drive play against

top lines, but he functioned as an okay middle-six, versatile forward. Looking at his spot on the chart and at this point in his career, it is clear that he will never be used as a pure offensive option again.

Observation: Myers occupied a specific position in the mid-left quadrant, receiving defensive-zone deployment against below-average competition.

Fantasy Impact: This was a “transition” role. He was not being leaned on as a defensive anchor, nor was he being heavily sheltered. This made him a volatile fantasy asset whose production was largely dependent on whether he could find chemistry with his partner rather than usage-driven opportunities.

Observation: Nick Robertson (now with Pittsburgh) and Cowan were located below the QofC line, with Cowan seeing tougher QofC but more offensive-zone starts, while Robertson saw mainly weaker QofC and more defensive-zone starts.

Fantasy Impact: Former Coach Berube was holding Robertson back, playing him carefully but not really giving him a chance to put points on the board, which is probably his greatest strength. Hopefully, in Pittsburgh, this changes for him. Cowan was deployed the way a typical rookie would be deployed, but not quite as sheltered as most. He did well, and that bodes well for his future.

Observation: Simon Benoit (now with Philadelphia), Calle Jarnkrok (UFA), Lorentz, and Joshua were locked into the lower-left quadrant, where they faced lower-quality competition but received very little offensive-zone deployment. All were in the orange, with Benoit and Jarnkrok a very dark shade of brown. Joshua’s bubble color was very good for that deployment.

Fantasy Impact: These players were primarily utilized for energy management and defensive maintenance. They were non-factors for offensive fantasy production and generally did not warrant a roster spot in standard formats.

Observation: Mermis and Quillan were situated in the low-usage zones, consistently receiving limited offensive opportunity and playing against the weakest competition.

Fantasy Impact: These players were fringe depth pieces. They were not trusted with significant responsibility in either the offensive or defensive zones, and they should have been avoided in fantasy regardless of league depth, as their ice time was too low to generate sustainable value.

Maple Leafs by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>WILLIAM NYLANDER</u>	R	65	61	1016	0.881	13.5	48.2	66	78.2	79.2	75.9	3.8	12	24.5
<u>JOHN TAVARES</u>	C	82	53.5	990	0.887	10.3	48.4	66.1	72.4	74.6	67.7	2.9	19	47.5
<u>MATTHEW KNIES</u>	L	79	50.8	1003	0.902	10.1	43	66.1	74.2	89.3	51.6	2.7	21	48.8
<u>AUSTON MATTHEWS</u>	C	60	53.5	1016	0.911	10.5	46.9	66.6	62.4	65.1	54.5	2.5	11	42.3
<u>MATIAS MACCELLI</u>	L	71	57.3	998	0.884	11.4	47.8	43.4	70.9	72.1	66.7	2.3	13	52
<u>N ROBERTSON</u>	R	78	45	1006	0.904	10.2	44.8	27.1	71.1	73.7	57.1	1.9	7	43.8
<u>MAX DOMI</u>	C	80	50.3	961	0.885	7.6	45	32.7	69.2	66.7	80	1.8	5	20.8
<u>EASTON COWAN</u>	L	66	53.2	1032	0.935	9.7	45.4	37.2	59.2	63.9	46.2	1.8	8	44.4
<u>DAKOTA JOSHUA</u>	L	55	31.8	1028	0.913	11.5	44.9	5.8	64.3	64.3	0	1.6	2	25
<u>O EKMAN-LARSSON</u>	D	78	55.6	1017	0.898	11.9	47	44.5	38.6	37.5	42.9	1.5	20	64.5
<u>BO GROULX</u>	C	13	31	1111	0.934	17.7	34.7	7.4	45.5	55.6	0	1.5	0	0
<u>NICOLAS ROY</u>	R	59	34.7	1020	0.919	10.1	47.2	17.7	53.2	56.4	28.6	1.4	5	33.3
<u>MORGAN RIELLY</u>	D	78	64.7	999	0.893	10.6	48.8	54.9	35.6	40	26.1	1.3	15	60
<u>STEVEN LORENTZ</u>	L	71	26.4	1000	0.906	9.4	44.1	0.3	62.1	69.2	0	1.3	5	45.5
<u>JAKE MCCABE</u>	D	80	35	1002	0.897	10.5	44.7	7.4	29.4	31.6	0	0.8	10	50
<u>JACOB QUILLAN</u>	C	23	32.9	987	0.882	10.5	39.9	0.5	50	50	0	0.8	1	50

- The gap in Pts/60 between top-liners Nylander and Matthews is astonishing, and in fact there are actually two players separating them. Matthews at 2.5 is easily his career low. He peaked at 4.2 in 2021–22 and since then has been between 3.4 and 3.8.
- If the Leafs need more skilled players capable of 2.0 Pts/60 or more, they need to look at young forwards who are close and then groom them accordingly. Robertson was a good candidate, but they traded him to Pittsburgh. Cowan is good candidate, though. Looking at the PUC (prior page), Cowan was being deployed the right way. Robertson most certainly was not.
- Nylander is a star player who plays with the best on the team, so his 5-on-5 shooting percentage should be high. But 13.5 is too high. His career high is 12 (2017–18), and his production dropped the following year. OEL's number was high, so expect a market correction there. Groulx was pretty impressive in his 13-game stint, but his puck luck was very high in that small window, so don't overrate it.
- On the low 5-on-5 S% side, only Domi pops here with a very low 7.6. His production year over year has stabilized, and there is not much further he can drop.
- The Leafs consistently used the same four forwards on the top PP: Nylander, Tavares, Knies, and Matthews. Rielly was also used most of the time, though OEL would occasionally sub in. Maccelli, Domi, Cowan, and OEL manned the second unit, with Robertson splitting time with Roy for the other spot. Why Robertson wouldn't be a key guy on that unit—you'll have to ask Berube. Domi was very good on the second unit.
- Rielly was almost a non-factor on the top unit with a paltry 26.1 PP IPP. I've never seen a number that low on the first PP unit in all my years of doing this.

Key departures	Craig Berube (Coach), Calle Jarnkrok (UFA), Mattias Maccelli (NYI), Nicholas Robertson (PIT), Simon Benoit (PHI), Joseph Woll (PHI), Dennis Hildeby (TB)
Arrivals	Jim Hiller (Coach), Gavin McKenna (Draft), Nick Paul (TB), Jack Roslovic (EDM), Colton Sissons (VGK), Brandon Duhaime (WSH), Teddy Blueger (VAN), Zack MacEwen (NJD), Darren Raddysh (TB), Emil Andrae (PHI), Sergei Bobrovsky (FLA)

Utah MAMMOTH

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Clayton Keller	82	30	89	33	Vincent Trocheck	79	21	58	56	Nick Schmaltz	83	31	71	18
Logan Cooley	72	25	68	32	Tij Iginla	68	14	31	35	Dylan Guenther	81	41	82	28
Anders Lee	84	23	39	50	Barrett Hayton	74	12	36	51	Daniil But	69	9	19	14
Kailer Yamamoto	67	12	27	18	Jack McBain	77	12	27	73	Lawson Crouse	83	21	40	41
Liam O'Brien	33	3	3	58	Kevin Stenlund	83	9	19	43	Brandon Tanev	51	3	5	30
Joshua Roy	24	2	6	4						Michael Carcone	71	15	29	32
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Mikhail Sergachev	79	10	60	38	M Weegar	83	8	33	59	Karel Vejmelka	60	37	2	2.70
Nate Schmidt	77	4	18	23	John Marino	76	3	30	24	Sebastian Cossa	30	14	1	2.75
Dmitri Simashev	74	3	24	30	Andrew Peeke	66	2	13	18					
Nick Desimone	33	2	7	7	Maveric Lamoureux	60	2	11	88					

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: Yamamoto worked his way back into the NHL and then worked his way back into regular ice time. He had 14 points in his last 33 games and then posted five points in six games playing with Cooley and Guenther in the playoffs, on a line that drove a CF% of 60. But then the Mammoth signed Lee. And on top of that, Iginla looks like he has a real shot at making the team. Cooley has struggled with faceoffs, so moving him to the wing is the logical move. But all this means that Yamamoto's chemistry with Cooley and Guenther won't be tested again. Where does he fit? He enters his BT season coming off a strong second half. I've been back and forth on Yamamoto's outlook, but the safe bet is that he again becomes a fringe player. But let's see how he's used in camp.

On the hot seat: Weegar needs a bounce-back year, and he needs to do it on the second PP unit. It's a pretty strong unit with a lot of talented bodies. Weegar had six PPPts last season after posting 21 the year before. Now 32, he has already lost a lot of fantasy relevance, but he'll lose all of it if he can't get back to the 40-point mark this season.

- Crouse suffered a slow start, thanks to being handcuffed to McBain and Carcone for much of the first half. Things certainly turned around when he was moved to a line with Schmaltz and Keller. He started off with just 14 points in 37 games. After December 20, he tallied 30 points in 44 contests. But bad news for Crouse owners: with the additions of Lee and Trocheck, as well as the likely promotion of either Iginla or Desnoyers, Crouse will likely not get back onto that line.

- One thing in favor of Crouse somehow keeping that spot is the fact that Keller's game went to another level once they were placed together. So, is Crouse the chicken or the egg? Keller had 36 points in 43 games, and then ended the year with an astounding 52 in 39. If Coach Andre Tourigny feels that he can handle Schmaltz's subpar faceoff skills as long as the line works, then Crouse will have a career year. But that's unlikely, given that the team went out and acquired Trocheck and paid a lot to get him.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Clayton Keller	97	87	Sebastian Cossa	100%	
Dylan Guenther	90	80	Dmitri Simashev	95%	
Logan Cooley	92	72	Tij Iginla	90%	
Nick Schmaltz	75	70	Maveric Lamoureux	80%	
Tij Iginla	90	65	Caleb Desnoyers	30%	
Mikhail Sergachev	73	62	Joshua Roy	20%	
Vincent Trocheck	72	55			
Caleb Desnoyers	80	53			
Ethan Belchetz	80	53			
Daniil But	70	48			
Barrett Hayton	67	47			
Lawson Crouse	58	42	Sleeper	Pts	%
Anders Lee	57	42	Tij Iginla	60	20%
Kailer Yamamoto	65	38	Logan Cooley	85	15%
Jack McBain	52	35	Vincent Trocheck	70	15%
MacKenzie Weegar	48	33	Caleb Desnoyers	55	10%
Dmitri Simashev	45	33	Kailer Yamamoto	45	10%
Tomas Lavoie	50	33			
Joshua Roy	70	32			

- Guenther is underrated and appears to be on track to becoming a star. The numbers he put up despite not always playing with Cooley, Schmaltz or Keller were impressive. From December 2 onward, Guenther, 22 at the time, had 54 points in 52 games, playing 93 ES minutes on three different lines: Keller-Schmaltz, Crouse-Hayton, Carcone-McBain,

not to mention 79 minutes with Yamamoto–McBain. No time to form chemistry with anyone, just putting up big points no matter who he played with.

- Lee traditionally shoots between a 12–13% success rate, and last year with the NY Islanders, his S% was just 9.5%. That tells us that he should score a few more than the 19 goals he got. But his 42 points in 2025–26? That seems legit, given his age (36) and the fact that he won't get in on Utah's top power play.
- Some fantasy owners probably remember that Cooley had 14 goals and 23 points in his first 25 games. It should be noted, however, that he had four points and three points in back-to-back games (against St. Louis and Minnesota), plus a five-point game against Vegas, clustering those 23 points. He is a high-upside player with consistency issues and—so far—injury concerns.
- Trocheck has been very consistent in that 0.72 to 0.79 points-per-game range. The only exception is when he saw a spike in PP time in 2023–24. He had 24 PPTs that year, pushing his points-per-game average up to 0.94. It stands to reason that Utah will give him that kind of PP time because he is their best faceoff man. For this reason, he makes a great sleeper pick for 70 points.

Injuries:

Hayton missed the Mammoth's final playoff game due to an upper-body injury. Likely a minor issue, as he signed a July 1 offer sheet with New Jersey that Utah matched. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Hayton.

Breakout Threshold:

Yamamoto, who stands at 5-9, has played 379 career NHL games and enters his BT season. All he needs is a chance, but he is unlikely to get it. Both Guenther and Cooley have just recently passed the 200-game mark. They each have tremendous upside and could have that star-powered season we know they can reach.

Goalies:

No goalie played in more games in 2025-26 than Vejmelka, whose 64 games were five more than the next-highest goalie. With that heavy volume, Vejmelka was only one win behind Tampa Bay's Andrei Vasilevskiy for the league lead. Perhaps the Mammoth would like to lessen Vejmelka's workload, as they have acquired 23-year-old top goaltending prospect Sebastian Cossa from Detroit. Cossa already has three solid AHL seasons under his belt, so he seems ready for NHL action. He may be limited to around 30 games as Vejmelka's backup, but he should stay in the NHL all season because he is no longer waiver-exempt and Utah parted with the 23rd overall pick to acquire him. Vejmelka won't need to play 60+ games anymore, but he should still be the starter for the Mammoth. **Dobber's confidence that Vejmelka is the starter: 99%**

Contract Year:

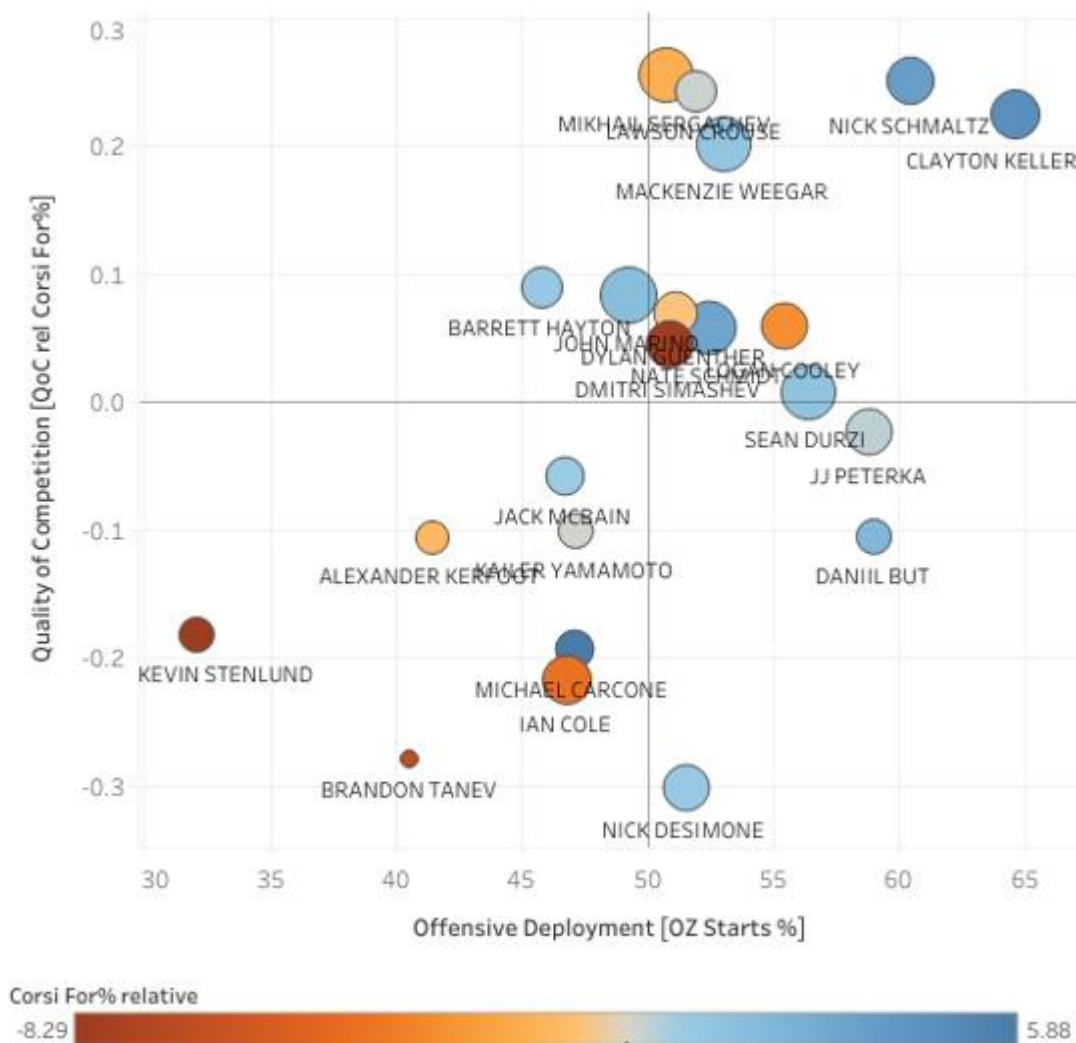
The offer sheet that Hayton signed (and was matched) was for one year, so it marches him straight to free agency if he is not extended by July 1. Note that the Mammoth can sign Hayton to an extension on January 1 or after, but they cannot trade him for one year. Hayton had a subpar year in 2025-26 and will be hoping to prove himself with the one-year deal... Crouse has been with the Arizona/Utah organization for a decade. His loyalty and physical play could make him a priority for an extension.

2027 RFA: none

2027 UFA: Hayton, Crouse, Stenlund, O'Brien, Peeke

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Dylan Guenther		
Boom or bust	Kailer Yamamoto		
Multicategory / Banger	MacKenzie Weegar		
Salary cap bargain	Karel Vejmelka		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Anders Lee	33	105	184
Barrett Hayton	37	33	133
Clayton Keller	32	10	222
Daniil But	47	46	124
Dmitri Simashev	81	44	75
Dylan Guenther	32	73	267
Jack McBain	48	268	100
John Marino	81	23	61
Kailer Yamamoto	22	52	74
Kevin Stenlund	58	50	75
Lawson Crouse	54	198	133
Logan Cooley	40	65	152
MacKenzie Weegar	174	182	165
Maveric Lamoureux	60	96	66
Michael Carcone	18	106	120
Mikhail Sergachev	134	47	150
Nate Schmidt	85	65	69
Nick Schmaltz	46	18	191
Tij Iginla	27	85	136
Vincent Trocheck	55	205	150

Dobber Advanced... MAMMOTH



Observation: Sergachev, Crouse, Schmaltz, Weegar, and Keller were clustered in the high-competition, high-offensive-deployment quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: These players were the engine of the Utah offense. They were tasked with driving play against the toughest competition, making them the most valuable “must-start” assets on the roster regardless of the matchup. The obvious best players on the team, and this is where the bubbles for the best players are generally found. Keller and Schmaltz, with more offensive-zone starts, dominated possession.

Observation: Marino, Guenther, Schmidt, Cooley, and Simashev occupied the offense/defense, neutral-to-moderate-competition zone. Cooley struggled a little despite often starting in the other zone, and Simashev’s bubble shading (in his 28 games) implies that he was way out of his element with that deployment.

Fantasy Impact: These players were entrusted with substantial responsibility, operating in a “heavy-usage” role where they were expected to produce offensively despite facing above-average competition. Far from being sheltered, they were being relied upon as legitimate top-nine/top-four contributors, making them high-value assets who were being tested in difficult, high-leverage minutes. Simashev’s struggles imply that he may need more time in the AHL, or if he’s in the NHL—better-sheltered deployment.

Observation: Hayton and McBain were situated near the center of the chart, operating in a neutral zone where they faced average competition (Hayton higher, McBain lower) with balanced offensive/defensive-zone deployment but leaning more defensive.

Fantasy Impact: This usage indicated a “middle-ground” role. They were neither the primary offensive drivers nor pure shutdown specialists, which made their production more dependent on finding chemistry with linemates rather than usage advantages. They functioned best as streamers. Production will be limited unless and until they get moved to another line and/or deployed differently.

Observation: But and JJ Peterka (now with Boston) were positioned in the offensive-right lower quadrant, receiving high offensive-zone deployment while facing lower competition on the roster. Somewhat sheltered and doing well with that deployment.

Fantasy Impact: This was a classic “sheltered” development deployment. The coaching staff prioritized offensive confidence and high-upside opportunities for these two, making them ideal targets for dynasty or keeper leagues where you are betting on environment-driven scoring growth. But’s bubble is lower, and it is no surprise given that he was a rookie. Peterka will need to be able to handle tougher zone starts in Boston because he’s been around long enough.

Observation: Kerfoot and Yamamoto were positioned in the mid-left quadrant, receiving low offensive-zone starts against lower-level competition.

Fantasy Impact: This was a mix of sheltering/no trust against QofC, but also fewer starts in the offensive zone, where they would obviously do better. This signals “depth player” and tells us to steer clear in fantasy.

Observation: Carcone and Cole were isolated in the low-offensive-deployment area, facing fairly soft competition. Similar to Kerfoot and Yamamoto, but trusted even less.

Fantasy Impact: These were energy-management minutes. The coaching staff utilized them primarily to bridge gaps between top-six shifts, which meant they had effectively zero fantasy relevance in points-only formats. Carcone’s dark-blue bubble implies that he was unfairly used this way, but fringe players trying to break in late in their career like this will have to do twice as much to get half as far.

Observation: Stenlund and Tanev were situated in the lower-left quadrant, receiving the least offensive opportunity on the team. Neither did well, despite low QofC.

Fantasy Impact: These players functioned exclusively as fourth-line energy assets. Their deployment was strictly for defensive maintenance, and they should have been avoided entirely in every fantasy league structure.

Mammoth by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>CLAYTON KELLER</u>	L	82	64.6	1013	0.893	12	55.9	70.8	70.4	70.9	69.2	3.4	20	32.3
<u>DYLAN GUENTHER</u>	R	79	51.1	1015	0.904	11.1	52.9	69.3	70.2	76.6	60	3.2	10	30.3
<u>LOGAN COOLEY</u>	C	54	55.5	1025	0.907	11.8	51.2	56.1	60.6	73.3	41.7	2.8	8	42.1
<u>NICK SCHMALTZ</u>	C	82	60.4	1006	0.885	12.1	55.2	68.2	62.7	69.2	54.1	2.7	11	26.8
<u>JJ PETERKA</u>	L	82	58.8	1016	0.919	9.7	53.4	42	71.2	77.8	41.7	2.2	11	50
<u>LAWSON CROUSE</u>	R	81	51.9	1018	0.899	11.9	53.4	22.3	58.7	63.6	16.7	2	6	30
<u>KAILER YAMAMOTO</u>	L	59	47.1	1021	0.892	12.9	53	9	62.2	62.2	0	2	3	30
<u>MICHAEL CARCONE</u>	R	79	47	987	0.898	8.9	56.9	20.9	64.6	65.9	57.1	1.9	7	46.7
<u>MIKHAIL SERGACHEV</u>	D	78	50.7	989	0.897	9.2	51.9	66.9	50	41.3	66.7	1.9	33	67.3
<u>ALEXANDER KERFOOT</u>	L	34	41.4	986	0.869	11.7	52.1	8.6	65	70.6	0	1.8	3	50
<u>BARRETT HAYTON</u>	C	67	45.8	973	0.893	8	54	43.7	47.2	47.5	46.2	1.5	8	53.3
<u>SEAN DURZI</u>	D	60	56.3	976	0.887	8.9	53.6	27.7	54	51.1	80	1.4	12	54.5
<u>JACK MCBAIN</u>	L	75	46.7	1006	0.907	9.9	52.6	7.8	50	52.2	0	1.4	6	37.5
<u>JOHN MARINO</u>	D	80	49.2	1043	0.911	13.2	53.8	1.8	37.9	39.3	0	1.3	17	53.1
<u>DANIIL BUT</u>	R	29	59	1001	0.919	8.2	53.5	27.8	46.7	33.3	100	1.2	2	50
<u>MACKENZIE WEEGAR</u>	D	19	53	948	0.882	6.6	51.6	20.5	40	38.9	46.2	1.1	3	50

- Some nice scoring depth on this team, with seven players posting 2.0 Pts/60 or higher. Seeing Yamamoto among them has me wondering what would happen if he were entrusted with more. After being a top prospect for years, he has been a fringe NHLer for three seasons now. His 5-on-5 S% was very high, though, so it's not a sure thing that things would get better.
- Weegar had a tough time putting points on the board in Calgary, and it didn't get any better with Utah, given his 1.1 points per 60 minutes.
- Yamamoto and Marino had 5-on-5 S% that was far too high, while Schmaltz, Cooley, and Kerfoot were also a little high with this stat. On the flip side, Weegar, Hayton, and But should be in for a positive market correction at even strength.
- The first unit with the man advantage featured Keller, Guenther, Schmaltz, Cooley, and Sergachev. Of these players, Cooley contributed the least at 41.7 PP IPP.
- The second unit saw Peterka, Hayton, But, Sean Durzi (now with NY Rangers), and Weegar. Carcone and Crouse also saw some PPTOI. Crouse did not help much, given his paltry 16.7% PP IPP. Durzi and But were the strongest. Given Sergachev is the primary defenseman on the top PP, it's unlikely Durzi would have moved up. But, But (see what I did there?) could threaten Cooley's spot if he doesn't do more.
- After having 35 secondary assists and 25 primary in 2024–25, Keller had 20 and 42 in 2025–26. That's a big swing. Getting a few more secondary "throw-in" assists would push him closer to 100 points.

Key departures	JJ Peterka (BOS), Alexander Kerfoot (NSH), Cole Beaudoin (NYR), Sean Durzi (NYR), Ian Cole (CHI), Vitek Vanecek (NYI)
Arrivals	Vincent Trocheck (NYR), Anders Lee (NYI), Andrew Peeke (BOS), Sebastian Cossa (DET)

Vancouver CANUCKS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Jake DeBrusk	83	25	45	16	Elias Pettersson	76	20	69	16	Linus Karlsson	80	15	37	40
Liam Ohgren	79	10	29	6	Marco Rossi	79	20	61	31	Brock Boeser	79	29	57	14
Drew O'Connor	84	14	30	34	Filip Chytil	51	13	29	21	Brendan Gallagher	81	14	30	56
Paul Cotter	80	10	16	42	Aatu Raty	69	9	22	20	Ty Mueller	30	3	5	10
Max Sasson	50	8	14	15	Braeden Cootes	8	1	2	0	Jonathan Lekkerimaki	15	2	4	0
Arshdeep Bains	14	1	2	4	Caleb Malhotra	2	0	1	0	M MacEachern	4	0	2	2
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Zeev Buium	78	7	32	42	Filip Hronek	77	8	48	38	Thatcher Demko	46	17	1	2.90
Elias Pettersson	72	3	10	43	Tom Willander	77	6	25	23	Kevin Lankinen	43	12	0	3.35
Jamie Oleksiak	83	4	13	37	Luke Schenn	65	1	6	45	Nikita Tolopilo	3	0	0	3.50
Kirill Kudryavtsev	20	1	12	2	Victor Mancini	17	0	3	4					
Sawyer Mynio	15	1	2	6										

Restricted Free Agents: none

Future Fantasy Stud: It seems as if Rossi has been in the league forever. He was drafted six years ago and his keeper-league owners have either lost patience or consider him a 60-point player. But the fact is, he has played just three NHL seasons, and one of them (last year) was marred by injuries. He is going to be an elite producer in this league, and he makes those around him—his linemates—much, much better. He is a serious “buy low” candidate.

On the hot seat: Do we really need to say it? Pettersson (C) followed up 102 points and 89 points with 45 and 51. He got his massive contract and then struggled to match the play that made him so great. He’s putting a lot of pressure on himself, too. Drafting him could mean an 85-point star or another 45-point dud.

- Vancouver has a strategy; we just don’t know what it is. If they are truly going for the first overall draft pick next year, they’ll send both Cootes and Malhotra back down. If they want to pretend they have a chance at a playoff spot, they’ll keep them. Just understand that keeping one or both of those players out of camp absolutely does not mean that they will keep them beyond the nine-game mark.

- Ohgren is a top prospect and a former first-round draft pick, part of the package acquired in the Quinn Hughes trade. He does have top-six upside; however, progress has been slow. But he’s only 22 and definitely making strides. After starting 2025-26 with just six points in 41 games, Ohgren started finding his stride with 12 in 28, primarily playing with Rossi. He hasn’t been given much PP time, so don’t consider him a keeper-league asset until that happens. But he’s on the right path.

- Rossi had 13 points in 17 games with Minnesota before being traded in the Hughes package. Two lower-body injuries marred his Vancouver time, but don’t worry too much about his proneness to injury—he played two full 82-game seasons before that. A healthy Rossi, even on a weak team, will still get you more than 60 points. And he is good enough to pad the stats of those on his line.

- Buium, the last member of the Hughes trade deal, was the only player to disappoint after arriving. He had eight points in the first 10 games of the season with Minnesota, five on the power play. And it was all downhill from there: just 18 points in 66 games after that, and only eight more points on the power play. By mid-January he was taken off the first

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Elias Pettersson	102	68	Caleb Malhotra	45%		
Marco Rossi	95	70	Braeden Cootes	45%		
Caleb Malhotra	73	62	Ty Mueller	40%		
Brock Boeser	75	57	Sawyer Mynio	40%		
J Lekkerimaki	75	52	Jonathan Lekkerimaki	30%		
Filip Hronek	67	50	Kirill Kudryavtsev	20%		
Zeev Buium	75	50				
Jake DeBrusk	65	50				
Braeden Cootes	68	50				
Adam Novotny	70	50				
Linus Karlsson	65	45				
Liam Ohgren	70	42	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Tom Willander	58	42	Marco Rossi	80	15%	
Niklas Aaram-Olsen	65	40	Linus Karlsson	50	15%	
Brooks Rogowski	62	40	Elias Pettersson	90	10%	
Riley Patterson	72	39	Caleb Malhotra	60	10%	
Filip Chytil	68	38	Braeden Cootes	50	10%	
Aatu Raty	68	38	Filip Chytil	55	10%	
Brendan Gallagher	50	35				

power-play unit, and given how well Hronek took over—do not expect Buium to get it back this season. Buium has quickly become a longer-term project, but still has tremendous (near-point-per-game) upside.

- Boeser had a very disappointing season, but he did collect 30 points in his last 36 games, so do not write him off just yet. He was put on a line with Rossi and Ohgren, and it completely changed his production. Yes, the “Rossi Effect” strikes again.

- Hronek had a respectable 16 points in 31 games (0.52) playing alongside Quinn Hughes at even strength and seeing secondary PP time. He had 33 points in 51 games (0.65) after that, and in the final 20 games he was manning the top PP unit. He had 10 PPPts in those last 20 games.

Injuries:

Chytil played in just 12 games in 2025–26 due to concussion issues. He says he will be ready for training camp, but at this point he should be considering whether continuing his career is worth it... Demko returned to the ice in late June, stating that he believes the most recent procedure will put an end to the lingering lower-body issues he has had over the past two-plus seasons. It sounds positive, but we’ll have to wait and see whether he will be ready for training camp.

Dobber’s Band-Aid Boys: Schenn, Chytil, Demko.

Breakout Threshold:

Rossi has played 235 career games. He’s 5-9 and technically qualifies for the 400-game BT. But he’s also a Top 10 pick, and we can see him hitting sooner. It’s another reason to consider him a buy-low candidate in your dynasty.

Goalies:

Demko’s three-year extension (starting in 2026–27) kicks in this season. Although he is optimistic that he can return to full health, we’ll have to see it to believe it. On top of that, the Canucks have begun a rebuild, which further discounts Demko’s fantasy value. Even if he is healthy, Demko may need to be limited to a timeshare role or at least not the high-volume starter he once was. That means Lankinen should see plenty of action, although his fantasy value is effectively no higher than Demko’s. If Demko is injured again and Lankinen is on the verge of being overworked as a result, Nikita Tolopilo should step in. He is no longer waiver-exempt, which means the Canucks should strongly consider carrying three goalies entering the season. Regardless, this is a situation to avoid. **Dobber’s confidence that Demko is the starter: 55%**

Contract Year:

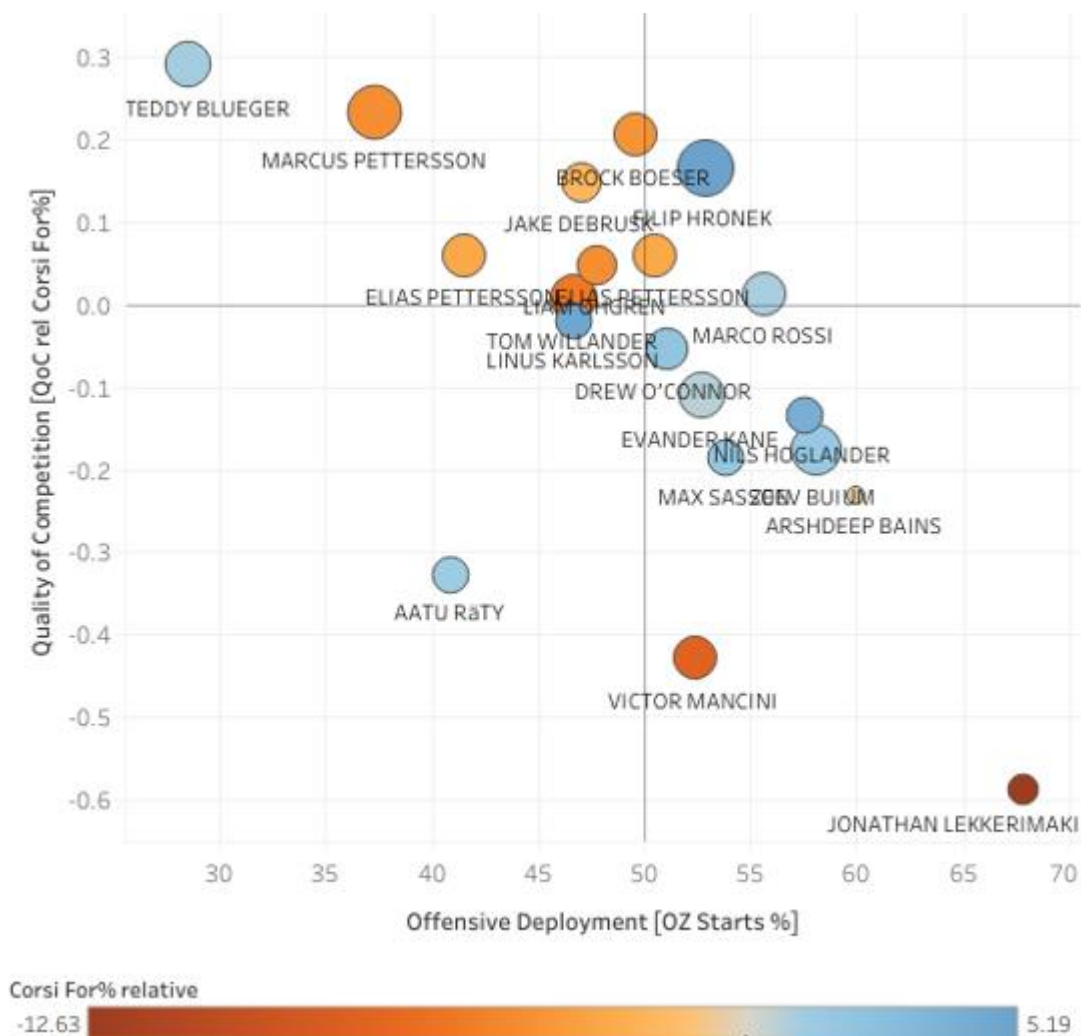
The biggest priority contract-wise will be Buium. An important component of the Quinn Hughes to Minnesota trade, his game resembles Hughes’ to some degree. He could be signed to a long-term extension soon... This is an important season for Lekkerimaki and Raty, who will both need to demonstrate they can contribute offensively at the NHL level... Gallagher will get to prove he still belongs in the NHL by spending the final year of his six-year deal in his hometown. If the Canucks are well out of the playoff race, he and other UFA could be dealt at the trade deadline for futures as the Canucks continue a full rebuild.

2027 RFA: Lekkerimaki, Ohgren, Raty, ~~Buium~~, E. Pettersson (the defenseman)

2027 UFA: Chytil, Gallagher, O’Connor, Cotter, Schenn, Tolopilo

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Marco Rossi		
Boom or bust	Elias Pettersson (C)		
Multicategory / Banger	Filip Hronek		
Salary cap bargain	Zeev Buium		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Aatu Raty	17	169	76
Brendan Gallagher	32	97	137
Brock Boeser	31	55	174
Drew O’Connor	46	79	142
Elias Pettersson	88	79	152
Elias Pettersson (D)	94	130	58
Filip Chytil	15	17	112
Filip Hronek	100	111	130
Jake DeBrusk	42	75	199
Jamie Oleksiak	132	101	74
Kirill Kudryavtsev	22	7	24
Liam Ohgren	51	87	119
Linus Karlsson	24	85	136
Luke Schenn	88	182	52
Marco Rossi	43	71	126
Max Sasson	25	25	50
Paul Cotter	28	208	88
Tom Willander	92	42	92
Ty Mueller	30	27	24
Zeev Buium	67	32	101

Dobber Advanced... CANUCKS



Observation: Teddy Blueger (now with Toronto) and Marcus Pettersson (now with NY Rangers) were locked into the high-competition, low-offensive-deployment quadrant.

Fantasy Impact: These players served as the team's defensive anchors. Because they were consistently tasked with the "hard" defensive minutes against the opponent's best, their offensive upside was heavily suppressed. They were generally poor options in points-only fantasy formats, functioning best in leagues that rewarded Hits, blocks, or defensive-zone stability. Now that they're gone, Oleksiak and Schenn will take on that role.

Observation: Boeser and Hronek occupied the offensive, high-competition zone. Hronek did very well in the role.

Fantasy Impact: These were the team's premier workhorses. By handling high-leverage defensive minutes while still being deployed in the offensive zone, they proved they were the only true matchup-proof assets on the roster. They represented the safest bets for high-floor production, and players in that spot are generally the most valuable assets on the team. Easier deployment would obviously help their numbers, but those were needed for the riskier players.

Observation: Elias Pettersson (C), Ohgren, Willander, O'Connor, and Karlsson functioned right around the center of the chart, facing average competition with zone deployment at both ends. Willander struggled a lot with that usage, and EP40 and Ohgren also struggled somewhat.

Fantasy Impact: This was a reliable "workhorse" usage. They were not sheltered, but they were trusted enough to drive play. This usage made them high-value, consistent fantasy contributors who could provide secondary scoring without the volatility of a purely sheltered role. In the case of highly paid star Pettersson, this result should be quite alarming.

Observation: Nils Hoglander (now with Nashville), Kane, Sasson, Bains, and Buium resided in the high-offensive-deployment area while facing easier quality of competition. All of them had strong/solid results.

Fantasy Impact: This was the ideal "offensive specialist" usage. The coaching staff successfully insulated this group

from the opposition's shutdown units, which inflated their scoring chances. Bains did not do very well, but the others did fine. Buium's production slowed in the second half, but he obviously still did the right things.

Observation: Lekkerimaki operated as a complete outlier in the far-right, low-competition sector, receiving the highest offensive-zone deployment on the team with the softest competition. He did very poorly, posting a team-low relative Corsi For %.

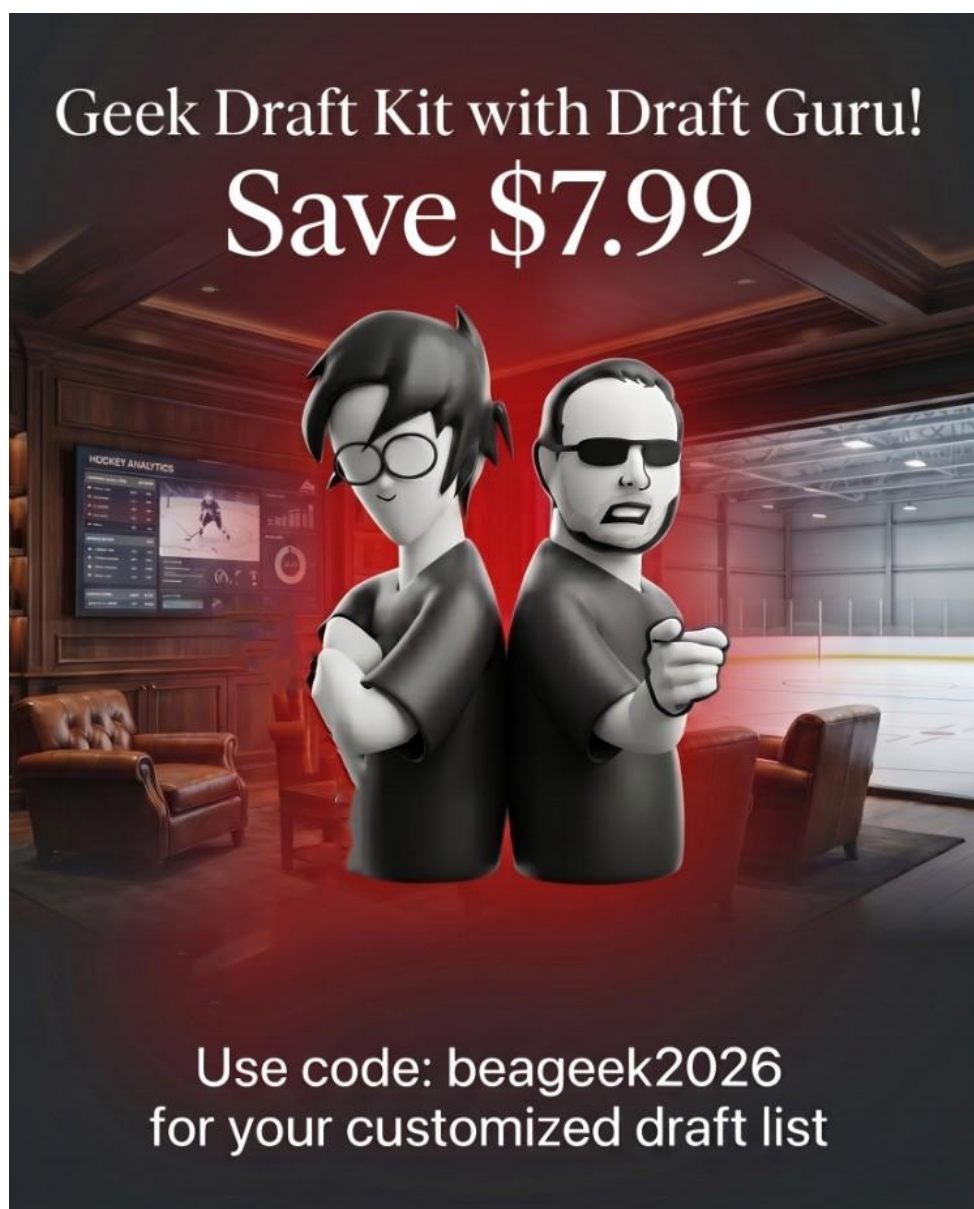
Fantasy Impact: This was a textbook "developmental" deployment. The coaching staff was clearly trying to force-feed him scoring opportunities to build his confidence. The fact that he couldn't build on this kind of usage should be very concerning for his keeper-league owners.

Observation: Rossi was given good offensive-zone starts (55%) and average QofC, centering faceoffs against any competition. He drove positive possession with this usage.

Fantasy Impact: This is as expected. He was acquired to potentially be a top-six center—even a No. 1 center if Pettersson continues to falter—so giving him the zone starts needed to succeed is what we knew would happen.

Observation: Raty sat in the defensive, low-competition quadrant with little offensive deployment. He did reasonably well in that role.

Fantasy Impact: Raty was clearly in a transition phase. He wasn't being buried, but he wasn't getting the premium offensive starts needed to thrive. His fantasy production was likely inconsistent, making him a "wait-and-see" prospect rather than a reliable start in most formats.



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Canucks by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
MARCO ROSSI	C	33	55.6	985	0.879	10.6	46.7	70.8	60.3	67.7	51.9	2.3	7	50
ELIAS PETTERSSON	C	74	50.5	971	0.897	7.4	44.7	69.8	50	49.2	59.5	2.2	16	44.4
LINUS KARLSSON	R	79	46.7	933	0.832	10.1	50.5	29.4	66	77.5	30.8	2.1	8	40
BROCK BOESER	R	75	49.6	953	0.879	7.4	44.5	72	60	74.4	47.5	2	6	23.1
TEDDY BLUEGER	C	35	28.5	967	0.865	10.2	44.8	3	65.4	76.2	100	1.8	5	62.5
JAKE DEBRUSK	L	81	47	966	0.893	7.3	45.3	66.8	56	56.3	61.5	1.8	9	47.4
EVANDER KANE	R	71	52.7	992	0.902	9	47.9	33.6	57.4	62.5	54.5	1.6	4	22.2
DREW O'CONNOR	L	82	51	986	0.898	8.8	48.4	8.6	63	70	0	1.5	2	16.7
LIAM OHGREN	L	51	47.7	981	0.905	7.6	42.7	9.8	69.2	70.8	0	1.5	3	30
MAX SASSON	L	66	53.8	963	0.886	7.7	50.1	8.4	70.4	72	50	1.5	2	33.3
FILIP HRONEK	D	82	52.8	987	0.906	8.1	49.7	42.1	50.5	40.6	75	1.4	19	46.3
ARSHDEEP BAINS	L	28	60	989	0.929	6	48.6	5.3	62.5	66.7	50	1.2	2	50
AATU RATY	R	66	40.8	998	0.92	7.8	48.4	2.7	60.9	63.6	0	1.1	4	40
TOM WILLANDER	D	70	46.7	985	0.886	9.9	43.2	26.1	44.7	45	50	1.1	11	68.8
FILIP CHYTIL	C	12	59.8	934	0.88	5.4	48.3	25.2	60	60	0	1	0	0
ZEEV BUIUM	D	45	58	975	0.906	6.9	48.3	43.1	41.3	32.5	56.5	0.8	5	55.6

- The Canucks were the only team in the league without a single player reaching 2.4 Pts/60. They had just four players hit 2.0. Interesting to see Karlsson finish third on the team. Rossi, the only player to reach 2.3, played 15 games with Minnesota and put up 13 points there, which boosted his Pts/60. Yes, last season was bleak.
- Nobody on the team posted a high 5-on-5 S%. Sure, Rossi was near the top, but still within a normal range. On the low end, there was no shortage. Elias Pettersson (C) finished at 7.4, making me look bad after last year's prediction that he would rebound. That 7.4 was the lowest—and worst puck luck—of his career.
- Boeser, DeBrusk, Ohgren, Raty, Chytil, Buium, and even Hronek all had 5-on-5 S% numbers that were far too low. It was team-wide—they simply couldn't score.
- Rossi, E. Pettersson (C), Boeser, DeBrusk, and Hronek (after Quinn Hughes was traded) made up the first power-play unit. Buium quarterbacked the second unit but also saw time on the top unit. Kane, Willander, and Karlsson rounded out the second unit. No other player had more than a 10.0 PP IPP, implying that first-unit players doubled up on the second unit (including Hughes before he was traded).
- Hronek was very good on the power play, with a 75 PP IPP. Buium's number was 56.5, which wasn't great—he still needs to adjust to the league.
- Karlsson wasn't strong with the man advantage. He had a great rookie season, but there may not be much more offensive upside beyond that.

Key departures	Adam Foote (Coach), Caleb Malhotra (Draft), Teddy Blueger (TOR), Nils Hoglander (NSH), Evander Kane (UFA), Marcus Pettersson (NYR), Derek Forbort (UFA)
Arrivals	Manny Malhotra (Coach), Brendan Gallagher (MTL), Paul Cotter (NJD), Jamie Oleksiak (SEA), Luke Schenn (BUF)

Vegas GOLDEN KNIGHTS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Ivan Barbashev	80	23	56	23	Jack Eichel	75	29	92	19	Mark Stone	63	22	60	15
Brett Howden	75	23	51	45	William Karlsson	58	16	38	13	Mitch Marner	83	27	99	20
Alexander Holtz	56	7	17	12	Tomas Hertl	75	26	55	29	Braeden Bowman	74	11	35	16
Trevor Connelly	52	11	25	16	Nic Dowd	76	10	20	60	Victor Olofsson	77	15	32	11
Jonas Rondbjerg	31	2	7	6	Tanner Laczynski	11	2	4	4	Marc Gatcomb	63	9	11	10
					Kai Uchacz	12	0	3	6					
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Brayden McNabb	78	5	17	33	Shea Theodore	69	10	61	21	Carter Hart	51	35	2	2.70
Noah Hanifin	80	9	39	18	R Andersson	82	13	43	61	Adin Hill	30	17	1	2.80
Parker Wotherspoon	79	2	19	55	Jeremy Lauzon	69	3	12	88	Carl Lindbom	8	3	0	3.00
Ville Heinola	18	1	4	4	Jaycob Megna	6	0	1	2					
Dylan Coghlan	5	0	1	2	Adam Ginning	7	0	1	4					

Restricted Free Agents: Holtz

Camp battle: Bowman will compete with Holtz and hotshot prospect Connelly for the final top-nine spot and second PP spot. Bowman has some NHL experience, has been successful at times, and has the inside track. Holtz has likely run out of chances, but he's still just 24 and is just shy of his breakthrough threshold (BT) mark (191 career games played). Connelly is the wild card. He is Vegas's top prospect coming off a very good AHL season. He has been hampered by injuries a little, which could also play a role. But if he wins the job, he is a worthy waiver pickup.

What to look for in camp: Last season, the Golden Knights employed a five-forward PP system. And what's more—those five forwards played nearly 80% of the available PP time, barely leaving any scraps for anyone else. It was the sole reason that Theodore's numbers tanked. Now they have a new coach and, due to cap reasons, were forced to trade Pavel Dorofeyev to the NY Rangers. Changing back to four forwards and one defenseman on the power play is the difference between Theodore getting 40 versus 60+ points.

- Holtz was a seventh-overall pick in 2020 and has been nothing but a disappointment ever since. While his top-six upside potential is pretty much DOA, there is some hope of salvaging middle-six numbers. He enters his BT season, and he had nine points in his last 19 games playing on a depth line.

- Most people into hockey and fantasy hockey already know about Howden's playoff performance, but just in case—he was put on a line with Marner and Karlsson and the line took off. Marner was out of this world, and Howden scored 14 playoff goals. That's more than the 12 he got in the entire season. While Howden will not sustain that pace, simply playing with Marner will see him reach career highs, assuming the chemistry holds. His career high so far is 40 points.

- Marner disappointed last season, and many actually believe that he's just not as productive in Vegas, even with the playoff surge. Not the case. The fact is, he is a winger. And when Karlsson went down very early in the season, the cap-strapped Golden Knights had no other option for center. So, they put Marner there. He's not a center, but as with all elite players, he can certainly play the position. But his production slid down as a result. Karlsson was back in time for the playoffs, and you saw what happened to Marner after that. As long as Karlsson can center that unit, Marner will produce like his old self. If Karlsson gets hurt again, Marner owners better hope the team acquires a center for him.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Mitch Marner	118	98	Trevor Connelly	70%	
Jack Eichel	112	92	Ville Heinola	40%	
Mark Stone	92	68	Kai Uchacz	40%	
Tomas Hertl	77	65	Adam Ginning	35%	
Ivan Barbashev	70	60			
Shea Theodore	75	58			
Rasmus Andersson	57	48			
Brett Howden	58	47			
Trevor Connelly	80	45			
Noah Hanifin	55	42			
William Karlsson	67	42			
Jonah Sivertson	72	42	Sleeper	Pts	%
Braeden Bowman	65	40	Shea Theodore	60	20%
Lukas Cormier	55	37	Trevor Connelly	50	15%
Alexander Holtz	58	35	William Karlsson	55	15%
Victor Olofsson	50	35	Brett Howden	60	10%
Jakob Ihs Wozniak	72	35			
Mateo Nobert	67	35			
Tuomas Uronen	65	35			

- Stone has gone seven consecutive seasons playing 66 games or fewer. He has been struggling with back issues and is a high risk to miss time. Despite that, and despite being 34, he is still a prolific producer. That being said, the wear and tear of the season takes its toll, and he tends to slow as the season goes on. Last year he had 13 points in the first six games, but just 13 in the last 17.

- After the trade to Vegas, Andersson's PP time went from just under three minutes per game down to just one minute per game. In 33 games with Vegas, he had 17 points, versus 30 points in 48 games before that.

- Theodore went from about three minutes of PP time per game down to 1:23 last season, thanks to the five-forward system. He generally gets 15–19 PPTs, so last season's five really hurt his fantasy owners. He'll get the spot back, as noted, thanks to the Dorofeyev trade. Need proof he will bounce back? In the playoffs, he played over two minutes PPTOI and had 18 points in 22 games.

- After Stone was sidelined, Bowman was recalled and enjoyed early success on the Eichel line, posting 13 points in 20 games. It was short-lived, and his numbers faded as time went on. Do not overrate. He had just 13 in 34 after that.

Injuries:

Karlsson underwent surgery in June for a broken wrist that occurred during the Stanley Cup Final... Pietrangelo (hip) has been returned to LTIR for the final year of his contract. The move to LTIR allowed the Golden Knights to sign Andersson to an extension, so the door has probably closed on Pietrangelo's time with Vegas—and likely his career as well. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** *Eichel, Stone, Karlsson, Theodore, Howden, Olofsson, Lauzon.*

Breakout Threshold:

Only Holtz qualifies. He has played 191 career NHL games. The Dorofeyev trade certainly opens a spot for yet another opportunity for Holtz, but he needs to take advantage before Connelly arrives.

Goalies:

Former Coach John Tortorella showed complete faith in Hart during the playoffs, with Hart proving he can still perform at a high level after his nearly two-year layoff. Yet, is Hart's starting job as secure with new Coach Ryan Craig? Vegas still has Hill on the roster, even though trading away his \$6.25 million cap hit with five years remaining would be understandable. Hill has Vegas's Stanley Cup, but he played only 27 games in 2025–26 due to multiple lower-body injuries while posting a career-low 0.870 SV%. Hill has the bigger contract, but Hart has the most recent success. We'll lean toward the more recent success, but in the end, this could be one of the less stable goaltending situations... Carl Lindbom had a strong AHL season and could be in the mix for starts if either Hart or Hill is injured. **Dobber's confidence that Hart is the starter: 75%**

Contract Year:

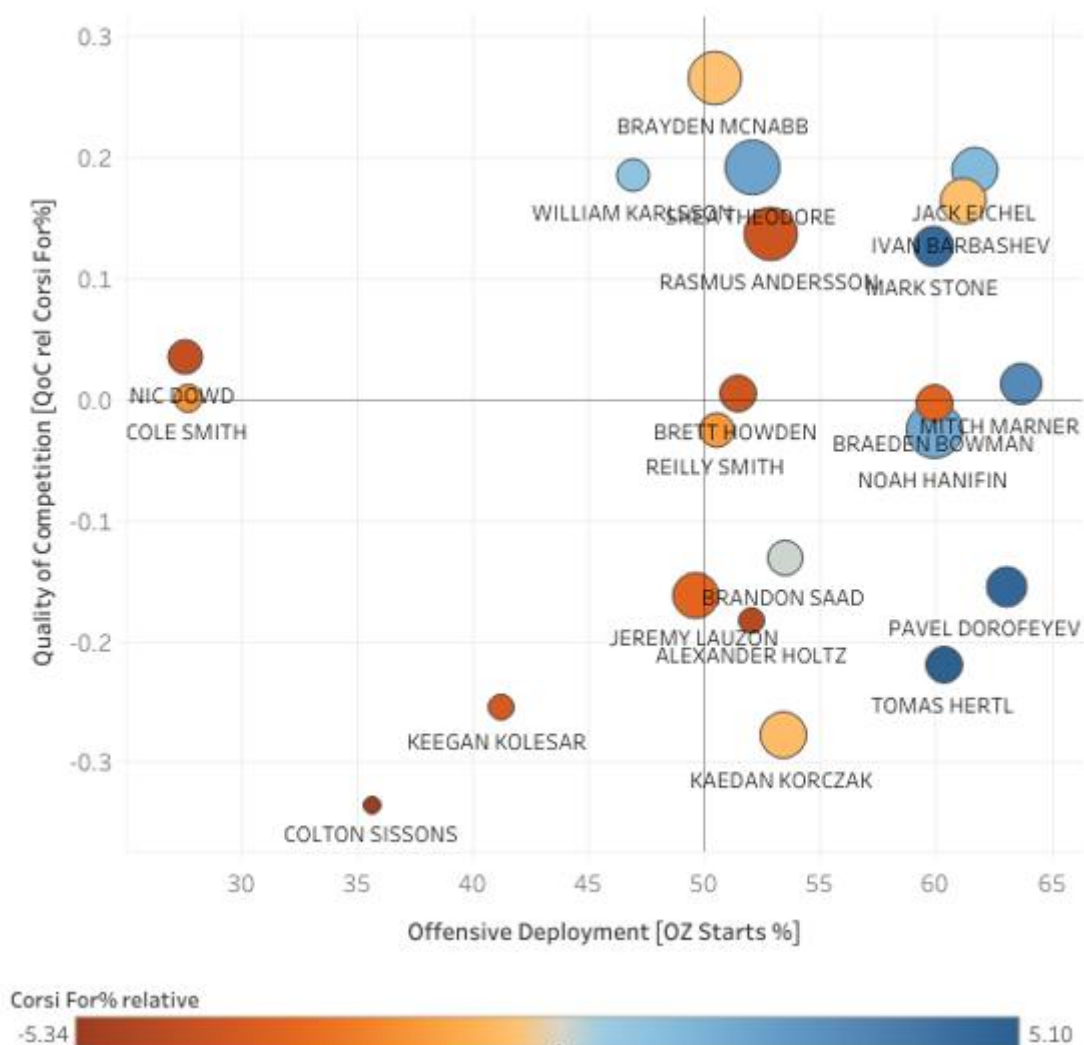
The Golden Knights don't have a ton of young players, so their RFA responsibilities are dwarfed by what they need to consider from a UFA perspective. Stone's next contract won't be an easy one to forecast. He is now 34 years old and regularly misses a chunk of the season due to injuries. The Vegas captain is still very productive when healthy, but another injury-filled season could mean that the cutthroat Golden Knights move in a different direction... Hart has already paid dividends on his two-year, \$4 million contract with a trip to the Stanley Cup Final. He could become more expensive with another solid season, and the Knights are already paying Hill over \$6 million until 2031.

2027 RFA: *Bowman, Holtz*

2027 UFA: *Stone, Karlsson, Dowd, Olofsson, Pietrangelo, Heinola, Wotherspoon, Hart*

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Carter Hart		
Boom or bust	William Karlsson		
Multicategory / Banger	Jeremy Lauzon		
Salary cap bargain	Carter Hart		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Alexander Holtz	23	62	73
Braeden Bowman	36	29	96
Brayden McNabb	176	133	93
Brett Howden	34	122	113
Ivan Barbashev	37	126	128
Jack Eichel	45	29	255
Jeremy Lauzon	90	248	69
Jonas Rondbjerg	12	8	37
Marc Gatcomb	34	244	63
Mark Stone	40	30	132
Mitch Marner	50	33	174
Nic Dowd	57	132	61
Noah Hanifin	112	42	152
Parker Wotherspoon	110	144	71
Rasmus Andersson	148	41	172
Shea Theodore	85	4	138
Tomas Hertl	45	98	180
Trevor Connelly	21	16	94
Victor Olofsson	21	23	139
William Karlsson	42	23	128

Dobber Advanced... GOLDEN KNIGHTS



Observation: McNabb, Karlsson, Theodore, and Andersson handled the toughest assignments. McNabb saw the highest QoC on the team. Andersson struggled in the role, but the shade of his bubble was influenced by his time in Calgary.

Fantasy Impact: These were the team's workhorses. They were leaned on heavily to shut down the opposition, which meant they faced the hardest competition night in and night out. While they were reliable real-world anchors, all that defensive heavy lifting meant their offensive stats were usually capped. It explains why Theodore didn't have anywhere near the season expected of him.

Observation: Eichel, Barbashev, and Stone were the big guns, operating with high offensive deployment and facing elite competition. Stone was dominant and was the top player on the team for relative CF%.

Fantasy Impact: These were your "set it and forget it" players. The coaches trusted them to carry the mail against the other team's best lines, and they still managed to get prime offensive looks. They were the most matchup-proof assets on the roster and represented the safest bets for high-floor production. It makes you wonder how great Stone could truly be if he weren't plagued by injuries so bad that they are bound to impact his quality of life after retirement.

Observation: Marner, Hanifin, and Bowman were deployed in the sweet spot, enjoying plenty of offensive-zone time against manageable competition. Marner led the team in offensive-zone starts, and Bowman struggled with possession metrics at this kind of usage.

Fantasy Impact: Marner played with Dorofeyev all year, and Dorofeyev surprised everyone with his goal-scoring success. He played most of the year with Hertl as well, and yet you see their bubbles firmly in the "sheltered" area. This shows us how often Marner was used as a safety net in the offensive zone, getting added zone starts with other lines against stronger opposition. The dark-blue bubbles for Hertl and Dorofeyev are a reflection of Marner playing with them against such weaker competition. It's a huge statement about the underrated impact of Marner.

Observation: Howden and Smith lived in the neutral zone, starting in either zone against middling QofC. They did not do well in these roles in terms of driving possession.

Fantasy Impact: These were your classic middle-six guys. They weren't getting buried, but they weren't getting the red-carpet treatment either. Their production was pretty volatile and usually dependent on whether they caught a hot streak with their linemates—perfect for streaming, but tough to rely on week to week. Howden had a great postseason, but this shows that he would be a risky pick for 2026–27 because he would rely solely on getting sheltered deployment and playing alongside Marner.

Observation: Pavel Dorofeyev (now with NY Rangers) and Hertl were the beneficiaries of “sheltered” minutes, getting fed easy starts and soft opposition matchups.

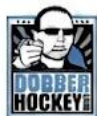
Fantasy Impact: The coaches clearly wanted to squeeze some offense out of these two by protecting them. They were basically being force-fed offensive-zone starts—and with star player and elite possession beast Marner.

Observation: Smith and Dowd were the shutdown crew, tasked with playing against the best while starting in the defensive end.

Fantasy Impact: As with most teams, these guys were there to make life miserable for the other team's stars, not to score. Unless your league rewards defensive-zone faceoffs, they were total non-factors for your fantasy roster.

Observation: Kaeden Korczak (now with Pittsburgh), Keegan Kolesar (Detroit), Lauzon, and Holtz were mostly just filling out the depth chart. They saw low QofC, leaning toward the offensive zone, and they didn't drive possession very well.

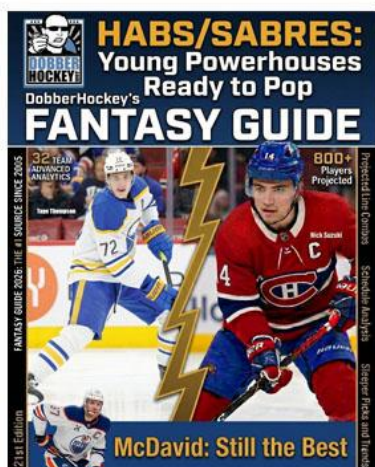
Fantasy Impact: Despite the sheltered deployment, Holtz's bubble was still dark orange. He's now 24, and it's time to call the experiment over. A failed seventh-overall draft pick, he still hasn't figured out the NHL. His only thread of hope is the fact that he has played, in bits and pieces over the years, 191 career NHL games, which brings him to his BT season.



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Golden Knights by the Metrics...

	<i>Pos</i>	<i>GP</i>	<i>ZS%</i>	<i>PDO</i>	<i>5on5 SV%</i>	<i>5on5 S%</i>	<i>CF%</i>	<i>%PP</i>	<i>IPP</i>	<i>ES IPP</i>	<i>PP IPP</i>	<i>PTS/60</i>	<i>Sec Asst</i>	<i>Sec Asst %</i>
<u>MARK STONE</u>	R	60	59.9	1014	0.893	12.1	55.8	77	66.4	69.2	64.3	3.8	14	31.1
<u>JACK EICHEL</u>	C	74	61.7	1011	0.895	11.6	53.7	81.7	67.2	70.6	60.9	3.4	33	52.4
<u>MITCH MARNER</u>	R	81	63.6	1018	0.907	11.1	54.8	79.9	65.6	77.5	48	3	18	32.1
<u>IVAN BARBASHEV</u>	L	82	61.1	1011	0.896	11.5	52	19.1	71.8	71.4	75	2.7	15	39.5
<u>PAVEL DOROFYEV</u>	R	82	63	994	0.9	9.4	55.7	76.8	63.4	63	63.8	2.7	9	33.3
<u>TOMAS HERTL</u>	C	82	60.3	947	0.86	8.7	56	77.3	56.3	62.3	50	2.5	16	47.1
<u>WILLIAM KARLSSON</u>	C	14	46.9	934	0.91	2.4	51	19.3	100	100	100	2	1	33.3
<u>BRAEDEN BOWMAN</u>	R	54	60	940	0.832	10.8	49.4	31.4	63.4	64.7	57.1	2	9	50
<u>REILLY SMITH</u>	L	69	50.5	960	0.884	7.6	50.7	9.2	74.3	78.1	50	1.7	4	40
<u>ALEXANDER HOLTZ</u>	R	28	52	1022	0.89	13.2	46.8	10.2	64.3	64.3	0	1.7	4	66.7
<u>SHEA THEODORE</u>	D	70	52.1	1002	0.915	8.7	54.1	30.4	44.3	45.3	45.5	1.5	15	51.7
<u>BRETT HOWDEN</u>	L	58	51.4	967	0.875	9.2	50.4	13.7	62.9	61.3	75	1.5	6	60
<u>RASMUS ANDERSSON</u>	D	33	52.9	995	0.9	9.5	49.9	24.3	45.2	45.9	56.5	1.4	3	30
<u>BEN HUTTON</u>	D	55	64.1	998	0.882	11.6	50.7	5.7	38.5	38.5	0	1.1	6	66.7
<u>KEEGAN KOLESAR</u>	R	82	41.2	941	0.877	6.4	48.9	1.6	58.6	57.1	0	1.1	2	18.2
<u>NOAH HANIFIN</u>	D	71	60	983	0.894	8.9	53.2	18.2	37.8	34.4	70	1	16	64

- Stone was dominant in the 60 games he was healthy, leading the Golden Knights in Pts/60 by a fair margin. Three players topped 3.0, and an impressive six topped 2.5.
- Stone's 5-on-5 shooting percentage was a tad high even for a player of his star caliber. The other top-six players are probably close to the number they should be, and no correction downward is anticipated—at least due to puck luck.
- Karlsson's 5-on-5 S% is obscenely low, but keep in mind he only played 14 games, and when you have a small sample size like that you get messy numbers. Hertl, Theodore, and Hanifin are the notable names with low 5-on-5 S% and should see a bump upward in ES production in the season ahead.
- The top PP unit was locked in and played nearly 80% of available PP time, not leaving much for the second unit. The unit comprised Stone, Eichel, Marner, Dorofeyev, and Hertl. The weak point on this unit was actually Marner, who chipped in with just a 48.0 PP IPP. No chance he loses that spot—he was the "defenseman" on the unit.
- The second unit, for what it's worth: Barbashev, Theodore, Hanifin (Andersson after he arrived), Bowman, and Howden (Karlsson when healthy). Theodore not being on that top unit killed his production. A new coach will likely fix that, and if he does, Theodore will really pop, making him an excellent dark horse.
- Hertl was a minus-17 last season. But in his defense, the goalies behind him had a 0.860 save percentage when he was on the ice! Don't overthink his plus/minus if your league counts those things.

Key departures	John Tortorella (Coach), Pavel Dorofeyev (NYR), Colton Sissons (TOR), Keegan Kolesar (DET), Cole Smith (CHI), Reilly Smith (UFA), Brandon Saad (UFA), Ben Hutton (UFA), Kaeden Korchak (PIT), Akira Schmid (FLA)
Arrivals	Ryan Craig (Coach), Victor Olofsson (CGY), Marc Gatcomb (NYI), Parker Wotherspoon (PIT)

Washington CAPITALS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Alex Ovechkin	77	29	55	21	Dylan Strome	83	25	71	35	Jordan Kyrou	81	32	62	19
Ryan Leonard	78	23	57	36	Pierre-Luc Dubois	75	17	57	64	Alex Tuch	81	32	55	54
Aliaksei Protas	79	27	59	24	Justin Sourdif	80	18	37	36	Tom Wilson	78	31	59	120
Ilya Protas	46	9	29	14	Boone Jenner	62	16	31	31	Jonny Brodzinski	35	5	10	8
Anthony Beauvillier	76	14	25	18						Ethen Frank	45	9	16	16
Josh Dunne	20	1	2	24						Ivan Miroshnichenko	19	3	5	6
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Jakob Chychrun	81	21	56	59	Timothy Liljegren	61	4	19	30	Logan Thompson	58	33	3	2.50
Cole Hutson	80	14	50	48	Rasmus Sandin	64	3	26	17	Charlie Lindgren	25	11	1	3.40
Martin Fehervary	78	4	24	30	Matt Roy	78	3	20	27	Clay Stevenson	4	2	0	3.00
Vincent Desharnais	63	2	6	58	Justin Holl	12	0	2	4					
Dylan McIlrath	13	0	2	17										

Restricted Free Agents: none

What to look for in camp: The Caps' second PP unit was upgraded in the offseason and, frankly, it's probably going to be better than the first unit if things unfold the way they're shown above. The Caps stubbornly refused to sit Ovechkin out of any PP time, but if they do—that second unit looks very good. The only question is: will it be Kyrou or Tuch on the top unit? Or maybe Leonard? A few combinations will be tried, and it probably won't be resolved in camp. But nonetheless, it is something to look for.

On the hot seat: Ovechkin. Well, he's not feeling any pressure because he is already a rich man and his legacy is cemented forever. But if you skip ahead and read some of what we have to say about his metrics (Dobber Advanced), it isn't pretty. For the sake of the team, will he take reduced ice time and PP time? The Caps missed the playoffs when it perhaps could have been avoided. If this year is about leadership and supporting the offense, his numbers will take a hit, but everyone else will be better for it. If this year is about Ovechkin pushing to score 35 goals and seeing all the PP time...well, others will suffer from seeing a lower PPTOI.

- Sourdif started last season with three points in the first 21 games and averaged about 12 minutes TOI. After that, he collected 32 points in 57 games, including a five-point effort on January 5. He saw his most success with Aliaksei Protas and Wilson. The new acquisitions may have pushed him down the depth chart, but he's good enough to hold his own, and if he ever gets a chance to move higher, he'll seize it.

- Ilya Protas made a strong impression when he had a cup of coffee last year. His 6-6 frame alongside his brother's and Wilson's made for the biggest unit in hockey. However, his metrics weren't great despite being sheltered, and he could use more AHL time. The fact that the Caps brought in Kyrou, Tuch, Jenner and still brought back Ovechkin means there is not much room for the younger Protas—at least to start.

- Kyrou started last season very slowly in St. Louis, as did many of the Blues. He wasn't working well with different linemates, and he also missed time in the first half with injury. He had just 17 points in his first 35 outings. After that, playing mostly with Pavel Buchnevich and Jake Neighbours, Kyrou had 29 in 37, which is about what to expect from him.

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect	%	
Dylan Strome	85	67	Cole Hutson	99%	
Ryan Leonard	80	67	Ilya Protas	45%	
Aliaksei Protas	75	65	Andrew Cristall	5%	
Pierre-Luc Dubois	78	63			
Tom Wilson	82	63			
Alex Tuch	80	62			
Jordan Kyrou	77	62			
Cole Hutson	75	58			
Alex Ovechkin	70	58			
Jakob Chychrun	70	57			
Ilya Protas	78	57			
Andrew Cristall	85	55	Sleeper	Pts	%
Oliver Suvanto	70	55	Cole Hutson	55	25%
Ivan Miroshnichenko	75	53	Ryan Leonard	70	20%
Terik Parascak	75	53			
Justin Sourdif	70	45			
Lynden Lakovic	80	43			
Petr Sikora	65	40			
Boone Jenner	62	35			

- On January 5, Leonard was put on a line with Connor McMichael (now with St. Louis) and Sourdif, and it was a smashing success with Sourdif getting five points, McMichael four and Leonard two. The line was, of course, kept together for a while, but it turns out the magic was a one-time deal. As a trio, they lost possession and production stumbled. In fact, the third quarter was the quarter in which Leonard had the most ice time (15:48) and PP time (3:16)—and yet he had his worst numbers, with just eight points in 21 games. He is at his best with Dubois.

- Jenner had 19 points in 27 games with Columbus to start last season, but he slowed to 19 in 40 after that.

- Wilson was obliterating his career season up until the Olympic break, posting 49 points in 50 games. However, he missed the first game back upon returning, and then posted a mere 13 points in 22 games. Something happened—either the Olympics drained his energy, or he came back with a nagging injury.

Injuries:

Kyrou underwent a minor knee procedure at the end of the season, but he should be ready for camp... Dubois (upper body) missed the final game of the regular season... Sandin is expected to miss a "decent amount of time" to start the 2026–27 season, according to GM Chris Patrick. Sandin underwent surgery for a torn ACL... Lindgren (upper body) was shut down late in the season. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** *Liljegren, Jenner, Desharnais.*

Breakout Threshold:

None. Unless you like Desharnais' chances of surging! (That was a joke, don't pick him.)

Goalies:

Thompson has been trending toward being a legit starting goalie for a few seasons, and he was finally able to make that happen in 2025–26. Only Tampa Bay's Andrei Vasilevskiy had more quality starts than Thompson (39), who also appeared in over 50 games for the first time in his career. With the Capitals reloading in the offseason for what might be one last run with Ovechkin, Thompson could be in for a very big year. He may even be worth drafting as a top-five goalie. On the other hand, Lindgren no longer seems timeshare-worthy, with his value likely held to spot starts... Clay Stevenson would only be a factor if one of Thompson or Lindgren is injured, although he may challenge Lindgren for starts if Thompson is injured. **Dobber's confidence that Thompson is the starter: 99%**

Contract Year:

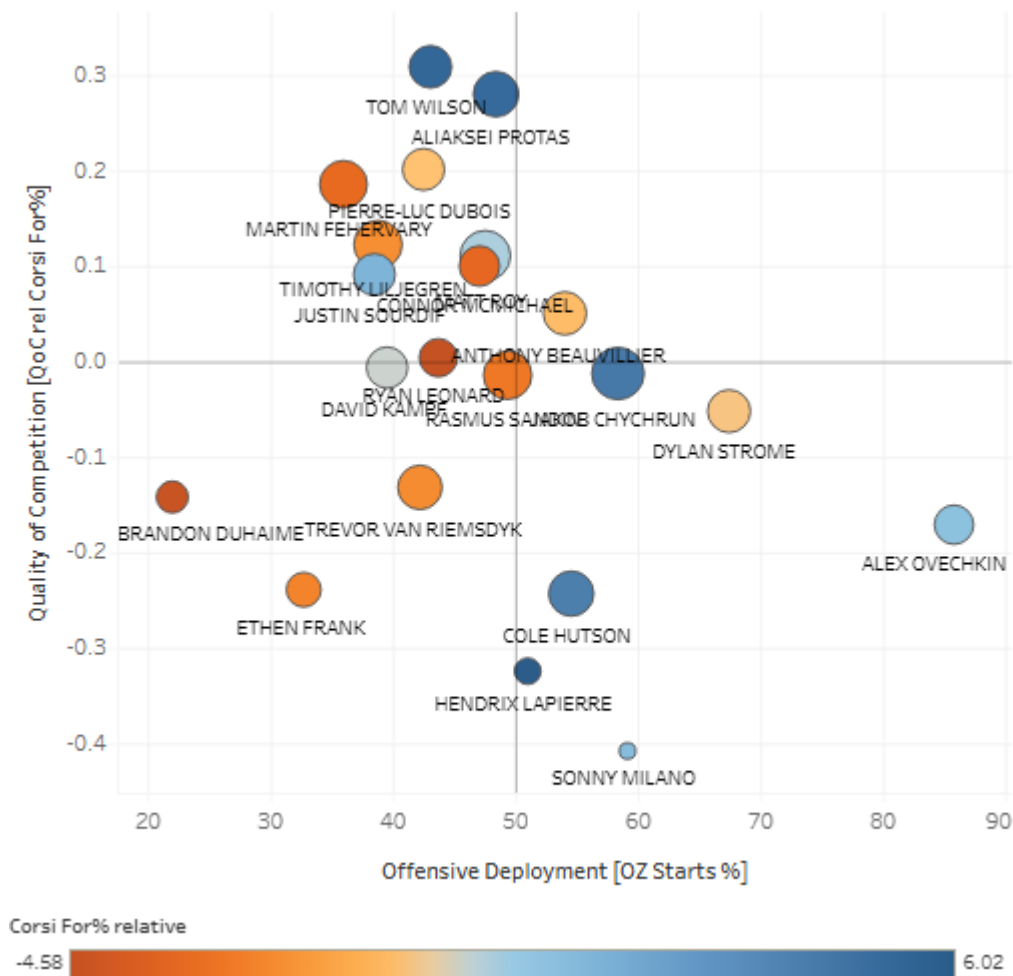
The Capitals have effectively been able to retool on the fly, which has included drafting Leonard and trading for Sourdif. These two forwards have an opportunity to lock themselves in as part of the post-Ovechkin years with big seasons. Speaking of Ovechkin, he is on a one-year deal at a reduced rate (\$4.25 million cap hit). The question of whether he will continue his career will come up again at the end of the season. The Capitals will need some sort of plan in place in case this is in fact his final season. At least they have addressed their forward depth, with several key contributors signed to at least three more years after this one.

2027 RFA: *Leonard, Sourdif*

2027 UFA: *Ovechkin, Beauvillier, Holl*

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Ryan Leonard		
Boom or bust	Alex Ovechkin		
Multicategory / Banger	Tom Wilson		
Salary cap bargain	Ryan Leonard		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Alex Ovechkin	15	120	224
Alex Tuch	97	81	202
Aliaksei Protas	43	31	173
Anthony Beauvillier	41	86	137
Boone Jenner	56	127	130
Cole Hutson	56	91	160
Dylan Strome	55	15	150
Ethen Frank	36	42	59
Ilya Protas	18	18	78
Jakob Chychrun	113	65	218
Jordan Kyrou	32	26	210
Justin Sourdif	45	110	112
Martin Fehervary	156	117	70
Matt Roy	133	110	102
Pierre-Luc Dubois	41	59	120
Rasmus Sandin	130	88	92
Ryan Leonard	27	133	164
Timothy Liljegren	98	55	73
Tom Wilson	62	186	155
Vincent Desharnais	100	132	38

Dobber Advanced... CAPITALS



Observation: Protas and Wilson faced the toughest quality of competition, leaning more toward defensive-zone faceoffs, and they absolutely dominated possession. They led the team in relative CF%.

Fantasy Impact: While they already put up decent points, they could certainly put up a lot more with optimal usage. But clearly this is helping the team tremendously and won't be changed anytime soon. It means that the numbers you just saw are probably not going to change due to usage changing.

Observation: Ovechkin saw the highest offensive-zone start percentage in the entire league and faced low QoC. He was sheltered and drove positive possession.

Fantasy Impact: This has been the location of Ovechkin's bubble for several years now, taking advantage of his natural scoring ability. At this point he was an offensive specialist only.

Observation: Hutson posted great numbers in his brief debut, but he was heavily sheltered.

Fantasy Impact: With a bubble shaded darker blue, Hutson did very well with that deployment and can probably handle tougher minutes. However, if the deployment gets too tough, his numbers won't be quite as nice. A big year is by no means a guarantee.

Observation: McMichael (STL) was deployed as more of a defensive forward along with Sourdif, Dubois (when healthy), and Leonard. They all saw more defensive-zone starts and moderate to strong quality of competition (other than Leonard, who saw moderate). Of the group, only Sourdif drove possession well.

Fantasy Impact: In fact, Sourdif being the only blue bubble in a sea of orange bodes very well for his career. It remains to be seen if he can work his way up to a second-line producer reaching 60-plus points, or a third-liner posting 40, but he's an NHLer with a high floor. McMichael and Leonard were miscast in that role.

Observation: Higher quality of competition seemed to be split between Fehervary (the obvious, for-sure shutdown guy), Liljegren (after arriving from San Jose), and Roy. All three bubbles are pretty good considering their role, although

Fantasy Impact: Liljegren played only four games for Washington, so this is misleading. In his four games, his defense partner was Chychrun. San Jose used him in more of a defensive capacity, but it appears Washington may use him differently. If he stays healthy and holds that plum spot, Liljegren will surprise.

Fantasy Impact: This will be status quo for Chychrun, and there is little to take from this other than his even-strength production will likely be stable.

Fantasy Impact: Strome was handcuffed to Ovechkin all season, and that influenced his possession metrics. He had to cover off any mistakes and get back to his own zone with more tenacity than he might have otherwise with a two-way skilled linemate. I wouldn't read anything into Strome's bubble for last season.

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Capitals by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>TOM WILSON</u>	R	72	43	1016	0.906	11	53.1	56.9	67.4	72.5	54.5	2.7	15	46.9
<u>ALEX OVECHKIN</u>	L	82	85.7	1029	0.918	11.1	50.8	91.6	61.5	71.4	46.3	2.7	10	31.3
<u>RYAN LEONARD</u>	R	75	43.7	1046	0.929	11.7	46.7	47.7	65.2	68.9	58.3	2.5	7	28
<u>COLE HUTSON</u>	D	14	54.5	990	0.909	8.1	48.5	49.3	71.4	50	100	2.5	2	28.6
<u>DYLAN STROME</u>	C	80	67.4	1030	0.906	12.4	49.5	64.2	53.2	49.3	61.8	2.4	16	41
<u>PIERRE-LUC DUBOIS</u>	C	29	42.5	1006	0.899	10.7	46.8	46.4	67.9	59.1	100	2.3	7	50
<u>ALIAKSEI PROTAS</u>	L	76	48.4	1015	0.905	11	53.1	9.5	62.7	64.1	50	2.3	9	33.3
<u>JOHN CARLSON</u>	D	55	53.8	1007	0.902	10.5	53.8	51.2	54.1	53.5	56	2.2	17	47.2
<u>CONNOR MCMICHAEL</u>	L	78	47	1017	0.907	11	47.2	33.3	63.9	65.6	50	2.1	10	31.3
<u>JAKOB CHYCHRUN</u>	D	80	58.3	1047	0.929	11.8	51.9	62.7	50	44.7	69.2	1.9	21	61.8
<u>ETHEN FRANK</u>	R	62	32.7	1033	0.927	10.6	47.3	31.1	57.1	60.6	44.4	1.9	5	41.7
<u>JUSTIN SOURDIF</u>	C	78	38.4	1035	0.934	10.1	50.5	20.6	56.5	60.4	33.3	1.8	9	45
<u>SONNY MILANO</u>	R	31	59.1	1003	0.902	10.1	52.4	22.5	57.1	66.7	0	1.7	0	0
<u>HENDRIX LAPIERRE</u>	L	74	50.9	988	0.899	8.9	54	2.7	61.5	61.5	0	1.5	7	58.3
<u>A BEAUVILLIER</u>	R	82	54	1004	0.914	9	49.1	10.5	47.5	47.3	50	1.3	6	46.2
<u>RASMUS SANDIN</u>	D	73	49.3	1002	0.902	10	47.9	17.2	45.3	46.7	33.3	1.2	10	41.7

- Ovechkin's 2.7 Pts/60 was his second-lowest output in the 14 years we've tracked this, with 2023-24 at 2.6. Now 41 in September, it would be a safe bet to see this number slip again.

- It was scoring by committee, as fully nine Capitals topped 2.1 or higher, and 12 reached 1.8 Pts/60 or higher.

- Both Strome and Chychrun saw significantly higher-than-average 5-on-5 S% numbers. On the chart, seven players were at 11.0% or slightly higher. They got their points at even strength and, checking the data, Washington was 24th in power-play efficiency. They only scored 43 PPG as a team, yet they were 15th in overall scoring (therefore—a larger number of goals came at even strength).

- Both the first and second PP units featured Ovechkin, the power-play king. He was only in on 46.3% of the PP goals scored when he was out there. The team struggled to score on the power play, and Ovechkin was out for 91.6% of available power-play time. You do the math. I love Ovechkin, but if his name was Smith he would have played less and seen secondary PP usage at most. Did the lack of PP scoring cost Washington a playoff spot?

- The first PP unit, other than Ovechkin, was Wilson, Strome, Carlson (before his trade to Anaheim last year), and Chychrun. Of that group, Ovechkin was the weakest link.

- The second unit saw quite a bit of ice time as well, with Leonard seeing 47.7%. Dubois (when healthy), Hutson (after joining the team late), McMichael, Frank, and Sourdif were the others. Surprisingly, Protas saw just 9.5% of available power-play time.

- Sourdif didn't see a lot of PP time, but his PP IPP was quite low at 33.3%, indicating that he didn't deserve more PPTOI.

Key departures	Connor McMichael (STL), Hendrix Lapierre (PIT), Sonny Milano (NL), David Kampf (ELH), Brandon Duhaime (TOR), Trevor van Riemsdyk (PIT)
Arrivals	Alex Tuch (BUF), Jordan Kyrou (STL), Boone Jenner (CBJ), Vincent Desharnais (SJS)

Winnipeg JETS

Left Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Center	GP	G	Pts	PIM	Right Wing	GP	G	Pts	PIM
Kyle Connor	84	42	96	17	Mark Scheifele	81	34	93	55	Gabriel Vilardi	75	29	72	20
Cole Perfetti	76	17	46	18	Viggo Bjorck	72	11	42	14	Alex Iafallo	83	13	29	12
Isak Rosen	72	12	25	10	Adam Lowry	77	10	22	40	V Namestnikov	74	10	23	35
Nino Niederreiter	75	14	30	26	Morgan Barron	75	11	25	24	Cole Koepke	70	9	20	16
Nikita Chibrikov	62	7	23	22	Brayden Yager	18	1	4	4	Brad Lambert	40	3	14	10
Walker Duehr	2	0	0	0	Parker Ford	11	2	2	2	Noah Gregor	53	5	9	25
Defense					Defense					Goalies	GP	W	SO	GAA
Josh Morrissey	81	13	60	33	Dylan Demelo	84	3	19	39	Connor Hellebuyck	62	38	5	2.50
Mario Ferraro	81	5	20	42	Neal Pionk	69	8	27	49	Stuart Skinner	25	12	1	2.85
Dylan Samberg	70	3	17	28	Elias Salomonsson	65	4	15	10					
Haydn Fleury	36	2	5	13	John St. Ivany	48	3	9	23					
Isaak Phillips	2	0	0	2	Henry Thrun	5	0	1	2					

Restricted Free Agents: Kupari (Europe), Samberg

Future Fantasy Stud: Winnipeg is in desperate need of a second-line center immediately, and a first-line center in four or five years. Perhaps more desperate than most teams, especially the “immediately” part. And Bjorck fits that description to a tee. On a lot of teams, he would be given another year to develop, but on the Jets, he has a real chance of cracking the roster and playing a significant role.

What to look for in camp: Rosen is a young player from Sweden, and so is Bjorck. If the two end up lining up together and form chemistry, and they both make the team, this would be a huge boon for Rosen’s long-term fantasy outlook. Keep an eye on this situation.

- Losing Nik Ehlers last summer to free agency was more devastating to the Jets than you may think. He was tied for tops on Winnipeg with 3.5 Pts/60. He leaves, and the Jets go from three players above 3.0 to two. His linemates go from 2.4 to 1.8 (Perfetti) and 1.9 to 1.0 (Namestnikov). Secondary scoring disappears. The team falls out of the playoffs. And the team Ehlers joins wins the Stanley Cup.

- Perfetti signed a five-year, \$30M contract in July. That would have been at least 50% higher had Ehlers stayed and helped boost Perfetti’s numbers. But without Ehlers, Perfetti slipped from what might have been 55 or 60 points (or 45, given that he was injured) down to 32. Playing with Jonathan Toews (now retired) turned out to be a huge downgrade from Ehlers. In the second half, Perfetti played with Vilardi and his numbers improved to 24 points in his last 42 games (eight points in 26 before that).

Long-term: Upside / 3YP			Prospect		%	
Kyle Connor	100	90	Elias Salomonsson	95%		
Mark Scheifele	105	85	Isak Rosen	85%		
Gabriel Vilardi	82	68	Viggo Bjorck	70%		
Josh Morrissey	82	62	Nikita Chibrikov	55%		
Cole Perfetti	78	60	Brayden Yager	40%		
Viggo Bjorck	85	55	Brad Lambert	20%		
Brayden Yager	67	53				
Kieron Walton	75	50				
Isak Rosen	73	48				
Brad Lambert	72	40				
Alfons Freij	53	40				
Nino Niederreiter	58	38	Sleeper	Pts	%	
Elias Salomonsson	53	38	Cole Perfetti	60	15%	
Nikita Chibrikov	65	38	Viggo Bjorck	60	15%	
Colby Barlow	67	35				
Sascha Boumedienne	55	35				
Morgan Barron	53	33				
Alex Iafallo	55	32				
Adam Lowry	50	30				

- In an effort to spread out the offense, Coach Scott Arniel moved Vilardi to play with Perfetti and bumped Iafallo up to play with Scheifele. The latter actually saw an uptick in production (55 points in the last 42 games after 48 in 40 to start), so it is possible that Iafallo gets put back on that line. Iafallo himself saw a small bump, but without getting on that first PP unit, his numbers will remain modest.

- Connor didn’t work as well with Iafallo. While Scheifele’s numbers went up, Connor’s went down—just 14 points in his last 15 games after posting 78 in 67.

- Morrissey went into the Olympic break in a bit of a slump, and then he suffered an undisclosed injury at the games and wound up missing a couple of weeks after the break. He never got going again and wound up with just 13 points in the last 28 games. He had 42 in 49 before that.

- Barron had a brief window of fantasy interest last year when he came out of the gates flying, posting five points in four games. Poolies were claiming him left, right, and center! He had just 18 points in 61 games after that. Needless to say, he was mass-dropped a week later. A wasted claim.

Injuries:

Chibrikov underwent core muscle surgery at the end of the season, but he is expected to be ready for training camp... Namestnikov and Iafallo (both undisclosed) were shut down a few games before the end of the season... Barron was dealing with lower-body and concussion issues to end the season... Salomonsson underwent shoulder surgery at the end of April. The rehab is expected to take 5–6 months, which means he could miss the start of the season... Pionk (undisclosed) was shut down a few games before the end of the season. **Dobber's Band-Aid Boys:** Pionk, Perfetti, Samberg, Vilardi.

Breakout Threshold:

Last year was Perfetti's BT season, and he certainly blew that. His fantasy owners are probably cursing Ehlers right about now. Vilardi is 6-3 and fits our 400-game BT model. A breakout season for him would push him close to the Scheifele/Connor stratosphere. We don't think he has that in him, but wouldn't bet against it given his usual linemates. A breakout by our definition would mean 86 points, which pushes him slightly above his upside.

Goalies:

Perhaps the most interesting offseason goalie signing was Skinner joining Winnipeg. In the past, backup goalies to Hellebuyck have been used sparingly. Skinner, however, has played in 50 games for four consecutive seasons. The Jets may be planning ahead in case they find the right trade for Hellebuyck. If not, they have an opportunity to rest their star goalie more often. The 2025–26 season was the first time in five years that Hellebuyck did not appear in at least 60 games, and that was due to an injury. Hellebuyck also posted the worst save percentage of his career (0.895 SV%), so at age 33 he might already be showing wear and tear. Assume the scenario of a Hellebuyck/Skinner tandem for now, but Skinner's value will obviously improve with a Hellebuyck trade. **Dobber's confidence that Hellebuyck is the starter: 100%**

Contract Year:

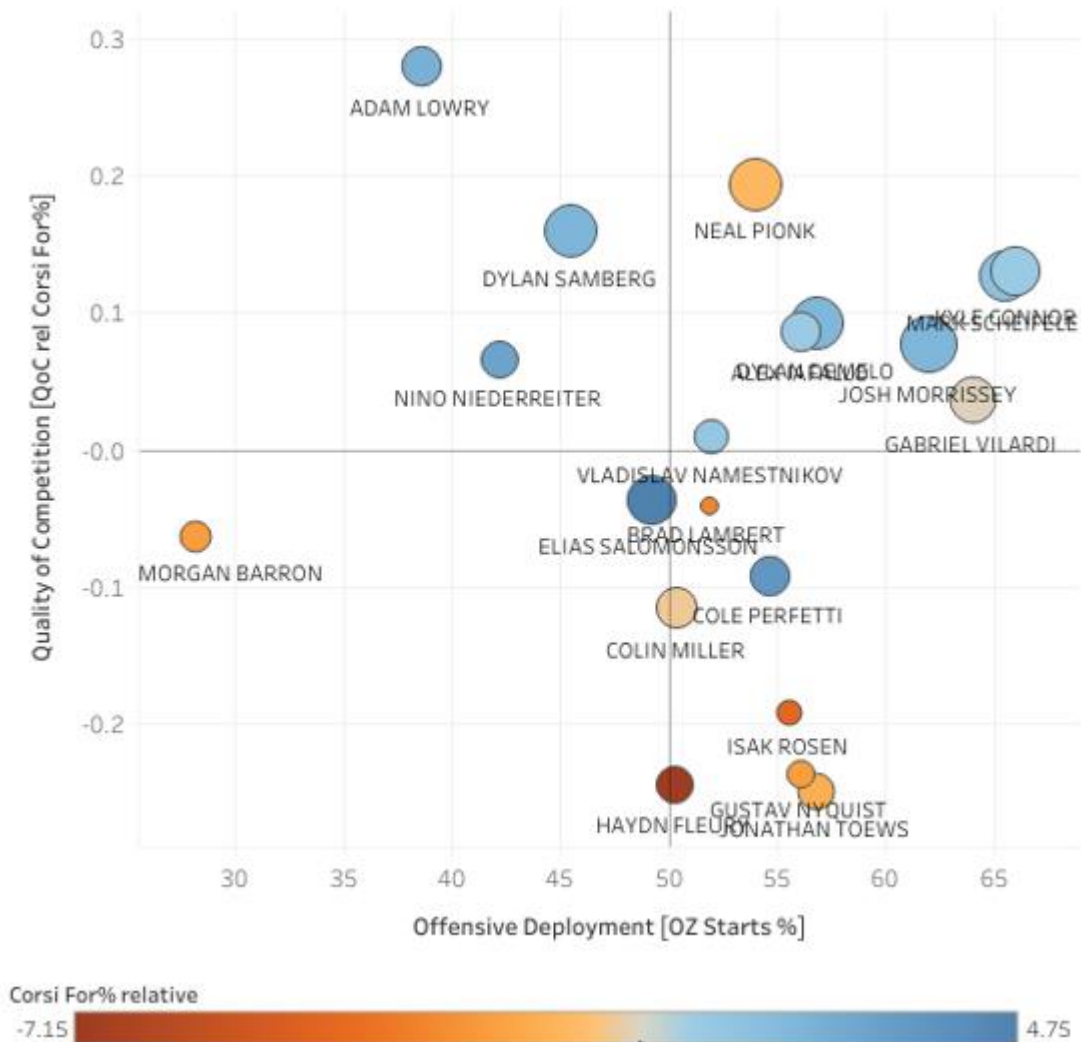
The Jets' core is by and large locked in for the long term, so the focus here is on secondary pieces or players that have yet to prove themselves... Lambert's scoring at the AHL level has declined for three consecutive seasons. He is still probably on the bubble to make the Jets, but this is a key season for him as he completes his entry-level deal... If the Jets are out of the playoff race again, Niederreiter should be of interest to contending teams as a middle-six forward. Namestnikov can also fill in on a scoring line in a pinch.

2027 RFA: Lambert, Salomonsson

2027 UFA: Niederreiter, Namestnikov, Barron, Fleury, St. Ivany

On the fantasy radar			
Top breakout candidate	Viggo Bjorck		
Boom or bust	Isak Rosen		
Multicategory / Banger	Neal Pionk		
Salary cap bargain	Josh Morrissey		
Multicat projections	BLKS	Hits	SOG
Adam Lowry	46	161	84
Alex Iafallo	54	100	108
Cole Koepke	23	183	84
Cole Perfetti	39	63	144
Dylan Demelo	113	109	76
Dylan Samberg	116	60	105
Elias Salomonsson	68	115	89
Gabriel Vilardi	38	23	143
Isak Rosen	36	33	79
Josh Morrissey	122	44	163
Kyle Connor	25	25	277
Mario Ferraro	155	140	98
Mark Scheifele	49	41	171
Morgan Barron	42	135	98
Neal Pionk	97	153	125
Nikita Chibrikov	35	117	68
Nino Niederreiter	30	94	105
Noah Gregor	24	74	63
Viggo Bjorck	18	43	144
Vladislav Namestnikov	44	87	89

Dobber Advanced... JETS



Observation: Connor, Scheifele (overlapping the Connor bubble), Morrissey, and Vilardi were the team's high-octane engines. Top offensive-zone starts, usually against stronger competition, and they drove possession quite well.

Fantasy Impact: These were your undisputed core pieces, making them your "set it and forget it" fantasy anchors. If you needed consistent production, these were the guys doing the heavy lifting at both ends of the ice.

Observation: Demelo, Iafallo, and Pionk were secondary offensive options, with Pionk out there against the toughest lines (but not doing as well as he should).

Fantasy Impact: They weren't easy minutes, though slanted toward the offensive zone. Deployment like this should mean 50–60 points for forwards and 45–55 for defensemen. Demelo fell short of that, but he has been partnered with Morrissey for a long time and is the defensive conscience of the pair. Pionk had 12 points, which for a guy with a 54% ZS% is pretty bad, even against the tough lines he faced. Iafallo drove possession well, but 29 points isn't what the team is looking for in that role. All three could and should see a shift to the left so that those offensive minutes can be put to better use.

Observation: Lowry, Samberg, and Niederreiter were the shutdown crew, drawing the toughest defensive assignments with very little offensive deployment. Lowry led the team in QoC, and yet his bubble is blue.

Fantasy Impact: These players were essentially used as structural anchors to neutralize the other team's top lines. Because they weren't being put in positions to score, their point ceilings were pretty low. They were valuable for real-world defensive metrics but largely irrelevant for standard points-only fantasy formats.

Observation: Namestnikov, Lambert (limited games), Salomonsson (limited games), Perfetti, and Colin Miller (now playing in Switzerland) were riding the "sweet spot," getting decent offensive looks without constantly being buried by elite opposition. Lambert struggled, while Salomonsson and Perfetti did very well.

Fantasy Impact: This group was the secondary support. They weren't quite the go-to stars, but they were in the perfect environment to chip in points. They were solid depth pieces for deeper leagues, often providing good value when their usage aligned with a hot streak. This chart hints that Lambert may not pan out as a prospect, but Salomonsson is looking very good.

Observation: Rosen, Nyquist, Fleury, and Toews were clearly being "sheltered," receiving heavy offensive-zone starts against lower-quality competition. None of them did well.

Fantasy Impact: The coaching staff was trying to force-feed these guys offensive minutes. They weren't being asked to play against the top pairs, which gave them a higher floor for scoring if they could capitalize on the softer matchups. For the most part, they did not. This part of the chart is telling us that Toews is probably not going to bounce back (as he figured, since he retired), and neither is Nyquist. Given Rosen's age, he will get another shot, but he's not enjoying the success he had in Buffalo. As for Fleury, well, he didn't do much to show that he can play in the NHL.

Observation: Barron was exclusively used as a defense-first forward.

Fantasy Impact: He started with 14 points in 34 games, but continued usage like this made it impossible for that to continue. He's now 27, so his role is defined.

Jets by the Metrics...

	Pos	GP	ZS%	PDO	5on5 SV%	5on5 S%	CF%	%PP	IPP	ES IPP	PP IPP	PTS/60	Sec Asst	Sec Asst %
<u>MARK SCHEIFELE</u>	C	82	65.5	1021	0.892	12.9	50	66.9	77.4	84.2	62.9	3.5	25	37.3
<u>KYLE CONNOR</u>	L	82	66	1016	0.888	12.8	49.7	65.7	71.9	80	55.9	3.1	20	37.7
<u>GABRIEL VILARDI</u>	R	82	64	1018	0.897	12.1	48.9	65.1	65.1	63.4	70.6	2.7	19	48.7
<u>COLE PERFETTI</u>	L	68	54.7	982	0.91	7.2	52.3	49.2	62.7	76.5	37.5	1.8	7	35
<u>JOSH MORRISSEY</u>	D	77	62	1025	0.91	11.5	50.3	66.1	46.2	45.9	50	1.7	19	46.3
<u>MORGAN BARRON</u>	C	65	28.1	1018	0.927	9.1	48	0.8	79.3	85.2	0	1.7	6	50
<u>JONATHAN TOEWS</u>	C	82	56.8	975	0.916	5.9	48.1	41.9	63	75	47.1	1.5	6	33.3
<u>COLE KOEPKE</u>	R	66	36.8	1011	0.931	8	46.9	0.2	85	89.5	0	1.5	4	44.4
<u>NINO NIEDERREITER</u>	L	61	42.2	962	0.899	6.3	50.2	32.4	65.5	60.9	83.3	1.4	5	45.5
<u>TANNER PEARSON</u>	L	52	30.6	1043	0.942	10.1	46.1	3.6	62.5	62.5	0	1.4	3	50
<u>ALEX IAFALLO</u>	R	79	56.1	998	0.895	10.3	49.6	26	52.7	48.9	83.3	1.4	9	56.3
<u>BRAD LAMBERT</u>	R	25	51.8	956	0.891	6.5	46.6	27.5	75	83.3	50	1.3	1	33.3
<u>ADAM LOWRY</u>	C	70	38.6	976	0.901	7.5	51	1.7	61.8	62.5	0	1.2	6	37.5
<u>GUSTAV NYQUIST</u>	L	51	56.1	972	0.92	5.2	47.7	36.9	54.5	58.3	50	1.1	5	45.5
<u>V NAMESTNIKOV</u>	C	60	51.9	956	0.899	5.7	49	31	58.3	66.7	40	1	2	33.3
<u>ISAK ROSEN</u>	R	21	55.5	997	0.911	8.6	45.4	27.9	62.5	58.3	75	0.8	0	0

- Interesting that in 2024–25, Connor had a 3.5 Pts/60 and Scheifele was at 3.1. In 2025–26, those numbers were exactly reversed.
- A year ago, three players on this chart were above 3.0. Losing Nik Ehlers (3.5) via free agency to Carolina was devastating, and they didn't compensate for it.
- Perfetti and Namestnikov never made up for the loss of Ehlers. Toews took his spot for the first half of the season, and it wasn't even close. In all, Perfetti dipped from 2.4 Pts/60 to 1.8; Namestnikov from 1.9 to 1.0. Go figure. Ehlers was the single biggest reason for Winnipeg's massive decline... and the team he went to won the Stanley Cup.
- First PP Unit: Scheifele, Connor, Vilardi, Morrissey... the last spot rotated, with Perfetti and Toews seeing time (leaning more Perfetti as the season went on). Neither Perfetti nor Toews was integral on the power play.
- Morrissey, with a 50.0 PP IPP, marked the lowest of his entire career, matching that of his rookie season when he was getting 30 seconds a game.
- Niederreiter and Iafallo were very strong contributors on the second unit. Interesting that in 37 games between Buffalo and Winnipeg, Rosen had three PPPTS on the four PPG that were scored when he was out there.
- Both Scheifele, Vilardi, and Connor had high 5-on-5 S%. The line was a little too prolific, scoring more than their shots should produce. Without secondary scoring, you may see this line slow a little as the puck luck fizzles out.
- Vilardi, Lambert, Lowry, Nyquist, and Namestnikov each saw low 5-on-5 S% and should see a bump. I would mostly hone in on Vilardi with this idea, as the others hold little fantasy value.

Key departures	Gustav Nyquist (UFA), Jonathan Toews (Retired), Colin Miller (NL), Eric Comrie (SJS)
Arrivals	Viggo Bjorck (Draft), Noah Gregor (FLA), Mario Ferraro (SJS), Jack St. Ivany (PIT), Stuart Skinner (PIT)

Du contenu

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Notable Unrestricted Free Agents

By Dobber

Michael Bunting, F – (79-17-19-36, 50 PIM)

Jonathan Drouin, F – (64-12-22-34, 18 PIM)

Matt Grzelcyk, D – (73-1-14-15, 29 PIM)

Connor Ingram, G – At this point, looking like the same situation as last season. He'll be brought in as a No.3 and then leapfrog the No.2 if the No.1 gets injured. Or if Pittsburgh signs him he'll have a shot at the top job. Upside, but risky.

Evander Kane, F – (76-18-13-31, 61 PIM)

Patrik Laine, F – (27-5-5-10, 8 PIM)

Nick Leddy, D – (50-2-6-8, 8 PIM)

Gustav Nyquist, F – (72-9-14-23, 12 PIM)

Tanner Pearson, F – (65-8-7-15, 19 PIM)

Pavol Regenda, F – (17-3-5-8, 8 PIM)

Reilly Smith, F – (77-14-14-28, 16 PIM)

Cam Talbot, G – Now 39 years old, Talbot will be a backup providing experience, assuming he doesn't retire. He has no fantasy value.

Vladimir Tarasenko, F – (79-19-24-43, 10 PIM)

Eeli Tolvanen, F – (82-17-21-38, 26 PIM) – Tolvanen's numbers could go up or down wildly depending on team and fit. He does have upside and provides multi-category appeal (200+ Hits). **UPDATE: Added to NYR**

James van Riemsdyk, F – (73-15-13-28, 20 PIM)

Notable Training Camp Invites

Alex Nylander – CGY
Chris Driedger – VAN
Cal Petersen – WAS

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Time	%	Players	GF	GA	+/-	SF	SA	SF%	CF	CA	CF%
82:35	16.1	NATHAN MACKINNON - ARTTURI LEHKONEN - MARTIN NECAS	7	4	3	63	40	61.2	110	68	61.8
38:57	7.6	GABRIEL LANDESKOG - BROCK NELSON - VALERI NICHUSHKIN	3	0	3	19	15	55.9	41	35	53.9
27:02	5.3	LOGAN O'CONNOR - PARKER KELLY - JACK DRURY	0	1	-1	15	8	65.2	34	21	61.8
20:33	4.0	GABRIEL LANDESKOG - NATHAN MACKINNON - MARTIN NECAS	3	1	2	16	7	69.6	32	19	62.7
18:34	3.6	BROCK NELSON - VALERI NICHUSHKIN - ROSS COLTON	1	1	0	11	5	68.8	26	14	65.0
18:15	3.6	NAZEM KADRI - LOGAN O'CONNOR - ROSS COLTON	0	1	-1	7	9	43.8	19	16	54.3
17:13	3.4	PARKER KELLY - JOEL KIVIRANTA - JACK DRURY	5	1	4	13	6	68.4	23	18	56.1



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DOBBER'S 2026-27 CALDER TROPHY PICKS

Last year, I had Ivan Demidov at the top of the list followed by Maxim Shabanov, Yaroslav Askarov, Jimmy Snuggerud and Alexander Nikishin. They ended up finishing second, no votes, no votes, fifth and seventh. Not the greatest result. I did have the winner, Matthew Schaefer, at 14, and at the time was worried about whether he would make the team after missing most of the prior year with injury. I had Beckett Sennecke 27th (he was third) and Jakub Dobes 30th (he was fourth). With Sennecke, I wasn't sold that he would make the team and with Dobes I was thinking that Sam Montembeault wouldn't be terrible!

Just off the list this year are Radim Mrtka (BUF), Justin Carbonneau (STL), Roger McQueen (ANA) and Ty Nelson (SEA).

RK	Rookie	POS	Tm	Dobber says...
1	Gavin McKenna	LW	TOR	Doesn't have Stenberg's all-around game, but his upside has no peer
2	Ivar Stenberg	LW	SJS	All-around force could be the next Barkov
3	Porter Martone	RW	PHI	Made a huge splash with the Flyers to end last year
4	Anton Frondell	C	CHI	Another elite two-way prospect who will have a long career
5	Cole Hutson	D	WAS	May not reach brother Lane's heights, but he'll make his mark
6	Konsta Helenius	C	BUF	Forced his way onto the playoff roster. Tremendous upside and he'll work his way up
7	Viggo Bjorck	C	WPG	The Jets have a huge hole to fill on the second line and have penciled him in to fill it
8	Roman Kantserov	LW	CHI	Broke Kiril Kaprizov's KHL goal-scoring record, but he can pass too.
9	James Hagens	LW	BOS	The Bruins need the secondary offense that he can provide
10	Jacob Fowler	G	MTL	Being behind an elite young proven goalie, but Fowler is just as good
11	Carter Yakemchuk	D	OTT	The Jake Sanderson factor will hold him back, but he's good enough to produce anyway
12	Tij Iginla	C	UTA	Fantasy owners have waited a long time for the over-achieving Tij
13	Sergei Murashov	G	PIT	As I write this, Murashov has the backup role. He'll fall down the list if Pens sign someone
14	Charlie Stramel	C	MIN	The Wild need centers badly, so he'll get every opportunity
15	Sebastian Cossa	G	UTA	Karel Vejmelka is a top tier goalie, so only an injury will open the door for Cossa
16	Bradly Nadeau	RW	CAR	Cup Champs are a deep team so Nadeau will have a hard time homing in on the top six
17	Trevor Connelly	LW	VGK	At press time, Vegas is in dire need of a third-line skilled guy. Is Connelly ready?
18	Adam Jiricek	D	STL	Blues are in need of a legit puck mover. Fowler isn't it. Is it Mailloux, Lindstein or Jiricek?
19	Victor Eklund	RW	NYI	Underrated skill on team that desperately needs it. 11 points in 10 AHL/NHL games
20	Ryan Ufko	D	NSH	Has shown he can move the puck at the NHL level already.
21	Ilya Protas	LW	WAS	Probably a year away, but if he makes the team, he'll produce
22	Caleb Malhotra	C	VAN	Can his father/coach actually cut him? I think he will. But if not—watch out
23	Brady Martin	C	NSH	Hard worker could force his way onto the team, but may not dazzle with numbers
24	Dylan Garand	G	NYR	This would obviously require an injury to Shesterkin. But Rangers won't rack up the W's
25	Michael B-Nygard	RW	DET	Not ready to take the league by storm, but the upside is there
26	Ben Rautiainen	C	TBL	Top scorer in Liiga one of the most improved prospects of the past year
27	Vitali Pinchuk	C	NSH	Undrafted 24-year-old scored 31 goals in the KHL last year
28	Jake O'Brien	C	SEA	The Kraken can't seem to produce a 70-point player. Can O'Brien change that?
29	Alberts Smits	D	NYR	With Fox in place, it will be tough to make his mark. But Fox has struggled with injuries
30	Sam O'Reilly	C	TBL	A leader and two-way stud could force his way onto the third line and go from there
31	Eric Pohlkamp	D	SJS	Sharks have been dying for a right-shot puck-mover. Pohlkamp could step in
32	Cole Beaudoin	C	NYR	More of a two-way forward who is unlikely to crack the roster, let alone the top six
33	Tanner Molendyk	D	NSH	Top prospect is still adjusting to the pro game, has slipped behind Ufko on depth chart
34	Braeden Cootes	C	VAN	The Canucks may want to shelter him from what is likely to be a long, tough season
35	Caleb Desnoyers	C	UTA	Between his offseason injury, and Utah's acquisition of Trocheck, it could be tough
36	Artur Akhtyamov	G	TOR	Would need injuries to hit the top two goalies, but that's not exactly a crazy scenario
37	Trey Augustine	G	DET	As above, Augustine would need injuries to hit the top two G's to get his shot
38	Theo Lindstein	D	STL	Doesn't have the upside to win a Calder, but good enough to get some votes
39	Brayden Yager	C	WPG	Still needs time to adjust to pro hockey, and now Bjorck is likely ahead of him

40	Seamus Casey	D	NJD	Coming off a tough year, but now Nemec is out of the way. But Hamilton/Hughes still there
41	Alex Bump	LW	PHI	Doesn't have the upside to win a Calder. But his calling card is: 'exceeding expectations'
42	Aleksei Kolosov	G	PHI	Finally started to settle down in the AHL. Needs a Vladar/Woll injury to get a shot
43	Justin Robidas	C	CAR	Likely too small to crack a deep lineup. But he could get claimed off waivers...
44	Cole Eiserman	LW	NYI	An off-year in the NCAA was followed by a successful AHL stint. Defense an issue
45	Cruz Lucius	RW	ANA	Breakout NCAA season led to Ducks trading for, and promptly signing, him
46	David Reinbacher	D	MTL	Injuries, injuries, injuries. But he was a fifth overall pick so the potential is there.
47	Fabian Lysell	RW	COL	After the trade to the Avs, Lysell finds a team that actually has room on the pro roster
48	Amadeus Lombardi	C	NJD	Devils worked hard to acquire the AHL scorer, and gave him a decent contract, too
49	Felix Unger Sorum	RW	CAR	In many organizations, FUS would be Top 20 on this list. Not Carolina though
50	T.J. Hughes	RW	COL	Undrafted NCAA star was last year's undrafted free agent prize

2026 Preseason Scoring Leaders

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Upcoming in This Fantasy Guide

Content added before the 2025-26 season

1. Updated rosters and predictions (of course!)
2. All the latest cuts...
3. Training Camp Invites – check for updates
4. 2026 Preseason Scoring Leaders
5. ~~Dobber's Calder Trophy Picks~~
6. ~~Predicted NHL Standings~~



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PROJECTED TEAM GOALS-FOR

By Dobber

Last year in this column I projected a 4% increase in scoring league-wide. I said it was a little aggressive and that it probably wouldn't reach that number, but an increase was going to happen. Scoring ended up going up 2.85%. This season, I project scoring will go up just a little, to the tune of 1.5% (after adjusting for 84 games this season). I think it is starting to level off. The overall rise over the last decade can be directly attributed to the size of goalie equipment being regulated. If you give a shooter 5% more net to shoot at, he's going to score more goals.

The biggest jump in projected scoring goes to the New Jersey Devils. Better health for Jack Hughes brings up the scoring of several players. Just keep him out of the kitchen this year! Next is Washington, who replaced Connor McMichael with Jordan Kyrrou and Alex Tuch. Throw in a full season of Cole Hutson and you have a nice spike in goals. Florida (everyone healthy, added Brady Tkachuk), St. Louis (their top line is healthy and rolling) and Chicago (added Patrick Kane, Bowen Byram, and Roman Kantserov) should also see nice bumps.

On the flip side, with the added two games it is difficult for a team to actually score *fewer* goals, but some teams will manage to accomplish the feat. Pittsburgh overachieved last season, plus they lost Anthony Mantha's 33 goals. Ottawa lost Brady Tkachuk, Dallas lost Mavrik Bourque.

PROJ. RK	TEAM	GF (PROJ.)	GF (LY)	LY RK	INC/DEC	PROJ. RK	TEAM	GF (PROJ.)	GF (LY)	LY RK	INC/DEC
1	WAS	307	263	15	44	17	STL	265	231	25	34
2	COL	299	302	1	-3	18	DAL	264	279	8	-15
3	UTA	288	268	13	20	19	OTT	264	278	9	-14
4	CAR	287	296	2	-9	20	PIT	262	293	3	-31
5	BUF	287	288	5	-1	21	CBJ	261	253	16	8
6	MTL	287	283	6	4	22	PHI	260	250	20	10
7	TBL	286	290	4	-4	23	VGK	259	265	14	-6
8	EDM	282	282	7	0	24	NYI	257	233	24	24
9	TOR	277	253	17	24	25	NYR	252	238	23	14
10	NJD	277	230	27	47	26	DET	252	241	22	11
11	FLA	274	251	18	23	27	LAK	251	225	29	26
12	MIN	271	272	12	-1	28	WPG	251	231	26	20
13	NSH	266	247	21	19	29	CHI	246	213	31	33
14	SJS	266	251	19	15	30	SEA	245	226	28	19
15	ANA	266	273	10	-7	31	CGY	235	212	32	23
16	BOS	266	272	11	-6	32	VAN	217	216	30	1



PREDICTED STANDINGS

By Dobber

The Avalanche had a 31-2-7 start to their season last year. I had them edged out of the playoffs in a tie-breaker here. So yeah, standings predictions are not my forte, but let's give it a go anyway. To explain, I felt that the Avs didn't have the depth to sustain a lengthy run. But they had late-summer signings to bolster things, and roared out of the gate. And to be fair, they technically didn't have enough depth, since they kind of ran into a wall, going 23-14-4 after that. But that pace would have still had them well into the playoffs, so that was a whiff. So take this for what it's worth—my take on how things will shake out as of September 1. Any big moves would obviously shake things up.

Buffalo continues the dominance that saw them 39-9-5 and become the top team in the league, edging out the Avs and the defending Cup champion Hurricanes. The Habs will continue their ascension, as do the Sharks. The biggest caveats I have here are for the Devils and Blues. If Jack Hughes, Robert Thomas and Dylan Holloway are all mostly healthy (i.e. 75 games at least), then those two teams will enjoy strong bounce-back seasons. As soon as you hear any of them are seriously injured you can toss this page into the waste basket.

EASTERN CONFERENCE						WESTERN CONFERENCE					
Atlantic	W	L	OTL	Pts	Playoffs	Central	W	L	OTL	Pts	Playoffs
Buffalo	51	22	9	111	x	Colorado	50	21	11	111	x
Montreal	48	24	10	106	x	Dallas	47	23	12	106	x
Tampa Bay	45	30	7	97	x	Minnesota	46	26	10	102	x
Florida	45	30	7	97	x	Utah	46	28	8	100	x
Boston	42	30	10	94	x	St. Louis	41	31	10	92	x
Ottawa	42	30	10	94		Nashville	36	36	10	82	
Toronto	41	30	11	93		Chicago	34	36	12	80	
Detroit	40	33	9	89		Winnipeg	33	37	12	78	
Metropolitan	W	L	OTL	Pts	Playoffs	Pacific	W	L	OTL	Pts	Playoffs
Carolina	51	23	8	110	x	Edmonton	43	28	11	97	x
Washington	45	28	9	99	x	Anaheim	43	31	8	94	x
New Jersey	44	32	6	94	x	San Jose	42	32	8	92	x
Philadelphia	41	30	11	93		Vegas	37	31	14	88	
NY Islanders	42	35	5	89		Los Angeles	35	35	12	82	
Pittsburgh	38	32	12	88		Seattle	33	38	11	77	
Columbus	37	33	12	86		Calgary	32	40	10	74	
NY Rangers	35	38	9	79		Vancouver	27	45	10	64	

Stanley Cup Pick: Edmonton over Montreal

Norris Trophy Pick: Cale Makar

Hart Trophy Pick: Connor McDavid



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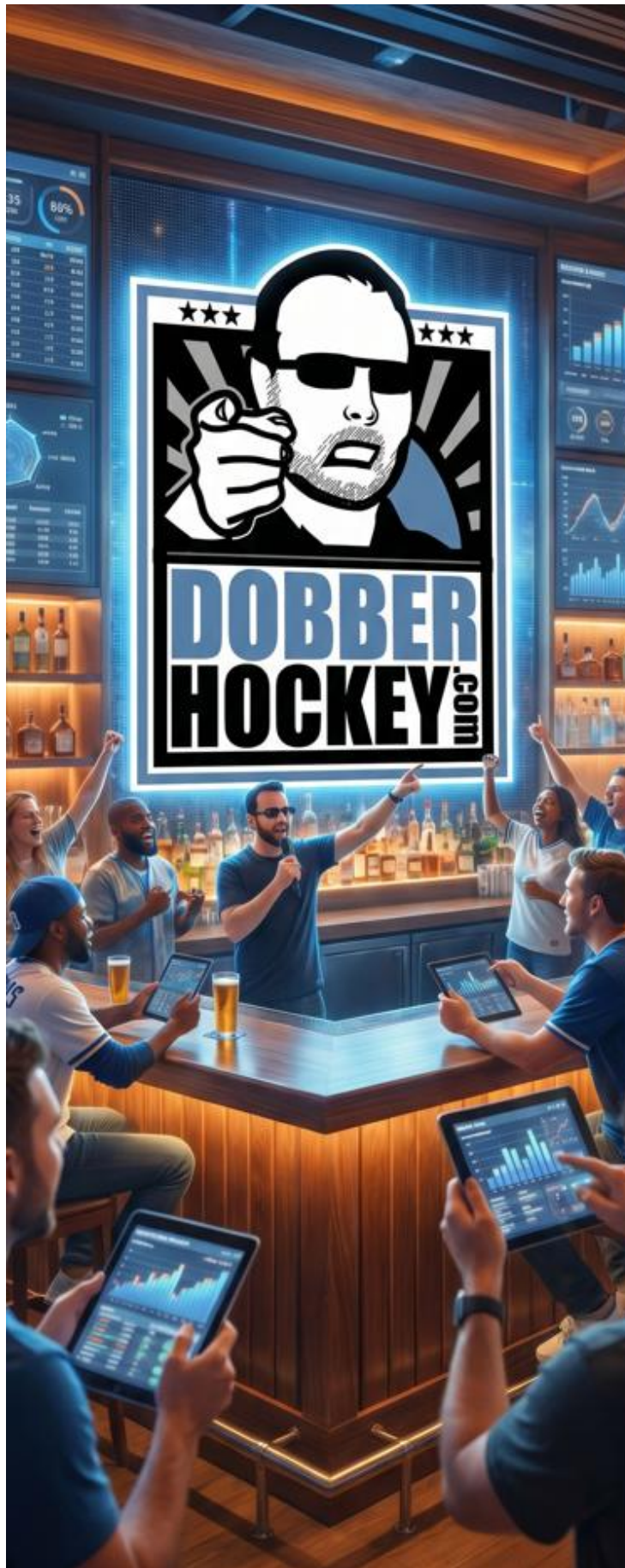


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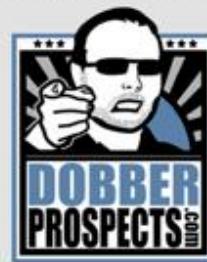
(changes will be tracked here)

- Chase Reid error fixed, removed from SEA depth chart
- Camp Battle rewritten (SEA)
- Jugnauth added to chart (SEA), Nelson adjusted
- Farrell moved from MTL to ANA
- Pastujov moved from ANA to MTL
- Linked players in depth charts to their Frozen Tools profile page
- Mantha, who was in the NJD depth chart in the second-last edit, was missed in the final edit. He was in the Hits chart, but not in the main chart. The error was brought to my attention and the proper depth chart has been put back in.
- Beecher correction BT note (FLA)
- Salaries fixed in spreadsheet (AAV and Cap were fine)
- Massive Koivunen note (PIT)
- Marchand inj. note, adjustment (FLA)
- Merzlikins inj. note, adjustment, Copley added to chart (CBJ)
- Savoie, Andersen, Janmark, Regula inj. note, chart adj (EDM)
- Further Savoie update with timeline (EDM)
- Predicted Standings complete (page 233)
- Calder Picks (Top 50)
- Tolvanen added to several charts (NYR)
- Evangelista trade, players adj. (NSH, NJD)
- Huberdeau inj. update, adj. (CGY)
- DFS coupon code added (see page 235)
- Gustavsson inj. update, chart adjustments (MIN)



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